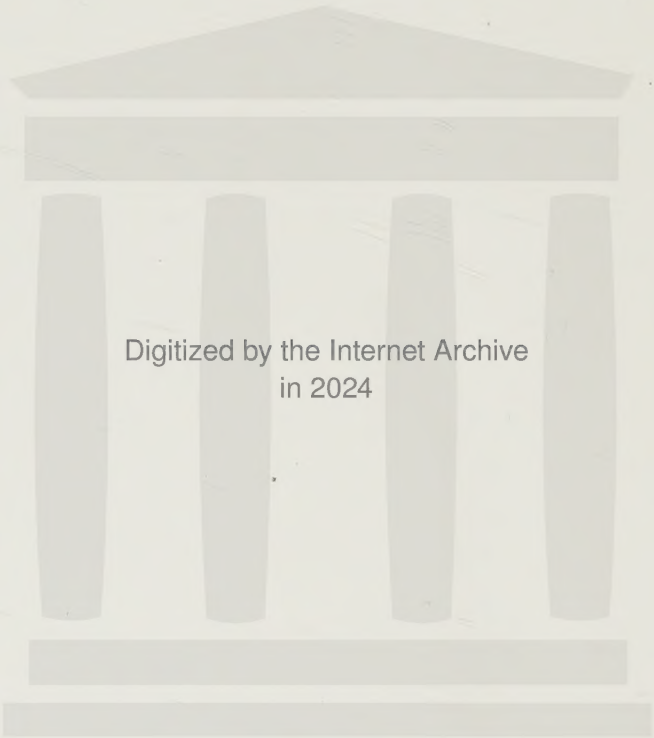
Southern Exposure

Recovery Under The Sun


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Southern Exposure

Recovery Under The Sun

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DISCLAIMER

The information in this publication is a compilation of available fellowship archives and memorabilia as well as group, area, and regional records. Books, magazines, newspapers, and internet sites were also used to ascertain data, as were interviews conducted with members of Narcotics Anonymous.

Despite the exhaustive effort undertaken to verify the accuracy of the materials and corroborate all accounts shared by individuals, the possibility of factual or interpretational errors may still exist.

This material was compiled by and for members of Narcotics Anonymous. This publication is not World Service Conference *or* fellowship-approved literature. The Florida Regional Service Office, Inc. produced this publication for members in Florida. Any opinions expressed in this book are not necessarily those of N.A. as a whole.

All proceeds from the sale of this book go to the Florida Regional Service Office.

Southern Exposure

THE FLORIDA HISTORY OF NARCOTICS ANONYMOUS

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NOTES TO THE READER

Many of the individuals named in this text made significant contributions within Narcotics Anonymous both in Florida and beyond. We have protected their individual anonymity by using only first names and last initials regardless of their current status as alive or deceased. The only exception to this rule involves those who have had their full identity disclosed in other publications. We kept this same policy when deciding which photos to include in this book.

We have used individual first names and initials of last names accurate as of a specific period of time. Due to marriages, last initials may have changed throughout the text.

Narcotics Anonymous has no opinion on outside issues, though within the context of this book we occasionally used statements of fact to explain issues in our history. Footnotes, endnotes, as well as a reference section was used in this publication in order to attribute the source used and to clarify when information used in this publication came from sources other than Narcotics Anonymous materials, literature or its members.

Throughout our history, incidents occurred which may reflect personal behavior that could be considered inappropriate or does not reflect the spiritual principles practiced by members in our fellowship. We have attempted to explain these incidents without distributing blame. In some cases, we used the word "we" rather than specify any individual or group.

All due diligence was employed in verifying the facts and anecdotes recreated in this book. Nonetheless, the possibility remains that evidence to the contrary may arise. In regards to "firsts," dates, places, times and the like, we used specific dates when indisputable evidence was available. Otherwise, we used months or weeks when we did not have specific dates, and we used portions of years or a specific year to prevent inaccuracies.

Some of the information contained in this publication are excerpts from published materials. The publications and related documentation are acknowledged and noted as such in an addendum section at the end of the book.

If anyone believes errors have been made in fact or conclusion or can offer a new discovery, we invite you to direct this information along with any documentation that verifies such claims to the Florida Regional Service Office. This publication is a first edition and subject to revision at a later date.

PREFACE

The idea for this book came from the members of the Narcotics Anonymous fellowship in Florida. In 1969, the first Narcotics Anonymous meeting was held in Florida, although this meeting was short-lived. Finally, in October, 1974, another fledgling meeting began, but this time it gave birth to the fellowship of Narcotics Anonymous.

The Florida fellowship was nearly thirty years old and Narcotics Anonymous itself nearly fifty years old when this project was undertaken. Many of the earliest members from the 1970's and early 1980's had moved away, passed away, or relapsed. It became obvious that something should be done to capture the spirit of "those who came before us."

At the September 2002 meeting of the Florida Regional Service Committee of Narcotics Anonymous, a motion was submitted and passed to establish The Florida History Project. The project was to focus on the entire state, including the groups and areas in the Florida region, South Florida region, and areas in Northwest Florida.

An ad hoc committee was established and a group of members met and began the project shortly thereafter. The initial goal was to research and compile information through a variety of means to create a book of the history of Narcotics Anonymous in Florida. The information and material collected and compiled would be placed in trust at the Florida Regional Service Office (RSO).

The second goal was to establish the office as the proper and perpetual trust for the collection, storage, and cataloging of documents, memorabilia, photographs and other records in order to properly honor materials that may be historical in nature. Finally, the material collected would be available to the fellowship by means of creating a permanent portable display available to any regional, area convention, or other event so that our history is available to all members of the fellowship.

The first obstacle in writing this book was its mandate that the narrative must come from addicts. Compiling and writing a history book comes with its own challenges. Typically, recovery books focus on the experience, strength and hope of our members; thus, they are a compilation of experiences in recovery.

History, on the other hand, must be factual, objective, and not swayed by personal bias. Therefore, the committee endeavored to present an accurate and precise viewpoint of our history. Through the years, our memories fade and recollections can differ widely. This is a natural occurrence of age and health as well as individual perspectives and personal growth.

INTRODUCTION

History by its very nature can be tedious and, at times, dull. Consequently, the History Ad hoc committee set out to offer an enlightening story that would stimulate gratitude for the program of Narcotics Anonymous.

"In order to recover we must first understand the nature of the illness, the nature of the addict and the nature of recovery."

Jimmy K.

Therefore, the story begins with some helpful background information, a brief history of the evolution of drugs, addiction and recovery movements from their earliest known origins. Then the birth of Narcotics Anonymous and its early years in California are chronicled. Next, the book focuses on the development of the fellowship east of the Rockies and beyond. Primarily, though, this publication will underscore the evolution, growth and development of Narcotics Anonymous throughout Florida and its significant impact on the entire fellowship.

This book is a collection of individual and shared experiences told by members of the N.A. fellowship. These accounts express the Sunshine State's humble beginnings during the '70s and early '80s, which led to the entire fellowship's rise out of obscurity. The story includes accounts of how a once small and relatively unknown fellowship overcame adversity and eventually won the hard-earned respect of the entire recovery community and society alike. We conclude with the explosive growth that continued into the '90s and beyond.

Many may not be aware of the obstacles confronted by those who found N.A. in earlier years. Perhaps by making this information available, some may be motivated to express their gratitude through greater participation in N.A. service work. Others may learn a new appreciation for the Twelve Traditions by becoming aware of how early members struggled, endured adversity, and eventually flourished from adherence to these principles. They are truly "the ties that bind us together."

We hope you enjoy this book

"Southern Exposure – Recovery Under The Sun"

A Brief History of Narcotics Anonymous in Florida

Southern Exposure

Recovery Under The Sun

Chapter One

AS OLD AS MANKIND

As Old As Mankind

"In order to recover we must first understand the nature of the illness, the nature of the addict and the nature of recovery."

Jimmy K.

Addicts mostly learn about the disease of addiction and the nature of recovery from their own experiences, by attending Narcotics Anonymous meetings and through treatment programs. Although many books have been written about these topics, a need has been expressed for an overview of the particular people, places and things that influenced the birth and maturity of recovery movements. Therefore, we have compiled a brief history of the evolution of drugs, addiction and recovery efforts from its earliest known origins. This chapter will provide some helpful background information about the history of the illness.

AS OLD AS MANKIND

Three of the most addictive drugs known to mankind date back to ancient human history. Based on the data we have gathered here, we suspect that even those in the Stone Age knew of them. For example, opium, hashish and cocaine are all products found in plants. Opium use goes back thousands of years. The Sumerians, an early-civilized tribe, recorded a description of their cultivation and preparation of opium onto clay tablets that date back to 7000 B.C. According to one translation of those inscriptions, opium was mentioned over three dozen times along with over a hundred other drugs of botanical origin.

Similarly the Egyptians, Persians and Greeks knew opium very early and used it medicinally. The Arabs most likely took opium into China during the 9th century, although its use did not become widespread until the 19th century. The use of marijuana and hashish has also been clearly identified and dates back to 2737 B.C. in China, where at the time it was considered a legitimate medication.

The record of such medicinal recommendations is found in the writings of the Chinese scholar-emperor Shen Nung. He compiled a book about herbs, a forerunner of the medieval pharmacopoeias that listed all the then-known medications.

Modern-day discoveries also reveal drug use and abuse in many early cultures and civilizations. One of the more confounding examples of this came to light as recently as 1992. The mummified body of Henut Taui – the Lady of the Two Lands from the 21st dynasty – sat in a museum in Munich. The sarcophagus had been discovered in Egypt almost a century earlier.

In 1992 researchers embarked on a project to investigate the contents of the mummies. When traces of cocaine were found in the mummies, it spawned news headlines and broad speculation about *"The Mystery of the Cocaine Mummies"* – because it would have been seemingly impossible for ancient Egyptians to possess this substance. A group of reputable scientists determined the cocaine found in the 3000-year-old mummies was not due to contamination, the use of fake mummies, or from Egyptian plants contained in the burial encasements. Their conclusion: the possibility that the Egyptians gained access to cocaine through an international drug trade whose links extended all the way to South America!

One thing is for certain: research indicates the use of drugs and alcohol dating back to historic and possibly pre-historic times: The earliest historical record of the production of alcohol, which has many of the same properties of an addictive drug, was in 3500 B.C. in the Euphrates Valley, known today as Southern Iraq. A description of an actual "brewery" was included in an Egyptian papyrus; and there is a multitude of additional references to alcohol throughout early history.

DISCOVERY, EXPERIMENTATION & PROLIFERATION

History is checkered with the discovery, experimentation and popularity of all kinds of drugs. In 1525, for example, a Swiss chemist named Paracelsus introduced the use of laudanum, or tincture of opium, into the medical profession. It quickly gained popularity in Europe, where it was hailed as a "cure" for a variety of ailments and its use and abuse became widespread.

However, it was not until the 19th Century that the active substances in drugs were extracted. In 1805, a German chemist, Freidrich Wilhelm Adam Serturner, isolated the active ingredient in opium, which he called morphine. Serturner named the ingredient after Morpheus, the Greek god of sleep and dreams, no doubt because of morphine's trance-like effect.

In 1822, Thomas DeQuincey's *"Confessions of an English Opium Eater"* was published. This acclaimed book is believed to be the first

modern hardback detailing the "addictive nature." It was so highly regarded it was made into a movie over a century later during the "shock genre" era of film in the 1950's.

Between 1839 and 1842, the first Opium War took place as the British Empire forced China into the opium trade. China was reluctant to enter the opium trade, since it had promulgated the first modern drug law in 1792, outlawing possession of opium. The sentence for those caught with opium was death by strangulation.

Even now, current Chinese law differs little from the earlier punishment. Those found guilty of opium possession in China today can be sentenced to death before a firing squad. Chinese society's disdain for opium possession is so strong that family members of those who are caught violating the law are sometimes forced to pay the cost associated with their loved ones' execution.

Nevertheless, strict laws and harsh sentences have done little to stymie the growth of drug use or of the drug trade. The British, along with the French, extended their powers to distribute opium in China in the second opium war in 1856.

Meanwhile, in the United States, a rash of drug use and addiction erupted during the mid-1800s due to several important events. These included the invention of the hypodermic syringe, the isolation of cocaine into its purest form, the laboratory creation of benzene acid (the first barbiturate), and the use of hashish as a treatment for mental patients and the mass importation of opium to the U.S. West Coast by Chinese migrants.

Opium dens flourished openly in most states while marijuana farming went unrestricted on the East Coast. The U.S. Civil War further created a need for the massive medicinal use of morphine as a painkiller. Drug use and addiction became so widespread it was estimated that nearly half a million addicts existed just among those in the military.

Addiction was finally being recognized as a social dilemma in the 1800's, resulting in the first attempt at alcohol prohibition in the state of New York. The short-lived law failed to produce any decline in inebriation, but did result of the establishment of the first "treatment centers" or sober homes. These homes welcomed those with alcohol ills as well as people with other drug problems.

After the Civil War, hundreds of "bottled cures" made by recognized druggists, touted as panaceas for almost any ailment, became widely popular and were readily available. Most of these contained large

volumes of alcohol and/or opium as well as a variety of other narcotics. During the 1800s and through the very early 1900s, many so-called "medications" were marketed without any government regulation and were sold at local general stores and county fairs. Some were even available by mail order.

Often these elixirs were hawked out of the backs of wagons by traveling salesmen. "Snake-oil" peddlers sold colored water, tincture of opium, even morphine, as cures for any and all diseases known to man, and no one seemed to object. Labels were not required to indicate what these nostrums contained and warnings were unheard of or rarely posted. Consequently, tens of thousands of Americans became hooked on opium, heroin and other addictive drugs. In recognition of this widespread use, the American Pharmaceutical Association adopted as one of its constitutional goals to restrict the dispensation and sale of medications to druggists and apothecaries.

Also during the latter part of the 1800s, another commonly known drug was quietly making its way into mainstream use in the United States and abroad. In 1883, German Army physician Theodor Aschenbrandt, secured a supply of pure cocaine from the Merck pharmaceutical firm. It was subsequently issued to Bavarian soldiers during their maneuvers in Europe while Aschenbrandt reported on the "beneficial effects" of the drug in increasing the soldiers' abilities to endure fatigue.

The following year, the respected Dr. Sigmund Freud treated his own depression with cocaine. Freud described his experiences as a feeling of "exhilaration and lasting euphoria, which in no way differs from the normal euphoria of the healthy person." Following Freud's published reports, many other recognized physicians began treating those suffering from depression by dispensing cocaine.

The use of coca leaves in bottled cures was also common in the 1800s. They were even used in refreshment drinks. In 1885, for example, John Sythe Pemberton (who had previously manufactured patent medicines such as Triplex Liver Pills and Globe of Flower Cough Syrup) introduced "French Wine Coca – Ideal Nerve and Tonic Stimulant." The next year, Pemberton introduced syrup he called "Coca-Cola." The product relied heavily on extract of coca leaves, or cocaine, which was listed in the contents label of Coca-Cola until 1903, when manufacturers decided to use spent coca leaves and substituted caffeine in place of the cocaine.

In 1898, Diacetylmorphine, commonly known as heroin, was

synthesized in Germany. It was widely lauded as a "safe preparation free of addiction forming properties." At the time, cocaine, morphine and heroin were legal and available through a druggist.

A general opinion was formed that heroin was the ultimate cure for fevers; it was prescribed by physicians as a reliable treatment for morphine and opium addiction. By the turn of the century, there were wide-ranging estimates of 300,000 to one million addicts in the United States alone.

U.S. LEGISLATION

The first legal measures against drug abuse in the United States came in 1875 when "opium dens" were outlawed in San Francisco. The first federal drug law was the Pure Food and Drug Act of 1906, which required accurate labeling of patent medicines containing opium and certain other drugs. Before this act became law, it was possible to buy medicines containing morphine, cocaine, or heroin in stores and by mail order. Heroin became the last legal opiate; it wasn't until 1925 that the importation of heroin was banned in this country.

The Sixteenth Amendment, enacted in 1913, created the legal authority for federal income tax. During the preceding years dating back to 1870, the tax on liquor provided one-half to two-thirds of the whole internal revenue of the United States. After the turn of the century this amounted to about 200 million dollars annually. This Sixteenth Amendment made it possible just eight years later for the enactment of the Eighteenth Amendment – Prohibition.

The Harrison Narcotics Act was passed in 1914. The bill was "an act to provide for the registration of collectors of internal revenue and to impose a special tax upon all persons who produce, import, manufacture, compound, deal in, dispense, sell, distribute, or give away opium or coca leaves, their salts, derivatives or preparations, and for other purposes." The act further required all manufacturers, importers, pharmacists, and physicians prescribing narcotics to be licensed to do so, at a moderate fee. Registered physicians were now required to keep records of drugs they dispensed or prescribed. It is unlikely that legislators realized in 1914 that the law Congress was passing would later be deemed a prohibition law.

After passage of the law, the clause "in the course of his professional practice only" was interpreted by law enforcement to mean that a doctor could not prescribe opiates to an addict to maintain his addiction. The Harrison Act and a subsequent 1919 U.S. Supreme Court case *(Webb*

vs. U.S.) maintained that addiction was not a disease and that an addict could not be considered a patient. In accordance with that legislation, law enforcement considered opiates prescribed to an addict to be antithetical to a doctor's professional practice.

Between 1919 and 1925, it is estimated that 25,000 physicians were arrested as a direct result of this interpretation of the law. Some were convicted and imprisoned. But despite the crackdown, use of narcotics and other drugs continued at relatively the same level as prior to the Act's passage.

A study by a congressional committee in 1918 documented that about one million people were using opium and other narcotics and that underground traffic in narcotics was about equal to the legitimate medical dispensation of the drugs. "Peddlers" appeared to have established a national organization, smuggling drugs through seaports or across the Canadian and Mexican borders in an effort to subvert the crackdown caused by the Harrison Act.

Over twenty cities reported increased use in narcotics, including New York and San Francisco.

From 1920 until 1933, the manufacture, sale, and consumption of alcohol were prohibited in the United States. During this period, marijuana gained a "grassroots" popularity. It was widely grown and supplies were harvested openly. In New York, it was reported that "tea pads" resembling the opium dens of the past were established in 1920.

Most of the marijuana was harvested from supplies that grew wild on Staten Island and in New Jersey and other nearby states. One of the first state laws making marijuana illegal was passed in Florida. The law made it illegal for anyone under the age of 21 to posses a "cigarette, wrappers or any substitute." Once the law was enacted, those arrested for possession were held and coerced to testify and reveal their source in an open courtroom.

In 1937, the Marijuana Tax Act was passed. It seemed to be written in the same manner as the Harrison Tax Act of 1914. Since the only patent medicine at the time for cannabis was in the preparation of corn plasters or corn removers for feet, the law generated little revenue. Instead of paying the government, manufacturers of those products elected not to register under the tax, and stopped including the substance in their formulas.

Around this time, the government began sponsoring "public service educational films" meant as anti-drug abuse campaigns. The films

generally produced an adverse result, forcing addicts even further underground. The most notable or notorious film was *Reefer Madness,* released in 1936. It is still popular today among hard-core cult movie aficionados. These types of films continued to be produced over the next several decades.

Movie moguls recognized the dramatic effects of drug addiction upon the psyche. This created a completely new genre of Hollywood films focusing on the nature of addiction and the perceived lifestyle. One critically acclaimed film released in the late sixties was *Panic in Needle Park.* The unedited version, vastly more explicit than what the general public saw, gave a somewhat accurate depiction of the "junkie lifestyle." This movie later became a staple in drug treatment centers during the seventies.

In addition to the proliferation of heroin, cocaine, morphine and marijuana use, experimentation with other mind and mood-altering drugs continued around the world. In 1938, Drs. Albert Hoffman and W.A. Stoll of the Sandoz Laboratories in Switzerland discovered the ergot derivative d-lysergic acid diethylamide. Since it was the twenty-fifth lysergic compound the scientists had discovered, they simply called the substance LSD-25. It later became known as simply LSD.

Since testing with LSD on animals showed no interesting properties of the drug, it was shelved for the next five years. In 1943, however, Dr. Hoffman ingested what he thought was a very small amount (250 micrograms) of his newfound chemical. He began taking notes of its effect, which included "dizziness, inability to concentrate and uncontrollable laughter."

Since Hoffman's self-testing took place during WWII and there were no cars, Hoffman got on his bicycle to ride the four miles home after taking a dose of the LSD. The literal origin of the term "acid trip" comes from this bicycle experience. Again, LSD was another drug that was thought to have no addicting characteristics.

During the next two decades LSD was tested as a possible cure or treatment aide for a variety of medical conditions. In the summer of 1960, Dr. Timothy Leary tried the Mexican psilocybin mushroom. Soon after, he purchased some psilocybin from Sandoz Laboratories for an experiment. Leary and his partner Dr. Richard Alpert began their own experiment; they would "turn on" themselves and many of the students at Harvard University where they worked. By 1963, they were asked to leave Harvard and the

"cult revolution" began. Leary joined the staff at the very liberal University of California at Berkley.

By 1965, the Drug Abuse Control Regulations were passed. They were written in the same fashion as the Harrison Act. This new law covered depressants, stimulants and hallucinogenic drugs. In a 1966 *Life* magazine article, the author estimated that over a million people had taken LSD. Despite the new regulations, LSD was further popularized during the "Summer of Love" in 1967 and was later openly used in massive quantities at universities and musical events in the following years leading into the seventies.

Published documentation is widely available about the use of LSD by one of the founders of Alcoholics Anonymous, Bill Wilson. Bill W., as he later became known, used LSD from 1956 to 1958 in his quest for continued "spiritual enlightenment." Additionally, Bill W. experimented with amphetamines and barbiturates to treat his depression. Listed on an A.A. history-related website entitled *"Friends of Alcoholics Anonymous"* was the infamous Timothy Leary.

THE VIETNAM WAR ERA

The use of narcotics as a painkiller on the battlefield may date back before the U.S. Civil War. The Civil War, however, led to extensive medicinal use of morphine, opium and other drugs that were available at the time. As pharmaceutical advances continued during the turn of the 20th century, painkillers were made available to soldiers in World War I, World War II, the Korean War and Vietnam. Each time, the many soldiers who were given the painkillers as medical treatment or who used the drugs to diminish their emotional and mental discomforts associated with a wartime environment, spawned a new generation of addicts.

The earliest record of intravenous use of amphetamines occurred with U.S. servicemen during the Korean War. Some soldiers stationed in Korea and Japan during the 1950s had the habit of mixing heroin with amphetamine to create a variation of the modern-day "speedball," in which heroin and cocaine are combined. Amphetamines were issued to the American, British, German and Japanese armed forces to combat battle fatigue. Following the war, physicians routinely prescribed amphetamines for depression.

The Vietnam War similarly produced a new generation of addicts and brought many young people who would otherwise never have seen an

opium poppy into contact with heroin. Heroin, marijuana, amphetamines, barbiturates and LSD were easily accessible during the war. Cannabis and opium poppies were native to Vietnam, so marijuana and heroin were particularly inexpensive and readily available.

During a 1971 Pentagon-sponsored amnesty program, it was reported that over 16,000 servicemen voluntarily admitted they were using heroin during the final thirty days in Vietnam. Other estimates place this number far higher, up to 50,000. The pentagon figures did not include those who served before 1971. Nearly 6,000 returning soldiers were placed into Veterans Administration Hospitals by the summer of 1971. The primary treatment for heroin addiction at that time was methadone maintenance. Many of our early Narcotics Anonymous members were found amongst these numbers.

These days, drug use comes with neither the social stigmas nor the revolutionary political convictions that were part of the drug culture in the '50s and '60s. This new trend began in the '70s. By then the use of "party drugs" and many other addictive substances had begun affecting all areas of the population regardless of age, race, sex or economic status. By the eighties, the drug culture had permeated every area of society without barriers or prejudice.

Early Recovery Movements

As long as illness and disease has existed, man has attempted to overcome and conquer them; it is only human nature to do so. Since it has been established that the availability and use of drugs date back into history, we presume that those who became addicted have attempted through the same trial and error method used to overcome other illnesses, was enlisted to conquer addiction.

CIRCLES TO BOTTLED CURES

Many in recovery today generally accept the notion that all recovery movements began with the Oxford Groups, a Christian-based predecessor to Alcoholics Anonymous. But there were also other organizations and recovery oriented movements, some of which date back prior to the founding of this country.

For example, alcoholic mutual-aid societies known as "Circles," existed within various Native American Tribes around 1750. Some evolved into abstinence-based Native American cultural revitalization movements and temperance organizations. Some continued even into the 19th century.

One of the more well-known early temperance movements was the Washingtonian Society, organized in 1840 by and for "hard cases." They grew rapidly to over half a million members before their precipitous decline late in the decade. A social institution – The Fraternal Temperance Society – replaced many of the Washingtonian groups.

In early April of 1840, six drinking buddies gathered at Chase's Tavern in Baltimore. A well-known temperance speaker was lecturing that night. Four of the buddies thought it would be a good joke to go and hear him. As they discussed the lecture later that evening, one of them proposed that they form a total abstinence society. Each agreed to bring a man to the next meeting. They wrote and signed a pledge not to drink. The name Washington Temperance Society was chosen in honor of George Washington.

In November of that year, they held their first public meeting. That event, and subsequent monthly meetings, proved such a success that by their first anniversary, the Baltimore Washingtonians counted "about 1,000 reformed drunkards and 5,000 other members and friends in the parade to celebrate the occasion."

The Washingtonians have been credited as being a precursor to Alcoholics Anonymous due to their "self-help" type practices.

Meanwhile, after the Civil War, many returning soldiers had become addicted to morphine and alcohol. The State of New York legislated the first period of prohibition in the U.S. This policy existed for two years before it became apparent that it would not succeed in reducing alcohol consumption.

In 1864, the first known "treatment facility" opened in the states, the New York State Inebriate Asylum in Binghamton, N.Y. This was the first of many "asylums." Shortly thereafter, a private "inebriate home" located in Fort Hamilton, N.Y., became the first of many asylums to open its arms to those addicted to the drugs other than alcohol that were prominent during this era. The most common addictive drugs at the time were opium, morphine, cocaine, ether and chloroform. The next year the first "asylum" dedicated to treating women opened in Chicago, named after the first "First Lady" – The Martha Washington Home for Women.

In 1872, Jerry McAuley opened the Water Street Mission in New York City. McAuley had "done time" in Sing Sing prison, where he experienced a spiritual transformation resulting in his quest to help others. The Water Street mission became the birthplace of a society known as the United Organization of Boozers. They were eventually integrated into the Salvation Army mission of "providing a helping hand to inebriates."

The Salvation Army was one of the first sources of support for recovering alcoholics in Florida, although it was not until the mid-1980s that they offered assistance to those whose addictions was were to drugs other than alcohol.

By the late 1800s, Dr. Leslie Keeley founded over two hundred treatment centers or asylums, although current information only substantiates a few dozen verifiable locations, and none of these were located in Florida. These centers marked a new era of private, for-profit, franchised facilities popularized again nearly a century later. Patients were given a secret "cure" in the form of injections.

These centers claimed and promoted themselves as having a fifty percent success rate. This was probably because people treated at these facilities who recovered from their problems stayed well as the result of treatment strategies employed beyond the seemingly useless, if not downright dangerous, injections (Gold, alcohol, and strychnine were some of the ingredients used in their concoctions.); these treatment centers encouraged group therapy and the exchange of information, as well as community involvement. These groups were a precursor to today's support

groups. From them it was learned that groups are important for recovery, and that there is strength in numbers.

During this same time period, Dr. Sigmund Freud and a number of other physicians recommended using cocaine to treat alcoholics and morphine addicts. Thus, otherwise well-meaning physicians began a pattern of using medicine as the primary source for treating those who were addicted, a practice sometimes referred to as drug replacement therapy. Physicians over the next several decades would use a variety of narcotics to detoxify and cure addiction to other narcotics.

Another phenomenon was the proliferation of "bottled cures" for alcohol and drug habits. Most would later be exposed to contain alcohol, opium, morphine, cocaine and cannabis and were sold and marketed by "quacks" or "hucksters." Even druggists were known to dispense them. The proliferation of these "cures" – made popular by "profiteers" as well as the open market availability of legitimate drugs – became one of the motivating factors in forthcoming legislation that influenced the creation of new treatment regimens after the turn of the century.

TREATMENT PROHIBITION

At the turn of the century, the opening of the Charles B. Towns Hospital for Drug and Alcoholic Addictions in New York City marked the beginning of a new type of "drying out" hospital – now known as medical detoxification centers or "detox wards." The Towns Hospital was a private, for-profit center that treated only the most affluent population of those addicted to drugs, including alcohol and narcotics. Bill W., one of the founders of A.A., would detoxify from his last drunken experience decades later at Towns Hospital under the guidance of Dr. William D. Silkworth.

Between 1907 and 1913, there were several waves of state laws passed which called for the mandatory sterilization of "defectives" – defined as the mentally ill, the developmentally disabled, and alcoholics and addicts. This began a pattern of addicts going "underground." to avoid such a fate.

As discussed in the previous section, the most notable law was passed in 1914, the Harrison Tax Act. This law brought opiates and cocaine under federal control and gave licensed physicians the only access to these drugs in the coming years. In 1919, the Supreme Court decided that physicians were not acting in "good faith" if they maintained an addict on his or her customary dose. This decision by the courts resulted in some

25,000 physicians being indicted for violations of the Harrison Tax Act between 1919 and 1925.

During this period, 44 communities had established morphine maintenance clinics to care for incurable and medically ill addicts. All would eventually close under threat of federal indictment; there was no conclusive evidence that any Florida locations existed. Treatment for narcotic addiction virtually disappeared for all but the most affluent Americans. The *Journal of Inebriety*, regarded for more than a half century as the professional's addiction publication, folded in the early 20's. It folded due to a drop in readership as a result of "treatment prohibition."

THE OXFORDS TO AKRON

In 1908, a man named Frank Buchman had a spiritual transformation that changed his life. In June of that year, he started a street-side church in Philadelphia with a donation of seventeen dollars. He resigned from his job and traveled to Europe, ending up at a large religious convention in Keswick, England. Feeling an urge to share this experience, he went to nearby Oxford University and formed an evangelical group among the student leaders and athletes. They aimed for absolute standards of Love, Purity, Honesty, and Unselfishness.

They became known as the Oxford Group and their principles were carried to the United States. Groups were in place in both New York City and Akron, Ohio, when Bill W. and Dr. Bob Smith hit their respective bottoms. These groups or "drunk squads" would befriend and teach their principles to the co-founders of Alcoholics Anonymous before they ever met, and then go on to host the fledgling groups of "newly dry" and nameless drunks.

When Dr. Bob and Bill W. finally met on June 10, 1935, the effect on the doctor was immediate, he found himself face-to-face with a fellow sufferer who had made good. Bill W. emphasized that alcoholism was a malady of mind, emotions and body. This all-important fact he had learned from Dr. Silkworth. Though a physician, Dr. Bob had not known alcoholism to be a disease. Responding to Bill W.'s convincing ideas, he soon got sober, never to drink again. This event was so significant that a *Time* magazine anniversary edition entitled "80 Days That Changed the World" recognized it as one of the most important events in the 20th century. It stated "...a simple set of principles – later refined into 12 Steps – that would become the foundation of America's self-help culture."

On June 11, 1935, Dr. Bob suggested that he and Bill W. both start working with other alcoholics; thus, Alcoholics Anonymous was founded.

In 1935, Alcoholics Anonymous was born in Akron, Ohio. A fellowship quickly developed born of the need of those who suffered from this widespread affliction. Commonly known as the co-founders of A.A., William Griffith Wilson, known as Bill W., and Dr. Robert Smith, took their shared spiritual experience and set forth to work with alcoholics at Akron's City Hospital, where one patient quickly achieved complete sobriety. Though the name Alcoholics Anonymous had not yet been coined, these three men actually made up the nucleus of the first A.A. group.

In the fall of 1935, a second group of alcoholics slowly took shape in New York. A third appeared in Cleveland in 1939. It took four years to produce one hundred sober alcoholics in the three founding groups. This, in essence, formed a fellowship that would result in a dedicated effort to "carry the message of sobriety" to alcoholics throughout the world.

These founding A.A. members were still part of the Oxford Groups; however, by mid-1936 they came under scrutiny. Bill W. was criticized for his ongoing work with alcoholics. In early 1937, they began to split away from the evangelical movement. By the summer of 1939, the withdrawal from their association with Oxford Group was complete. The Oxford Group was renamed "Moral Re-Armament."

Early in 1939, the yet unnamed fellowship published its textbook *Alcoholics Anonymous*. From the name of the textbook came the name of the fellowship. The text, written by the fellowship, explained A.A.'s philosophy and methods, the core of which is the now well-known "Twelve Steps." The book was reinforced by case histories of some thirty "recovered" members. From this point forward, the development of Alcoholics Anonymous was swift. By the end of World War II, small local A.A. groups quickly developed into fellowships in many major cities.

A.A. & ADDICTS

Bill W. responded to inquiries regarding the participation of addicts in A.A. groups. He clearly stated that A.A. should "avoid distractions and multi-purpose activity." Although sympathetic, he believed another solution could be found for their plight. Bill had even cautioned A.A. members about the use of narcotics in 1945.

A physician at the Narcotics Farm in Lexington wrote a letter to the *AA Grapevine* in 1944. The doctor's suggestion was the first that

envisioned how an adaptation of the A.A. program for addicts might be successful. His idea was to provide a subordinate faction within A.A. specifically for addicts. This issue, among others, created the need for a set of guidelines later known as the Twelve Traditions.

A.A. members questioned whether or not those addicted to drugs other than alcohol could even become A.A. members. Bill W. finally put to rest this question in another A.A. Grapevine article published in January 1965. He stated that "no non-alcoholic, whatever his affiliation, can be converted into an alcoholic A.A. member." Although their position was clear that addicts were excluded from participation in A.A., they fostered the idea that "another group" might benefit from their principles.

Over the years both Bill W. and Dr. Bob introduced the idea that Alcoholics Anonymous might allow "others" to adapt their model for people addicted to drugs other than alcohol.

ALCOHOLICS ANONYMOUS IN FLORIDA

"Our precepts are patterned after those of Alcoholics Anonymous, to which all credit is given and precedence is acknowledged."

From the original statement of purpose for the 1st Narcotics Anonymous meeting from The Key

The 35th Anniversary International Convention of Alcoholics Anonymous was held in 1970 in Miami Beach. Wesley P. from Pompano Beach, who was one of the early members in Ohio, chaired the convention. The earliest members of A.A. were commonly referred to as the "First 100."

Wesley later quietly became a friend of Narcotics Anonymous. At an A.A. meeting in late 1979, he was given a Little White Book by an N.A. member. The next week, surprisingly, Wesley had read the entire booklet. He asked for a copy of the "N.A. Big Book," but was told one did not exist, although someone in Atlanta was working on it. He urged that, as A.A. had, the N.A. book must be written "by your members and for them."

He insisted recovering addicts participate in writing "the N.A. Big Book." He influenced other A.A. members to be supportive of the "young fellowship." Wesley was later quoted as saying that "Narcotics Anonymous may someday become even larger than Alcoholics Anonymous."

The keynote speaker at the A.A. International convention in 1970 was Bill Wilson, the co-founder of Alcoholics Anonymous. This turned out to be his last public appearance. On January 24, 1971, Bill W. died at the Miami Heart Institute in Miami Beach.

HOUSTON S. & VICTOR H. VOGEL, M.D.

By 1929, the federal government recognized the need to make drug addiction treatment available for addicts. The Porter Act provided funds for treatment facilities. The U.S. Public Health Service established two hospitals. One was in Lexington, Kentucky, which opened in 1935, and the other was established three years later in Fort Worth, Texas. These institutions accepted patients on both a voluntary and an involuntary basis, although they functioned primarily as hospitals for imprisoned addicts. Treatment consisted of a seven-to-ten-day simple detoxification process, after which much of the patient's time was spent laboring in a variety of farming-related details. Addicts referred to treatment at Lexington as "getting the cure."

An article published in the August 7, 1954, edition of *The Saturday Evening Post* entitled "These Addicts Cure One Another," provided a detailed account of the earliest version of recovery groups using the name Narcotics Anonymous. The article alluded that the meetings were loosely patterned after the A.A. model. From New York to Los Angeles, clusters of divergent groups began to organize.

In June 1944, Houston S. was living in Montgomery, Alabama. He achieved sobriety in the early days of Alcoholics Anonymous. Houston would go on to "Twelve-Step" a gentleman who he had met in AA. named "Harry." Although "Harry" used alcohol, he was "strung-out" on morphine. "Harry" eventually was sent to the Federal Narcotics Farm in Lexington for his addiction to morphine. The name "Harry" was used in the Saturday Evening Post article; it was most likely was not his real name.

An engineer by trade, Houston was offered a job transfer to Frankfort, Kentucky, a small city near Lexington, in late 1946. Upon his arrival he remembered his friend Harry. Having made this connection, Houston believed that this could be the place where a program similar to Alcoholics Anonymous could help people like Harry. In the 1954 article, he was quoted as saying, "I was convinced that the Twelve Steps would work as well for drugs as for alcohol if conscientiously applied."

Houston visited "the farm" as it was referred to and there he met with Dr. Victor Vogel. Vogel was the medical director at Lexington. His name can be found again and again throughout the early history of Narcotics Anonymous. Dr. Vogel was an early pioneer in twelve-step movements for addicts. In 1954, he co-authored a book entitled *Narcotics*

and Narcotics Addiction. The following paragraph contains one such excerpt from his book. It offers a concise description of the nature of the illness from its very roots.

"Human beings have sought from pre-historic time for methods to make life pleasurable, and, at the same time to mitigate or diminish the discomforts, which inevitably accompany human existence. The ingenuity that they have shown is extensive and this perseverance with which they have experimented upon the physiology is truly remarkable. In a broad sense all improvements in human living, physical, esthetic, mechanical, and scientific, have resulted from this tendency; the motives behind this activity are, on the whole sound – if we accept human civilization as a healthy state – and the results have, in the cumulative sense, been desirable. While on the one hand, this experimentation has given us such advantages as insulin and surgical anesthesia, it has, on the other, introduced into human society certain drugs which have the capacity to enslave people beyond any other power known."

Victor Vogel, M.D., from Narcotics and Narcotic Addiction 1954

Houston proposed that a group, using the principles found in the A.A. program but adapted for addicts, might have the same success that A.A. had been reporting at the time. Dr. Vogel agreed with Houston's idea, and the first twelve-step meeting for addicts was formed. Houston, with the support of some local A.A. members, formed this new group.

This initial group began to meet on February 16, 1947. This was a group of inmates and patients. The group would call themselves "Addicts Anonymous," and later referred to as the NARCO Group. They met weekly into the early '60s. The group adopted the A.A. Twelve Steps, replacing the word "alcohol" with "drugs." In an ironic twist, "Harry" returned to Lexington and began attending the meeting that he inadvertently inspired. Shortly afterward, the Federal Narcotics Farm in Fort Worth, Texas adopted the Lexington model.

The Lexington meeting began a sequence of events that led to the beginnings of Narcotics Anonymous. The group produced a newsletter called *The Key*, which was sent to ex-patients and interested relatives across the country after patients were discharged from the facility.

Houston S. is likely one of the best friends the Narcotics Anonymous fellowship will ever know. He believed in the Twelve Steps and knew that they could work for addicts. His faith in the Twelve Steps for addicts eventually resulted in the Narcotics Anonymous we know today. He remained an avid supporter of the NARCO meeting until his "retirement" in the early '60s. Sadly, Houston did not live long enough to

see the development of his work transpire. Dr. Vogel, however, played a role in the birth of the California N.A. movement along with the hope and promise it offered to addicts.

GOTHAM & BEYOND

One voluntary patient at Lexington was an addict named Danny Carlsen from Brooklyn. He began attending the NARCO meeting at the Farm. Upon his discharge and return to New York City months later, he met Major Dorothy "Dolly" Berry, an official with the Salvation Army. Together they started a meeting in a New York prison. In the '40s and '50s all drugs were known as "narcotics"; therefore, they chose the name "Narcotics Anonymous" for this new venture.

Danny relapsed again and returned to Lexington in 1948 for the last time (he was admitted to Lexington on eight separate occasions). Six months later, Danny returned to New York and, again with the help of Major Berry, was allowed to use the soup kitchen at the Salvation Army on 45th Street to start the first meeting for addicts outside of a prison. This neighborhood was commonly known as Hell's Kitchen.

In 1950, Danny got permission to use a room at the McBurney YMCA in Manhattan for a Wednesday night meeting. It was later reported that six meetings existed for some time. The meetings were held at the Salvation Army, the YMCA on 23rd Street, and the House of Detention in Manhattan. Meetings were also held at St. Augustine's Episcopal and St. John's Catholic Churches in the Bronx. Brigadier Victor Dimond, another official with the Salvation Army, worked expressly with the "demoralized" inside New York area prisons and arranged for a meeting to be held at Riker's Island.

This version of "Narcotics Anonymous" was directly affiliated with the Salvation Army. It focused on detoxification, assistance with food and shelter, finding employment, and other social services tasks. These meetings began using the A.A. Twelve Steps. They simply scratched out the word alcohol and replaced it with the word drugs. Similarly, "powerless over alcohol" was replaced with "powerless over drugs."

With the assistance of the print shop at Riker's Island, members had a small booklet produced that closely resembles in size and shape the modern-day N.A. *Little White Book*. It was entitled *Our Way of Life – An Introduction to N.A.* This booklet was plagiarized directly from a '40s A.A. pamphlet. Three versions of the bootleg booklet were produced. The first

printing listed an address of Village Station in New York City. The second noted that it was printed at the Riker's Island print shop. The third was used by a later version of this N.A. in Cleveland though it was still printed at Riker's print shop.

Major Berry incorporated the program under the name, Narcotics Anonymous, Inc. and formed a Board of Directors. Unfortunately, the board was comprised primarily of non-addicts, with the exception of Danny Carlsen.

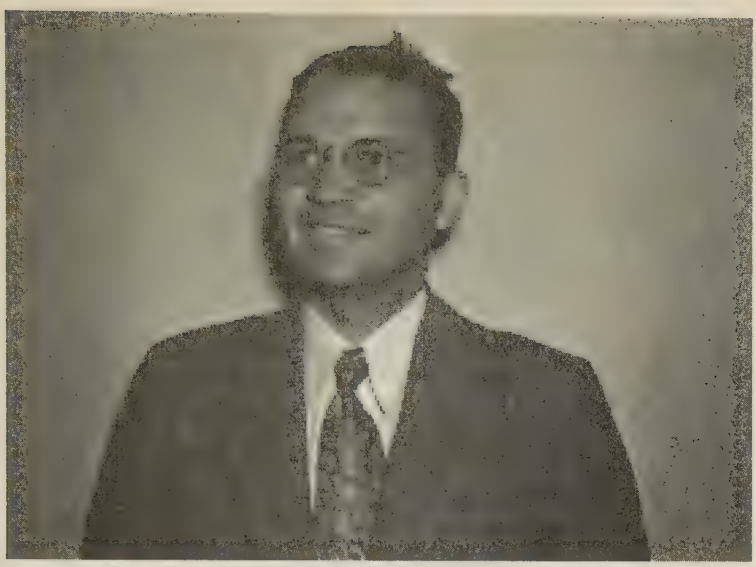
Danny was essentially indigent. His psychologist believed his venture (N.A. Inc.) would work, but they needed public funding. He and Danny helped organize another entity – the National Advisory Council on Narcotics. Danny received a stipend for his activities on behalf of the council.

One of the more notable council members was Mrs. Marty Mann – "The First Lady of Alcoholics Anonymous" – the first woman to stay sober in A.A. Edward R. Murrow, a distinguished journalist in that era, selected Marty as one of the 10 greatest living Americans in 1951. The AMA's acceptance of alcoholism as a disease can be attributed directly to Mrs. Mann's work on the National Advisory Council on Alcoholism.

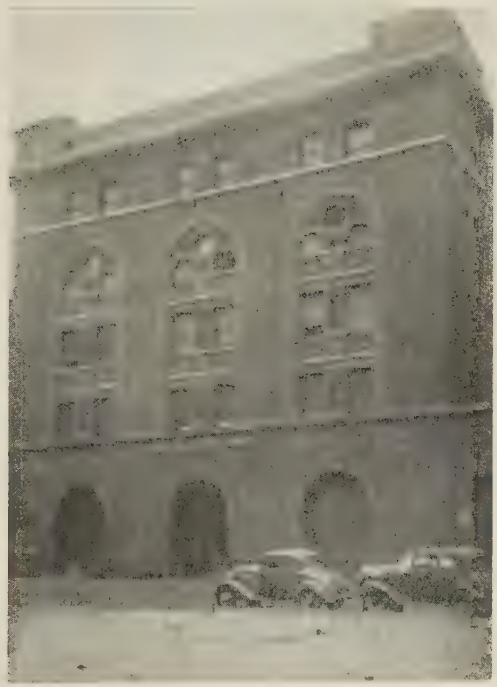
During the early '50s, dozens of articles were published promoting this organization. Danny served as the N.A. spokesperson and was the subject for many of these interviews. A publication entitled *Really Living* included a detailed description of one of the authors, Danny Carlsen. It reads in part:

"Founder of Narcotics Anonymous and organizer of the National Advisory Council on Narcotics. An addict for twenty-five years himself, Danny Carlsen took the "cure" repeatedly only to fall back into addiction. Finally, a religious experience helped him gain the victory, but he literally gave his life in vigorously striving to stamp out drug addiction in the United States. Danny was a popular speaker before civic, religious, social, medical, student, fraternal, patriotic, veteran's, and other groups, and frequently appeared at staff conferences in hospitals and at symposiums in universities, as a guest on radio and television programs."

Much of the early support and promotion that took place between 1951 and 1955 for the New York N.A. organization diminished after Danny Carlsen became ill and died August 19, 1956. The National Advisory Council on Narcotics folded. Danny's trusted ally Rae Lopez would



Dr. Victor H. Vogel



Salvation Army – Hell's Kitchen – Site of 1950 meeting



Danny C. – Founder of Narcotics Anonymous, Inc.



Bill W. – Co-Founder of Alcoholics Anonymous



Walla Walla Penitentiary – 1st prison meeting

continue to "carry the torch" for the surviving Narcotics Anonymous, Inc. meetings for several years.

As noted in the book *The Junkie Priest*, Rae was described as "a dark eyed, precociously mature and stunningly attractive teenager when she first came into contact with Father Dan Egan." She joined a Latin dance troupe, in effect seeking a "geographical cure and traveled extensively" including trips to Florida "where heroin was plentiful in Miami and Tampa."

By age 17, after a series of multiple arrests, she eventually was incarcerated at the House of Detention. Rae attended the Sunday N.A. meeting and met Danny Carlsen. She was released shortly thereafter and, according to *The Junkie Priest,* "she vowed God had given her a chance, so she would give N.A. a chance. She found a purpose in life that perpetuated her freedom." Rae originated similar chapters in the prisons at Marquette and Jackson, Michigan, and Passaic County, Newark, Hackensack, and Hoboken, New Jersey, all by mail. The Salvation Army meetings used their own version of the steps known as "The Thirteen Steps." These "steps" bore little resemblance to the accepted Twelve Steps.

Salvation Army Thirteen Steps

1. Admit that the use of narcotics made my life seem more tolerable, but the drug had become an undesirable power over my life.
2. Came to realize that to face life without drugs I must develop an inner strength.
3. Made a decision to face the suffering of withdrawal.
4. Learn to accept my fears without drugs.
5. Find someone who has progressed this far and who is able to assist me.
6. Admit to him the nature and depth of my addiction.
7. Realize the seriousness of my shortcomings as I know them and accept the responsibility of facing them.
8. Admit before a group of N.A. members these same shortcomings and explain how I am trying to overcome them.
9. List from my own understanding all the persons I have hurt.
10. Take a daily inventory of my actions and admit to myself those, which are contrary to good conscience.
11. Realize that to maintain freedom from drugs I must share it with others and the experience from which I have benefited.
12. Determine a purpose in my life and try with all the spiritual and physical power within me to move towards its fulfillment.
13. God Help Me.

In 1961, she was hired as a full-time city employee in the Office of Narcotics Coordination. Half of her office functioned as the headquarters of Narcotics Anonymous, Inc. free of charge. She continued to support the few remaining meetings until they faded.

Some isolated meetings did last into the '60s in New York, Chicago, and a few other cities where the Salvation Army had rehabilitative programs. One such example took place in Cleveland in 1963. Mickey McGuire, who worked at the Cleveland House of Detention, along with one Captain Edward Dimond (son of Brigadier Victor Dimond), who had recently accepted the position at the Harbor Light Center, discussed what they could do for addicts. Ed Dimond knew of the New York organization from his father. He also knew Dolly Barry and spoke with her about their efforts back in New York. He decided to make his facility available as a meeting place. Dolly Barry, not Rae Lopez, sent the booklet *Our Way of Life – An Introduction to N.A.* to Ed.

During an interview for this book, Ed recalled that Marvin S., upon his return from Lexington, became a founding member and the secretary of the Cleveland N.A. Group. Marvin was a professional drummer and member of a jazz band that toured the Vegas Strip. Marvin S. relapsed in 1964, but he resurfaced in 1975 in Miami. Marvin was a founding member of Narcotics Anonymous, as we know it today in Miami.

The Cleveland N.A. Group replaced the Salvation Army's 13 Steps with the more traditional version of the A.A. Twelve Steps. They simply replaced the word "alcohol" with "drugs." They grew to three meetings a week in Cleveland, and met on Sundays, Tuesdays and Wednesdays. The meeting format sheet stated, "The group had the option to break into the Synanon Game." This notation establishes that this early version of N.A. in no way resembles the N.A. we know today.

In the early '50s there were a few attempts at establishing recovery groups for addicts in the Los Angeles area. Habit Forming Drug (HFD) groups consisted of small secret meetings held in apartments. Individuals from A.A. dominated the meetings. Another short-lived group had formed in East L.A. that went by the name of Addicts Anonymous. They infringed upon the A.A. name, according to Jimmy K. The meeting died very quickly. Another group that we know existed was called "Hypes & Alcoholics." They met for a short period in 1959 in Los Angeles and many of the regular attendees would go on to assist in the formation of "Synanon."

Information is available about other groups started for addicts in prisons. Meetings were known to have existed at the Federal Prison in Lorton, Virginia, and even in the late '60s at Louisiana State Penitentiary at Angola. There continues to be a cadre of urban legends and unsubstantiated

information regarding similar meetings in at least a dozen other locales throughout the country.

During the '50 and '60s, dozens of books were published concerning addicts' bouts with their addictions and their experiences with these early meetings. Before his death, Danny Carlsen assisted in the initial compilation of a book called *The Addict,* was edited by Dan Wakefield. Carlsen also wrote a chapter in the previously mentioned *Really Living* and assisted in the compilation of five other chapters. He co-wrote these chapters with Barbara Doyle. She was one of the original corporate officers of Narcotics Anonymous, Inc.

Wenzell Brown wrote *The Monkey on My Back*, which had a chapter, entitled, "Narcotics Anonymous," referring to the meeting in the soup kitchen. There was an exposé in this same book entitled "Once an Addict – Always an Addict." This saying was referred to in a magazine article entitled, "The First Story about Narcotics Anonymous," printed in an earlier edition of *The Confidential* in 1953. The primary subject for this article was Dorothy Sorenson, who allowed her full name and photo to be published. Jimmy K. would later rail against this phrase. From this came his often quoted belief that the "The Lie is Dead – We Do Recover."

John D. Harris wrote *The Junkie Priest* referring to Father Daniel Egan who assisted with *"Wednesday Night at the Y,"* the meeting on 23rd Street. Egan became the "chaplain" and a board member of Narcotics Anonymous, Inc. He became part of the latter N.A. movement when he resurfaced in the early '80s at the 13th World Convention in New York City. The convention was held at the Vista Hotel, also known as World Trade Center, Building 3. It was destroyed in the 2001 terrorist attack of the World Trade Center complex. Later, the Florida fellowship also welcomed Egan at the 19th World Convention in Orlando as well as subsequent "spiritual retreats" he held in Florida. He was a friend of the fellowship until his death.

There were a few common ties among these early recovery efforts. Each meeting's origin can be traced to the Farm at Lexington. Many of these outside meetings were started by ex-inmates from Lexington and Fort Worth or through those connected with the Salvation Army. Another common link is *The Key*, a newsletter from Lexington that was circulated around to many of these groups and later played a role in the initial stages of the California movement.

These meetings for the most part operated independently of each other, as they never attempted to organize themselves into a full-fledged movement or fellowship. Most importantly, the concept of total abstinence from all drugs, including alcohol, was not widely accepted by those attending these early meetings, nor had it been accepted by society at this time.

Narcotics Anonymous, Inc. started in the right direction by adapting the A.A. Twelve Steps for use by addicts. The nature of this organization, however, was not a fellowship, per se; rather, it was affiliated with a social welfare fundraising group. Another important issue these organizations and groups had in common was that none of them had adopted the Twelve Traditions, nor had they asked permission of Alcoholics Anonymous to adapt their version of the Twelve Steps. The initial printing of the Twelve Traditions took place in the April 1946 edition of the *A.A. Grapevine.* This process continued for the next eleven months, detailing one tradition in each issue. The Traditions were subsequently approved at the 1950 A.A. International Convention in Cleveland. In May of 1953, A.A. published and distributed the first edition of the book, *The Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions.*

Subsequently, each of these early attempts failed due to a variety of issues and practices that we know today as obvious violations of the Twelve Traditions. These meetings did not constitute the Twelve-Step fellowship of Narcotics Anonymous, as we know it today. Most likely, though, these organizations were well-intentioned, community-based attempts to clean up and rehabilitate addicts.

HAZELDEN & SYNANON

In 1948, Hazelden began in a farmhouse retreat. Carroll, the first counselor, led a simple recovery program based on the principles of Alcoholics Anonymous. The Twelve Steps and a philosophy of "treatment with dignity and respect" would form the foundation for a treatment philosophy for the next decade.

In the mid-'50s, the Dupont Corporation developed the first "industrial alcoholism program," the predecessor to many later day "Employee Assistance Programs." Employees who were members of A.A typically led these early programs. Shortly thereafter, health insurance companies began recognizing alcoholism by authorizing payment for treatment.

The '60s were a period of great innovation and growth. Hazelden was the forerunner in the field of alcoholism treatment. This period is when the "holistic, multidisciplinary team approach to treatment really took shape, an approach" that became known as the Minnesota Model. This approach has been emulated in treatment centers worldwide. These initial twelve-step oriented treatment programs were generally limited to treating those with alcohol problems only. Those who used drugs other than alcohol were left with far fewer alternatives.

Chuck Dederich called himself a former Alcoholics Anonymous member; he was known to have coined the phrase, "Today is the first day of the rest of your life." In 1958, he established Synanon as an innovative drug rehabilitation center near the Santa Monica beach. The initial and primary educational tool that Synanon utilized was called the Synanon Game. This highly confrontational method involved placing a single patient in the "hot seat." Widely praised for years, Synanon slipped eventually into cult-like behavior, exercising strict control over its followers.

In its later years, the group became involved in highly publicized violent actions. Dederich and two assistants pleaded no contest in 1980 to charges that they solicited an assault and conspired to murder Los Angeles lawyer Paul Morantz by placing a rattlesnake in his mailbox. As part of the plea bargain, Dederich gave up control of Synanon. His prominence and that of Synanon declined rapidly after that, until Synanon ceased operating.

Many of the concepts used in Synanon were later copied by drug treatment centers in the '70s and '80s. These facilities were referred to as Therapeutic Communities. Behavior modification techniques were used in the therapy process. "Clients," as those admitted to these Therapeutic Communities were referred, were able to earn certain privileges – one of them being "drinking privileges." The total abstinence concept was not well received in the therapeutic community settings until the mid-'80s, making relapse commonplace prior to that time.

Beginning in the early '70s, a synthesis of the Minnesota Model and Therapeutic Communities concepts would take place in this new era of residential and hospital-based treatment settings. These facilities began recognizing all addicts, regardless of their particular drugs of choice, thus opening their doors without discrimination. Additionally, these same facilities would be a factor in the growth of Narcotics Anonymous in various parts of the country, particularly in Pennsylvania, Georgia, California, and Minnesota.

The '80s and '90s would mark a vast expansion of the private, for-profit, franchised facilities, financed by the sale of public stock offerings. These facilities adopted the disease concept of addiction and much of the terminology used in Narcotics Anonymous literature shortly after the N.A. Basic Text was published. Hundreds of thousands of addicts would be introduced to Narcotics Anonymous through these facilities during the next decade. The therapeutic communities revised their standard treatment methods. They accepted the Twelve-Step-based program of Narcotics Anonymous as a viable resource.

Chapter Two

BIRTH OF A FELLOWSHIP

JIMMY'S STORY – PAISLEY, SCOTLAND

Jimmy Patrick Kinnon is considered by many to be the founder of Narcotics Anonymous. He was one of the original seventeen who attended the very first N.A. recovery meeting as well as the preceding planning meetings in 1953. He spent the next three decades of his life in dedicated service to the fellowship. When N.A. died briefly in 1959, it was Jimmy who took a leadership role and restarted meetings. He opened the doors and made the coffee. According to his obituary, "he lived in near poverty," fitting his devotion to the fellowship.

This chapter covers the birth of the fellowship of Narcotics Anonymous, the early struggles and the building of our foundation. It will become clear that Jimmy K. was in every aspect the founder of the California movement, though others may recognize him only as "one of many significant contributors." This characterization is also very valid. Jimmy himself recognized that "there are no big shots in N.A."

Jimmy was born April 5, 1911, in Paisley, Scotland, and spent his early years in this small town known for colorful wildflowers, museums, and plentiful theatres. During our research, we had the opportunity to interview his widow Betty K., and she told us about one of his childhood experiences that clearly played a role in the development of the fellowship later in his life.

Jimmy was outgoing as a child. He even counted the town drunk, Crookshank, among his friends. Crookshank also befriended Jimmy. Jimmy would find him sick and injured as Crookshank got into fights from time to time. On one particular occasion, Jimmy found his friend badly beaten and bleeding. Jimmy went for help.

Jimmy wanted to know when his friend was coming back; his mother kept repeating "next week." He was unrelenting, so his mother took him to visit his friend. Jimmy found Crookshank in a wheelchair, incoherent and despondent. Once their visit concluded, Jimmy was quiet and subdued; his mother asked what was wrong. His response was prophetic. "When I grow up, I'm going to help people like Mr. Crookshank." As we know today, Jimmy's prophecy came true.

His family decided to move to the United States in the 1920's. Upon their arrival at Ellis Island, he was separated from his parents when

they were sequestered for medical reasons. A family from Germany watched him until his parents were cleared; they were obviously worried and unsure about their own disposition as political refugees. If the Germans were not admitted, they would be sent back and most likely, they would be put to death. Once his parents were cleared, Jimmy left, never to know what happened to his newfound friends.

First, Jimmy and his parents went to New York City, and then onto Philadelphia, where they settled. Jimmy was a fighter, both literally and figuratively during these years. He enrolled in a private school with hopes of eventually entering the priesthood, but it was a half-hearted goal. This began a period of alcohol use, and he began using other drugs as his addiction developed over the next twenty years.

While in his thirties, Jimmy moved to California and finally put down roots in Sun Valley, a small town in the San Fernando Valley bordering Lockheed Airport, which was later renamed the Burbank Airport. He became a roofer and painter, married and had six children, all the while continuing to use.

A series of arrests led Jimmy to confront some of his problems, and he was able to begin his recovery. Jimmy found his way to Alcoholics Anonymous in North Hollywood, California. On February 2, 1950, he began a 35-year journey. It was not long before he would find others whose addictions involved drugs other than alcohol.

In 1950, Jimmy was introduced through friends in A.A. to Betty T., who invited him to attend a Habit Forming Drugs (HFD) meeting. HFD meetings were held in private homes. Jimmy K. attended a few meetings but left disappointed. "These meetings were hidden; a few people meeting in apartments. They had no formal meetings or plans to do so." These groups did, however, create a place for addicts to share apart from A.A. meetings. This alone was significant, since addicts were not typically accepted in the "A.A. inner circle" if they spoke about their identification as an addict.

During the next year, he had what he described as a spiritual awakening. He suddenly knew that everything was going to be all right, and that if he would just follow directions according to his own conscience, things would work out. He felt that he had made contact with some inner part of himself and the entire universe, and he identified that as his Higher Power. It was undoubtedly this particular experience and his single-minded determination to make N.A. succeed that sustained him from the '50s to the '70s.

In 1951, Jimmy was asked by several A.A. members to help start a meeting for addicts. He learned about the New York meetings from the Lexington newsletter, *The Key*, and decided to contact them; he spoke with none other than Danny Carlsen. It is not clear whether this was the only communication or if others occurred later. Betty shared that Jimmy was offended with Danny's personal request for a donation to their struggling organization. The New Yorkers had sought and received plenty of publicity as published photos relinquished their anonymity. They were accepting monies from outside sources, allowed professionals to speak at their meetings, and appointed their own chaplain. Jimmy had already been schooled in the newly accepted Twelve Traditions; therefore, he was aware the New Yorkers would most likely not succeed.

"They were no more than a social service organization than a fellowship, but, I really liked their name – Narcotics Anonymous."

Jimmy K.

There are several variations as to how the initial meetings came to fruition, though the most reliable and accepted version indicates they took place at the insistence of either a Los Angeles County probation officer or police department representative (specifically the Narcotics Division). They knew something needed to be done to help addicts. Jack P., an alcoholic who knew little about addiction to other drugs, was asked to help by the official. His affiliation with the A.A. Institutional committee is the most likely reason he was involved in the initial formation of a group for addicts. The first meeting was held in the summer of 1953.

STAGG STREET

In July, a group of addicts began serious discussions about forming this new group. Cy M., an early member, attended the first two meetings and Jimmy attended the third meeting of what can best be described as informal planning meetings.

Finally, on August 17, 1953 a groundbreaking meeting was held at the home of Frank and Doris C. in Burbank, who were both friends of Jimmy. The purpose of this meeting was to formally create a program for addicts. The result: Narcotics Anonymous, as we know it today. Jimmy would later speak about this meeting while sharing at the 20th anniversary dinner in 1973:

"One of the first things...when we sat together trying to iron out some of the things we wanted to do, we came to very simple ideas. Number one – we believed that this program of Twelve Steps would work for addicts.

Two, that the Traditions must be followed if we were to grow – grow as a fellowship that could stand on its own feet aside from and away from A.A. We could take our own place as a fellowship and not be dominated by or affiliated with anything or anybody else."

"The first order of business we had when we got together was the name. I was elected the chairperson of what we called...The San Fernando A.A. N.A. Group. I said, "You simply can't do that!" "And the committee vetoed everything I said the first night, so I thought I was off to a pretty good start."

Therefore, the next order of business was to contact Alcoholics Anonymous to find out if we could use their name; and found out that you couldn't do it. So I got the satisfaction, at least, of being right on the first thing they vetoed."

Jimmy K. wrote to the Alcoholics Anonymous General Service Office in New York and their response was swift as they clearly stated the fledgling group could not use the A.A. name. However, Alcoholics Anonymous did formally permit them to adapt the Twelve Steps *and* Traditions. A.A. approved the Traditions in 1950, although they were not widely used or accepted by A.A. members as of yet. The first edition of the A.A. book, *Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions* was published in April 1953. It was Jimmy who emphasized and insisted they needed the Twelve Traditions.

With this, the new group became known as Narcotics Anonymous. Jimmy was elected the chairperson. The new movement set an historical precedent by planning the creation of the Narcotics Anonymous program. Seven such planning meetings were held, culminating in the first recovery meeting.

"It was very hard to find a place to meet; after we got together and agreed what we were going to do. You couldn't find a hall to meet in. Nobody would allow us in. They didn't trust us in any way, shape or form...eventually we did find a Salvation Army hall and they allowed us to use it for five dollars a month."

THE SAN FERNANDO DAD'S CLUB – MEETING #1

On October 5, 1953, the first Narcotics Anonymous recovery meeting was held at the Dad's Club at 10803 Cantara Street located on the corner of Cantara & Clybourn in the San Fernando Valley, just outside Los Angeles. There were seventeen in attendance at this inaugural meeting.

NARCOTICS ANONYMOUS – OUR PURPOSE

"This is an informal group of drug addicts, banded together to help one another to renew their strength in remaining free of drug addiction. Our precepts are patterned after those of Alcoholics Anonymous to whom all credit is given and precedence is acknowledged. We claim no originality but since we believe that the causes of alcoholism and addiction are basically the same, we will apply to our lives the truths and principles, which have benefited so many otherwise helpless individuals. We believe that in so doing we may regain and maintain our health and sanity. It shall be the purpose of this group to endeavor to foster a means of rehabilitation to the addict, and to carry the message of hope for the future to those who have become enslaved by the use of habit-forming drugs."

STARTING MONDAY NIGHT OCT. 5, 1953
EACH MONDAY NIGHT THEREAFTER AT 5:30 P.M.
CORNER OF CANTARA & CLYBOURN, SUN VALLEY, CALIFORNIA
DIRECTLY BEHIND SUNLAND LUMBER COMPANY

There were few newcomers in those first meetings due to their fears of being arrested. Jimmy went on to speak about the experience:

"I made a sign and we put it outside of the front door that said "N.A. Meeting tonight at 8:30" and then we opened the front door for business and we would get a dozen or so… came to help us. And then a car would pull down around the corner slowly and they'd look at the sign and they'd split. Nobody trusted anybody – you know they thought it was staked out. They wouldn't believe us when we told them there was no surveillance. And we weren't just too sure in the beginning ourselves."

LAPD NARCOTICS DIVISION

Five of the original members decided to have a meeting with the police, so they went down to meet with the L.A. Police Department Narcotics Division. The early founders had to make it known police interference could not be tolerated; they knew it would be detrimental if word got out on the streets and caused addicts to stay away from their fledgling meeting.

"We told them, we didn't ask them, and we're going to have a meeting of addicts. And they raised their eyebrows a little bit when we first mentioned it." The officer (Lt. Miller) listened and then he said "It's about time something like this happened, I have been trying to help addicts for years and with no success, I can't help anybody." He would listen and his responses were very supportive…all the way down the line he was all for us; he kept his word by the way.

"He called in another lieutenant to listen in on the conversation and see what he thought. He was a hard-nosed, old style, hope-to-die cop who knew for sure that none of us could recover. Lt. Miller asked him what he thought: "Ain't gonna work, once a junkie always a junkie...there's never any of them gonna get any better. I don't care what you say, I don't care what these people say, and it ain't gonna work!"

They looked at each other, not knowing what to say and then "Old Pat" spoke up:

"Lieutenant, my name is...I was raised in...I got arrested for the first time for...I was sentenced to...and starting there I want you to go back and check my record all the way through. I have been in every Federal Penitentiary except Danamora in the country. I haven't had a bit of junk...this program works for me. Now you look it up and prove it to yourself because I was never out of jail from the time I was a kid until the time I found this program."

"Whether the guy ever checked it out, I don't know, but I know that the police department and the Narcotics Division kept their word to us. And they never staked us out, they never busted us in any way shape or form, never rousted us coming or going to meetings."

The original group continued to meet at the Dad's Club until the next year. The Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions were adopted for Narcotics Anonymous and changed to reflect this new movement. They were the same then as they remain today. These historic changes imparted clear differences to the steps used by other movements. The word "we" was added to each of the steps; the word alcohol was not changed to drugs, but changed instead to read, "addict and addiction." This created an entire change of orientation away from a specific substance or symptom to one of behavior and specific disease.

There was one meeting held openly and scheduled regularly. Other meetings were held which reflected the stigma of drug addiction in the 1950's; they became known as "rabbit meetings," as they would hop from place to place. Those early members would meet like this for years to come. Addicts would "cruise" the meeting places checking for surveillance.

"We never knew where we were going to meet. If there were five or six of us at the meeting tonight, we decided then whose apartment or house we would have the meeting in the next week. And you would take the cups, the sugar bowls and format with you, then we would meet at your place the next week."

Jimmy purchased a coffee pot and cups, which were passed around for the meetings at Dad's Club and the rabbit meetings. Some years later, he

discovered the ceramic green cups amongst many items he stored in his home. A handful of the green cups, along with the original by-laws, minutes, second-generation photocopies, and some rare photographs, comprise the few surviving items from that first historic meeting.

In 1954, a collection was taken up around the fellowship to send Jimmy K. to a seminar at the Lexington facility. Betty confirmed this interesting story during our interview. This possibly establishes at least one more tie between the California movement and Lexington and possibly the New York organization. No one can confirm the rumor that Jimmy met Danny Carlsen at this event.

The first piece of literature was written by Jimmy K., Cy M. and Jack P. in 1954 and later published. The booklet had a beige cover later called the *Buff (Brown) Book*; it resembled later versions of the *Little White Book*. It contained only eight small pages. It is also known today as the 1956 booklet. This small booklet contained a list of "20 Questions," and small chapters entitled, "What Can I Do About It?" and "What Is the Narcotics Anonymous Program?" Additionally, the Just for Today Prayer was included in this booklet. Few surviving original copies of this booklet exist.

JUST FOR TODAY 1956 version

Tell yourself:

JUST FOR TODAY my thoughts will be on my recovery, living and enjoying life without the use of narcotics.

JUST FOR TODAY I will have faith in someone in Narcotics Anonymous who believes in me and wants to help me to recovery.

JUST FOR TODAY I will have a program. I will try to follow it to the best of my ability.

JUST FOR TODAY, through Narcotics Anonymous, I will try to get a better perspective on my life.

JUST FOR TODAY I will be unafraid. My thoughts will be on my new associations, people who are not using and who have found a new way of life. So long as I follow that way of life, even for today, I have nothing to fear.

The language used in the adapted Twelve Steps became the basis of the Narcotics Anonymous program. The influence of the words, "we," "addiction," and "addict," clearly dissociated N.A. from A.A. and similar twelve step programs. One of the oddities that stand out in the booklet is the

phrase "an honest and sincere desire to stop using." Clearly, times were different then; this seems to be one of the obvious written deviations from the Twelve Traditions.

NORTH HOLLYWOOD INEBRIATE ASYLUM

From 1954 to 1959, there existed only one regularly scheduled meeting and various "rabbit meetings" taking place in member homes. The regular meeting was held at a facility known as Shier's Dryer, a detoxification center run by Dr. Shier. Its official name was the North Hollywood Inebriate Asylum.

Cy M. had a strong personality that enabled him to become the de facto leader of the group. One of Betty's comments was that Jimmy and Cy "never saw eye-to-eye." Cy's influence was felt almost immediately, as all the original members resigned their roles in the group by the end of 1953. The meeting was moved to the North Hollywood Inebriate Asylum from its original location at the Dad's Club.

In a 1984 taped interview, Jimmy stated that he stayed involved with the group but only in a peripheral role. He brought newcomers to the meeting at the asylum from time to time and continued to participate in the rabbit meetings, including ones held in his brother's home.

In later years, the meeting at Dr. Shier's was moved to another facility located on Ventura Boulevard while the Shier residence was being renovated. Once the upgrades were completed, the meeting remained at the Ventura location and was led by Scott K., who was sponsored by Cy. The group was not self-supporting, as the facility supplied the meeting space and refreshments for the group at no charge. A second meeting was started at the newly renovated asylum; Cy led this group.

By 1959, the meeting was dwindling because of a number of issues that had arisen during the years from 1954 to 1959. Members at times could not distinguish whether they were attending an A.A. meeting or an N.A. meeting. When the meeting started, there would be a show of hands to determine if there were more alcoholics in attendance than addicts; if so, the group adopted an A.A. format, and vice-versa. Others report that Cy would put individuals on the "hot seat" during the meetings. This was a practice used later by the therapeutic community Synanon. Some members began to relapse, it was harder to find newcomers, and the few regulars began to have personality conflicts.

There is a story in our basic text, *Narcotics Anonymous*, entitled "I Found the Only N.A. Meeting in the World." This is the story of Bob B.; the title refers to his attendance at the early Shier's meeting. Though Bob admitted that his wife actually found the meeting, she strongly recommended that he attend, and he did, simply to appease her request. Bob relapsed and continued to use for several more years.

Cy M. and another member appeared on a television interview; this disturbed Jimmy, as he believed the other member might have been "loaded" at the time. Additionally, this was an obvious violation of tradition. This event caused a great deal of controversy. The remaining meeting folded in either late September or October: Narcotics Anonymous died!

For several months, there existed no Narcotics Anonymous meetings. Jimmy witnessed the California movement as well as the early version of N.A. in New York. He quickly associated the need for the Traditions. There was no need for any "big shots in N.A."

It was Jimmy K., along with his friends Sylvia W. and Penny K., who planned to resuscitate Narcotics Anonymous, and this time they were resolute that they would follow the N.A. Twelve Traditions.

LITTLE CHAIRS TO MANHATTAN BEACH

In late 1959, Narcotics Anonymous was restarted. The meeting that was formerly held at the North Hollywood center was moved to the church on the corner of Rhoades & Moorpark in Studio City. This newly rebuilt meeting had humble beginnings; they first met in the Sunday school room with small tables and chairs – referred to by some as the Little Chairs meeting. Later they moved downstairs to a more suitable meeting room. This rebirth took hold and the movement began to grow. Again, there were several rabbit meetings and one regular meeting, but this time, members were resolved to strictly following the Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions.

The meeting at Rhoades and Moorpark functioned as Jimmy's home group. Later the group adopted "Architects of Adversity" as their group moniker.

DR. VOGEL AGAIN

In 1961, the California Rehabilitation Center came into being, known to many as CRC. The first director of the newly opened state-sponsored center was Dr. Victor Vogel, the same Dr. Vogel who was instrumental in the birth of the NARCO group back in Lexington in 1947. The NARCO group was the very first twelve-step meeting oriented specifically for addicts. With the support of Dr. Vogel, CRC became the site of the first institutional meeting held by the California movement of Narcotics Anonymous.

Shortly after the opening of CRC, another facility was opened nearby for women. Combined, these two facilities would welcome a stream of newcomers into the newly reorganized fellowship and for decades to follow. Again, Dr. Vogel played another vital role in laying the groundwork for addicts to recover through the twelve steps. His definition of the nature of addiction was used in the opening paragraph of this book.

P.O. BOX 622

At the end of 1962, Jimmy K. rented a Post Office Box – number 622 – at a small depot in Sun Valley. This was the only address "old-timers" still around today had for Narcotics Anonymous until the early 1980's. He listed Narcotics Anonymous in a local phone book, creating the first answering service enabling addicts to find the fellowship. Also in 1961, the 1954-56 buff-cover booklet was reprinted with a white cover thus becoming the *Little White Book*, though the authors had yet to revise its contents.

There were two regularly scheduled open meetings – the first at the Unity Church in Studio City on Friday nights and another at St. Stephen's Church on Thursday nights. By the end of 1963, a meeting in downtown Los Angeles began and another at the home of Bill B. in the San Fernando Valley.

Bob B., who had attended a meeting in 1959, was incarcerated at Tehachapi State Prison. He was released in 1961 only to end up back in prison shortly thereafter. Jimmy K. stayed in touch with Bob while he was in prison. Bob even started a meeting while locked up. He was released in 1963 and immediately became involved in N.A.

Chuck S. had attended the 1959 meeting years earlier while he was still using. By now, he was attending A.A. meetings, but was not completely comfortable in that fellowship. Chuck and his friend Jack W. decided to start an N.A. meeting in Manhattan Beach. This meeting remains the longest ongoing meeting in the entire fellowship; it continues to meet at the Trinity Lutheran Church at 11th & Roswell as it has for over four decades.

THE LITTLE WHITE BOOK & BOARD OF TRUSTEES

By the end of 1963, Jimmy K., who had experienced the fellowship coming to an end in 1959, became concerned about the rapid resurgence of the N.A. program and wanted to ensure its survival. Through the existing groups, a loosely knit Board of Trustees was established to become guardians of the N.A. Traditions. Their main purpose was to insure that Narcotics Anonymous would follow the Twelve Traditions so that the fellowship would not die again. These were the informal but significant beginnings of a service structure.

In 1960, Jimmy and his close friend Sylvia W. began to write

down their thoughts. From those journals, Jimmy K. wrote, "What Can I Do?" "Another Look," "Who Is An Addict?", and the paragraphs included with the steps in "How It Works." Together, Jimmy and Sylvia wrote, "What Is the N.A. Program," and "Why Are We Here?"

With these initial pieces complete, the newly organized Board of Trustees met to select the personal stories that would be included in the next edition of the *Little White Book*. After much discussion, two new sections were selected for inclusion in the upcoming edition: "Recovery and Relapse" and "We Do Recover," written by Jimmy K.

Additionally, five stories submitted by members were also selected for inclusion: "One Third Of My Life," by Phil P., "I Can't Do It Anymore," by Penny K., "The Vicious Circle," by Gene H., "One Woman's Story," by Betty G., and "Something Meaningful," by Bob B. Bob B. later rewrote his story for the basic text under the title, "I Found The Only N.A. Meeting In The World." "One Woman's Story" was later removed when Betty G. relapsed.

SAN FRANCISCO & WALLA WALLA PRISON

In 1965, many of the early pioneers from Southern California moved north to work at the Addiction Center, or ADD Center, sponsored by the University of California at Berkley. These individuals were the founding members of the Northern California fellowship. Sylvia and her brothers Scott and Richard, along with Russ and others including Penny K., followed later. They formed a strong base for a quickly developing fellowship.

In 1966, the *Little White Book* was published with the stories enclosed. This edition played a role in the first meeting held in Florida a few years later as well as the fellowship then in its infancy in Northern California.

A member named Les traveled frequently on business; on one such trip to the State of Washington, he visited Walla Walla State Prison in 1962. The prison officials were apparently impressed enough to allow prisoners to begin an N.A. meeting of their own at the institution. One of the inmates who attended was Henry S., a man who eventually made his way to N.A. again in Miami and settled finally in St. Petersburg, Florida. The meeting at Walla Walla was one of the first outside of California. The inmates ran it themselves, although prison personnel monitored the meeting. N.A. meetings have continued to this day at Walla Walla.

A Fellowship with a Vision

"A fellowship without a vision is a farce."

Jimmy K.

"ANOTHER LOOK"

Jimmy K authored the first I.P. – Another Look. It has remained in use since it was distributed around to groups in 1967. It was published in *The Voice* in 1968 and later as an I.P in the seventies. Another Look is still on literature racks today.

THE VOICE

In early 1968, *The Voice*, the first N.A. newsletter was printed. There is one simple line in the first edition, which many believe refers to the other movements and the earlier existence of N.A. "...west of the Rockies, (which) started with one group in Sun Valley."

This was the first public confirmation of the earlier version of N.A. in New York. *The Voice* became a valuable tool for communication within the fellowship, especially since there was a general lack of written materials available in N.A. at the time. Later, newsletters would be used extensively by developing fellowships to communicate information on upcoming events and to pass along personal experiences in the form of stories. These were used in the formulation of N.A. literature late into the next decade.

THE PARENT GENERAL SERVICE ORGANIZATION

By 1968, over a dozen meetings had come into existence. Jimmy and his close friend Bill B. got together at Bill's barbershop and held ongoing discussions resulting in the creation of a service structure. From these meetings, they formed the Parent General Service Organization. In effect, this was the first committee that was representative of the fellowship, a precursor of Area, Regional and World Service Committees.

On May 20, 1968, a new Board of Trustees consisting of four dedicated members signed a trust agreement: Jimmy K., of course, and his friend Bill B., along with Jack W. and Bob B. Two other members, Chuck S. and Gene H. were added to the board shortly thereafter. The board then began the process of assembling group representatives.

TRUST AGREEMENT

We the undersigned, appointed and approved as members of the GENERAL SERVICE BOARD OF TRUSTEES by duly elected representatives of the Fellowship of NARCOTICS ANONYMOUS do accept that trust placed in us.

We hereby will act in that capacity to the best of our abilities and act at all times to carry out the purpose of our society, in the light of our own conscience and that of the fellowship.

We will guard and preserve our Traditions and implement and enlarge our General Services to better carry our message. We will oversee all services and use all funds, entrusted to us, prudently and wisely for the growth and betterment of all.

To be aware in the course of our duties of the need for a truly democratic balance of power, since excessive power in any one arm of service may undermine the whole.

The Board of Trustees then met with Group Service Representatives each month to discuss issues relative to the times.

THE N.A. SYMBOL

Later that year, Jimmy K., who suffered from tuberculosis, had another bout with this disease and required hospitalization. Jimmy remained active in the program even while fighting this illness in the hospital; he designed the N.A. symbol on a napkin. The importance and philosophical significance of his design has only increased over the years.

"Simplicity is the keynote of our symbol; it follows the simplicity of our Fellowship. We could find all sorts of occult and esoteric connotations in the simple outlines, but foremost in our minds were easily understood meanings and relationships.

"The outer circle denotes a universal and total program that has room within for all manifestations of the recovering and wholly recovered person. The square, whose lines are defined, is easily seen and understood; but there are other unseen parts of the symbol.

"The square base denotes Goodwill, the ground of both the fellowship and the member of our society. Actually, it is the four pyramid sides which rise from this base in a three-dimensional figure that are the Self, Society, Service and God. All rise to the point of Freedom.

"All parts thus far are closely related to the needs and aims of the addict seeking recovery and the purpose of the fellowship seeking to make recovery

available to all. The greater the base, as we grow in unity in numbers and in fellowship, the broader the sides and the higher the point of freedom. Probably the last to be lost to freedom will be the stigma of being an addict.

"Goodwill is best exemplified in service and proper service is 'Doing the right thing for the right reason.' When this supports and motivates both the individual and the fellowship, we are fully whole and wholly free."

Jimmy continued to wage his battle with TB with repeated hospitalizations; it was during this time that Bob B. took over some of Jimmy's responsibilities. One of those urban legends heard in the rooms is that the World Service Office operated out the trunk of a car. This was somewhat true, as Bob B. would ride around to meetings, carrying the small stockpile of literature in his trunk. The trustees, committees and groups continued to meet monthly with Group Service Representatives.

At the end of the decade, word spread across the country about the California movement. Rumors began in California regarding meetings in Pennsylvania. Another such meeting was known to have existed in late 1969 until sometime in the early seventies in Key West, Florida.

THE FIRST "WORLD" CONVENTION

In 1970, the N.A. program started with much uncertainty following a decade that included the assassination of three American icons – President John F. Kennedy, Robert F. Kennedy and Martin Luther King, and followed the Vietnam War era, which divided local communities. There were 25 meetings listed in this informal directory for both Northern and Southern California. The General Service Office that was envisioned and discussed extensively in the late '60s had not come into existence due to lack of funding.

In 1971, the Board of Trustees and group representatives continued to meet. They approved the inclusion of personal stories in the *Little White Book*. Mel H. suggested they hold a convention. Another idea which was discussed was that of holding a conference of sorts. After much deliberation, it was decided they would call it a convention for the entire fellowship. They hoped this event would raise enough funds for the fellowship office.

Around this time, several members began working in the treatment field. One treatment program was called Impact House, which consisted of homes used for residential treatment. One site was located in Sun Valley

and was headed by Bob B. He could not be there all the time, so a resident who was a virtual newcomer was put in charge. Ben W. would lead the facility for nearly a decade until he left to manage a hotel in Daytona Beach in late 1980. Ben W. started the first N.A. meetings in that city, which later became the third area to join the Florida Region Service Committee.

In November, the brainstormed convention became a reality. The First World Convention of Narcotics Anonymous was held at the Amerada Country Club in Southern California. Just under 200 people attended. The convention earned a grand total of $234 profit, falling short of their goal. Jimmy K. left his hospital bed to speak at the opening event. More importantly, this event would be the vehicle used for more than a decade by fellowships throughout the country to bring this young fellowship together and spread a message of recovery and hope.

A business meeting the second day of the event focused on establishing an office and hiring staff. Individual members made pledges to donate a certain amount each month, funds that never materialized in reality. At the end of the event, an updated meeting list had been gathered, listing a total of 38 meetings, including one in Denver, the only recorded meeting in existence outside California.

By year's end, Greg P., who was a relative newcomer at the time, was then selected to chair the General Service Organization. A protégé of Jimmy K., their friendship lasted nearly a decade. At the time, a significant amount of animosity had developed between the fellowships in Northern California and Southern California. Northern California had begun printing bootleg literature and meeting directories. This infringed upon the ability of the office to fund itself by copying and printing their own literature.

Despite little financial support, the office opened in January of 1972. Its home was a small storefront office located at 2355 Crenshaw Boulevard. Bob B. lived in an apartment upstairs in the same building.

Later that year, the second World Convention of Narcotics Anonymous was held at the American Legion Hall in North Hollywood, California. Fewer than 150 people attended this event. Again, it failed to raise any funds, another disappointment as a fund-raising event. In 1972, Jimmy K. wrote the Gratitude Prayer. Shortly thereafter, several meetings begin using it as their closing prayer.

By 1973, the Board of Trustees decided to hold a 20th anniversary dinner. The Third World Convention was scheduled to be held in San Jose, located in Northern California, so the dinner would serve as their premier

event that year. At that time, local committees ran the WCNA's, as there was no structure in place to manage this event. Therefore, the "bidding" for the following convention and all the planning and subsequent funding was handled independently of any existing service structure. It took on a life of its own and then took over a decade to begin to correct those procedures.

Discussion began regarding the need for additional literature. The Northern California fellowship had been working on a booklet for almost two years that they presented to the Board of Trustees. It was immediately rejected as a direct and heavily plagiarized version of A.A. material. This only fueled the rift between the Southern and Northern California fellowships, as members from Southern California dominated the Board of Trustees.

THE 20th ANNIVERSARY DINNER

On August 18th, the 20th anniversary of Narcotics Anonymous was celebrated at the Islander Restaurant on La Cienega Boulevard. Jimmy K. was the keynote speaker; he gave an account of the history of the fellowship from its inception. Jimmy had appeared at the convention despite being again hospitalized for tuberculosis; Bob B. picked him up and returned him to his sick bed after the speech. Attendance at that event was slightly larger than that at the previous World Convention.

By fall of 1973, the office was moved again, this time to 1246 North Highland Avenue, near Sunset Boulevard in Hollywood; this location was smaller and more affordable, with rent of $50.00 per month. It was renamed the World Service Office of Narcotics Anonymous.

In October, the Third World Convention of Narcotics Anonymous would take place in San Jose with about 300 in attendance. This time, a small profit, of just under $500 was earned. These monies were turned over to the World Service Office.

THE SAN FERNANDO VALLEY AREA

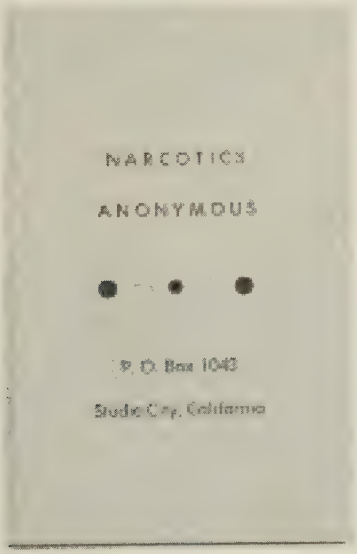
Greg P. presented an idea to several groups in the Valley. The groups liked it, so later become known as the San Fernando Valley Area Service Committee. A newsletter produced by the WSO spoke of the success of creating a formal gathering of groups; this created a new branch of service – the area service committee. The author, Bob B. spoke of other areas with similar interests that could benefit from this idea, such as those in San Francisco, San Jose, and Philadelphia.

In 1974, the Fourth World Convention was held again in Southern California at the Royal Inn, a property near Disney in Anaheim with 225 in attendance. The theme for this convention was "Just for Today." At the business meeting the next day, it was decided that the WSO should form a board of directors to oversee the office finances.

The decision was made to incorporate the World Service Office, and Jack B. was elected the first president of its board. Early in 1975, Jack B. moved the office to a space at the Suicide Prevention Center on Highland for $1.00 per month. That summer, the World Service Office moved to Jimmy K.'s home, where it would remain for the next several years.

The site of the Fifth World Convention was chosen; it would be held at the El Rancho Tropicana Motel in Santa Rosa. It was the only facility of its type in the country. It had two full football fields for use by its guests. The hotel also served as the training camp and home of the NFL's Oakland Raiders football team. This began a new era for the world convention. The next seven conventions were held at either once posh or unusual and quirky hotels. Just over 300 people attended, again earning a small profit for the fellowship of just over $500.

A new era was about to begin as the foundation of the fellowship continued to be built by the founding and early-dedicated members.



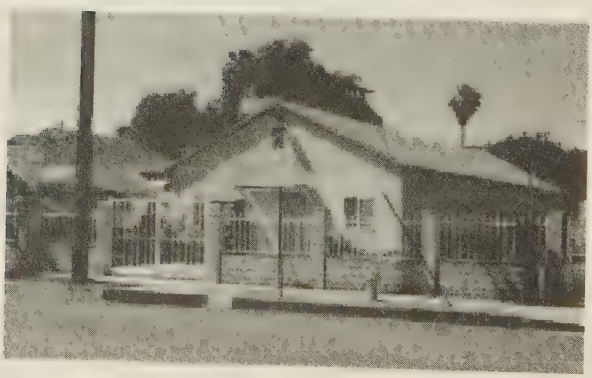
First piece of N.A. literature



Jimmy K. – Founding member of N.A. as we know it today



Original logo designed by Jimmy K.



Site of 1st recovery meeting – Cantara & Clybourne – Sun Valley, CA

Chapter Three

BEYOND SOUTHERN CALIFORNIA

FALSE STARTS

The '60s began with the rebirth of Narcotics Anonymous. The first meeting took place in Southern California at the church on Moorpark. A small, but stable fellowship began to develop; six meetings existed there by 1966. Later that year the first meeting in Northern California began in Berkeley, followed shortly by one in both San Francisco and San Jose. This marked the fellowship's first growth outside of Los Angeles. Meetings outside of California would crop up during the next several years.

For the most part, meetings would typically start and fold within a short period of time. While causes differed for these false starts, this trend would continue through the '70s.

In 1967, a short-lived meeting for those with drug problems began in Victoria, British Columbia. Only one addict stayed clean: James D. The next year James started the Victoria Group, best described as a rabbit meeting, like those that occurred in the early years in Los Angeles. The group ceased again in 1970, but James restarted it in 1972. In 1975, the group asked A.A. for permission to change their literature to reflect language that was more appropriate for addicts. A.A. cited copyright laws and their Twelve Traditions when they denied the request and courteously referred them to the World Service Office of Narcotics Anonymous.

It was not until 1976 that the Victoria Group had enough members to get a formal meeting place. While Jimmy K. was speaking at the annual anniversary banquet in Southern California, he noted, "I got a letter this afternoon from a man I have never met. He said, 'Please send us some more booklets right away.' He's starting another group in Victoria, British Columbia..." The Victoria Group of N.A. continued to meet weekly.

Halfway across the continent, a man named Jim N. found recovery in A.A. In early 1971, he started a Thursday-night N.A. meeting at St. John's Hospital in Salinas, Kansas. The Salinas meeting ceased after Jim moved to Iowa. In 1973, Jim started another small meeting in Cedar Falls, Iowa that lasted less than a year before Jim moved to Nebraska.

In May 1972, a letter was sent to the World Service Office from a member in Cleveland who informed them they received assistance from a member from San Francisco. They had two meetings a week and had written their own piece of literature they called "The Twelve Points."

These meetings may have had ties to the meetings held by the Salvation Army under the name N.A. in the '60s in Cleveland. At least one meeting continued until late 1970. Major Dimond (was a Captain in the sixties) was the head of the Salvation Army there. He was even invited to the International A.A. convention in 1970 to speak about their "version" of Narcotics Anonymous. Major Dimond could not attend the convention but sent Major Harry Davis in his place. The meeting began to fade when they moved out of the Salvation Army and into the Together Group, another organization that began offering similar social services as the Salvation Army along with more comprehensive medical examinations and treatments.

In the 1976 and 1979 World Directories, only one meeting was listed in Ohio. According to Ohio members from that era, there were no direct ties to the earlier meetings. That sole meeting precipitated from contact with the Pennsylvania fellowship.

Meetings were started at a prison in Waterloo, Michigan, most likely through a contact from San Francisco, and one began at another correctional facility in Ontario, Canada. Jimmy K. would soon speak about the Canadian meeting at a Hospital & Institutional Committee event in 1979. The inmates generally ran these types of meetings, sometimes with support from local A.A. members. Information about these meetings is sketchy at best, limited to one or two communiqués.

In 1971 at the first N.A. World Convention, a list of known meetings was announced; there were thirty-eight at the time. A Denver meeting was the only one listed outside of California. In the financial report given at the convention, there was a note regarding donations received from four meetings: Las Vegas and Reno, Nevada, Haley, Idaho, and Atlanta, Georgia. Information about the origins of these groups and their validity are non-existent other than personal, unsubstantiated recollections. If these meetings existed, they likely told another tale of short-lived false starts.

.As you will see in the chapter entitled "Florida – In the Beginning," there is a story of the first N.A. meeting ever held in Florida, a short-lived meeting in Key West.

DICK F. & ROY P.

There are several instances in our early history when the fellowship had extraordinary support from those Jimmy K. referred to as "our good friends in A.A." The following is one of the more remarkable

stories that resulted in the birth of Narcotics Anonymous on the East Coast.

In 1959 Dick F., an alcoholic, would find a new way of life in A.A. at the Philadelphia Young Men's Club, known for their rigorous, almost radical, hard-line approach to sobriety. Dick was committed to the A.A. approach and was constantly reaching out to other alcoholics. In November 1968, he received a call from Annette, a fellow A.A. member who had met a newcomer named Roy. Roy P. had just arrived from California. Dick thought this would be just another 12-step call. However, Annette informed him that Roy was a heroin addict. Dick was taught to "never say no," so he went on the call anyway. Dick initially disliked Roy on the grounds that he was a "junkie," but within a few minutes, Dick began to identify with Roy's feelings and his destructive way of life. Roy thus began attending A.A. meetings at the Young Men's Club and continued to stay clean with the support and friendship of Dick, who later, ironically, became his sponsor.

At that time, addicts were not allowed to speak or chair at some A.A. groups, while other groups would oust addicts completely from their meetings. At one meeting Roy was attending regularly, the members held a business meeting and banned his participation in their group since he was not an alcoholic, per se. Roy was in tears outside the meeting hall as he spoke with Dick about what transpired.

The exchange that followed dramatically altered Dick's perspective towards addicts. Dick suggested that Roy should have a few drinks and then he could qualify as a member of A.A. However, Roy's response was indisputable and persuasive. "If I begin to drink, I'll be back using heroin again." Dick then realized that alcohol, like heroin, was a drug. He defiantly escorted Roy back into the meeting.

After a few months, Roy planned a trip to California to visit his father and his friend Bob L., who had 12-stepped Roy in California. Before he left on his trip, Ray L., another friend at the Young Men's Club, heard about the California Narcotics Anonymous movement and suggested Roy contact them once he got there. While in California, Roy and Bob L. attended an A.A. convention, at which Roy met a couple who shared about Narcotics Anonymous and gave him a pamphlet called the *Little White Book.* Once he returned to Philadelphia, he showed it to Dick, and together they decided to print a thousand copies of the *Little White Book.*

EAGLEVILLE & WHITE DEER RUN

Shortly after the reprinting of N.A.'s sole piece of literature, Dick went to work as the Chief Counselor at Eagleville Hospital, located just outside Philadelphia. Eagleville opened in 1909 as a hospital for tuberculosis until the mid-'60s when it began treating alcoholics. Upon Dick's arrival, it opened its doors to drug addicts as well. Dick used the *Little White Book* as part of the literature handed out to the addicts in the program.

In the summer of 1969, Dick and Roy started the first N.A. meeting for the patients at that hospital. This meeting lasted only about six months, as Roy unfortunately relapsed and Dick was hired as the director of a new treatment center.

In December 1970, Dan and Mike S., brothers who had attended the N.A. meeting while at Eagleville Hospital, along with several other addicts, started the first open Narcotics Anonymous meeting at a local counseling center in Norristown, Pennsylvania. Dan and Mike started two more meetings in Montgomery County just outside Philadelphia. By June 1972, three more meetings began, two in Philadelphia and one just across the bridge in a New Jersey suburb. Some were short-lived, but other meetings began in their place. By the end of the year, there were eight meetings in and around Philadelphia.

Meanwhile, a new center opened called White Deer Run. It was located in rural Central Pennsylvania on a mountaintop overlooking Allenwood Federal Prison, infamous for its country club atmosphere, and the facility where principals of the Watergate debacle were imprisoned in the late '70s. Ironically, both Eagleville and White Deer Run initially served as tuberculosis treatment centers, a disease for which Jimmy K. suffered from for much of his life.

Because of Dick's experience with Roy, he was resolute that his treatment program would adhere to the "concept of total abstinence" found in the *Little White Book*. A handmade poster was hung near the entryway to the building that read: "Alcohol Is a Drug." Dick established an admission policy that was open to addicts.

The *Little White Book* was part of the literature package given to patients. "Compliments of White Deer Run" was imprinted on the back cover, a practice that continued until the end of the decade.

Dick asked N.A. members from Philadelphia to assist him in starting "drug" meetings at the facility, which sometimes Dick at times ran

by himself. Incorporating parts of two therapeutic regimens into one program created a new era of drug addiction treatment: the 12-step model initiated by Hazelden and the therapeutic community environment and originated at Synanon years earlier.

Dick, unyielding in his position that White Deer Run maintain a drug-free environment, instituted a strict drug-testing policy. Patients, visitors, staff, even speakers at the A.A. and N.A. meetings, were required to participate.

Patients leaving White Deer Run began to relocate in a network of informal "three-quarter houses" in surrounding rural towns. Addicts rapidly overran the local A.A. meetings and thus animosity ensued.

THE PENNSYLVANIA STORY

Something had to be done to alleviate the on-going hullabaloo caused by all the addicts attending A.A. meetings. A solution arrived by year's end in 1971. The N.A. meetings in essence were moved outside of White Deer Run. On the last Tuesday of January, Don L., simply using the most appropriate name he could think of at the time, started a meeting for addicts at St. Lewis Church in nearby Lewisburg. It was called Drug Abusers Anonymous. In September, another meeting began a few miles to the north at Divine Providence Hospital in Williamsport. A few months later, these groups contacted the World Service Office in California and became registered as official Narcotics Anonymous groups. The meeting at Divine Providence Hospital still meets each Friday. The Lewisburg meeting ceased in 1975, but was started again in 1978 and continues to meet today.

One oddity about the two groups was their adoption of the drug-testing policy used by White Deer Run. This was intended to ensure their members were actually clean. In effect, these meetings functioned like institutional meetings, though they were held on the outside. The drug-testing policy was the source of a division between them and the Philadelphia fellowship until the policy was revised.

The fellowship quickly expanded in both Philadelphia and Central Pennsylvania. By April 1973, Philadelphia had adopted similar by-laws to those used by the Parent General Service Organization in California. They established the earliest version of a service structure on their own. The "Intergroup" got a hotline in full swing, meeting schedules printed, social activities and raffles were held, a newsletter published, N.A. literature was

copied and they even published their own version of the A.A. 20 *Questions* leaflet.

In 1976, the Philadelphia committee adopted the service structure outlined in the *N.A. Tree*, the original service manual and a regional service committee was formed. However, as late as 1978, "The group of meetings established in this area, known to members as "the region..." functioned more like a large area service committee. There were no specific area committees, nor Area representatives; each G.S.R. attended these early regional meetings. Ray D. attended the World Service Conference in 1978, becoming the first formally elected regional service representative from the East Coast. Near the end of the '70s, the Pennsylvania fellowship had grown to nearly fifty meetings in and around Philadelphia, Pittsburgh, Harrisburg, Scranton and Williamsport.

In the decade since Dick started that first meeting, both Eagleville and White Deer Run attracted patients from up and down the eastern seaboard. They sent nearly 4,000 addicts back into their respective communities carrying their *Little White Book* and a message of N.A. in the northeast and beyond.

Near the end of 1978 and early into the following year, Dick left White Deer Run. This was just after the Three Mile Island nuclear disaster occurred in nearby Harrisburg. Meanwhile, unemployment skyrocketed in Pennsylvania due to the decline of the steel industry. Yet, a new era of air travel afforded virtually anyone with even minimal means to relocate at will. Therefore, over the next few years, local members began to migrate elsewhere, with South Florida becoming the destination of choice. Dennis P., Rich V. and his brother Jeff, and John F. headed south. Blaine, Jean, Brett, Jeff and Bob G. followed them. Nearly thirty N.A. members from Pennsylvania moved to Florida within the next few years.

It took just one *Little White Book* and a good friend from A.A. who believed the twelve steps would work for addicts. In the book, *My Years with Narcotics Anonymous*, the author pointed out how "Dick F. became the father of Narcotics Anonymous in Pennsylvania as well as much of the eastern fellowship." Dick became the modern day Houston S. Yet he was unaware of his impact and his place in our history.

THE PEACH STATE & THE GREAT PLAINS

The old saying, "three is a charm," was never more true than in 1974 when Jim N., after starting meetings in Salinas, Kansas, and Cedar

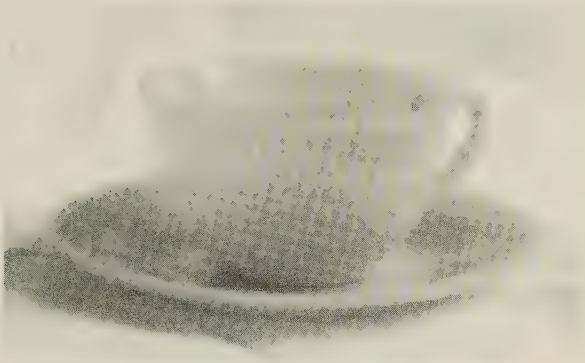
Falls, Iowa, started his third in as many years. Jim was now living in Lincoln, Nebraska. Moreover, this time N.A. was here to stay, as the new meeting would take hold and he found others to play an active role. By 1976, the group started a second meeting, and the new mid-western fellowship quickly spread to other cities. Again with Jim's help, meetings cropped up in York and Omaha, Nebraska.

Cindy D. would begin her recovery in Lincoln, but shortly after, she moved to Topeka, in early 1977. She found a few other addicts and together they started a meeting in February of that year. In rapid succession, several more meetings followed, and a local fellowship was born. Meanwhile, just across the Mississippi River, another meeting started in Waterloo, Iowa, and others followed. By the end of the decade, the fellowship in the Great Plains states – Nebraska, Iowa, Kansas and Oklahoma – had grown to over thirty meetings, forming the foundation for the second fellowship east of the Rockies.

During July 1972, in Atlanta, Georgia, Pat H. found hope through Alcoholics Anonymous, kicking a heroin habit at age 19 and later accepting a job at Charter Peachford Hospital. One day in 1974, an A.A. member approached her and said, "Why don't you help get these addicts out of A.A.? You've heard about Narcotics Anonymous, haven't you? They're in California." So Pat contacted the only drug program she was aware of in California – Synanon – and spoke with Chuck Dederich, their founder, who referred her to the World Service Office. She called and left a message but never received a response. Through a close friend, Pat got in contact with Jim P., a founding N.A member in Dallas. Jim wrote her back and included some bootleg copies of the *Little White Book*.

The New Connections Group in Atlanta started on August 24, 1974, and continues to meet today. Pat sought out other addicts in A.A. Among those, she would find were Cecil L., and Bo S., who later became instrumental in the literature movement responsible for the Basic Text. Narcotics Anonymous grew rapidly in and around Atlanta, which held a prominent role in the growth of the fellowship throughout the South. Prior to the eighth World Convention, the fellowship in Atlanta had grown to more than ten meetings and its representatives in that city decided to submit a bid for the next convention. Pat and Bo led a bid committee that succeeded in their quest to become the host city for the ninth World Convention. By the time of the convention, the host city offered twenty meetings, thus becoming the third fellowship east of the Rockies.

Prior to that convention, the Milwaukee, Houston, and Twin Cities (Minneapolis and St. Paul) fellowships were the only other cities that had developed enough to be considered a fourth fellowship. Atlanta and Wichita would serve as the host of the next two world conventions. In 1980, the Central Pennsylvania fellowship hosted the first East Coast Convention, since few actual regional service committees existed at this time, this event acted as the first regional-like convention held on the East Coast. Each of these three conventions played a pivotal role in the early development of the Florida fellowship.



Coffee cups used in early meetings



"The Mother Group" – Rhoades & Moorpark – Studio City, CA



Dick F. – "The Father of N.A. on the East Coast"



Ed Dimond – Salvation Army – Cleveland, OH



Site of 2nd World Convention – N. Hollywood American Legion Hall

NARCOTICS ANONYMOUS

P. O. Box 622
Sun Valley
California
HO 3-3123

September 20, 1971

Dear Friends:

This letter is your invitation to a Narcotics Anonymous Conference to be held on the weekend of November 5 - 7 at the La Mirada Country Club in La Mirada, a suburb of southeastern Greater Los Angeles. This Conference is not limited to N.A. members; all those interested in Narcotics Anonymous, or wishing to learn more about our N.A. recovery program, are cordially invited to attend.

In addition to an offical business meeting for delegates from all N.A. groups, we will have speaker and participation meetings, general discussion sessions, a banquet, and sufficient free time for those who wish to visit Disneyland, Knotts' Berry Farm, or other nearby attractions. Come and bring your friends.

The principal purpose of this Conference, however, is to get together delegates from N.A. groups in all localities (both in the U.S. and in other countries) to establish an N.A. World Central Office and elect a paid, full-time business manager to be in charge of this office. The formation of a central office and the election of its manager by representatives of N.A. as a whole (rather than by members from any one region) were so voted by the Board of Trustees of Narcotics Anonymous at the July 23, 1971 Trustees' meeting.

We feel that such a World Central Office will do a great deal toward solving the communication problems that have arisen in N.A. during its recent period of rapid growth. We want to be sure that the experience, strength, and hope developed over the years in the many areas where N.A. has been effective are made available to new groups everywhere. We want to be sure that requests for N.A. literature and for information about our fellowship are answered promptly and accurately.

However, we're not inviting you to just a business meeting, important though the business may be. This will be the first conference given for Narcotics Anonymous as a whole, and we'll have various types of meetings, socializing, and lots of fellowship. So please plan to attend - the more the better.

Pre-registration forms are included with this letter. Please let us know if you are planning to attend. If you need additional registration forms, or if you would like more information about the Conference, just write to the address on this letter (preferably to "Attn: Conference Committee.")

We look forward to seeing you in November. Yours in fellowship,

Narcotics Anonymous Board of Trustees

THE CALIFORNIA CONFERENCE & THE NA TREE

The Board of Trustees adopted *The Tree* as a part of N.A. literature in early 1976. Several hundred copies were sent out to the fellowship. The manual immediately received ample attention, and trepidation arose precipitating much disagreement. Greg P., with Jimmy's input, wrote this initial service manual. Most of the concern revolved around the structure of the three branches of world services: the WSO, the Board of Trustees and the proposed World Service Conference. Chuck S., a long-term Trustee speaking at a Board Meeting during WCNA-12 in Milwaukee stated, "The adoption of *The Tree* was a blunder."

A California Service Conference was planned for March of that year in San Luis Obispo, located on the Central California coast, thus maximizing participation from both the Southern and Northern California fellowships. Many of the issues talked about at this conference turned out to be far more significant to our history:

♦ The participants decided that the first World Service Conference should be held concurrent with the sixth World Convention in Ventura in November.

♦ The World Service Office move to Jimmy's house was met with approval. Getting the office incorporated was a primary concern.

♦ New literature written by Jimmy K. and Greg P. (also of Southern California at that time) was presented. The package was distributed to the participants for fellowship approval at the upcoming conference in November. The new literature were one-page pamphlets that could be reasonably priced. These cleanly designed leaflets were known as Informational Pamphlets or IP's. Included in the package was: Who, What, How and Why, The Group, and Another Look. Another pamphlet was written by Greg's wife Lois entitled, "So You Love An Addict." The latter I.P. was withdrawn in later years as an endorsement of the outside fellowship Nar-Anon.

♦ The Little White Book was updated. Three stories were added: "I Was Different," by Greg P., "Fearful Mother" by Betty K., Jimmy's wife, and "Fat Addict," written by Bill B.

♦ The group conferred and reached a consensus to establish a literature committee as a sub-committee of the conference. Clearly, the participants felt there was a need for more literature.

♦ Participants were persuasively encouraged by Jimmy and Greg to implement the structure outlined in The Tree.

♦ Jimmy asked for updated registration forms so the office would have current and accurate meeting information.

Regardless of the inherent confusion about World Services in *The Tree*, the manual and this conference laid the groundwork for the next few years. Area Service Committees were being established and they were evolving rapidly, beginning the process of accepting responsibility for the provision of their own services.

Shortly after the San Luis Obispo conference and as a result of the dissemination of *The Tree*, a newfound spark was becoming evident in the form of service in both Northern and Southern California. Public relations activities, as they were called, were flowing, increasing incoming calls to hotlines, and the Northern California and Pennsylvania fellowships began discussions about reorganizing their respective structures to fit into the new plan laid out in *The Tree.*

For years, Northern Californians had been using A.A. literature in their meetings and they finally ceased purchasing anything that was not N.A. approved. They recognized the former practice as a violation of the Traditions. The need for more N.A. literature became evident.

THE FIRST WORLD DIRECTORY – 200 MEETINGS?

Greg P. and Jimmy K. decided in April that they needed a World Directory of meetings, and Betty K. was soon enlisted to perform this task. She even took typing lessons to aid her with this project. It was tedious process. A letter was written to all known meetings asking them for updated information. The mailing of this initial letter was tiresome. The handwriting on many of the registration forms was illegible, and some addresses were found written on note pads that Jimmy used while on the phone with members. Further complicating the process, some older records were lost in the moves between the Highland addresses and Jimmy's house.

Nevertheless, the letter generated responses from across the country. Betty was thorough in her efforts to complete this project in a timely fashion, and by the end of October, she began typing this revised World Directory in preparation for the World Convention in Ventura. The copies had to be collated; stacks were spread around the office and into the kitchen and living room. Jimmy and Betty compiled the directory by hand, one entry at a time. They would walk through the house placing collated stacks into a complete package, then tack on the bright yellow cover on top and staple the package together.

A total of 224 meetings were listed in this new directory, with 83 in California, 125 in the remaining states, and 16 more in far away

Australia. Many of the meetings listed in the early directories would be considered Hospital & Institution meetings by later standards. At least 50 meetings were held in prisons, recovery houses or other institutions without any outside participation or support.

Communication with groups outside California was periodic and problematic, according to many who attempted to reach the World Service Office, as several meetings listed in the directory had moved or folded by the time the directory was printed. In 1996, the Fellowship Office in Australia published a booklet entitled, *Recovery Down Under – A Brief History of Narcotics Anonymous in Australia.* In hindsight, it appears that the 16 meetings in the directory were a compilation of all known meetings that had existed over an extended period of time in Australia. The book notes, "There were 13 meetings by the end of 1976."

In Florida, there were six listings, although, as we know today, only three of these were active meetings, and one would have been considered a Hospital and Institution meeting. After exhaustive and fruitful research, we were able to find out about each of these meetings.

1976 WORLD DIRECTORY – FLORIDA

The directory consisted of less than 200 meetings worldwide. The following is a list of meetings from Florida.

DELRAY BEACH - UNITY GROUP -
N.W. 22nd St. & Swinton Ave. 33444 - Thursday - 7:00p.m.
Bruce W., 322 N.E. 8th Ave - Ph. (305)-276-0548

CORAL GABLES - 4621 Lejeune Rd. 34406 - 305-442-9055 - Tue. O/C (Agape Club) - Richard S. - (305)-822-0461

WEST PALM BEACH
Mainline Group Detox. Center. - 317 Lakeside Ct. - Tue. & Sat.
Micheal B. - 418 Fern St. - W.P.B. 33401 - 305-833-1113

NORTH MIAMI - BRIDGE GROUP. 13140 N.W. 7th Avenue 33054.
Check with Secretary for meeting time. 305-758-5830
Shelley L. - 10950 N.W. 14th Ave. 33167 - Apt. 13F

TAMPA - Contact Fred K. - 610 S. Newport Ave. 33606 - 813-258-6671

COPELAND - Inst. Mtg. - Friday 7:30p.m. - PO Box 97 - Copeland, FL
(Check with captain for rules.)

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The initial directory as well as subsequent editions may have included some unintended errors or misinformation. Still, it was clear the fellowship was growing beyond California, though the content of the directory may not have reflected that reality. The number of active meetings available to any addict could have been only half of those listed in the directory.

Nonetheless, in the five years since the first list was compiled, N.A. had multiplied from thirty meetings to more than a hundred that were open to any addict. We were just getting started!

THE WORLD SERVICE CONFERENCE

In November 1976, the sixth World Convention of Narcotics Anonymous was held at the Holiday Inn in Ventura with nearly 400 people in attendance. The convention made a net profit of $1,500. At that time, this was considered a massive amount of money.

The first World Service Conference was held on the Saturday at the convention. The discussion at this initial conference centered on *The Tree*, which remained a source of controversy for years to come. The most contentious part of the manual addressed the World Service Office and its relationship to the conference and Board of Trustees.

The Tree was not approved at this conference, although the Board of Trustees had approved it earlier in the year and then widely distributed it. In the book *My Years with Narcotics Anonymous*, the author, Bob Stone wrote, "Because it [*The Tree*] was so confusing, it quickly brought out a body of detractors that never seemed to go away."

Since getting addicts to follow procedures could at times be an unwieldy task, Jimmy had the forethought to hire a parliamentarian to assist in managing the proceedings at the conference. Bob Stone, a non-addict referred to Jimmy through a mutual acquaintance, would fulfill this position for years to come. In an ironic twist of fate, Bob would later take over Jimmy's role as the manager of the World Service Office, becoming an integral part of the service structure for over a decade.

Following the conference, Northern California formed their regional service committee and was beginning to talk about opening its own office. Philadelphia formed a regional service committee shortly thereafter, using the newly distributed service manual, *The Tree*. This effort united the groups throughout Eastern Pennsylvania.

In January 1977, another piece of the foundation was put in place when the World Service Office and C.A.R.E.N.A., the publishing arm of the WSO, were incorporated. Jimmy continued as the office manager, handling the daily affairs. He was now mailing a dozen packages per day and answered all the phones himself.

There was much excitement about the upcoming convention, as service activity increased throughout California and communication between the WSO and fledgling N.A. communities around the country had improved, though still not to a point where all parties agreed. Certainly, the office moving to Jimmy's house enabled him to become fully committed to the WSO.

SAN FRANCISCO

Later that year, in October, the seventh World Convention of Narcotics Anonymous took place at the Jack Tar Hotel in San Francisco. It is now known as the Cathedral Hill Hotel, though "locals still refer to it as the Jack Tar."

"Now We Are Thousands" was the theme, declaring the fellowship had grown significantly, though the registered attendance exceeded just 600. Accounts of the actual numbers varied widely, with some having claimed attendance actually in excess of 1,000. This was most likely wishful thinking, according to Chuck S. Many of the attendees were actually patients from treatment centers that were bused in from local facilities.

The past several conventions were held at the same hotel as A.A.'s California Young People's convention, but a week apart. The N.A. convention would alternate between Southern and Northern California each year. This was believed to be a way to attract people to Narcotics Anonymous. Once the convention left California, this premise would be proven incorrect. In actuality, it revealed a dependence on A.A. that existed in those days, as most members participated in both fellowships.

Bo S., from Marietta, Georgia, would attend this convention. He was interested in meeting those involved in writing the "N.A. Big Book." Bo was sent to Greg P. and Jimmy K. and learned there was no one taking on this task. Thus, Bo decided to make this task his mission for most of the next decade. Greg P. and Bo formed a kinship that would continue until Greg's death in the late '90s. In Greg, Bo met someone who shared his same dreams and notions for the future of Narcotics Anonymous.

The first seven world conventions were held in California. Since the second one, it became common practice to rotate the location between Southern and Northern California. Nevertheless, at WCNA-7 there were multiple bids from Southern California – from Pasadena, represented by the San Fernando Valley area and from Santa Monica, represented by the Bay Cities Area, as well as token individual entries from Santa Clara and Phoenix, Arizona.

Chuck S. recalled four people in attendance from Texas who were vacationing in San Francisco. Although they were not in town for the convention, they heard about it after arriving and decided to attend. Subsequently, they volunteered their city, Houston, as another option. The first vote was taken and ended up a tie or too close to call. Typically, the voting at that time took place during the convention at a "bid meeting" when attendees would gather together with the group of their choice in opposite parts of a ballroom, with the largest contingent winning.

"Somebody started walking over to the Texas side, and it was like a flood. Even the other competing bids went over to the Texas side rather than support each other's bid. Everybody went to the Texas side," Chuck recalled. "Being a God given program this wasn't an accident; it was one of the greatest things that ever happened to Narcotics Anonymous." Narcotics Anonymous was finally heading east of the Rockies!

The second World Service Conference was to take place at the seventh convention in San Francisco, just as the first conference occurred at the previous year's convention. However, there was a general lack of interest, as only one regional representative was present. The Board tried delaying it until a later time, pending more attendees, but this too failed. A decision was made to hold the World Service Conference independently of the World Convention since the next one was to be held in Houston.

LOS ANGELES VALLEY COLLEGE

Early in 1978, the World Service Office received an invitation from the National Institute on Drug Addiction. They asked that a representative from Narcotics Anonymous participate in an upcoming conference on self-help programs. Greg P. was immediately selected to represent N.A, as Chuck S. referred to him as "the educated one." Greg used the opportunity to visit various N.A. communities on the East Coast. In March, he visited the Pennsylvania fellowship, attending meetings in Central Pennsylvania and Philadelphia. He was quickly welcomed. This

was ironic, as it was extremely rare back then that any local member would meet with someone from the West coast and a Trustee no less! Greg discussed with those he met, the necessity to participate in the World Service Conference that spring.

The second World Service Conference was deferred to April of that year following the aborted meeting at WCNA-7. The conference would take place on the pristine campus of Los Angeles Valley College, located near Jimmy's home in the San Fernando Valley. This location would serve as the conference's home for several years. In addition to the Southern and Northern California delegates, this time there was some representation from members throughout the country.

Since they had been selected as the site of the upcoming World Convention, Texas was represented. The Southeast had Tommy B. from the Atlanta Area Service Committee, who would also report on any knowledge of meetings in neighboring states. While some of his information came from second-hand sources or unconfirmed rumors, he spoke about the existing groups located in Alabama, the Carolinas, Tennessee and Florida.

The "Midwest" representative reported on meetings or purported meetings in Kansas, Nebraska, Oklahoma, Iowa, Minnesota, and the Dakotas, and generally any existing meetings along the Mississippi River from Oklahoma to the Canadian border.

Finally, the Pennsylvania fellowship was present. Ray D. was their representative; they were the oldest existing fellowship on the East Coast. Other attendees included representatives from Colorado, Minneapolis, and even British Columbia.

Only three of the nine regions in attendance had actually formed regional service committees. For several years, the term, "region," at the conference was more geographical than structural. Others represented their area service committee or their local groups, paying their own way to the conference. Those who could afford to travel would in effect become the representatives. In some locations, there was no formal service structure; a few only represented their groups. This was common in the '70s and early '80s, as developing fellowships lacked the funding for travel expenses.

The conference established several committees. In effect, the conference served as a learning seminar for many of these first-time participants. Nonetheless, the conference was a success, as all members of the Board of Trustees were present and the sub-committees that were established filled all their positions.

Tommy B., the representative from Atlanta, was elected the next vice-chairperson of the conference. Upon his return, he informed the local members that if there was substantial interest, the Atlanta fellowship should attempt a bid for the next world convention after the Houston event.

HOUSTON, TEXAS

In September, the first World Convention east of the Rockies came to fruition – though just barely! WCNA-8 was held at the Shamrock Hotel in Houston, a resort popularized in the '50s and known for its humongous tropical-style pool area. The fellowship in Houston consisted almost solely of A.A. members, which was disappointing to many of the Californians in attendance. Attendance was a lowly 250, with about two-thirds coming from California and the remainder from the local fellowship and various small N.A. fellowships located east of the Rockies.

However, the convention did propel growth in areas east of the Rockies; many of those in attendance would carry the N.A. message back home to their small fellowships. Especially motivated were those who attended from cities in the states that would make up the Midwestern region. They would propose placing their own bid package together with the intent of landing the tenth world convention and would succeed. Even far-flung areas benefited from attending the conference. There were a few attendees from Fargo, North Dakota. Filled with a newfound spirit of service, Fargo fellowship would quickly build a small but strong and united fellowship.

"Carrying The Message to Houston" was the convention's theme, although it seemed those who attended from outside of Houston might have enjoyed more of the benefits of the convention spirit. The Atlanta bid was successful and kept the convention on the east coast, and fortunately for the future of the Florida fellowship, within a reasonable distance for travel. In fact, that convention would become pivotal to the growth and development of the fellowship in Florida. This conference gave Bo S. of Atlanta and Greg P. another chance to meet and discuss their ideas, especially the beginnings of the literature movement that eventually led to "The Book."

AREA SERVICE COMMITTEES

At least ten Area Service Committees (ASC's) were functioning or in their developmental stages around the country, enabling local fellowships to provide services on a larger scale. These local efforts would become the

basis for rapid growth throughout the country. San Fernando Valley was the original area service committee and site of the birthplace of Narcotics Anonymous. The Bay Cities Area supported groups in and around Santa Monica with their early efforts focused on increasing responses to their helpline. Ventura and Eastern counties had also formed ASC's in Southern California.

The Northern California GSO was renamed the Berkley/San Francisco Area. Not long after, outlying meetings to the north merged to form the Santa Rosa Area, and now two Areas existed in Northern California. Elsewhere there were areas in various stages of development in Atlanta, Lincoln, Wichita, and Philadelphia. All of these were formed out of the three original fellowships east of the Rockies. In 1979, Sydney, Australia, had formed an Area Service Committee, becoming the first international outgrowth of the *The Tree*.

THE LITERATURE MOVEMENT

Bo S. continued his efforts to enlist willing members to assist in writing "The Book." This effort created an entirely new group of members that became involved in service. More importantly, it created a vast communication network among members throughout the states and around the world. Tommy B. had served diligently as WSC Vice-Chairperson the previous year. He insisted that Bo attend the next World Service Conference and get involved in order to expedite the completion of the "Big Book."

In April of 1979, the third World Service Conference took place with the same number of regions, state delegates, and spokespersons as the 1978 conference. The regional representatives in attendance were from Southern and Northern California, as well as the newly formed Midwest Region, consisting of Kansas, Nebraska, Iowa and the surrounding states. The Pennsylvania fellowship was not represented that year.

The Southeast Region primarily represented the Atlanta fellowship but again reported on groups in the surrounding states. Colorado, Nevada, and Texas were the others in attendance.

Several agenda items were discussed and approved by the conference, including discussions about the updated version of the *The Tree*, the revised informational pamphlets, *We Made A Decision, Another Look*, and *So You Love an Addict*, as well as a review of the new booklet, A *Fourth Step Guide – Getting Realer*. Each of these would become

controversial in the years to come, and most were eventually removed from publication or revised. The first sub-committee handbook, the *Public Information Kit* was also distributed.

Tommy B. was elected the WSC Chairperson, the first non-Californian to hold the position and would become the initial link between Florida and the service structure. Bo S. was elected the Literature Chairperson and a World Literature Conference was quickly scheduled to take place in Wichita, Kansas, immediately following the World Convention in September. There was a strong desire among many avid members that the "N.A. Big Book" be completed in short order, motivated by a fellowship-wide craving for more N.A. literature that would enhance the fellowship's own identity. Despite the fellowship's growth outside of California at the time, the new areas were so desperate for literature that they often used A.A. literature in their meetings. This practice was common throughout the fellowship; it even took place near the birthplace of N.A in Los Angeles, only miles from the World Service Office. Many who initially found recovery in A.A. felt a certain amount of gratitude and allegiance to the older fellowship and were proponents for the continued use of their literature at N.A. meetings, despite the conflict with the Sixth Tradition. Therefore, they did not share the enthusiasm felt by other N.A. members to expeditiously get new literature out to the fellowship.

These issues, among others, would further drive the World Literature Committee into a frenzied pace to compile "The Book" and other pieces of literature for the fellowship. Use of A.A. materials would become a controversial issue almost immediately in Florida, as it did elsewhere until a vast array of literature became available.

The literature movement began as the seventies ended. The eighties would become an era of massive growth and intense change for the fellowship of Narcotics Anonymous. Before we discuss the eighties, we revisit the seventies once again; the next chapter is dedicated to the birth of Narcotics Anonymous in Florida.

Chapter Four

PLANTING SEEDS

KEY WEST – 1969

Key West was originally named in Spanish, "Cayo Hueso," or "Island of Bones." It was believed to be a burial ground for the Caloosa Indians. Ponce de Leon originally claimed Key West for Spain in 1513 before it came under British rule in 1783. It officially became a Florida city in 1828. Key West, located at the end of a string of small islands off the southeastern tip of the state is the southernmost city in the continental United States.

Key West is an isolated tropical paradise steeped with a rich and quirky history. This little village has a long history as a haven for pirates, salvage wreckers, smugglers, illegal immigrants, the downtrodden, and even celebrities seeking solace and isolation in paradise.

In 1969, a man named Ross M. was attending N.A. meetings in San Francisco and nearby Berkley, meetings that were still in their infancy. Ross's parents had long since departed their native New York for the ambiance of the Florida Keys. Both Ross's parents were in declining health and his father had recently suffered a major stroke. Consequently, Ross moved to Key West to care for his ailing parents.

THE ANCHOR'S AWEIGH CLUB

The Anchor's Aweigh Club was located in Key West's Old Town section, where most of the buildings were maintained in their original state, a place similar to the area known as the French Quarter in New Orleans, but with a tropical flare.

The clubhouse was an oasis in a city later coined by one of its more famous residents as "Margaritaville." Arriving that summer, Ross found a small band of drug addicts amongst those in the smoke-filled A.A. room. Therefore, it was here that the very first recorded meeting of Narcotics Anonymous in Florida took place. The meeting started sometime in September 1969. At that time, only 25 meetings existed in the world; unfortunately, this meeting would become one of many "false starts." Hundreds of meetings started between the late '60s and early '80s often lasted for short periods, thus, the term false starts.

Jimmy K., who suffered from tuberculosis for most of his adult life, was fighting several bouts with that disease between 1969 and 1973. His illness did not allow him to stay in regular contact with the new meeting in Florida. He last heard of the Key West meeting in 1970.

There remains no detailed information available about this Saturday afternoon meeting. While conducting research for this book, the authors were able to find a small amount of data. In a binder of archived meetings lists, we found a two-page list of contacts for *Meetings of Narcotics Anonymous in the U.S.A.* The second page listed meetings that were started in 1972 and later. The first page appears to be a list of meetings that existed prior to 1972. The second meeting listed was the little meeting in Key West, Florida. The contact name was Ross M., 9th Avenue, Key West, Florida. While researching Key West newspapers from that era, an obituary was found for what appears to be Ross's father in February of 1970.

The authors of this book were unable to locate Ross or any living relative, although one may conclude by way of mounting evidence that this meeting did exist, though it was likely the first of many false starts that occurred then and in the coming years.

THE BERKLEY WHITE BOOKLETS

Sometime in January of 1980, two members from Fort Lauderdale went to Key West on a weekend getaway. There were not any N.A. meetings at the time, so they ventured over to the Anchor's Aweigh Club, which had been moved to Perry Court, a small section of the town consisting of former military housing.

While sitting in the smoke-filled A.A. meeting, Nina P. noticed a small bookshelf across the room. After the meeting, they skimmed through the selections, and to their surprise, hidden between several books, were three Little White Books that were clearly aged and discolored from cigarette smoke. These pamphlets were later identified as the 1966 version of the Little White Book, which had a Berkley and a Studio City address on the front cover. On the inside cover of one of the booklets was a handwritten notation: "Sober & Clean Meeting – September 1969."

Two more years would pass before another N.A. meeting found a home in Key West. A decade later, Narcotics Anonymous meetings would become the dominant tenant of the Anchor's Aweigh Club.

Mainline – Where it all began!

With the American psyche deeply scarred by the turbulent events of the '60s, the '70s began with much uncertainty, a mindset witnessed by the availability of drugs common to all socio-economic groups.

West Palm Beach was one of the few passionately conservative areas left in Florida. Local and state laws made life uncomfortable for addicts and available treatment options were limited. All these factors combined to make West Palm Beach an unlikely candidate to become the birthplace of the Narcotics Anonymous fellowship in Florida. There was the one meeting in Key West five years before, but West Palm Beach would truly be the birthplace of Narcotics Anonymous as a fellowship in Florida.

BOB B.

In 1970, Bob B., a hardcore heroin addict, entered a New York therapeutic community because "that was all there was at the time." Bob then moved to West Palm Beach. In January 1974, Bob was introduced to the Twelve Steps of Alcoholics Anonymous. He made the coffee, set up the meeting room, got a sponsor, worked the Twelve Steps and learned about the Traditions. However, he could not identify; he felt as if he was in what he called a "wasteland."

After Bob had been attending meetings for a while, the elders in A.A. began greeting him at the door. They asked him to stop identifying himself as a drug addict and "cease speaking about all those drug stories with the gruesome particulars." He responded that he could not do it. "Not to identify with the disease I suffer from is to deny it and to deny is to die." He went to meeting after meeting with the same response. One particular clubroom where A.A. meetings were held even banned Bob from their meetings.

He went out to coffee one night with his friend Pete F. and began complaining about how unappreciated he was in "those A.A. meetings." Pete responded, "Why don't you do something about it?" Pete went on to tell him about a recovering addict he had heard about in California named Jimmy Kinnon. Jimmy had started a program for other addicts out there called Narcotics Anonymous.

Bob did do something. He got the phone number and called; he spoke with Jimmy, who asked if Bob and his friends had anything going on

now. Bob explained that small core groups of narcotics addicts had been meeting informally at a coffee shop since January. Bob and his friends talked about their own problems and being kicked out of A.A. meetings, an on-going dilemma. Together, the coffee shop gang tried to figure out what they could do for themselves.

Bob wanted to know what Jimmy could do to help them. Jimmy told him he would send him literature and a starter kit. Suddenly excited, Bob thought he had found the answer for his small band of addicts. He went back to the coffee shop and told his friends he'd spoken to Jimmy and that Jimmy had promised to send literature and everything else they would need to start a different kind of meeting of their own. "It's going to have all the bells and whistles," he said. "Now we are going to know what to do."

A manila envelope arrived in the mail a few weeks later and out came one *Little White Book*. He looked in the envelope, only to find it was empty. So Bob called Jimmy and asked, "Where are the instructions?" Jimmy responded, "Didn't you get my package?" and Bob said of course he did. Jimmy replied, "That's it!"

IRIS STREET

"It was a long and arduous journey to get to October 23, 1974, at 7:00 pm at 421 Iris Street in West Palm Beach to start the very first Narcotics Anonymous group in Florida," said Bob. It was one of only 50 open N.A. meetings in the world. They chose the name, The Mainline Group. That first group consisted of addicts who had little experience in any twelve-step fellowship and obviously none in N.A.

These pioneers made up flyers and posted them at the same A.A. clubhouses that had banned addicts from participation in those groups; they sent the flyer to therapeutic communities, alcoholism treatment centers and the like. For several years, their sole link to Narcotics Anonymous was through telephone conversations with Jimmy.

"DON'T BE AFRAID"

During one of those initial calls, Jimmy asked Bob a question: "You're afraid, aren't you?" Bob responded in the affirmative. Jimmy told him "Don't be afraid. If what you're doing is right, God won't let you fail; just go do it!" Over the years, Bob made a lot of phone calls to Jimmy.

The group went on in an environment not conducive to addicts

recovering openly. One professional's opinion about that era described Palm Beach County as "the last bastion of fanatical conservatism along with an abundance of draconian drug laws that prohibited addicts from gathering together."

Paranoia reigned supreme, as the members wondered what might happen to them. Jimmy urged them to "have faith," and so they did. Bob received a phone call one day from the Chief of the Palm Beach Sheriff's Narcotics Division. He asked Bob, "What are you doing with those meetings." Bob answered, "They're twelve-step meetings. We're a bonafide organization based in California; call them if you want." He even got indignant, by mentioning, "We have a constitutional right to meet."

Finally, group members began to feel safe and secure in the rooms. "It got to be ok," he said. "We went through a lot of odd, strange, Fellini-esque experiences." One of the earliest experiences was the group's concern over letting in too many addicts that used different kinds of drugs. It might be too much for the group to handle, so the group considered only letting in heroin addicts. In a moment of clarity, someone suggested Bob should call Jimmy and ask him if there was a "Heroin Addicts Anonymous." In these early years and for years to come, there was a very apparent bias towards non-heroin addicts. After all, this group was the only place for hard-core addicts, junkies, criminals, pimps, and hookers – "the dregs of society" – and there was a fear that someone who was unknown to them might be a "narc."

Jimmy responded with laughter when asked about "Heroin Addicts Anonymous" and then used the mantra, "Don't be afraid." The group decided to welcome anyone who admitted having a drug problem and wanted help. "We really tried to be there for the dope fiend when he needed it," Bob recalled. "It was about staying clean, bonding with each other, staying together and being true to yourself. Our service work was one addict helping another addict."

OLIVE AVENUE

The group attendance grew from a few to 10, then 12, and after the first year, up to 35. By 1976, a second meeting was started on Saturday nights. Later, the group moved to larger, more comfortable quarters at 1105 North Olive Avenue. This new address became their home until the early eighties. The group started a third meeting at the county detoxification center in 1979.

Hints of paranoia continued for years until the early eighties as the Mainline Group survived in isolation. Later in the eighties, the Mainline Group became one of the largest N.A. meetings in the fellowship, with upwards of 250 in attendance.

At the conclusion of Bob's interview, he stated, "If not for the heartfelt support of Jimmy K., I wouldn't have stuck around." Bob and Jimmy both attended the 13th World Convention in New York City. This was the first and only opportunity for them to meet. While at the convention, Bob was going up in an elevator when Jimmy was coming down. Therefore, they never met physically, but their hearts had met spiritually through one addict helping another – the N.A. Way.

MARVIN S.

In 1962, Marvin S. was arrested in a well-publicized drug bust along with several other jazz musicians. He was court-ordered to the federal narcotics farm at Lexington Hospital where he would attend the Addicts Anonymous meeting, more aptly known as the NARCO Group.

Upon his return to Cleveland in August of 1963, he was given the name of an A.A. member that had also used drugs who would become his sponsor. His sponsor introduced Marvin to Captain Edward Dimond at the Salvation Army. "Captain Ed," as Marvin referred to him, would volunteer the use of a room at the Harbor Light Center.

"Narcotics Anonymous was started in Cleveland on November 6, 1963, sponsored by the Salvation Army Harbor Light Center"

Excerpt from letter dated 2/15/71. Signed by Edward V. Dimond

Different from the early New York movement, the Cleveland Group adopted the Twelve Steps of A.A. by simply penciling out the words "alcohol" and "alcoholic" and replacing them with "drugs" and "drug addict." They quickly grew to three weekly meetings, one each on Sundays, Tuesdays and Wednesdays. Members around Miami recall Marvin speaking about being the secretary of the Cleveland Group of Narcotics Anonymous in the sixties. Most assumed it was the same Narcotics Anonymous, as few knew about the early New York and Cleveland versions of N.A.

From all outward appearances, the early version of the Cleveland N.A. success seemed promising. They produced a newsletter, copied the bootleg literature from the New York movement, and for entertainment, the members even formed their own jazz band. Marvin, who was the group leader, relapsed in 1964.

Major Dimond kept the meeting going with the assistance of "lay staff," various members who acted as group leader. Ed was even asked to speak about the group at the International A.A. Convention in 1970 in Miami.

The Salvation Army in Cleveland had long been supportive of Alcoholics Anonymous; Ed counted A.A. members amongst his friends. The meeting was discontinued October 1, 1970.

MIAMI – 1975

Ray K. attended Narcotics Anonymous meetings a few years before while living in California. He attended meetings in San Francisco and Berkley. Big Ed attended the Agape Group, which can best be described as a special purpose group for A.A. members. Opinions differ widely about "Agape A.A. Groups." The common thread was that members could discuss absolutely anything at these meetings and periodic retreats. This forum became a haven for addicts to speak openly about their addiction, which was not acceptable in A.A. meetings.

Marvin S. had moved to Miami and attended an "Agape Weekend" in the spring of 1975, where he met Ed and shared their need to have a place for addicts. Marvin then met Ray who knew about the World Service Office in Sun Valley. Ray and Marvin worked together at the county detoxification center. Marvin spoke to Jimmy K, who mailed them some literature.

THE BRIDGE GROUP – MIAMI 1975

June 24, 1975, marks the date of the first Narcotics Anonymous meeting in Miami. Marvin, Ray, Big Ed, Nancy, John, and Jeanine met at the Community Outreach Center just off Northeast 141st Street and Biscayne Boulevard in North Miami. The name, The Bridge Group, was selected to indicate the bridge between addicts who were floundering in A.A. and could now cross the bridge to N.A., where they could be true to themselves.

Charlie hit a bottom and found a friend in Marvin S., who took him to the fledgling meeting and became his sponsor and good friend. Now there was a core group of addicts. Just before the bicentennial celebration in 1976, they moved to an A.A. clubroom – The Little River Club, located at the corner of 79th Street and Biscayne Boulevard on the second floor above a McDonald's restaurant.

The new meeting space was small, and on nights when the clubroom had an event booked, the group were relegated to meeting at a later time. Addicts were not generally welcomed in A.A. meetings. In fact, they were reduced to sitting in the back of the A.A. rooms. Charlie recalls attending one particular meeting in a clubroom when the club president walked in and said, "What are all these addicts doing here? They are taking up all of our chairs."

For the next several months, the Bridge Group became a rabbit meeting like those held in the '50s in California, moving from member homes and then back to the Little River Club until finally they found a place of their own.

THE BACK ROOM CLUB

With the financial assistance of a friend, Marvin raised the capital necessary to rent a small converted apartment at 7111 Biscayne Boulevard. In September 1977, the Bridge Group found a home at what they called the Back Room Club. The clubroom remained there for the next several years. It allowed the group and N.A. itself to gain some stability and earn respect among their many doubters.

The Back Room Club would become a sanctuary for addicts seeking recovery. A.A. members referred addicts to the small clubroom. Addicts named Skinny Kenny, Carla, Jimmy III and others lived in apartments in the same building, in essence becoming caretakers. One member hand-painted the "steps" on a wall; others donated furniture, wall hangings and even appliances. Most significant, a phone was installed and the number listed in the phonebook, constituting the earliest version of a hotline. Shelly K. recalled, "It was more than a clubroom, it had a sofa that he and others used to detoxify."

By the middle of 1978, it was not uncommon to see a dozen or so people at one or more of the meetings. Charlie M., Joan D., Marvin S., Nancy S., Skinny Kenny N., Carla, Mike, Betty, Shelly K., John J., Buddha Bob, Jack, Casey, Vinny, Jimmy and Rosalie R. formed the core of the Miami fellowship, though many continued to relapse.

Joan D. became the unofficial institution chairperson. Whenever Jimmy K. received communication at the World Service Office from someone seeking help in a Florida institution, he would send a postcard with the prisoner's information to the Back Room Club and Joan would write to them.

By the end of the year, when a few addicts from Hollywood and Fort Lauderdale heard about the N.A. meeting on Biscayne Boulevard and they ventured south to the clubroom. It was here that Joey M. met Marvin in April of 1978. He would give her the information and literature necessary to start another meeting.

Others from the neighboring county followed. Tom M. was given the moniker, "Hollywood Tom," since he was the only recovering addict

living in Hollywood. Big Robert and Kurt from Fort Lauderdale introduced an invasion of members from the Pennsylvania fellowship that began relocating to South Florida and the Back Room Club. Brett H., Blaine H., Jean, Rich V., Jeff V., Jeff C., Bob G. and others had heard about the N.A. meetings at the clubhouse. It was home to many of the first activities, but more importantly, the seeds of recovery had been planted here. This all occurred in isolation with a lack of awareness of both the Mainline Group and the Copeland meeting.

COPELAND ROAD PRISON – NAPLES – 1976

Florida's first institutional (H&I) meeting took place at a small prison near the enclave of Everglades City in the rural southwest part of the state. Copeland Road Prison vaguely resembled the facility depicted in the movie, *Cool Hand Luke*. The scriptwriter for that film visited Copeland among many other "road camps," and the resulting movie embellished on the camp's work and security practices used to control the prisoners. However, the portrayal of chain gangs was overstated, as the practice had been discontinued for decades. The primary function of these road gangs was to provide some of the necessary labor required on highway construction projects. The population of the camp was approximately 50 able-bodied male inmates.

Jimmy K. answered the phone at the World Service Office in the summer of 1975 and spoke to Pastor Shelton, the newly appointed chaplain at Copeland Road Prison. The chaplain had recently moved to Southwest Florida to open a new church. Pastor Shelton had interned at Eagleville Hospital near Philadelphia. Amongst several documents he brought along to Copeland was one *Little White Book*.

Jimmy sent some literature and a group registration form to the prison. The facility occasionally purchased literature from the office until the end of the decade. The meeting was facilitated by prisoners and supervised by a guard similar to the Walla Walla experience, as it was made clear that "outsiders" were not openly welcome in those early years. Males who wanted to attend had to undergo a background check and strip search. The meeting was scheduled for Friday nights, although they did not meet consistently. Sometimes, the meeting was altered or cancelled many times due to inmate work schedules.

At the time, there were just two N.A. meetings in the entire state and they were in their infancy. Contact with Copeland Road Prison ensued

when the newly formed South Florida Area Service was made aware of their existence in 1980. In 1982, when the fellowship started in Naples, they began to bring in a panel meeting. Nevertheless, the prisoners were even taken to the inaugural outside N.A. meeting.

According to a former warden at the Copeland Road Prison, the meeting remained a part of the curriculum for years to come until the facility closed in 2001. Copeland was part of N.A. lore for a quarter century.

THE 1976 WORLD DIRECTORY

The 1976 World Directory was compiled, typed and published in the fall of that year. Florida was listed on page 15. Six listings were included, one of which was simply a contact name. The Mainline Group, the Bridge Group, and the Copeland meeting were prominently displayed along with three other meetings. Anecdotal information that was uncovered offered strong evidence these other meetings took place, but they were very short-lived. If they did exist, they did so in anonymity and their lifespan was fleeting.

When Bob G. met Jimmy K. in 1980 at the World Service Conference, he asked what Jimmy knew about N.A. meetings both past and present in Florida. Jimmy gave detailed information about meetings in Key West, West Palm, Miami, the prison meeting at Copeland, and later ones in Fort Lauderdale, Orlando, Pensacola, as well as more current meetings in Bradenton and Sarasota. He offered no further information nor had he any recollection of the other listings.

THE UNITY GROUP – DELRAY BEACH – 1976

One might assume there was a direct connection between the Mainline Group and the Unity Group simply by their close proximity to each other. However, the evidence points to two likely conclusions: First, there is the possibility that both meetings existed without any or little knowledge of the other, though this assumption is unlikely. Second, it could be assumed the two meetings both existed in anonymity and lasted only a short period of time. Mainline functioned without any outside contact other than Jimmy K. in California and knew of no other meetings nearby, though Bob B. vaguely recalled rumors of another group in South Palm Beach County.

On a 1998 history tape, Jack W. recalled that he, Marvin S., and a few others drove up to Palm Beach County from Miami to assist a few addicts who wanted nothing to do with the Mainline Group, as they were seemingly connected to CARP, the county alcoholism rehabilitation program. They wanted to start their own meeting. According to Jack, their meeting was located somewhere off Hypoluxo Road in Delray Beach and it took place in 1976. The Unity Group was the result of that effort.

On a CD-ROM given to all registrants of the 30th World Convention was a 1978 newspaper article that went into detail about the Unity Group in Delray Beach. This was probably the first published article about N.A. in Florida.

Bruce W. was the group secretary, treasurer, and coffeemaker, and performed all the other group tasks as well. Unlike the Mainline Group, Unity remained very small, though they continued to meet for several years until 1979. The group met upstairs at the Unity Church at the corner of Swinton Boulevard and 22nd Avenue, becoming the first N.A. meeting in South Palm Beach County. This area is known today as the Mid-Coast Area.

NO GROUP – TAMPA – 1976

This listing appears differently than the other five in the Florida section, the others providing specific meeting information, times, dates, contact phone numbers, etc. The Tampa group appears as only a contact name in this listing. Most likely, a literature purchase was made and sent to the contact person listed in the directory. The individual named was known to have worked for a county-owned therapeutic community in the mid- to late-1970s. A methadone clinic was located at the address where the literature package was sent in Tampa.

In the '70s, Operation PAR in Clearwater had an institutional meeting at their facility run by one of their counselors. The counselor was released by the facility because he ran the meeting "as if it was his personal fiefdom." He had opened a bank account under the name, Narcotics Anonymous, and cashed several bad checks. When the Bay Area was formed, they tried to open a bank account and were notified of this previous activity.

A letter from an addict in a Tarpon Springs hospital was published in the January 1980 edition of *The Voice*; he had found a *Little White Book* while in treatment. A few months later, another addict named Alice

acquired a *Little White Book* from a counselor in Tampa and a meeting ensued in Bradenton. She initiated the meeting as the result of receiving the booklet. The only literature ever sent to this area prior to 1981 was the 1976 order from the WSO. There simply was not any information to tie it all together. The World Service Office had no further documentation available in their archives. Meetings in nearby St. Petersburg and Clearwater did not start until 1981 and Tampa meetings finally began in early 1982.

THE AGAPE GROUP – CORAL GABLES – 1976

There appear to be several different accounts as to the validity and nature of the Agape Group gleaned from the information obtained from those interviewed for this book. One recollection was, "They had a drug-addicts meeting" at the Agape Club, a small meeting place off LeJeune Road in Coral Gables that took place on Tuesday evenings at 8:30 p.m. Big Ed was initially involved in this meeting and Marvin S. attended as well. The group had no trusted servants and folded shortly before the Back Room Club opened in 1977.

Another person interviewed recalled the meeting as an "A.A. meeting for druggies," where attendees read what appeared to be N.A. literature. Other early N.A. members cannot recall ever hearing about this meeting. This meeting is suspected to have been another short-lived false start, but it was the first meeting in what would later become the South Dade area.

FUN IN THE SUN CONVENTION – PANAMA CITY – 1977

This event started in 1977 purely by accident. Four members from the Atlanta fellowship, simply seeking a weekend getaway, drove south to Panama City. Word got out about their fun experience and so Lynn W. formally organized this casual getaway in 1978. It became an event for the entire North Atlanta fellowship. Ironically, there were no local meetings in Florida. Hence, "Fun in the Sun" became an Atlanta satellite convention held several hundred miles to the south in Florida.

The Atlanta Fellowship even chartered a bus for the trip in 1980. In addition to the Georgians, members from areas around Florida and from nearby Alabama, Mississippi, and Louisiana joined the trek to this event. This annual spring event remains the oldest ongoing convention in Florida and the East Coast.

BUDDHA BOB

Bo S. met Bob M., a brash Californian, at the Shoney's Restaurant on Old Buford Highway outside Atlanta. Bo proceeded to spend hours bantering back and forth with his newfound friend. Bob had been sober in A.A. in California but thought he could still smoke pot. They actually talked for so long that they had consumed two full meals; this was uncommon even for Bo. Bob apparently heard what he needed, as he would become a member of the New Connections Group, the first N.A. meeting in Atlanta.

After just a year clean, Bob, full of entrepreneurial spirit, moved his furniture business to Miami. Now in recovery, he built a very successful enterprise. He was able to design and build his own estate in Western Dade County. This still-rural area allowed him to develop a unique home of his own. He was proud of the fact that it was built mostly by hand using only natural materials and was completely solar-powered. Bob's passion for meditation resulted in the nickname he carried throughout the years: Buddha Bob. Split into three unique spaces, the center of the home was an oriental-style open-air garden where Bob meditated each morning. Although, Buddha Bob passed away several years ago from cancer, his impact on the fellowship continues today.

NEW CONNECTIONS GROUP – COCONUT GROVE 1977

Bob, not forgetting his Atlanta N.A. roots, started a meeting in Coconut Grove named the New Connections Group. The meeting began in early August at St. Stephens Catholic Church. Coconut Grove was a small village south of downtown Miami; it was the city's "hippie enclave" in the late '60s and early '70s.

The New Connections Group would become the second N.A. group in Miami that still meets today. In November of 1977, Rosalie R. picked up her "white chip" here, becoming the first person "twelve-stepped" directly into N.A. in Miami. All others attending N.A. meetings to this point were refugees from A.A. In 1978, the group moved to the American Legion Hall located at 61st and Biscayne Boulevard. Shortly thereafter, the group moved again, this time to the Back Room Club where met twice a week on Tuesday and Thursday evenings. Later the group moved to North Miami General Hospital, where they remained for several years.

NEW BEGINNINGS GROUP – MIAMI – 1977

The next meeting in Dade County occurred in 1977 at the Village South Rehabilitation Center, an old-school therapeutic community. This was a short-lived, controversial stay, as almost immediately, clients of the center realized they could attend N.A. meetings without need for further treatment. After the third client left the facility, the group was asked to depart promptly.

The Thursday night meeting was folded into another group – The New Connections Group that already held a Tuesday night meeting. The group moved to the Back Room Club meeting on both Tuesdays and Thursdays.

NEW FREEDOM GROUP – FORT LAUDERDALE – 1978

In 1975, Joey M. discovered Alcoholics Anonymous, and in the ensuing year, she met other addicts in the A.A. rooms. Joey's personality and appearance differed from the other addicts appearing in A.A. at the time; she had a respectable job and was more presentable than many of the other addicts who frequented A.A. By 1978, she began to notice an increased amount of drug addicts attending meetings, a trend that created considerable animosity at several A.A. meetings.

While attending an Agape Weekend, Joey met Marvin S., who told her about Narcotics Anonymous and the Back Room Club. Joey was working part-time for the Broward County Sheriff's Office chaplain. The following week, she informed BSO Pastor Connie Sjostrum about the meetings in Miami. The pastor supported Joey in starting a meeting and offered his storefront location next the Broward County Courthouse in downtown Fort Lauderdale.

Joey tried to contact the World Service Office on several occasions but received no response. She and another addict named Tommy H. drove to the Back Room Club and began attending meetings. In Joey's own words, "Marvin was very generous in allowing us to take what we needed back to Fort Lauderdale." He contributed literature, a starter kit and flyers for a first anniversary picnic fundraiser for the Back Room.

Joey was involved in the A.A. institution committee and brought a weekly meeting to Broward Correctional Institute, a women's detention center in Pompano Beach. She informed the inmates at that meeting about the Narcotics Anonymous meeting she was going to start, and they were asked to pick the name of the group. After a few suggestions such as Mainliners and New Freedom – the women settled on the New Freedom Group. Joey promised there would be an N.A. meeting waiting for them upon release. Mo (Maureen), a hard-core New York junkie, was the inmate who suggested the New Freedom Group as their group name. She listened to Joey, and upon her release, faithfully attended the group, becoming the first person in the area to find N.A. through an institution.

While preparing for the first meeting, Joey tried to contact the World Service Office but, again, had no success. She wanted to print copies of the literature she was given by Marvin. Pastor Connie allowed her to gain access to a copying machine. How ironic and hilarious it was to be making bunches of copies of the Narcotics Anonymous literature on the Broward Sheriff's Office copying machine!

It was time to get the word out about the upcoming meeting, and Joey and Tommy, an ex-carnival worker who went by the moniker of "Carni Tom," began passing out flyers around A.A. meetings. The New Freedom Group was held for the first time on July 18, 1978. Joey did not recall who attended the first few meetings other than herself and Tommy H. and a few others from a St. Francis Mission located a few blocks away. The meeting struggled for some time until others began to attend in early to mid-1979. Marvin, Charlie, and Rosalie would sometimes attend along with

Joey M., Carni Tom, Hollywood Tom, Big Robert, Kurt E., Karen D., Nina P., Lorain, Steve, Rick E., Jody, Jersey Joe, Austin B. and Maureen F. By June of the following year, a completely new group of addicts who had relocated from Pennsylvania had begun to attend – Blaine H., Jean, Rich V, Jeff C., Jeff V., John F., and Bob G. Having 20 to 25 addicts in attendance was not uncommon.

In July of 1979, an addict named Mark F. went to the county detoxification center seeking help to detoxify from a methadone habit. The counselor there told him they did not treat drug addicts and knew of no place for him to go for medical help, though he had heard of a new entity called Narcotics Anonymous. Mark felt instant relief when he heard the words, Narcotics Anonymous. That night (July 22), he picked up his first and only "white chip," becoming the first addict to directly find recovery in Narcotics Anonymous in Broward County. Mark is still clean today.

According to Joey, there were new people coming every week. Maud B. came to the meeting seeking help "for someone else," but when she stood to leave the room, she spilled her purse full of pills on the floor. "Maybe you should stay for the meeting," Joey suggested. Maud stayed and is still clean today. Another newcomer, Paul E., came to his first meeting with a briefcase in tow; he was wearing a blue leisure suit and a "pimp hat."

From the inception of the group in 1978 until mid-1979, Joey and others would bring impromptu institution meetings to the Women's Detention Center and the Broward County Jail. She even registered these meetings with the World Service Office under the names the Natural High and New Hope Groups as noted in the 1979 World Directory.

WESTSIDE GROUPS – JACKSONVILLE – 1978

In the fall of 1978, a handful of addicts began what can best be described as a "rabbit meeting." This anonymous group met in a private home on the westside of Jacksonville. Two of the folks were from California, and therefore had previously been exposed to Narcotics Anonymous. A small amount of literature was obtained from California and copied. This informal meeting lasted approximately six months and then folded.

In the spring of 1979, a few of those that started the short-lived "Westside" meeting attempted to initiate another meeting. This time it was scheduled at a small church. It became known as the first N.A. meeting in Jacksonville.

Five to ten people attended regularly. The literature they used was meager; they simply copied some when they needed it. Orders reportedly were taking four to five months to arrive from California. On occasion, some literature was obtained from the Mainline Group in West Palm Beach. The only contact with other N.A. members occurred when a member from Jacksonville attended an Agape A.A. meeting while in Miami and met Rosalie R., an N.A. member in Miami, during this second "false start." This meeting again was located on the Westside and it too met the same fate as it lasted about nine months and then folded.

Apparently, during 1979, there were other attempts to organize yet another meeting on the eastside of town in the Jacksonville Beach area. This supposed "rabbit meeting," if it occurred as rumored, was held sporadically.

STOREFRONT CENTER – SARASOTA – 1979

Narcotics Anonymous expanded to another Florida city in August 1979. Sarasota is located just south of Bradenton. Steve Z., an employee of the Storefront Counseling Center, heard about a new meeting in nearby Bradenton, so he called the World Service Office and spoke with Jimmy K. Jimmy sent Steve twenty dollars' worth of literature. The purchase was made with center funds. A few weeks later, Steve and another addict named Kathy started the first N.A. meeting in Sarasota at the Storefront Counseling Center at 331 South Pineapple in downtown Sarasota each Wednesday evening at 8:30. This group later added a second meeting on Monday nights at the same location.

This meeting was the first held on the west coast of Florida other than the prison meeting at Copeland. Steve Z. registered the group with the World Service Office just in time to be listed in the 1979 World Directory. This same directory revealed that Steve was also active in formation of Narcotics Anonymous meetings in Illinois. He was listed as the sole contact person for each of the four existing meetings within the City of Chicago boundaries in the '79 directory. All this took place prior to his July arrival in Florida.

NATURAL HIGH GROUP – FORT LAUDERDALE – 1979

Joey noticed that the meetings were packed and believed it was time to start another meeting, so she found another facility. It was an old, Florida-style home located near the end of the runway at Ft. Lauderdale International Airport. This "pilot's bunkhouse" had a rich history when it

was part of the Ft. Lauderdale Naval Air Station during World War II. The most notable resident was a young Navy pilot named George H.W. Bush who later became the 41st president of United States.

The Natural High Group held their first meeting there on a humid Sunday evening in the middle of August. It was the first dedicated "step meeting" held in Florida. Every seat was taken and latecomers had to sit on the floor.

Later, the group started a second meeting at the same location, another first – a Young People's N.A. meeting. The facility hosted the first South Florida Area activity. "The Masquerade Ball" was actually the first N.A. event in Florida; the only others events were held in support of the Back Room Club in Miami. The building also served as a site for many early business meetings.

PENSACOLA NAVAL AIR STATION – PENSACOLA – 1979

One of the service efforts of the California fellowship in the early '70s was assisting the U.S. military to establish Narcotics Anonymous meetings at their bases. The Navy opened a substance abuse program disguised under the more acceptable term, "alcoholism program," at the Miramar Naval Hospital on the San Diego base. A meeting was started along the lines of an institutional panel, and the patients in the program held another meeting on their own.

The success of the program was immediate. Other Navy installations adopted similar-style programs, which included the use of N.A. meetings in various formats adopted to meet the needs of their particular facilities. Pensacola became the site of the first of these "military issue" N.A. meetings in Florida. Entry procedures differed from base to base, each with a variety of restrictions. Therefore, outside participation was, in effect, non-existent. The N.A. meetings were held in a building near the base medical center; it started during the summer of 1979 and lasted until 1980.

DRYDOCK GROUP – ORLANDO – 1979

Janet Greeson was a social worker employed at a counseling center at the Orlando Naval Air Station base. With the assistance of some local A.A. members, she started a substance abuse group that quickly changed its name and went under the banner of Narcotics Anonymous. The A.A. meeting held there was named the Drydock Group, so the N.A. group adopted the same moniker. The Tuesday-night meeting met in Building

2693 and was lightly attended, but it served a greater purpose, as other locals were now aware of the existence of Narcotics Anonymous. The N.A. Drydock Group led to the birth of the Orlando fellowship.

Policies changed, allowing patients to participate in "outside" and "open" meetings in the '80s. Military-only meetings have continued in some form at a few facilities, although several programs closed due to cutbacks and base closures as in the case of Orlando Naval Air Station. The programs no longer were concealed under the "alcohol" program veil; they adopted the term "addiction."

IT'S JUST THE BEGINNING

The first seeds of Narcotics Anonymous planted in Florida extended from Pensacola to Key West between 1969 and 1979. Those of the early meetings that survived flourished and became the cornerstone of their local fellowships for decades. The meetings and groups were started or supported by members who had experienced N.A. meetings elsewhere or had direct contact with Jimmy K. Unfortunately, the same struggles that existed then in Florida exist today in far-reaching foreign countries that are currently in their N.A. infancy.

Many parallels exist between those early meetings in the '50s and '60s in California and the early meetings in Florida in the '70s and '80s. Perhaps the greatest challenge was learning how to apply the Steps and Traditions without any relevant literature or material to assist group members. Someone with a few years clean would be considered an "old-timer" in Narcotics Anonymous. In essence, these meetings functioned as a special purpose group for "drug addicts," as virtually everyone attending meetings then, whether they desired to or not, would predominantly attend A.A. meetings. These same struggles continued throughout the early '80s and in some rural settings, into the early '90s as well.

The day prior to the ninth World Convention on September 5, 1979, the seeds were about to sprout. The Mainline Group in West Palm Beach had three active meetings, with the Bridge Group and the New Connections Group each meeting twice weekly at the Back Room Club. Meanwhile, the attendance at the New Freedom Group and Natural High Group was growing rapidly. The members from the late '70s watched; the seedlings were about to sprout and grow far beyond their dreams.



Anchor's Aweigh Club – Key West
Site of the first meeting in Florida – 1969



Photo of Mainline Group 1st Anniversary – 1975



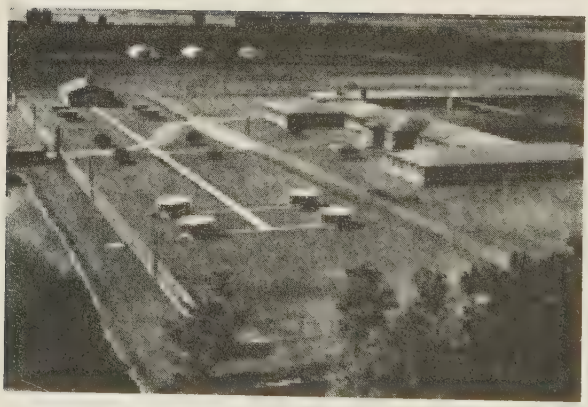
Site of the first meeting place of the Mainline Group
oldest Group and ongoing meeting in Florida



Site of "The Back Room Club" – 7111 Biscayne Boulevard - Miami.



St. Stephens Church – Coconut Grove



Copeland Road Prison

Chapter Five

THE BILTMORE TO MARCO POLO

I CAN'T – WE CAN

N.A.'s 9th World Convention (WCNA-9) was the fellowship's first major event held east of the Mississippi River. It proved to be the impetus for rapid growth up and down the east coast. The Biltmore had been the discriminating choice of the sophisticated and affluent in previous decades, but this once-grand Georgia hotel was steadily declining, and by convention time, the deterioration was apparent.

Registration records for WCNA-9 were apparently lost, but depending upon the source, estimates of attendance varied between 300 and 500. Those interviewed placed the actual crowd around 300, including family members, half of whom hailed from Georgia. Atlanta's fellowship suffered a significant fiscal deficit that took over a year to rectify. The positive impact of the convention would be felt for years.

The main obstacle confronting the convention surrounded the choice of speakers. Board of Trustees President Chuck S. went so far as to call the event a "great young people's A.A. convention." The main speaker was an "A.A. circuit speaker," and the Sunday speaker was from New Mexico, which had yet to register a single N.A. group.

The bid meeting for WCNA-10 was held Saturday, with only one serious contender. Although no official bid was made by the South Florida fellowship, Rosalie R. and her contingent did mention Miami as a viable site, planting a seed. At the banquet, it was announced that the following world convention would be held in Wichita, Kansas, the "Land Of Oz."

Twelve addicts from South Florida took the trip to Atlanta. In hindsight, their attendance would comprise Florida's first step in joining a worldwide fellowship. The Sunshine State's fellowship would no longer exist in isolation. Moreover, the enthusiasm of these members became infectious, creating the momentum that transformed isolated groups into a united fellowship.

Rosalie was the only attendee from Miami, with the others coming from Fort Lauderdale's New Freedom Group. Karen D., Big Robert, Hollywood Tom, Joey M., Nina P. and Kurt, to name a few, all returned to South Florida filled with passion and a newfound commitment to Narcotics Anonymous.

THE SOUTH FLORIDA AREA SERVICE COMMITTEE

Karen and Rosalie knew enthusiasm was a transitory emotion and a poor long-term motivator, so they quickly scheduled a brainstorming session for that weekend. Suggestions concerning a concrete game plan ensued throughout the week. They met that Sunday at the storefront meeting room, with most of the local N.A. fellowship in attendance. *The Tree* was used to define the purpose of an area service committee. They decided to go back to the groups, seeking their support for this new endeavor, and a second meeting was scheduled two weeks later.

The inaugural Area Service Committee (ASC) meeting was held September 30, 1979, at Rosalie's home in North Miami. A pattern of meeting in private homes would continue for the next year. The five existing groups were represented: the Bridge and New Connections groups that met at the Back Room Club, along with a brand new meeting – the New Horizons Group. Fort Lauderdale's New Freedom and Natural High groups also attended.

Elections for the first officers took place, with Rosalie elected as chairperson, Rich V. as vice-chair, Nina P. as secretary, and "Methadone Mary" as treasurer. The only sub-committee established was the Institutions Committee; Robert M. was elected its chairperson. This was not an election in the typical sense; it was more a meeting to determine how each person wanted to contribute to the ASC. The election became a mere formality.

Another meeting was scheduled two weeks later in order to capitalize on the newfound zeal for the Narcotics Anonymous program. Robert quickly went to work, gathering support from other members. Within a few weeks, the first meeting commenced. Robert contacted Helene, a counselor at Coral Ridge Hospital's substance abuse treatment program. Soon an "open" meeting began on Monday nights. This meeting would send dozens of addicts to N.A. over the next several years. The hospital owned an outpatient facility nearby where they allowed the others to start a third outside group – The Survivors Group. In October, the first institutional meeting was started at the Hollywood Work Release Center, with another following at South Florida State Hospital. In December, the third began at Hollywood Pavilion, a private psychiatric hospital.

Bob G., elected literature chairperson at the next area meeting, promptly purchased a used mimeograph machine to print a newsletter and copy literature. He thought he should contact the World Literature

Chairperson Bo S. to find out when the "N.A. Big Book" was going to be completed.

At the November meeting, they discussed the need to get "hotlines" for both Dade and Broward counties. An activity was planned to raise funds necessary for the projects the area planned. Also discussed was the recent discovery of the West Palm group and their potential involvement in the ASC.

THE PANHANDLE – FROM THE NAVY TO THE YWCA

Pensacola is located at the far northwestern corner of Florida, in an area called "The Panhandle" which is somewhat self-explanatory after viewing a map of the state. Many also refer it to as "Florida's Bible Belt."

The history of Pensacola Beach and Santa Rosa Island is rich with political intrigue, military combat, multicultural life, individual triumph and sorry failure. It all began with the ill-fated expedition of Tristan de Luna to create the first Spanish settlement in North America in 1559.

In the late '70s, a short-lived N.A. meeting existed at the Pensacola Naval Air Station. It is unlikely this meeting contributed to the birth of others in the area, as "old-timers" were blatantly unaware of its existence.

Eventually, Bob, his spouse Kelly, and a few others, saw the need for an open N.A. meeting in Pensacola. So on a cool Wednesday evening, October 3, 1979, the Third Tradition Group was born, meeting at the local YWCA at Blount and 12th Avenue. That group has continued to meet ever since. In fact, a newcomer named Steve who attended that first meeting and picked up his "white chip" that night still attends and is still clean today.

The next meeting started up in the fall of 1979 at Camp Five Road Prison in Cantonment. This road prison was unique since it was the only county-operated work camp in Florida. An employee of the prison found out about Narcotics Anonymous while attending a seminar in which a Copeland Road Prison representative spoke about that facility's N.A. group, an institutional meeting in place for nearly four years.

Unlike Copeland, Camp Five sought the help of local A.A. members to start its meeting, which took place at 6:00 p.m. each Saturday. The meeting had the support of local N.A. members; Bob M. and several others attended it regularly for years.

For several years, the fellowship in and around Pensacola existed in isolation. They grew slowly until eventually, there was a meeting held every night of the week.

CARRYING THE MESSAGE BEYOND FLORIDA

Bob R., originally from Missouri, came to Florida for treatment at the Palm Beach Institute, a private treatment center located in downtown West Palm Beach. He attended the Mainline Group while in treatment and immediately knew it was where he belonged. His new friends at the meeting included Mary and Keith, who would leave a lasting impression.

After returning to Missouri in the summer of 1979, Bob was unable to find N.A. By the fall, however, he found other addicts in A.A., and together they started the first meeting in the Show-Me State. Bob soon discovered addicts from different parts of the state who were creating N.A. meetings. Early the following year, they formed an area service committee.

Bob never lost touch with his Florida roots and later was selected to speak at the 19th World Convention in Orlando. Bob's wife was ill at the time, but she insisted he go. Sadly, she passed away while he was speaking in Orlando.

Steve M. moved to Nashville from Fort Lauderdale. He had attended N.A. in both Fort Lauderdale and Miami. Using the World Directory, he could not find any active meetings around Nashville. In late December, he went to A.A. and found other addicts. Steve carried his *Little White Book* in his pocket, sharing it with any addict he met. He quickly became acquainted with, and was welcomed by, Gina H. and a few others. Gina found a place for the city's first open N.A. meeting, which began by April 1980.

These are just the first of many illustrations in this publication of members from the Florida fellowship who played a significant role in assisting in the birth and growth of Narcotics Anonymous throughout the country and across the globe.

THE MAQUERADE BALL

The new ASC's first fundraiser was held at the small house at the end of the runway at the Pilot's bunkhouse at Fort Lauderdale Airport in early December. There was plenty of participation from members from Miami and Fort Lauderdale, as well as a large contingent from the local Young People's A.A. Group. Surprisingly, they netted a $500 profit, enough money to attain an answering service for both Dade and Broward Counties.

HOTLINES

Karen D. researched their options and finally settled on an answering service named Ding-A-Ling, which seemed appropriate. The service provided a phone number for both Dade and Broward counties. In late February, the hotlines, as they were referred to, were up and running. Karen was the de facto Broward chairperson, with her home phone serving as the first hotline until the answering service started. The number of calls was initially slow but steadily rose. Many of those initial calls came from family members and loved ones of active addicts. Clearly, the one by-product of these hotlines was the formation of Nar-Anon.

MAINLINE WAITS PATIENTLY

The February South Florida ASC meeting in West Palm Beach's Olive Avenue meeting place was received poorly. The Mainline Group had been in existence for five years. Bob B., Toby, Mary, Keith and John A. were just some of those in attendance. The area had welcomed their participation, but the group was hesitant and decided not to join at the time. Mainline existed successfully in complete isolation for years and distrusted what they believed to be a brash group of young addicts to the south. The group did have a GSR, but without an area, his main responsibility was to communicate with the WSO and purchase their literature, while sending regular donations to the office.

Although Mainline refused to join the area immediately, there were positive outcomes. It was agreed that the group and ASC would stay in touch to get to know each other better. Shortly after the meeting, Mainline decided to get its own hotline. Subsequently, Bob G., Rosalie, Nina P., and Big Robert attended activities in West Palm Beach, creating a closer relationship. At one particular event, the area people met a relative newcomer – an energetic soul named Jason T. He would play a pivotal role in bridging the gap between the West Palm Beach and Fort Lauderdale fellowships. This relationship ultimately resulted in the formation of the Gold Coast and eventually Palm Coast Areas.

THE MIAMI HERALD

Once the hotlines were in place, the need for public information activities took center stage. Big Robert had a contact at the Miami Herald who arranged an interview. Karen D. and Big Robert were interviewed

about the N.A. program. The article was published in the Miami Herald on January 27, 1980, and was widely read. The response was unexpected, as friends, parents, spouses and other loved ones of suffering addicts began calling the answering services, leading to the formation of Nar-Anon in South Florida.

Surprisingly, only one addict actually called as a direct result of the article. Paul E. cut the article out and posted it on his refrigerator, but was not quite ready to make the call. However, he called the following month and spoke with Karen D. As luck would have it, the two would eventually marry. Kurt, a local member, gave Paul a ride to the Natural High Group, but the newcomer was apprehensive and not convinced this group would work for him. Yet, he returned that Tuesday to the New Freedom Group. After leaving prematurely, Paul ran into Mark F. outside the meeting. Ironically, the two had grown up and used together in New York. So Paul returned for the remainder of the meeting. Today, he is still clean!

TOMMY B. VISIT

Tommy B. from Atlanta was elected chairperson of the WSC in April 1979. He worked for an airline, which gave him the opportunity to travel free-of-charge and visit fellowships around the country. His purpose was to ensure emerging local fellowships, areas, and regions were represented at the conference to facilitate improved communication fellowship-wide.

In February of 1980, Tommy had a trip on his itinerary that included Fort Lauderdale, so he called ahead and ended up attending the New Freedom Group. Since the group was alerted in advance about his visit, Rosalie, Marvin and others from Miami were able to attend. After the meeting closed, an impromptu area meeting took place. Tommy briefly introduced himself and urged the others to participate in the next conference; he fielded questions for the following hour.

It was an important visit because Tommy B. represented the entire fellowship through the service structure. In essence, South Florida was immediately accepted as a legitimate ASC.

NEW ALTERNATIVES TO SURVIVAL

In early 1980, Kenny N., also known as "Skinny Kenny," spoke to Dr. Delores Morgan at South Miami Hospital's Chemical Dependency

Treatment Unit, and discussed starting a meeting there. Dr. Morgan was not an avid supporter of N.A. at the time, as she did not believe it would survive the test of time. She felt addicts were too troublesome. Later, she confided she initially only referred those she considered unlikely to recover to N.A. She feared that if allowed entrance to her facility, recovering addicts would smuggle drugs to patients. However, her patients were predominately drug addicts. With some hesitation, Kenny was allowed to start a group at the facility. It was named New Alternatives, and patients were allowed to attend.

New Alternatives was not an N.A. meeting, although Kenny would read from the Little White Book and other approved informational pamphlets. Yet, it met the criteria of Narcotics Anonymous in every respect. The meeting caught on immediately and the results were evident. Within a short period, an actual N.A. meeting was started on the outside – the Survival Group. St. Louis Catholic Church was the site of its first meeting in April. The group then moved – this time with the blessings of Dr. Morgan – to the auditorium at South Miami Hospital. The Survival Group remains a cornerstone of the South Dade area. Kenny, Lee B., and the other members had achieved a huge breakthrough.

South Dade is made up of middle-class bedroom communities, trendy areas, affluent enclaves, alongside the predominantly Hispanic neighborhoods near "Little Havana." So almost immediately, Survival attracted a diverse crowd consisting of the more affluent as well as Hispanics – then new to the fellowship in South Florida – who primarily spoke Spanish. Demographically, South Dade's early affluent fellowship differed vastly from those in North Dade and Fort Lauderdale, whose members consisted mostly of prototypical addicts – "junkies and stoners."

The South Miami treatment program sent thousands of addicts into the South Dade fellowship over the next decade. Many early members such as Lee B., George H., Leah G., Jay R., Kenny, Bob K., Steve D., and Jim G. found N.A. through this hospital. The group in turn influenced the hospital's program, which changed its name to the Addiction Treatment Program. Other centers used more confusing terminology such as chemical dependency, alcohol and drug, and substance abuse.

THE CARE UNIT AT NORTH MIAMI GENERAL

Just as South Miami Hospital began accepting addicts into treatment, the Care Unit at North Miami General Hospital also opened their doors to addicts that March. Marvin S. held an unofficial institutional meeting in the unit and gained approval to take patients to outside meetings. John L. was one patient Marvin took to his first N.A. meeting and who was quite influenced by Marvin's example. Though new to recovery, John immediately developed a passion similar to Marvin's for reaching out to those in institutions. Together, they touched the lives of many in these facilities. Following the lead of South Miami Hospital, the Care Unit sent hundreds of addicts into the North Dade fellowship over the coming years. It was the first facility to provide every patient with a *Little White Book* as a part of his or her reading material.

THE WEST COAST – BRADENTON

Alice was admitted for the second time to a treatment center late in 1979. She had heard about Narcotics Anonymous earlier while in a West Palm Beach treatment center. She checked the local phone directory with no results, finally contacting a friend in Tampa who heard of N.A. but believed they were only located in California. After several vain attempts at contacting the World Service Office for information, Alice finally found one *Little White Book* through a friend in Tampa.

The trio of Alice, her husband David, and their friend Phil, received permission to use the Christ Episcopal Church and created the Fresh Start Group of N.A. on April 12, 1980, which met on Saturday nights. This would become the first open meeting on the west coast of Florida, preceded only by the institutional meeting at Copeland Road Prison, south of Naples. Fresh Start eventually moved to Sacred Heart Catholic Church in downtown Bradenton, where it met for years. They subsequently joined the Bay Area Service Committee once it formed in 1982.

THE SOUTHERNMOST MEETING IN THE U.S.A

Key West is the southernmost city in the United States, located closer to Cuba than the U.S. mainland. In 1969, it became the site of the first N.A. meeting ever held in Florida. When the spring of 1980 arrived, a second meeting started. The '69 meeting had been one of only a few dozen in the world; yet this 1980 meeting was one of a few dozen in Florida alone.

Due to its isolated location and the transient nature of its attendees, meetings in the Florida Keys would struggle for several years before finding stability and growth. The free-spirited nature of Keys' residents was obviously manifested in the local A.A. fellowship's lenient approach with addicts.

The new meeting was held in Big Coppitt Key, just north of the old city – Key West. At first, the group virtually consisted of only Steve W. and his wife Pam. The couple basically held it together for some time. It was one of the very few closed meetings in Florida, held at 8:30 p.m. Wednesday nights at 718A 4th Street. It folded when the couple moved away.

However, another meeting eventually started up in April 1982, at the Community Mental Health Center on the old Navy base's Truman Annex. This was a weekly Saturday night, 7:00 p.m., discussion meeting, which grew into the Key Recovery Group. Several months later, the Florida Keys Medical Center on Stock Island became the site of yet another new meeting.

BOB G. GOES TO CALIFORNIA

In early April of that year, Bob G. called the WSO to inquire about the upcoming World Service Conference and spoke with Jimmy K. With the encouragement of Jimmy, Tommy B. and Bo S., he decided to pay his own way to California. Bob was given $200 by the Gold Coast ASC to purchase literature in order to establish a stockpile as an alternative to reprinting it. The conference was held May 2-4 at L.A. Valley College.

A role call of the attendees included the Southern and Northern California, Midwest and Southeast Regions; actually, the latter did not even meet the qualifications of an official Region. Also represented were an assortment of ASC's and individual addicts from Hawaii, Alabama, Tennessee, New Jersey, Virginia, Western Pennsylvania, West Virginia, Ohio, Texas, Nevada, and Idaho – and for the first time, Florida. This group represented a significant increase in participation over previous conferences.

Southern and Northern California had fully developed regional service committees, the only two regions with duly elected representatives. The other representatives consisted of elected or non-elected participants from ASC's, as well as from informal areas or groups. "We were mostly a

group of concerned citizens in N.A., basically volunteers from small and undeveloped fellowships," Bob recalls. The attendees were referred to as "delegates" instead of "representatives."

After the meeting, Bob was introduced to Jimmy K. He was invited to Jimmy's home, where they talked about every meeting in Florida Jimmy had contact with over the years. Bob handed Jimmy the envelope with money, and the following morning Jimmy brought him a small box containing 100 copies of each piece of literature in existence. Oddly, Jimmy never looked in the envelope. Bob told him he wanted $100 worth of white books and of each informational pamphlet. Jimmy responded, "We might not have that much." The South Floridian was shocked and surprised that his meager order could possibly deplete the WSO's available literature stockpile. Jimmy returned to the conference the next day with several boxes containing five hundred *Little White Books*.

Each delegate gave informal reports of service activities and events in their respective parts of the country. All conference participants paid close attention to the number of meetings in each area. Of the 16 states represented at the conference, only the Pennsylvania, Southern and Northern California regions, and Texas and Georgia had more meetings than Florida. It was clear the fellowship was only in its infancy.

The number of meetings in Florida ranked sixth among the states. This was an alarming revelation, as the South Florida Area had only been in existence a short eight months. The 23 meetings consisted of four loner meetings, the Mainline's three meetings, and six in Dade County, with the remainder in Broward County.

Several noteworthy decisions were made the next day:

- Hospital & Institution cans were approved for use in any N.A. meeting. Essentially, they were coffee cans with Hospitals & Institutions labels wrapped around the outside. They were passed, in addition to the standard 7th Tradition baskets, to collect money for H&I literature for several years – having both a positive and a negative impact.

- The World Literature Committee submitted a handbook for approval, and a second WLC was scheduled immediately following the upcoming Wichita convention. The literature movement was officially underway, with an "N.A. Big Book" as the goal.

- A motion was passed that any N.A. meeting using non-conference approved literature (most notably A.A. literature) should be removed from meeting lists.

Although obviously an appropriate decision, it remained a major source of discontent in smaller fellowship communities.

Jimmy K. gave the WSO report. Although usually very direct, his explanation of the relationship of the WSO to its publishing arm CARENA was unsettling to even his most avid supporters. Due to the convoluted way, the WSO was described in the service manual, along with Jimmy's claim that the two corporations were essentially not answerable to the conference; mistrust arose for both Jimmy and the WSO.

Most importantly, after speaking to several other participants, it became clear that Florida could easily be in position to place a successful bid for the next World Convention; no other community had expressed any serious interest at this point.

JACKSONVILLE AGAIN

In the spring of 1980, a third attempt was made to initiate an on-going N.A. meeting in Jacksonville. This time the fledgling meeting lasted nearly a year until January 1981. It did however function as the founding meeting there.

This inaugural group was another attempt by one of those who participated with the previous folks. The closed discussion meeting took place at the Riverside Tradition House located at 2911 Riverside Avenue on Saturday evening at 8:00 p.m.

A small group of eight to fifteen attended this meeting. The group had obtained a small amount of literature and for the first time they were able to hand out "chips." Still, this was the third failed inaugural meeting in Jacksonville.

PAUL E. GOES TO THE BIG APPLE

Bob brought "the suitcase full of *Little White Books*" to the New Freedom Group that Tuesday. After the May 6 meeting, Paul E., a relative newcomer, grabbed an armful of the booklets.

Paul was on disability and was traveling to New York City to visit his father, though he had another purpose in mind. He wanted to share his newfound experience with addicts in the Big Apple. New York was still virgin territory for N.A. The state's Rockefeller Law, named after its then-governor, outlawed the congregation of convicted felons, which law enforcement interpreted to include all "known addicts."

Upon arrival, Paul attended A.A. meetings, seeking out addicts and subsequently sharing the *Little White Book* with them. Paul was an unabashed New Yorker with a distinguishing voice and intense personality. His whit and sincerity were infectious, enabling him to become a recognizable and amiable figure in the local fellowship.

The next year, Terry R. from Queens, N.Y., came to Florida to visit his friend Maureen – the same woman who named the New Freedom Group from her prison cell. She took Terry to the Clean & Serene Group in Pompano. He attended other N.A. meetings while in Fort Lauderdale and soon he was noticeably transformed from this benign introduction to Narcotics Anonymous. Upon his return to the Big Apple, he became a founding member of the Narcotics Anonymous fellowship there; starting the metropolis's first meeting in April 1981.

SOUTH AFRICAN CONNECTION

Ironically, the same evening Paul grabbed a pile of books for his journey to New York, Rick E., an avid member of Young People's A.A., also asked for some literature. Rick had recently been selected by the A.A. General Service Office to participate in an exchange program with overseas fellowships. He was to leave shortly for Johannesburg, South Africa. Therefore, Rick also left the meeting with a bundle of *Little White Books*, a '70s version of the N.A. group starter kit and a few informational pamphlets. He promised to distribute them to those interested in starting meetings there, and he did!

Eight months later, the World Service Office received a letter from an addict living in a suburb of Johannesburg. She reported one "rabbit" meeting in existence for those in A.A. who used drugs other than alcohol. They were holding a weekly Friday night "meet and eat." Those attending the meeting would bring covered dishes. Martin, the group's secretary, noted the group's success had led to the planning of a second meeting.

Incredibly, the suitcase full of *Little White Books* literally traveled thousands of miles from Jimmy K. in California to Fort Lauderdale and then to New York City, South Africa, The Virgin Islands and several other cities.

1st EAST COAST CONVENTION – BUCKNELL UNIVERSITY

In June, four South Florida members attended the 1st East Coast Convention at Bucknell University in Lewisburg, Pennsylvania. Lewisburg was the site of one of the oldest N.A. meetings on the eastern seaboard. The

importance of this event was simple: it was the first gathering of Narcotics Anonymous in the Northeast. Many of the founding members of the Pennsylvania fellowship were there. Guido chaired the convention, and Bob P. from Pittsburgh was the dance D.J. Dick F. – "the father of Narcotics Anonymous on the East Coast" – attended his one and only N.A. convention and was the Sunday-morning speaker.

Although there were fewer than 200 addicts at this three-day retreat, it served as a catalyst for the growth of the fellowship throughout the northeast for years to come. In addition to the Pennsylvania members, addicts showed up from New York, New Jersey, Maryland, West Virginia, Virginia, Ohio, Tennessee, Louisiana, Georgia, Alabama, Florida, California, Nebraska, and Kansas.

Inadvertently, this event provided Florida with a major opportunity. Three of the six reasonably developed fellowships east of the Rockies had hosted a major event in the previous few years. Only formal bids would be taken seriously from Minnesota, Wisconsin, and Florida for the next world convention. The only other possibility would be an entry from California. But most in attendance adamantly resisted any move back to California, primarily due to the growing displeasure and distrust with the WSO. Nina P. and the others from Florida began gathering support and promoting the Sunshine State to the attendees.

Bo S. held an unscheduled literature workshop. "He resembled an evangelist working the crowd from a pulpit," one addict recalled. The workshop, in effect, became a recruiting session for those not exposed to the literature movement, producing a newfound passion for the urgent completion of the "The Book."

NAPLES – THE GULF COAST

The summer of 1980 was eventful indeed, as the first open N.A. meeting in Southwest Florida began in June. In late 1978, a group of A.A. members got together and started and A.A. offshoot meeting. If a drug addict came to the A.A. meeting at Trinity, they were sent to "the back room" where the "druggies" met. Addicts were not welcomed into A.A. readily then. A few A.A. women decided to start a "secret" meeting; they met at the Lely Firehouse, although this meeting only lasted a little more than a month.

In April, Mike T. and two friends drove across the alley to Fort Lauderdale; they attended a meeting there and were able to get some N.A. literature – one *Little White Book*. Finally, in June 1980, they started the first N.A. meeting in Naples. The addicts then began to meet Thursday nights at 8:00 p.m. in the "back room" at Trinity by the Cove located in the Port Royal section of town. They met there for about nine months and then moved to an A.A. clubroom. Later, this fledgling group became the Crossroad Group. Mike, Richard, and Shirley were some of its early members.

A meeting was originally created there in 1975 at Copeland Road Prison, becoming the first institutional meeting in the state. However, prison officials allowed very limited participation from outsiders. Johnnie, Richard, Willie, and Adolph were the trusted servants of that group. However, they were actually allowed out to attend the new N.A. meeting. Copeland later hosted events at their facility as a close relationship developed over the years.

The next summer, Big Robert drove across Alligator Alley, a notoriously dangerous two-lane road linking Fort Lauderdale to Naples on the southwest coast. He attended an A.A. meeting there and found several addicts. They talked about Narcotics Anonymous, and Robert left his new friends with a copy of the *Review Form – the Grey Book* – of what would later become the *Basic Text*. Robert also informed them about the upcoming convention in Miami.

Mike was one of a handful of addicts from around the state who attended the world convention a few months later. He became the "Face of the Gulf Coast fellowship" for several years.

Two other meetings followed in Naples on Monday and Thursday nights, but it was not until 1984 that an area service committee formed, consisting of groups in Naples, Bonita Springs and Fort Myers to the north. Until then, the Florida Regional Service Committee (RSC) had accepted Mike as the representative of the Naples fellowship. He attended the first Florida Regional Convention and his first regional meeting on the Sunday following the convention.

FIRST MEETING LIST – *"From the Palm Beaches to Key West"*

Finally, there were enough meetings to create a Florida meeting list. The heading on the cover came from a phrase used by a local pop radio

station: "From The Palm Beaches to Key West." The hospital and institution meetings were listed amongst the open meetings. The list included those in South Florida, as well as meetings in Pensacola almost six hundred miles away. Nineteen entries, including the H&I meetings, were listed in this initial edition as well as the hotlines for each of the three counties.

THE SATURDAY NIGHT LIVE GROUP

The Back Room Club had closed due to internal strife, and the meetings in Miami were adapting to new surroundings. Many who had become accustomed to simply showing up at the Back Room now had to set up new meeting facilities, order literature, make coffee and clean up – responsibilities that had previously been taken for granted. However, this was an opportunity for the fellowship to grow beyond the doors of a clubroom.

One key event would create an atmosphere of unity and hope. A new meeting was started in North Miami to create unity between members from South Dade, North Dade, and Broward Counties. It was scheduled for the only night that previously lacked a scheduled meeting. The popular show Saturday Night Live was adopted as the name of the group. This meeting would truly bring addicts together and form a core group of the trusted servants. The first meeting met in Phil D.'s house, as did many service committee meetings. Then the meeting found a more stable home at the First Lutheran Church at 12800 N.E. 6th Avenue in North Miami. Started originally as a unity meeting, bringing together members from the three counties. They became the core group of trusted servants in South Florida and beyond. It exceeded its original purpose, creating relationships that have lasted over 20 years.

After the meeting, addicts would gather for "all-nighters," staying up and sharing about themselves and their hopes in this new way of life. The all-nighters were held at the homes of various members, including Angie, Carolyn Q., Phil D., and Patti H. Some called them "Nara-thons."

THE WCNA-11 BID PACKAGE

The South Florida Area Service Committee appointed an ad hoc committee in May to create a bid package, in hopes of being selected the site of the 11th World Convention. The upcoming 10th World Convention was to be held in Wichita, Kansas. The committee was convinced that if a suitable hotel on the beach could be found, it would easily succeed in its quest. The beach would likely attract thousands of addicts to South Florida. During the months preceding the Wichita gathering, several trusted servants visited half-dozen hotels. They even made an unrealistic attempt to secure the posh Fontainebleau Hilton Resort. The Newport Beach Hotel and the Marco Polo Resort Hotel submitted suitable offers.

When Wichita delegates presented their bid at the Atlanta convention for the 10th World Convention, they said 20 meetings then existed in Kansas and surrounding areas. Therefore, the South Floridians believed they needed at least 20 to qualify as a suitable bidder, but only 17 existed just prior to the convention, and this included those held in institutions. The single meetings in Pensacola, Bradenton, and Orlando were included on the list, which still left the count one short of 20, so Bob and Nina typed in a non-existent meeting. The word at the time was that the entire bid package was a sham, but the single non-existent meeting was the only misleading information. Finally, it was given to Nina to take to the convention.

THE LAND OF OZ – WICHITA, KANSAS

In late August, Big Robert loaded his car and headed toward Kansas. First, he stopped at the Rising Sun Clubhouse in Marietta, Georgia, just outside of Atlanta. Once he arrived, Bo S. asked him to give another friend a ride. So on his way to Wichita, Robert stopped again in Tennessee to pickup Gina H. Meanwhile, Rosalie R. and Nina P. were boarding planes from Miami and Fort Lauderdale, respectively, and John A. began his odyssey hitchhiking from West Palm Beach. Each was on their way to the Land of Oz.

The 10th World Convention was held September 4-7, 1980, at Wichita's Broadview Hotel. The hotel had a long history dating back nearly

60 years, another in the line of grand hotels. This was the first major event in the Great Plains and would leave the local and surrounding fellowships healthy and vibrant.

Just over 300 addicts showed up, with about a third coming from outside Kansas. The four Floridians were busy seeking endorsements from all in attendance; a Saturday-morning business meeting was held with just one item on the agenda: the presentation of bids for the next world convention. The only serious contenders were from Milwaukee and Miami. After three days in the Great Plains, the prospect of spending four days on Miami Beach was the obvious choice.

This was a significant achievement for the fledgling Florida fellowship. Just a year prior, there were only a few active groups with just six meetings and no more than a few dozen members.

The 10th World Convention was one of the most successful conventions financially, making a respectable profit. The revenues paid off the remaining debt from the Atlanta convention, while defraying some of the expenses for the upcoming literature conference. It also assisted the Miami convention.

The 2nd World Literature Conference took place immediately following the convention from September 8-14 in Lincoln, Nebraska. The committee became obsessed, working at "hyper speed" in the following year, on the production of a text for Narcotics Anonymous. Five conferences, beginning with the one held in Lincoln, were held that year. These events laid the groundwork for much of the literature available in the fellowship today.

Meanwhile, the Floridians were more concerned about the next convention, knowing it would create a completely new awareness and era of growth in Narcotics Anonymous in the Sunshine State, as it had in Kansas. Nina P., Rosalie R., Big Robert, and John A. returned to Florida from The Land Of Oz with the sense that something special was about to occur — and it did!

TOGETHER MORE THAN EVER

Both excitement and apprehension abounded in South Florida following the Wichita convention and Lincoln literature conference. After all, very few local members had ever experienced Narcotics Anonymous outside of their home group. Many members of the WCNA Planning Committee were also involved in the area service committee.

The first planning meeting was held September 14, the Sunday following the Wichita Convention, at Fort Lauderdale's St. Francis Mission. Rosalie, Big Robert, and Nina P. shared about the Wichita experience.

Elections were held, and Rosalie R. was selected as chairperson, Big Robert as vice-chairperson and Nina P. as secretary. Karen D., trustworthy and the resident "old-timer," was elected treasurer, with Rich V. as her alternate or assistant treasurer.

The meeting was characterized by tremendous participation and support, and there were multiple nominations for each position. Joan D. would handle the Registration Committee and Leah G. would later assist her. Bob G. was elected Hotel Liaison & Hospitality Committee chairperson. He recruited Dwayne L. to assist with the hospitality and Joey P. with transportation. Valen E., a professional artist, was a perfect fit as Arts & Graphics chairperson. George H. was elected Public Relations chair with Lee B. assisting him. A priority for the committee was the avoidance of two pitfalls encountered at past world conventions: financial losses and substandard speakers. Paul E. was elected Entertainment and Fundraising chairperson. At the time, he possessed the most personable and aggressive personality on the committee, making him the obvious choice. Paul recruited Phil D. to assist him. Meanwhile, Kurt E., amiable and steadfast, became Program Committee chairperson, recruiting Hollywood Tom as vice chair.



1st East Coast Convention – Bucknell University – 1980



11th World Convention – Marco Polo Hotel – Miami Beach – 1981



Holy Cross Episcopal – 6th World Literature Conference – 1981



1st Florida Regional Service Committee meeting – 1981

A second meeting was held two weeks later to select the theme, identify the convention hotel, and to decide how much to charge for registration. A convention flyer could then be printed and distributed by the year's end.

Paul E. called the theme selection process a "spiritual experience." The suggestions offered were weak, and it came down to two choices: "Together More Than Ever" and an "off the wall" suggestion that no one seemed to recall. It was something like "No More Needles *or* From Heroin to Happiness." The latter titles, surprisingly, were the favorite by consensus, as most early members were junkies. However, after some strong arguments, Rosalie suggested the committee take a break and pray for "God's will." Upon their return, all the hands were raised for "Together More Than Ever."

The quantity of convention flyers produced quickly became important. Ten thousand flyers were printed and distributed to every known address in the fellowship. More importantly, thousands were distributed in Florida. The mailing included every treatment center listed in the Florida Alcohol and Drug Abuse Association directory. In a sense, this was a grand Public Information activity. Now hundreds would know of the convention, but more importantly, they would know of Narcotics Anonymous. In this manner, a few recipients heard about N.A. for the first time. Three meetings in Florida were formed as a result of the flyer mailing.

The Area Service and Convention Planning Committees would meet in succession on the same day since many committee members were serving in multiple capacities. One event at the time was particularly noteworthy: The WCNA Planning and ASC meetings had generally taken place each month in member homes. The next was scheduled at Phil D's house. Phil had a roommate named Billy who was still using and dealing drugs. Phil's living room had a large sliding glass door that overlooked a pool area. Oddly, on that noticeably sunny day, all the shades were drawn tight. Phil warned everyone not to look outside. Nevertheless, curious, John L. opened the drapes, which revealed a yard filled with bales of marijuana. Suddenly everyone realized the potential damage the fellowship would incur had authorities caught wind of this scenario. Thus, it was decided future business meetings would no longer take place in member homes.

BO'S VISIT

Bo S. from Atlanta was asked to speak at the Saturday Night Live group in October. He had been asked to spend the weekend in Fort Lauderdale to promote the literature movement to local members. Bob G. arranged for Bo S. to stay with Paul E. The two were in many ways polar opposites, but each recalled their all-night talk fondly.

The next day about 20 addicts gathered at the St. Francis storefront meeting room. Bo gave everyone an overview of the literature movement and its goal of completing "The Book." Previously, only a handful of local members had knowledge of all that had occurred. As part of his "ritualistic dog and pony show," the Georgia native carried a footlocker containing much of the prospective book's unedited material. Eventually, people began asking, "What can I do?" Bo emphasized the need for members' personal stories for the compilation process. Many of those in attendance wrote and submitted their stories to the World Literature Committee. Before returning to Atlanta, Bo visited his old friend Buddha Bob. Bob was too busy with his thriving business to actively participate in the literature movement, but instead chose to assist quietly and anonymously.

FAST TRACK RECOVERY – DAYTONA BEACH

Ben W. found recovery in Narcotics Anonymous in 1970. With barely a month clean, he was hired by Bob B. to work at Impact House, a fledgling treatment center in Sun Valley, California. In the fall of 1980, Ben and his wife moved cross-country to Daytona Beach. An entrepreneur seeking out new opportunity, he and his spouse purchased a hotel on the beach.

The city of Daytona back then was essentially a small town and was known mainly as a haven for spring break college students and an annual gathering of motorcycle enthusiasts. It was also billed as the home of the Super Bowl of NASCAR – the Daytona 500. Ben became the founding member of the N.A. fellowship there. Both he and his wife had a decade in recovery, a rarity in Florida at that time. Consequently, the local fellowship had its first old-timer before the new members ever met.

Ben recruited several other addicts from A.A., resulting in the first Daytona meeting on January 15, 1981. This small discussion meeting was named the Sunshine Group and was held Thursdays at the Central Baptist Church on Fairview. Ben knew of the upcoming world convention and

literature conference in Miami and planned to attend both. It would also serve as a great opportunity to reconnect with his old friend Bob B. While in Miami, he was welcomed to the Florida fellowship by several of the members from South Florida.

A letter was sent out announcing the upcoming formation of a regional service committee in Florida. The registration list from WCNA-11 was used to notify everyone in the state. Limited by business commitments, Ben could not become as involved as he wished, so he asked Ted C., another Daytona trusted servant, to pinch hit.

Ted, now representing Daytona, attended the RSC in January 1982, reporting his new area had two meetings. These were the humble beginnings of the third area to join the Florida Region.

West Palm Beach hosted the first two regional meetings. At the second meeting, it was decided subsequent meetings be rotated around the region in order to reach out to entire fellowships throughout the state. Daytona hosted the next meeting in February. This outreach practice has continued for decades.

Ted was elected the region's first Literature Committee chairperson. He became involved at a time when Florida's commitment to literature development was at its highest. Ultimately, Daytona hosted the 1st Florida Literature Conference in 1982.

THE GREY BOOK

The 3rd World Literature Conference, which took place in Memphis from January 31-February 8, 1981, resulted in the printing of the *Grey Book* or Draft Form of the prospective N.A. Book. It was a draft of material compiled during the past several years. It was a significant starting point, as now the end zone was in sight, and members nationwide were asked for financial support. Their goal was to complete an Approval Form of the book and submit it to the World Service Conference in May.

Donations indeed arrived. A later financial report listed several from Florida: The Survival Group sent $300, while Paul E. and Patti H. donated $30 and $20, respectively. Never before had a conference of this sort produced so much in such a short time span. The book was distributed freely to members across the country. The fourth World Literature Conference was scheduled for the week prior to the WSC in late April.

BEYOND MAINLINE

Jayson T. had become the GSR of West Palm's Mainline Group. Big Robert, Nina P., Rosalie R., and Bob G. came to visit one day, encouraging the group's participation in the upcoming World Convention and inviting them to join the ASC. Jayson's relationship with the Broward and Dade addicts had enhanced over the past year. He had attended meetings in Fort Lauderdale and favored his group's admission to the area. Mainline had been in existence for nearly seven years without the support of other nearby groups. The Strawberry Fields Group became the second Palm Beach County group, meeting at Lake Worth's Lake Hospital on Wednesday nights in April. Soon, other groups were started there. The Saturday Step group was the third meeting.

KAREN D. GOES WEST

The Area Service Committee held a fundraiser, securing the cash necessary to send Karen F. and George H. to the World Service Conference, thus making them the first formally elected representatives from Florida to attend the conference.

Karen was the old-timer in the fellowship, having found hope in A.A. nearly ten years earlier. She was a charter member of the New Freedom Group and the South Florida Area Service Committee and was the treasurer for the upcoming World Convention. She also sponsored many women in N.A.

George, on the other hand, was a virtual newcomer. The son of a prominent state senator who worked as a Senate Page during his active addiction, he was well acquainted with parliamentary procedure. Service involvement seemed predestined for George. Upon his release from South Miami Hospital, Lee B. brought him to his first outside meeting that weekend an area service committee meeting! Upon discovering George's most important asset. The ASC immediately and unanimously elected him as the alternate representative. Given his wife Sue worked for Pan American Airways, he could travel free-of-charge!

The WSC was held May 1-3, 1981. Karen gave her report the first day, announcing 35 meetings that existed in Florida. She spoke about the considerable work of the area sub-committees, especially with regard to hospitals and institutions. Karen also gave a brief report on the brand new meeting in New York City. The South Florida Area had donated *Little*

White Books, and Paul E. was traveling there regularly to support the meeting. Karen gave a pitch for the upcoming world convention in Miami, passing out registration flyers to all those in attendance.

In his book, *My Years with Narcotics Anonymous*, former World Service Office manager Bob Stone titled his the ninth chapter, "Open Conflict." Prior to the conference, Jimmy K., then the WSO manager and board president, and Board of Trustees chairman, Chuck S., met to discuss the progress of the literature committee. Unfortunately, according to Stone, their conversation was extremely acrimonious! Chuck believed the book would save many lives and should be completed quickly. Conversely, Jimmy was not as optimistic and wanted final say. The ensuing discussion was anything but peaceful or cooperative, and this was abundantly evident at the conference. Bitter disputes surfaced quickly, reaching rancorous levels. The WSO and WLC became diametrically opposed in their objectives, creating an on-going conflict lasting for years.

The office passed out its report as well as a letter to the participants announcing that each regional committee chairperson would be automatically placed on the WSO's Advisory Board of Directors. Most perceived this as a veiled attempt to circumvent the literature committee's fundraising success. According to various estimates, the literature committee had collected between $25,000 and $50,000 the previous year. Yet the WSO's historically meager donations totaled less than $5,000 during the same period. There was no mention of the vast amount of money raised by the use of Hospital-and-Institution cans.

The rancor between the office and the literature committee was enormous; the rift was so evident during the conference that even neutral and uninformed parties began to take adversarial positions. The office declared itself independent from the fellowship and thus only responsible to its own board. This issue became a focal point of discussions throughout the fellowship during the coming year.

During the conference, however, one key decision was agreed upon that had a direct and immediate impact on Florida. It was decided that "...no outside enterprise *be* listed in meeting directories" There had been obvious emotional ties between the N.A. and Nar-Anon fellowships. Despite the approved motion, Nar-Anon remained listed for several more years.

DADE COUNTY AREA GROWS

"The number of meetings in Dade County had doubled in the past year, and such rapid growth could hardly be ignored. The 11th World Convention was just four months away and addicts could attend N.A. every night of the week. At long last, addicts were able to find complete recovery in Narcotics Anonymous without attending other fellowships.

Without much debate, it became obvious that Dade needed to form its own area. George, Lee, Leah, Rosalie, John, Joey, Steve, Bob, Jim and other active members created the Dade County Area Service Committee, which began in May with nine groups and a handful of hospital & institution meetings. George was elected the new area's chairperson. Its main focus was reaching out to those in institutions. Opportunities for growth were unlimited, as Miami was home to a half-dozen therapeutic communities, a dozen hospital or residential treatment programs, as well as an extensive array of local, state, and federal prisons.

JACKSONVILLE – THE FIRST COAST

Jacksonville was the site of the first European settlement in Florida, but it was never a Spanish stronghold. In 1562, Jean Ribault and a group of settlers, mostly Huguenots who wanted to escape religious persecution, came ashore and claimed the land for France. They later established Fort Caroline at the mouth of the St. Johns River. Citing a previous claim to Florida made during the 1513 voyage of discovery by Ponce de Leon, Spain quickly dispatched soldiers to rid the land of the French interlopers.

Jacksonville is the largest city in Florida and the largest city in the United States by land area. It is a major hub of commerce and has extensive freight-handling facilities. Blessed with a deep-water port, the town has prospered from shipyards, automobile imports, and naval operations that played a key role in the birth of N.A. in Jacksonville.

Following the third "false start" in Jacksonville, in the fall of 1980, an N.A. meeting would begin and this time it functioned as the "mother group," giving birth to the Jacksonville fellowship.

Rick L. was a military brat who'd ironically found recovery through the military at a Naval hospital treatment program. He never felt quite comfortable in A.A.; he attended a Narcotics Anonymous meeting while in treatment and felt comfortable there.

Rick decided to start a meeting for addicts, so with the assistance of some friends, they recruited other addicts out of A.A. meetings. The Free to Be Group began meeting on Thursday nights at 7:00 p.m. at the Alcohol Rehab Center – Building 590 on Keily Street at the Jacksonville Naval Air Station in "either September or October of 1980." They started a second open meeting shortly thereafter at the Tradition House on Saturday nights at 8:00 p.m.

Groups began meeting in Orange Park and Jacksonville Beach. It is not clear whether these were additional meetings or whether the original meetings had moved to other locations. Rick continued recruiting addicts from A.A. meetings to the point of badgering those he believed belonged in N.A. One such addict was Larry J. who finally capitulated after a couple of weeks, attending his first N.A. meeting in July 1982.

In September of 1982, the Jacksonville groups formed their own version of a service structure. A knock-off version of A.A.'s structure was used initially as a guide and met informally in local restaurants. Sandy B. was another person there. She somehow got in contact with Bo S. from Atlanta who gave her some Informational Pamphlets (IP's) that the Jacksonville members promptly photocopied and distributed at their meetings.

Larry J. attended the 2nd Florida Regional Convention in Fort Lauderdale in July 1983. Before he left, he was asked by someone to bring flyers for the A.A. Young People's Convention. Larry was somewhat naïve when it came to the Traditions, so when he was putting them on a table with the other flyers, his friend, Dale A., who visited Jacksonville on business, grabbed him and began explaining the Traditions to him.

One of the first people Larry met was Jim S. from Clearwater who started corresponding with Larry. Jim told him about the regional meetings they had been holding and invited Larry to attend. Again, Larry relented and attended the June 1983 RSC meeting in Orlando as an observer. He was overwhelmed at the committee's response as "everyone was cheering and clapping because Jacksonville had finally arrived!" Larry went back to Jacksonville inspired by the support he received at that meeting. He shared his experience and advocated that Jacksonville formally change their structure and terminology to fit Narcotics Anonymous, and so they did. Larry became ASR of the newly renamed area committee – the First Coast Area – and he held the position for many years.

They started their first Hospital & Institution meeting at the River Region Treatment Center, which became a constant source of newcomers for years to come. Out of this meeting came Don C. and Nick B. Both eventually left Jacksonville and became involved in Gainesville (known as the Uncoast Area) along with their spouses Rose C. and Jane B. Subsequently, these two couples started meetings in and around Ocala, an area that split off from the Uncoast Area to become the Forest Area in 1985.

ST. PETERSBURG – THE BAY AREA

Danny G. was admitted to a therapeutic community in California called Synanon in the '70s. When the facility began to rub him the wrong way, he departed abruptly, stealing his counselor's vehicle and driving east. Danny ended up in a methadone program in Chicago and was thrown out after a year. This resulted in an admission to a detoxification facility in Illinois in the fall of 1978. There he attended his first N.A. meeting, one of only a handful available in that part of the country, finding hope in his life for the very first time.

After leaving the facility, Danny continued to use, wandering in and out of treatment programs across the country. Late in 1980, his sister sent him a plane ticket to the St. Petersburg area. Danny began attending A.A. meetings there and found a sponsor who was involved in Young People's A.A. Danny never felt quite comfortable in A.A., as he was told not to talk about drugs. He kept telling his sponsor about the N.A. meeting he had attended years earlier. His sponsor knew about N.A. in Atlanta, and upon their return from a Young People's A.A. Convention in Minnesota, they stopped in Atlanta. There, Danny was introduced to Greg P. and Bo S., who chided him to start a Narcotics Anonymous meeting in St. Petersburg. With the help of a Little White Book, he did just that!

The inaugural meeting in St. Petersburg was held in the third week of July of 1981 at his girlfriend's house, and 10 people attended. Danny was so enthused, he went out and bought a coffee pot for the meeting the following week – but at that meeting, no one showed up. He then contacted his friend, Brenda, and they found a church for the next meeting. This time three people showed up, forming the DOA group, an acronym for Defeating Our Addiction. The group still meets today.

Danny took it upon himself to communicate with local treatment centers. Several facilities agreed to send patients to the Thursday night

group. Several months later, Henry S. – who initially found N.A. in the early '60s as an inmate at Walla Walla Penitentiary in Washington – walked into the meeting. Henry had stayed clean for a decade before relapsing. He found recovery again in South Dade in 1981 before moving to the Bay area, where he remained clean until his death in the late '90s. Now there was a core group of three clean addicts in St. Petersburg.

A copy of WCNA-11's registration list was used to notify everyone in Florida about the newly formed regional service committee. Danny's sponsor gave him his copy of the letter, and Danny traveled to the next regional meeting in West Palm Beach. Also in attendance was Carol, who had started another meeting in nearby Clearwater – coincidently on the same night as the DOA group. Oddly enough, it was at this RSC where Danny and Carol first met! It was, for all practical purposes, the first meeting of the Bay Area Service Committee, and this newfound partnership precipitated the eventual entrance of the fourth ASC into the Florida Region. Also pivotal in the new area was Jim S., who started another meeting at a treatment center about 20 miles north of DOA.

THE MAGIC CITY – ORLANDO

The existence of the Drydock group at the Naval Air Station provided at least an awareness of Narcotics Anonymous around Orlando. The Grove Counseling Center served as the location of the city's first open meeting in August 1981. Linda C., an ex-Playboy bunny, and George, a paraplegic, were its founding members. Although their participation was short lived, they did manage to keep the doors open until others arrived.

Lovell H., a "suit-and-tie" A.A. member whose addiction was kept mostly under wraps, soon joined the group. He became the contact person for addicts in A.A., leading them to the N.A. meeting. "It was like meeting a new connection," one addict recalled. "I was told to look up Lovell at a particular A.A. meeting, and he would tell you about N.A."

Bruce G. was introduced to N.A. through White Deer Run in Pennsylvania while in treatment that June. Upon discharge, he returned home to New Jersey where he met "Hoboken Joe." Joe introduced him to the three existing N.A. meetings in Northern Jersey. Bruce, who had relatives in Florida, quickly tired of the Garden State and moved to Orlando. After briefly attending A.A., where he spoke openly about his addiction, it was strongly suggested he find Lovell.

Bruce "Biff" K. was admitted to the Palm Beach Institute and was introduced to his first N.A. meeting, the Mainline group, in 1980. Oddly, its members, who had a mistrust of newcomers in those early years, did not greet him. After completing treatment, Biff, a podiatrist, enrolled in a specialty treatment program for physicians in Atlanta, where he found a friendlier version of Narcotics Anonymous.

The Atlanta fellowship was cohesive and relatively large in comparison to the miniscule fellowship in Orlando. Initially, Biff attended a Young People's A.A. meeting, which would split into small groups. "Drug Addicts were sent to the 'other room,'" he recollected. He sat next to Lovell, and another N.A. connection was made.

Bruce, Biff, and Lovell attended the Narcotics Anonymous meeting at the Grove, an adolescent treatment center, and then quickly started the first open meeting in Orlando. This unlikely trio would form the core of Orlando's fellowship for the next decade. Bob B. referred to them as the "Three Musketeers."

In early December, 1981, the three started a new meeting at the annex of a rundown YMCA on Oakridge Road. Shortly thereafter, another was started at the Seminole County Mental Health Facility, known as the Altamonte Springs Counseling Center, this meeting quickly outgrew the facility and moved to St. Mark's Church in Altamonte Springs. This group became known as the Clean & Crazy Group.

Bruce G. had plenty of spare time as his work did not require him to work regular hours. He would ride around and look in various areas of town for meeting places. When he found one, he would get together with Lovell and Biff and they would decide if they wanted to have a meeting at that facility, what the name and format of the group would be and what time it would meet.

The new fellowship would use Biff's office copier to expand its literature supply and print meeting lists, sometimes even on his letterhead. The three men finally acquired their first female member when a full-blown addict named Jackie walked in off the street.

Newcomer Richard N. arrived at St. Mark's early one evening. Eager to get involved, he asked, "What can I do?" Bruce told him to hug everyone coming through the door. After a few weeks, Richard looked around the meeting and noticed about 30 people. He thought, "I must have hugged a 100 people." Afterward, he realized he had hugged everyone, including those attending church meetings, civic meetings – even the Boy

Scout leaders. Bruce visited his parents a few weeks later, locating an N.A. meeting in nearby Fort Lauderdale.

It would be another two years before Orlando had a meeting every night. Many still had an allegiance to the Monday night Young People's A.A. Group. A Monday N.A. meeting was finally created in August, 1983, at which point Orlando had developed a full-time fellowship.

Several of the group's members soon got wind of the new regional service committee, and it was suggested that Orlando send representatives. After returning home, Bruce discussed the matter with Biff and Lovell. After some uncertainty, the three agreed to attend the third regional meeting in Daytona.

TOGETHER MORE THAN EVER

THE MARCO POLO HOTEL – WCNA-11 – MIAMI

"Together More Than Ever" – suggested by a Coral Ridge Hospital patient – became the theme for the upcoming world convention. So much had happened during the past year. Amongst the committee members, dissention and anger sometimes reached a boiling point. Rosalie and Robert diplomatically acted as peacekeepers. Ultimately, however, the moment had arrived: it was convention time and all parties agreed the convention was the single most important event to occur in Florida. Its benefits and repercussions would be felt for decades to come.

The 11th World Convention took place at the Marco Polo Resort in Miami Beach, September 10-13, 1981. During the months prior to the convention, committee members projected attendance estimates ranging from a pessimistic few hundred to a preposterous several thousand. Some uncertainty existed, along with the fear of repeating the financial debacle previously suffered by the Atlanta fellowship. However, 625 registered attendees showed up, representing more states and countries than ever before. An urban legend had the attendance figure ranging far higher due to unofficial participation from local hospitals and institutions. Buddha Bob, a key figure in the '70s, anonymously contributed $1,000 to make it possible for anyone from local hospitals and institutions to attend. Of the registrants, 279 were Floridians; this figure did, however, include registrants from Nar-Anon.

One notable story involves Doug W. Unbelievably; Doug made the entire trip from his home in Lincoln, Nebraska, to Miami on his bicycle. After weeks pedaling, when Doug finally arrived in South Florida, he

simply stayed. He became one of the first regional literature committee chairpersons and regional service office managers. Not surprisingly, he would never take another bicycle trip.

To avoid the pitfalls of previous conventions, all potential speakers had been screened to avoid the inadvertent selection of Young People's A.A. circuit speakers. Chuck S., then Chairman of the Board of Trustees, who had attended all previous world conventions commented, "This was the first real Narcotics Anonymous convention." Long-time Los Angeles member Bob B. concurred.

Page C. from Marietta, Georgia, and Mollie from New Orleans were the Friday evening speakers. Olivia, who months earlier had arrived in the United States from Dublin, Ireland, became the first international speaker. Sally E. from Buena Park, California, was selected as the main speaker at the Saturday evening banquet. At the time, she was the only female Board of Trustee member. Notably, she was one of the first women to stay clean in Narcotics Anonymous. Sally found N.A. when there were just 10 meetings in Southern California in the late '60s.

The banquet was the main event and was sold out, even exceeding the fire regulations for allowable occupancy. Much to George H.'s disappointment, the mayor of Miami, scheduled to welcome the convention to the city, was a no-show. Interestingly, his honor was not the committee's first choice as the welcoming speaker. Their preference was then-Miami Dolphin Head Coach Don Shula, but the beloved coach sent a letter regretfully declining due to a previous engagement in New York the following day with the rival Jets.

Paul E. and Phil D. were given the task of performing a state-by-state roll call. They spent hours at a local library looking up the state birds and flowers to spice up their presentation. Chuck S. spoke on behalf of the Board of Trustees, and Gina H. sang a song she wrote for the fellowship. This was followed by the "entertainment" – a garage band called "The Misfits" who were promptly booed off the stage. Consequently, quick thinking by the convention committee gave way to an impromptu auction where much of South Florida's valuable historical memorabilia was sold. Auctions subsequently became a staple at conventions.

Pastor Conny Sjostrum, a good friend and strong advocate of the local fellowship, opened the spiritual meeting Sunday morning. The closing speaker, Nona B. from Salinas, California, followed.

The convention clearly had a major impact nationwide. Ironically, perhaps one of the most affected places was New York City. Prior to that historical weekend at the Marco Polo, there were only two fledgling meetings in the Big Apple – one in the Bronx and another in Queens. Terry R. and Henry M. came to the convention independent of each other and would meet for the first time at this event. There was an immense sense of empathy and support for these newfound friends. Many of those in attendance who founded and nurtured their local fellowships knew that the task ahead for the duo might be overwhelming. It was common knowledge that New York State's Rockefeller Law had effectively outlawed the Narcotics Anonymous program for years. The law forbade two or more "known addicts" from gathering in public.

The majority of the South Florida fellowship had ties to New York City; therefore an emotional, well-intentioned gesture was offered on their behalf – a token bid for the next world convention. Milwaukee, one of the more developed fellowships at that time, had several enthusiastic members in attendance armed with an attractive bid package. Common sense prevailed, and the Milwaukee fellowship was awarded the 12th World Convention, although the vote was surprisingly close. The duo from the Big Apple left the convention with a sense of hope and the support of the entire fellowship.

A Board of Trustee meeting was also held during the convention, led by Board Chairman Chuck S. Elections were held to fill open positions. Michael Bohan, a non-addict physician with the U.S. Navy in Norfolk, Virginia, was elected. He became one of the most respected trustees. Mike found Narcotics Anonymous through contact with the Nar-Anon fellowship. He had the right disposition and objectivity necessary to deal with addicts. He became a mainstay in public information efforts. James D., the same addict who started N.A. meetings in Victoria, British Columbia, in the early '70s was also chosen.

The board addressed several issues involving the ongoing feud between the World Service Office and the World Literature Committee. After his meeting with Jimmy K. earlier that year, Chuck concluded it was futile to act as a mediator between the two groups, stating, "It is in God's hands."

WCNA-11 became the most successful event financially in N.A.'s short history. The committee had held a half-dozen profitable fundraisers throughout the year and kept expenses to a minimum, eliminating any

extravagances. The convention earned an unfathomable net profit of $11,000. Once Chuck was informed about the windfall, he literally grabbed his chest in response.

One source recalls how the committee split the profits. One thousand dollars was given to both the World Literature Conference to defray some of the expenses and the local Nar-Anon fellowship. The remaining $9,000 was split equally between the WCNA-12 host committee, the World Service Office, and the local N.A. fellowship, the latter of which used its funds to establish a literature stockpile.

The effect of the convention upon avid members had already become clear. "They were enthused and knew there was much more to be done." There were a handful of attendees from West Palm Beach, St. Petersburg, and Daytona; their attendance would later prove to be essential in the birth of the Florida Region. After the banquet, George H. approached other Florida trusted servants to discuss the formation of a regional service committee, with all agreeing to make this their next endeavor. Even Jimmy K. was quoted as saying, "We can no longer contain the fellowship in California." Of course, the local members made it clear it could not, nor had it any desire, to contain the fellowship in South Florida either.

In the book, *My Years with Narcotics Anonymous*, the author, Bob Stone offered a virtual testimonial to the success of WCNA-11. "This event," he wrote, "probably was the most convincing signal that the fellowship outside of California was capable of doing anything and was equal to the old-timers out west."

THE SIXTH WORLD LITERATURE CONFERENCE

Father Jim Jones was one of the fellowship's best friends ever. A recovering alcoholic and A.A. member himself, the Episcopal priest was director of Concept House, a therapeutic community. In 1980, the clergyman realized Narcotics Anonymous was the best solution for his patients, despite the sentiments of many in his profession. He then made a major decision, equally unpopular among other therapeutic communities, and abruptly eliminated "drinking privileges" for both Concept House clients and staff. He phoned N.A. member John L., also an employee at the facility, asking him to inform the staff about his decision. Father Jones completely embraced the concept of "total abstinence" professed by N.A. and almost immediately began to see results.

Concept House became the first treatment program of any type to avidly recruit and employ members of Narcotics Anonymous such as Rosalie R., John L., and Roger T. Father Jones then opened the doors for clients to attend outside N.A. meetings, another unprecedented act. Written on a blackboard were contact numbers for Narcotics Anonymous for every city throughout the country. Concept House would become a major source of newcomers for well over a decade.

Charles K., who recently moved to Fort Lauderdale after the Warren Literature Conference, was planning and making preparations for the upcoming literature conference. Rosalie enlisted the assistance of her boss and put Charles in touch with Father Jones. After all, few people back then would open their church on a 24-hour basis for a solid week to a group of recovering addicts. Father Jones arranged for the use of Holy Cross Episcopal Church located near Liberty City, an area known for the "race riots" only a year before.

The 6th World Literature Conference was scheduled to take place immediately following WCNA-11, beginning on a Sunday evening and ending the following Friday.

Characteristically, the humidity in Miami during September hovered around 100 percent with an average daily temperature over 90 degrees: a virtual sauna. The cost of renting the room was minimal, but it came without air-conditioning, which would have required an additional fee. A crisis could have quickly developed, but local members came to the rescue through donations. Up to this point, Charles K., Bob G., and recent imports Doug W. and Gina H. had been the only local members active in a literature movement. However, many South Floridian members would make invaluable contributions to the book.

Dr. Tom put up a $1,000 deposit out of his pocket for a copying machine, while others started passing baskets at local meetings to cover conference expenses. Buddha Bob anonymously donated several hundred dollars. Others donated food and opened their homes to participants. There was just enough money to turn the air-conditioning on periodically and rent industrial cooling fans.

The size of the conference vacillated from 20 to 60 people. The participants, in small groups of five to eight members, worked non-stop, sometimes through the night. Most of the chapters had previously been through a first draft and some even a second at the Warren, Ohio,

conference. However, by the end of that week, all had been edited a third and fourth time.

Sally E. recalled that the term "Basic Text" was brought up for the first time at the Miami Conference. "Our book is Basic," not "Big" was the common phrase.

Finally after two years and seven long weeks of conference work, the light at the end of the tunnel was clearly in sight. Each chapter was edited, proofread, revised, and then proofread again. One after another, the chapters were completed. It appeared as if the conference would finish with only one chapter left to complete – Chapter Four – "How It Works."

After a much-needed break, the trusted servants returned for highly unnerving news: the church had a previous engagement scheduled for the same social hall where those addicts had labored relentlessly for the previous five days. The room had been cleaned and set up for a wedding reception, effectively leaving the committee evicted, locked out and confused. Nevertheless, committed and relentless, Joey P., Bob G., Dwayne L. and Tom Mc. broke into the room, filling Joey's van with the copier and other supplies, and moved them to a small clubroom in Fort Lauderdale located at 4141 North Andrews Avenue.

A dozen or so dedicated members worked throughout the night; nerves were frazzled and tempers rose. In his book, *The History of the Basic Text*, Bo S. noted that conflicts were about to well up within the committee. Bo, with his gentle southern demeanor, recalled calming them down by explaining they were just a proverbial stone's throw from the finish line.

Within an hour, the *Basic Text of Narcotics Anonymous* was approved for printing in approval form. The impossible had been accomplished. And although another nine months would elapse before the book received final approval at the next World Service Conference, one fact remained abundantly clear to the group at that fateful moment: "We Have a Book!"

1981 WORLD DIRECTORY

The 1981 World Directory was published in October of the same year. Just fewer than 1,000 meetings were listed in the U.S. The new edition accurately confirmed the growth in Florida: 51 meetings or one for every 20 in existence nationwide were hosted in the Sunshine State, a significant increase from the mere six that existed in 1979. Now, only California and Pennsylvania had more! Again, it was just the beginning!

One oddity in the directory involved two listings in Pensacola. There were three meetings listed in the Panhandle: an institution meeting at Camp 5 and two others at Rainwater Specialty Care Center – The New Life Treatment Center. The meetings at the New Life Center were supposed to have taken place on Tuesdays at 8:00 p.m. and Saturdays at 9:00 a.m. But Barry M., a patient at the facility in late 1981, recalled that they were actually A.A. – not N.A. – meetings! How they became listed in the directory remains a mystery. But this was not an uncommon dilemma during that era. Quite often, any meeting consisting primarily of addicts was mistakenly referred to as N.A., when it was actually a meeting of another fellowship or some convoluted hybrid meeting. Shortly after Barry completed treatment at the New Life Center, he assisted in starting the first actual Narcotics Anonymous meeting at that facility in early 1982.

THE GREEN MANUAL & THE BIG WHITE BOOK

Two months after the approval form of the Basic Text was completed in Miami, the Mid-South Regional Service Conference in Memphis convened for the four-day Thanksgiving break. It was not designed as a regional function, but rather a meeting of the World Literature and Policy Committee's brain trust. Chuck S. and Bob R., the policy chair, both from Southern California, arrived primarily to work on the fellowship's service manual. The usual Literature Committee contingent was also present.

The resulting document was infinitely different from pre-conference expectations. A radical change was included: the World Service Office would now become a sub-committee of the World Service Conference. The booklet, sporting an emerald green cover, was quickly referred to as the Green Manual.

The stated purpose of this conference was to prepare the bulk mailing of the approval copy of the Basic Text. The booklet resembled an oversized Little White Book and was accordingly nicknamed the "Slick White Book" or the "Big White Book." The Floridians immediately put their copies to use, as Frank M. or "Fat Frank" printed 100 copies of the approval copy of the text on his family's business copier.

MIAMI BEACH – PINETREE DRIVE

Miami Beach is a peninsula set apart from the mainland of Miami. Many have referred to Miami Beach as the "6th borough of New York City" due to the many native New Yorkers who resided there, creating an enclave of New Yorkers. Miami Beach is considered the Beach & Bay Area of Narcotics Anonymous, which was, formed only recently, although the history of meetings in this area dates back to 1981.

In November of 1981, shortly after the 11th World Convention, a relative newcomer named Carolyn Q. volunteered the living room in her home on Pinetree Drive for the first meeting on Miami Beach. It was hard to find facilities where potential members were allowed to gather, especially on the beach, so the meeting continued at that location until the summer of 1982. Some of the first to attend were, of course, Carolyn, Bonnie B., Bernie B., Anna, and Louie C., who attended his first meeting here. Even out-of-town visitors came to the meeting, as did Lovell and Bruce G. from Orlando in April. This small meeting continued until the group at last found a formal place to meet at Miami Beach Senior High School. The Little Group began meeting there on Wednesday nights in the summer of 1982 and did so for almost two decades.



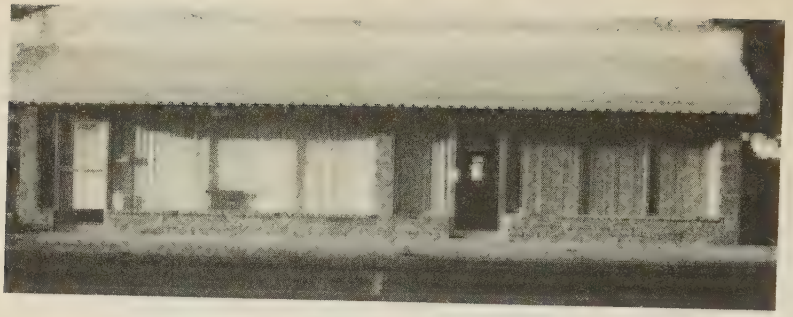
Central Baptist Church – Daytona Beach



South Miami Hospital Auditorium – South Miami



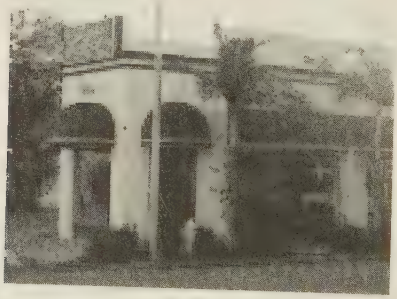
Site of 1st meeting in the Bay Area – St. Petersburg



Site of 1st meeting in the Space Coast – Titusville



Site of 1st meeting in Bradenton



Site of 1st meeting in the Sun Coast Area – Sarasota



Site of early meeting place in Orlando Area

Chapter Six

FLORIDA – THE EARLY YEARS

Bob B. of West Palm Beach was inspired with a renewed passion after attending the 11th World Convention in Miami. Less than two years prior, the Mainline Group had grown wary of its involvement with the South Florida Area Service Committee. Jayson T. had bridged the gap between the Palm Beach and Broward groups. Dade County now had meetings every night of the week in both ends of the county.

Roger T., chairperson of the WSC Literature Committee, had grown tired of the arguments and egos in that committee and chose to move to Miami. Roger, along with George H., Charles K. and others, laid the groundwork for the formation of a regional service committee, and an inaugural meeting was scheduled for Sunday, December 13, 1981, at 1 p.m., Bob B. found an ideal site: Lake Worth's Palm Beach Retreat at 1532 South Federal Highway. The retreat at one time was a Palm Beach style mansion. The facility's entry featured an ornamental stone archway; its floors were marble, and there was a vaulted ceiling with ornate woodwork and a fireplace. Clearly, the environment was uncommon for a service meeting!

Discussions ensued for several hours. Elections were conducted for administrative positions. Charles K. from Fort Lauderdale was elected chairperson and Shawn McG. as the vice-chair. Bob B. and Gayle A., both from West Palm Beach, were elected secretary and treasurer, respectively. George H., who had served as alternate delegate for the now-defunct South Florida Area Service Committee, was tentatively elected Regional Service Representative (RSR). Discussions also ensued regarding the establishment of sub-committees.

Although the meeting was well attended, it was decided to delay any major decisions until all N.A. meetings in Florida were notified about the plan. The trusted servants decided to send out a letter announcing their intent, hoping to bring together addicts from across the state. This introductory letter was then composed and distributed to everyone on the WCNA-11 registration list from Florida and all of the meetings in the '81 World Directory. Announcements were also made at meetings during the next month. The trusted servants gratefully accepted Bob's invitation to use the same facility for the next meeting the following month.

THE STORIES – BOOK TWO

The seventh World Literature Conference convened in Philadelphia on Friday evening, January 15, 1982. The committee's files included 130 personal stories from fellowship members in various stages of completion. It was determined the stories selected for the actual *Basic Text* should reflect a cross-section of the fellowship that also provided a pure N.A. message consistent with the language adopted in the first portion of the proposed text.

Chairperson Roger T. – now at peace in South Florida – was absent. After several unsuccessful attempts by WSC Chairman Steve B. and others to reach Roger, the committee opted to elect an ad hoc chairperson to marshal the text and stories through the approval process. Page C., the energetic protégé of Bo S. from Marietta, Georgia, was chosen.

The personal stories eventually selected for the approval copy included those from members throughout the country as well as from England, Germany, Tokyo, and Australia. Four Floridians' stories were among them. Two of those – Charles K.'s and Gina H.'s – were later included in the actual Basic Text. Although residing in other states prior to WCNA-11, both Charles and Gina chose to settle in Fort Lauderdale shortly thereafter. Their stories were entitled, "An Indian without a Tribe," and "No Excuse for Loneliness," respectively.

PALM BEACH RETREAT – RSC MEETING No. 2

The introductory letter proved to be a major success, as virtually twice as many addicts attended the second Florida RSC, held Sunday, January 17, 1982. Four areas were represented: Dade County, Gold Coast, Daytona Beach, and what would become the Bay Area. Danny G. from St. Petersburg and Carol from Clearwater met for the first time, thus forming the Bay Area. Since the first regional meeting, other developing fellowships throughout the state had been discovered, creating an air of elation.

After initial introductions, the trusted servants voted on this new venture's name, choosing to call it the Florida Regional Service Committee.

Area representatives then gave their reports:

- Dade County – Rosalie R.: "We're up to 16 meetings."
- Gold Coast – Valen E.: "Hey, Gold Coast has 21 meetings!"
- Daytona - Ted: "Thank you for welcoming me here today. Daytona has 2 meetings."
- Bay Cities – Danny and Carol summarized their respective meetings.

Elections were then held for subcommittee chairs. Roger T., chairperson of the World Literature Committee until the previous day, was elected as the Hospitals & Institution chairperson, with Chelsea from West Palm chosen as Activities chair.

Roger, Doug, and others with vast literature experience sat silently. They lived in South Florida. "It was like everyone had ESP; others from outside of South Florida needed to be included." When nominations for the next committee came up – Literature – Ted C. from Daytona was elected over others with vast experience in the literature movement. Other chairs elected were St. Petersburg's Danny G. for Public Information and Fort Lauderdale's Bob G. for Policy.

The trusted servants spoke about the Spanish version of the *Little White Book* and explored obstacles that might prevent certain addicts from finding recovery, especially addicts with physical handicaps. The result was the establishment of a Foreign Language and Special Services Committee, with Jorge H. selected as its chairperson. This committee was the first of its kind in Narcotics Anonymous.

An Outreach Committee was also created, as there was an obvious need to help known isolated recovering addicts and loner groups existing throughout the state in Jacksonville, Key West, and Orlando. Denny M. from West Palm Beach was elected to chair this new committee. Several other key issues were addressed at this meeting:

- It was decided future RSC meetings would initially be held monthly, moving from city to city where Narcotics Anonymous was known to exist – thus becoming an outreach effort in itself. The site of the next two meetings where chosen: Daytona Beach and St. Petersburg.

- Jayson T. suggested holding a regional convention to unite the Florida fellowship. Just months earlier, the 11th World Convention in Miami Beach had succeeded in doing the same for N.A. as a whole. He was instructed to form an ad hoc committee – the region's first – and to bring back more information and prepare a bid package.

The trusted servants had shown maturity uncommon to early service meetings. There were no arguments, just a desire to better serve the Florida fellowship. The Florida Regional Service Committee was born!

RSC MEETING No. 3 – DAYTONA BEACH – FEBRUARY

Ted C. began preparations for the first Florida Regional Weekend.

Previously, initial business meetings had been just that – meetings. Now RSC meetings had grown into events – gatherings of concerned N.A. citizens in Florida, rather than simple meetings. This traveling band of far-flung groups, areas, and even isolated addicts would emerge into an energetic force for growth and unity throughout the state. It was the first in a succession of hundreds of events whose members would travel across the state to attend. The purpose was always clear: simply to be supportive of other members, areas, or regional activities; it was second nature to be part of a truly statewide fellowship.

Ted had enlisted the assistance of his mentor; Ben W. Ben volunteered his hotel for the first statewide gathering of any sort outside of South Florida. He charged a nominal room rate of $18 per night. Bob B., the "Father of Narcotics Anonymous in Florida," filled several of his treatment center's vans with members from West Palm Beach, and even some patients, for the unexpectedly fun weekend. Delegations from Miami, Fort Lauderdale, West Palm Beach, St. Petersburg, and the host Daytona area literally came together at Ted's home for an oyster and clambake. Over 80 people attended; assuring those involved they were doing the right thing.

A carload of unfamiliar faces drove up. "The Three Musketeers" from Orlando arrived. Although their city had only one meeting, including those three addicts, they joined the movement. Upon completion of the roll call, the chair asked, "Are there any new areas?" The trio did not respond since they were not officially an area, but the chair pointed to the "three amigos" and said, "You're the Orlando Area!"

Also in attendance was Danny C., who had moved to Orlando shortly after this meeting, he had completed treatment in Brevard County. Danny mentioned the existence of an N.A. meeting he attended while in treatment at the facility in Titusville.

A new group had come into existence. This illustrated the need and appropriateness of establishing an Outreach Committee, which subsequently made contact with the loner group. The fruit of the committee's work was seen several months later with the creation of the seventh area to join the Florida region – The Space Coast.

As the area reports were given, it became clear the Florida fellowship was undergoing a period of rapid growth. The region now had 60 meetings, a staggering increase of 15 new meetings – or 33 percent – in just one month.

TAMPA HEIGHTS HOSPITAL

Big Robert left Fort Lauderdale for a job in Tampa in March. He was soon introduced to Danny G, Carol, and Brenda, but they lived across the Bay in Pinellas County. There were no N.A. meetings east of the bay in Tampa and the surrounding areas. Robert, needless to say, was determined to start one and decided to reach out to a familiar source for addicts: Young People's A.A.!

Bob continually announced his desire to start Narcotics Anonymous in Tampa at the Young People's groups. At one meeting, Robert found a volunteer to help him; he met an addict named Trey. Together, with the assistance of others, the pair began planning the inaugural N.A. meeting. Along with addicts Bruce and Vicki, they formed the core of the first N.A. meeting in Tampa at Tampa Heights Hospital.

Although a locked facility, the hospital allowed patients and addicts from the outside to attend the meeting, but "by invitation only." The meeting was held Wednesday nights, beginning in March 1982. They even chose a name for the meeting: The New Life Group.

The Tampa addicts quickly saw the need for a completely open meeting, and Bob searched for a location. After he received the approval of a minister at St. Paul's Church on North Dale Mabry Street, the Quest for Serenity Group was born in April 1982, meeting Monday nights at 8:00 p.m. The group, which later changed its name to Quest for Recovery, continued recruiting addicts from Young People's A.A., though this practice created an unhealthy dependency that stifled the growth of Tampa's N.A. fellowship for several years.

Initially, the groups in and around Tampa joined the Bay Area Service Committee. It was not until after FRCNA-3 that the groups in Tampa grew enough to form their own area committee. They chose Fun Coast as the name of their area.

TALLAHASSEE – THE BIG BEND AREA

Steve D. completed an enlistment in the United States Navy in its treatment program in Miramar, California, just outside of San Diego. Upon discharge, he moved to Tallahassee in March of 1981 to attend Florida State University. Having been introduced to Narcotics Anonymous in treatment, where he was exposed to both inside and outside meetings, he looked for a meeting in Tallahassee – but with no success.

Therefore, Steve called A.A., who referred him to the Appalachee Community Mental Heath Center. After receiving no response, he tried again a few days later. This time, he was told of a Sunday, 7:00 p.m., N.A. meeting. However, after building up hope, Steve ended up waiting on the steps of the alleged meeting place for an hour, as no one showed up. Keeping a positive mindset, he thought he might have misunderstood the meeting time and spoke again with the same person from Appalachee. After further research, she told him of a Friday evening meeting.

Filled with zeal, Steve showed up that Friday night, only to be informed the location was an A.A. clubhouse and the N.A. meeting in question had folded. He was also told by the bearer of the shocking news, an A.A. member, that there was no knowledge of any other N.A. meetings in the area. The A.A. member had come to the clubhouse to pick up materials for another meeting a few miles away. He invited Steve to go along, and the addict reluctantly agreed.

At the time, Steve had little choice but to attend A.A. while in Tallahassee. However, he would occasionally visit a sister in Atlanta, attending N.A. meetings there. Atlanta had a flourishing fellowship, and Steve was easily able to find it through the local phonebook. After a few brief relapses, Steve finally got clean on April 26, 1981.

While in Atlanta, Steve was told a Narcotics Anonymous convention was scheduled to be held there in February, 1982, just months later. The event was initially referred to as the first Southeastern Convention of N.A. and was later known as the Georgia Regional Convention. Back home, Steve convinced Bruce M., a fellow addict from A.A., to join him for the trip to Georgia.

At the convention, Floridian trusted servants George H. and Charles K. approached Steve, realizing who he was and understanding his dilemma in Tallahassee. The service-minded duo gave got him a starter kit and encouraged him to start a meeting right away!

After the convention, Steve began recruiting addicts from Tallahassee A.A. meetings. Bruce, Charles and Kathy, Rick, Cathy, Frank and Edna, all agreed to participate. Edna had been involved in the earlier attempt to start a local N.A. meeting. An organizational meeting was held the first week of March in 1982, yielding the group's decision to create a Sunday night meeting. It is still in existence today!

George and Charles had informed Steve of the formation of the Florida Regional Service Committee a few months earlier, suggesting they

attend the next regional meeting in April. Tallahassee soon became the Big Bend Area and the sixth area in the Florida region.

ST. PETERSBURG – MARCH – RSC MEETING – No. 4

The fourth regional meeting took place in St. Petersburg. Tallahassee became the sixth area to join the Florida Region. Six areas were represented, together reporting a growth of an additional 10 meetings from the previous month, or 75 in total.

Two major decisions were made at the meeting. First, the committee chose to move ahead with plans submitted by Jason T.'s ad hoc committee for an annual regional convention. This paved the way for the first Florida Regional Convention of Narcotics Anonymous or FRCNA.

Second, the Policy Committee, combining the wisdom of two informational booklets, compiled and submitted a proposed set of guidelines. Much of the information came from the Green Manual, the prospective service manual distributed to the fellowship a few months earlier. The other booklet became a staple in service meetings for years to come. A member had discovered Robert's Rules of Order in a bookstore and thought it might be a helpful aide in fulfilling the committee's objective. During the next few years, this little booklet became a mainstay at all service meetings. The region adopted the first policy package.

A long discussion ensued regarding many of the issues on the upcoming World Service Conference's agenda. Participants were told to bring their proposals to the next meeting. Miami and Orlando were accepted as the sites for the next two meetings.

REGIONAL MEETING No. 5 – SOUTH MIAMI – APRIL

The region was now four months old and still growing. The area reports showed another sharp increase in meetings to 85; several loner meetings were known to exist throughout the state. The new areas began bringing in some of these groups that were located relatively nearby. The Fresh Start Group in Bradenton along with the two new meetings in Tampa joined the Bay Area. Other meetings were discovered in Jacksonville, Pensacola, Gainesville, Naples, and Melbourne.

The Florida Regional Service Committee (RSC) was making preparations for the upcoming World Service Conference. Much of the meeting centered on the conference's agenda, including approval of the Basic Text along with the personal stories, the Green Manual, the

proposed service manual, and ongoing issues with the WSO and the Board of Trustees.

Suggestions were made regarding the Spanish literature, as the current translation was inadequate. Plans for FRCNA-1 were coming together quickly. George was given flyers to distribute at the World Service Conference. Additional suggestions were made regarding the need for additional literature, a "Twelve & Twelve" (Step and Traditions), as well as a daily meditation book.

The April meeting was held at South Miami Hospital just prior to the World Service Conference. Florida voted on issues sent back to the groups, and they voted on motions that would be put on the conference floor for consideration. Here is an excerpt from the minutes of that meeting that are deemed to have historic value:

- Charles K. read the motion, "To approve the proposed N.A. Book…all those in favor." Hands went up in the air from Bay Cities, Dade County, Gold Coast, Orlando and Tallahassee. The Daytona Area was opposed. Florida votes to approve the Proposed N.A. Book (The Basic Text) 5-1.

- The next motion was "To approve the Service Manual…all those in favor." Dade County was the lone vote in favor of the motion (four nay, two abstain and one yea). It was defeated soundly.

Then the following list of motions was approved. They were to be submitted on the floor to propose specific changes to the Little White Book …

- Change "recovered" to "recovering."
- Change "borrowed" to "adapted."
- Change "hopelessly addicted to alcohol" to "hopelessly addicted."
- Change "honest desire" to "desire."
- Insert "sex or sexual preference" into phrase "race, color, …"
- Change "emotional sobriety" to "recovery."
- Change "first fix, pill, drink" to "drug."

The WSC referred all of the motions to the Literature Committee. It initiated a process that years later resulted in a revised version of the *Little White Book*, which reflected language more appropriate to the N.A. message.

Additional motions were discussed and approved. George H. was to propose them at the conference. More importantly, he was given "crystal clear marching orders" to:

"... demand that the WSO become responsible to the fellowship and answerable to the World Service Conference. The Florida RSC wants the tenure of WSO trusted servants (Board of Directors) to be limited to five (5) years."

Florida would be well represented at the conference in California, with George and Rosalie as the elected representatives. Several other members of the regional committee were also planning to attend.

GEORGE H. GOES TO L.A.

The 1982 World Service Conference would, in retrospect, become one of the most significant, as it was a turning point in the history of Narcotics Anonymous. Steve B. from Santa Rosa, California, a dedicated member since the late '60s, chaired. The fellowship had experienced such astounding growth since WCNA-11 in Miami that a new location – Santa Monica's Retail Clerks Union Hall – was required for the conference, which was held May 5-9.

As Florida's alternate representative for the previous year, George H. had wisely used the time to become familiar with the service structure and its members, as well as current issues that needed to be addressed. There was no state in the fellowship whose recent growth was more evident than Florida's, which George more than adequately conveyed. In just one year, the Sunshine State's meeting list had expanded from 35 to 95, from one area service committee to six, and from 200 members to 1,000. The region was in the forefront of establishing working sub-committees, two of which had never existed anywhere else in Narcotics Anonymous. The Florida fellowship received a huge boost as the host of both "Together More Than Ever" and the sixth World Literature Conference. There were active groups or developing fellowships in their infancy in Jacksonville, Gainesville, Naples, Daytona, Tallahassee, Melbourne, Pensacola, Miami, Fort Lauderdale, West Palm Beach, St. Petersburg, Tampa, and Orlando. The Foreign Language & Special Services Committee was dedicated to exploring ways and means to reach out to the state's Hispanic and Haitian communities. The committee was also assisting those with other obstacles or barriers. The *Little White Book* was being translated into Braille, and volunteers were making tapes of the literature for those with sight impairments. It was George who suggested that the World Service Conference establish this committee. There was talk of starting the first Spanish-speaking meeting in Miami.

Florida's Outreach Committee became a "traveling band of addicts" whose main responsibility was to connect with isolated members throughout the state and assist loner meetings. It was quickly apparent that a dozen meetings existed in obscurity. The committee strived to make them a part of the region.

The Hospital & Institutions (H&I) committee was developing rapidly with numerous meetings throughout the state. H&I can collections had reached an unheard of amount of nearly $800 a month in just one area.

The Public Information committee had already made taped public service messages for both television and radio. Phil D. had thousands of stickers with the local hotline numbers printed on them. Members were placing them on every pay phone where they thought addicts might gather.

The conference participants were impressed with the expeditious growth in Florida as well as George's articulate presentation. This led to George's election as the next WSC Vice-Chairperson despite his relative newcomer status. Although an unknown among established "service junkies," George had been given a huge vote of confidence by his own region: he became the first member from Florida elected to any position at the world level. In essence, this was an acknowledgement of the emerging success and growth of the Florida fellowship.

Although the outcome of this conference was historical in nature, more importantly, it would lead to an entirely new generation of addicts finding recovery in Narcotics Anonymous.

Divisions between the World Service Office and the rest of the service structure had characterized the year prior to the conference, with the majority of those in service becoming obviously disenchanted. Jimmy's dedication and work ethic were never questioned; yet many of his personal confidantes, in an effort to protect him, appeared to have kept the fellowship's founder in the dark about many of the critical issues pending at the conference. An acrimonious relationship existed between the Literature committee and the office, leading to distrust and disunity. Jimmy's age and health were also of concern.

But one issue could not be ignored. Narcotics Anonymous would soon have a book resulting in a whole new stream of funds the current office was ill prepared to handle. The fellowship would soon explode, demanding responsiveness that in the past could easily have been overlooked. The office needed to function in a reliable, business-like manner in order to grasp the demands it would soon inherit. Clearly, the

collective thinking of the trusted servants seemed to point to the only solution: the eventual replacement of Jimmy K. as the World Service Office manager. Discussions regarding a competent replacement continued around the table. It was Florida's Rosalie R. who first pointed to Bob Stone, the articulate parliamentarian, as the likeliest and least objectionable candidate as the next World Service Office Manager. Bob would hold that position for years.

The most notable issue addressed at the conference was the approval of the *Basic Text*, though it took place swiftly and with little of the expected opposition. Almost everyone accepted the fact that the book would need to be revised in coming years. Miraculously, by the end of the '80s, the book had sold over one million copies.

Bob R. from Los Angeles chaired the policy committee, which had distributed the "Green Manual" for approval. It was a vastly different service manual than the *N.A. Tree*. The new service structure would provide a foundation for the impending growth of the fellowship.

A motion was approved to establish a magazine for the fellowship. Consequently, *The N.A. Way* has continued to serve addicts as a worldwide means of communication for over a decade.

An ad hoc committee was also created to formulate guidelines for future world conventions, eventually integrating the event under the auspices of the service structure.

For the first time, the conference elected five of the WSO's board members, thus opening the door to radical changes at the office. Similar changes would take place with the Board of Trustees. This would lead to the integration of the office and trustees under the auspices of the fellowship.

The input received at this conference about prospective pamphlets and books the fellowship desired maintained the World Literature Committee as an effective force for several more years. Over a dozen informational pamphlets would be compiled in the next year, and discussions ensued about an additional future text dedicated to the steps and traditions. Indeed, the 1982 World Service Conference laid the groundwork for the explosive growth that would take place globally over the next several years!

GATOR COUNTRY – GAINESVILLE

Once a Timucuan Indian village, the land upon which Gainesville is situated became part of a Spanish land grant given to Don Fernando de la Maza Arredondo, a Spanish merchant, in December 1817. The city's growth and prosperity continued in 1906 when the University of Florida began operations on land west of the city. To this day, more than anything else, the city revolves around Florida's largest university.

Chris got clean in South Miami in 1980. He moved to Gainesville to attend the University of Florida in January 1982. Since there were not any N.A. meetings, he decided to start one. He found some other addicts who were attending A.A. meetings. In May of 1982, Chris, "Hippie" Steve, "Wafflehouse" John, and Mark met at a local crisis center known as "The Corner Drugstore" on First Street.

Martin C. attended the August 1982, regional service meeting in Key West, thus adding Gainesville to the N.A. map, but barely. It would take another two years before Gainesville formed an official area service committee meeting. They would struggle for the next several years.

Gainesville became the ninth "area" to join the Florida Region. This was another example of a group being called an area based upon a geographic location rather than an existing service entity.

As noted in the 1983 April RSC minutes, Betsy M. was contacted by the newly opened Florida RSO to request her attendance. She was not aware of the upcoming meeting and could not attend due to the lateness of the communication. She informed them they had two meetings now in Gainesville. She inquired about the poor service they had received recently. The WSO sent them only German and Spanish literature instead of what they had ordered. They had already been without literature for several weeks before sending for the order. The RSO sent off free literature to the Gainesville groups.

In 1983, these groups joined the fledgling area service committee in Jacksonville. The next year following FRCNA-4 in Tampa, they formed their own area service committee, later known as the Uncoast Area Service committee. Mr. Bill was then the face of the Gainesville fellowship for the next several years.

ORLANDO – MAY – RSC MEETING NO. 6

The Florida Regional Service Committee (RSC) next met in Orlando the week following the conclusion of the World Service Conference. Florida now had 92 meetings.

The entertainment included a Saturday visit to Disney World. Everyone was ribbing George. They would jokingly ask, "Hey, George, now that you're the vice-chairperson of the World, what are you going to do next?" To which he'd respond, "Go to Disney World!" This was an obvious spoof of a well known post-Super Bowl commercial.

George gave his report on the conference. There was excitement that the fellowship would soon have a *Basic Text*.

Roger T. had, in essence, resigned as the H&I chairperson and relocated in New York, another in a succession of moves around the country.

The plans for the first Florida Regional Convention were coming together. Bob R. from Los Angeles, the newly elected WSC chairperson, was chosen as the convention's main speaker.

It was decided the next regional meeting would be informal. It was scheduled to take place at the convention hotel immediately following the closing meeting.

THE PALM COAST AREA

The Gold Coast Area had grown to nearly 30 meetings in the past year. The partnership between Broward and Palm Beach County groups was originally perceived as a temporary measure. They had truly functioned as one united area up until this point, despite the clear geographical separation. But everyone realized it was only a matter of time before the Palm Beach groups formed their own area. At the May ASC meeting, Broward believed the time for additional growth had arrived and brought up the issue.

Amazingly, there was little fanfare or resistance as an agreement was reached. This was probably the first and most congenial "splitting" of an area known of in the annals of N.A. history. Both parties shared their concerns and support for the other and then quickly agreed to split both the literature stockpiles and balance of the funds equally. The only request was that the Broward groups hold on to the area name – Gold Coast.

The Broward contingent met for the first time later that month. They had a multitude of meetings and a strong base of "purist service

junkies." The Narcotics Anonymous "Purist Movement" had been growing since the summer of 1980. Knowing the fellowship finally needed an identity of its own to experience massive growth, its subscribers were the ones responsible for writing and subsequent publishing of the *Basic Text* and the creation of N.A.'s own unique lexicon. Unfortunately, this caused conflicts with several West Broward groups, which had yet to accept our fellowship's newfound independence from A.A. The result was an "East Side – West Side" division for the next several years.

Meanwhile, the Palm Beach groups met collectively for the first time in June, 1982, forming the Palm Coast Area. The new ASC consisted of six groups, which met eight times a week. The minutes of that inaugural meeting noted a strange twist: during the introductions, all participants introduced themselves along with their amounts of clean time. Although only a handful had more than a year or two in recovery, seven areas had come together in Florida.

JUNE – WEST PALM BEACH – RSC No. 7A

The June regional meeting was more of a forum than anything else, as it took place prior to FRCNA-1. Jayson gave a report on the upcoming convention. He was gracious about his committee; he said, "They are very active and supportive." A series of motions were made to approve the program and participants. Most of the discussion revolved around the Special Language and Special Services committee, Outreach to new groups around the state, and development of policies and procedures.

FRCNA – FLORIDA'S UNITY CONVENTION

The regional convention planning committee was formed in late February, only four months prior to the scheduled event. The only funds available for the planning process came exclusively from pre-registration. WCNA-11's committee had a year to prepare for its convention, which had taken place just nine months earlier. It received funds from the previous world convention in Wichita and had an active fundraising committee.

Jayson made the contractual arrangements with the brand new Hyatt Regency at the corner of Okeechobee Road and Australian Boulevard in West Palm Beach. This was a quantum leap from the Marco Polo, the hotel for WCNA-11.

The Gold Coast Area, which then consisted of the Broward and Palm Beach groups, was selected as host area. Jayson was elected chairperson with Bob G. from Fort Lauderdale as the vice-chair.

"Today We Live" was chosen as the inaugural convention's theme. Flyers, shirts, and programs were printed with a logo of the State of Florida in the background and a small N.A. symbol placed near the location of each known fellowship in Florida.

The convention took place in June, 1982. There were over 500 paid attendees, while a few hundred others showed up for the main event. All but a few dozen were from Florida, nearly double the amount that attended WCNA-11 less than a year before. The registrants included 74 people from out-of-state, including Joe P. from Memphis, Bo S. and Motorcycle Ed from Georgia, Dale from Pittsburgh, and Al from Philadelphia. The convention made a small profit despite its low $5 registration fee.

This may have been the only event that all founding or original members from Florida attended together. The list included Bob B. from West Palm Beach, Marvin S., Buddha Bob and Skinny Kenny from Miami, Joey M. and Carni Tom from Fort Lauderdale, Steve and Bruce from Tallahassee, as well as Big Robert and Trey from Tampa. Also in attendance were Danny and Brenda from Clearwater; Mike T. from Naples, Ed from Melbourne, Rick and Mary from Jacksonville, Ben and Ted from Daytona, Biff, Bruce, Lovell, and Jackie from Orlando.

Newly elected WSC Chairperson Bob R. from Los Angeles was the main speaker. He formed a close relationship with George H. and several other Floridians that continued for decades.

The relative immaturity of the fellowship was obvious, despite the event's success. Clearly, N.A. was still in its infancy both individually as well as collectively. Members' behavior often resembled that seen in college fraternities. Ritual pranks took place that became part of the convention fabric for years until the fellowship and its members matured.

An example of such antics was apparent in the traditional practice of attendees "honoring" host hotel managers by throwing them in the pool fully clothed in business attire. This would happen not once, but twice, at FRCNA-1! The late-night Jacuzzi meeting also got slightly out of hand that year when a soapy mixture was poured into the water, creating a huge overflow of bubbles that enveloped the entire outdoor pool area. As the evening progressed and the meeting concluded, many addicts were either

partially or fully nude. This gave a completely new meaning to the concept of "conscious contact."

Florida convention-goers were already known as a rowdy bunch because of their behavior at the first Southeast Convention (later renamed the Georgia Regional Convention) months earlier. Not only did they throw a large quantity of toilet paper rolls out of the high-rise hotel, covering most of the landscaping below, but they also started a new ritual that continued fellowship-wide for years to come: throwing linen napkins and dinner rolls around the banquet hall to the sounds of air horns and confetti. This became a staple at future convention banquets.

Although the behavior seemed over the edge, it somehow functioned as a release for many in attendance. It was the first time that many of the early trusted servants had a chance to gather in a social atmosphere since WCNA-11. They all seemed to realize Narcotics Anonymous would grow and change dramatically over the next several years. Jim S. recalled that FRCNA-1 created an unprecedented excitement about N.A. – a joy quite new to many in recovery.

Those attending FRCNA-1 found not only hope, but also relief and strength from others who had found recovery in Narcotics Anonymous without utilizing other sources of support for recovery. The spirited fellowship became a movement of unity throughout the state.

Research showed that the convention theme was used to name new groups after each event. Over 40 meetings remain named after these themes.

Narcotics Anonymous was now a family that did not end with the home groups. FRCNA-1 was an enormous unifying tool. The camaraderie among addicts there resulted in long-term friendships, relationships and even marriage for some. Periodically, couples have since referred to their children as "FRCNA babies."

JUNE – WEST PALM BEACH – RSC No. 7B

This convention allowed an opportunity for trusted servants to meet once more; it was an open discussion for regular attendees and possibly an opportunity for other convention-goers to become involved.

After a long, sleepless weekend, it appeared many attendees simply wanted to go home. The most eventful part of the meeting was the introduction of Mike T. from Naples, the representative of the new Gulf Coast Area. Oddly, this area, consisting of just two groups in Naples, was actually named before it officially formed. Mike was the acting

representative for the next year until a bona fide area service committee was created. This was not uncommon during the early years, as a group or handful of groups was referred to as "an area."

Jason gave a summary report on behalf of the convention committee. He was shown much appreciation for his dedication and efforts to put together a committee on such short notice. Everyone agreed the event was a success in every way.

JULY – TALLAHASSEE – RSC No. 8

The RSC met the following month in Tallahassee at the University of Florida Alumni Center. This event, held less than a month after FRCNA, had fewer attendees than usual. Tallahassee, after all, was a six-hour drive from South Florida.

Steve scheduled a Saturday-afternoon trip to Wachula Springs, a clear Florida spring offering a variety of water activities. That evening, there was a dance with limited participation.

Denny M. represented the newly formed Palm Coast ASC; it was the new area's first regional meeting. Ed represented groups from Titusville and Melbourne, which ultimately became the Space Coast area.

One unexpected and significant decision was reached: the establishment of a central or regional service office. Carol from St. Petersburg offered an extra room in her apartment for this endeavor. Now Florida had an informal office; it was a humble beginning.

AUGUST – KEY WEST – RSC No. 9

The weekend was more of a retreat than a business gathering, as the ambiance of Key West was overwhelming. The El Rancho Motel, host hotel for the weekend, was an unfortunate choice. At the time, the El Rancho was a hotel used by the downtrodden, so many chose alternative lodging.

The Key West fellowship consisted of just two regular members and a handful of patients from a local hospital. The regional meeting was held at their meeting location at the Lower Keys Mental Health facility on the old Navy Base near Truman Annex.

Steve D. made the trek to Key West from Tallahassee. In back-to-back months, Florida's faithful traveled from one end of the state to the other. This was the ninth meeting in as many months and the last monthly RSC.

The Florida Regional Service Committee of Narcotics Anonymous had come a long way in only three-quarters of a year. Nine different ASC's across the state were now represented. A new fledgling meeting in Gainesville had just been discovered as well; Martin, that meeting's representative, attended RSC No. 9. The region's accomplishments included a complete policy package and an enormously successful inaugural convention. The Regional Service Representative (RSR) was elected WSC vice-chairperson, and plans were underway for a literature conference as well as an H&I event. On a grander scale, the *Basic Text* was soon to become a reality.

OUR GRATITUDE SPEAKS...

About 750 addicts showed up at Milwaukee's cavernous Hyatt Regency Hotel on September 2, 1982, for the 12th World Convention. The theme of the four-day event was "Our Gratitude Speaks," taken from the fellowship's Gratitude Prayer.

Also registered at the Hyatt that weekend were recording artist Diana Ross and future Major League Baseball Hall of Famers Reggie Jackson and Rod Carew, along with the rest of their California Angels teammates. At one point, Carew was overheard asking the hotel manager, "Who are these people? I did not sleep at all. They were up all night long!"

Over 30 N.A. members from Florida made the trek to Wisconsin. Although not the largest state contingent, they were perhaps the loudest. The Sunshine State delegation included many of those who had also been attending the monthly regional meetings.

It had now become commonplace to find Floridians at any convention, regardless of the location. John L. from Miami reunited with his friend Bob B. from San Francisco, now the WSC H&I chairperson. Consequently, John convinced Bob to be the speaker at the upcoming first Hospital & Institutions banquet that December in Miami.

Doug F., a New York native and protégé of Jimmy K., was the main speaker at that year's event. Doug strongly supported the fledgling fellowship from the Big Apple for the next convention bid. Fourteen months had passed since Terry R. started the first New York N.A. meeting. In that short period, the fellowship there had grown from just a few members to a hundred and hosted 10 meetings by convention time. At the banquet, it was announced that WCNA-13 would take place in Manhattan!

The first edition of *The NA Way* magazine made its debut at WCNA-12. Jim M. from Ohio, the committee chairperson, personally hand-distributed the red-covered booklet. During the banquet, Steve, the convention chairperson, took a minute to thank the Florida fellowship for its support that year.

THE FIRST FLORIDA LITERATURE CONFERENCE

The WSC Literature Committee (1982-1983) tasks for the coming year included completion of a long list of proposed informational pamphlets. The topics were suggested over the preceding years. The *Basic Text* had been completed and approved at the 1982 World Service Conference. The World Service Office was selling a limited edition copy for $25 to raise the funds needed to print the first edition.

Page C., the WSC Literature chairperson, recruited several regions with active literature committees to assist in the writing and compilation process. The first topic assigned to Florida was of vital importance to many in recovery. In the fellowship that was saving their lives, recovering addicts heard the concept of total abstinence often and loud.

Addicts with medical problems other than their addiction were sometimes alienated from meetings. Members were adamant on the message of "one is too many and a thousand never enough." There was a need for addressing the *Use of Medication in Recovery*, I.P. No. 17. It was commonly known that both Biff K. from Orlando and Dr. Tom from Fort Lauderdale were practicing physicians; thus, it was understood that their input would aid in the completion of this task. With their help and the experiences of the other addicts in attendance, a very difficult and controversial piece of literature was hammered out. The second topic assigned to the Florida literature committee was I.P. No. 11, entitled *Sponsorship*.

Ted C. enlisted Ben's assistance, as his hotel was used as a home base for this event. The conference was scheduled for October 15-17, 1982. A dozen or so members now living in Florida had participated in the literature movement, and their involvement and experience would be helpful in this task. Surprisingly, there was a large turnout for this event. The participants began work on the *Sponsorship* pamphlet, though by the end of the weekend, the material was incomplete.

The literature conference attendees made a commitment to meet again so they could complete their assignments. The group agreed upon meeting at the Serenity In The Sun mini-convention the following month.

SERENITY IN THE SUN

THE FIRST FLORIDA AREA CONVENTION

A month after the Daytona Literature Conference, the energy continued. The fellowship in Palm Beach County became the Palm Coast Area in June of 1982. They were still energized from WCNA-11, FRCNA-1, and the WLC-6 and were eager for more of the growth and unity that had emerged in the fellowship. What better way to keep the process going then to have another weekend of recovery and fun? The idea was to have something that would be a little more laid back than the hectic big convention, but they were on a mission. The mission was to finish our book and informational pamphlets; there was an overwhelming desire to document the reality of our message, "that no addict seeking recovery need ever die."

The Palm Coast Area decided to hold a mini-convention, the first area convention in Florida, which they named Serenity in the Sun Weekend. It was referred to as a mini-convention because of the shortened duration in comparison to regional events. The inaugural convention was a combination of recovery meetings and the continuation of the literature conference. The first Serenity Weekend was held November 19-21 at the Holiday Inn on Datura Street, in West Palm Beach. Registration for the weekend was $5; the room rate was $26 for a double; and the big affair was a Barbecue Luau Style, all you could eat for $14. The main speakers for the weekend were Biff K., Orlando, and Bob B. from West Palm Beach.

The co-chairpersons for the weekend were Denny M., Jayson T., and Debbie F. Jayson also took on the task of hotel liaison; Joe B. handled the registrations, and Don M. was the treasurer. While Serenity Weekend was going on downstairs, the literature conference was taking place upstairs. Even with all the activity, the sense of serenity, fun, unity, and recovery still prevailed. Each recovering addict carried a spark for the future. "When the sparks were fanned, a great Florida fire could be seen."

The Palm Coast event has been held annually since 1982, although a few variations in the theme occurred when the event was moved to an Oceanside hotel, becoming Serenity by the Sea. The event later returned to the original theme.

This first area convention was a roaring success and continues today as Serenity in the Sun. Over the years, many of the Palm Coast Area addicts discovered the joy of recovery through their participation in Serenity in the Sun.

Only the North Atlanta Area's Fun in the Sun Weekend in Panama City and the annual Florida Regional Convention have been around longer. Serenity in the Sun led to other areas creating local conventions.

THE FIRST LITERATURE CONFERENCE CONTINUED

As the Daytona conference continued, it included some new out-of-state participants, including Larry N. from West Virginia. Larry brought with him small posters of the Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions with the N.A. symbol as the background. Jayson T. acquired three sets of these posters, which later became the model for the first 3'-by-6' vinyl N.A. twelve-step shades. These N.A. step shades would hang in meeting rooms in Florida, and later in Georgia and New York City. The second half of the first Florida Literature Conference began with the same prayer used by the World Literature Committee while working on the Basic Text.

"God, grant us knowledge that we may write according to your divine precepts; instill in us a sense of your purpose, make us servants of your will and grant us a bond of selflessness that this may truly be your work, not ours, in order that no addict, anywhere, need die from the horrors of addiction."

Excerpt from the Basic Text – Preface – First Edition – 1983

Sixteen addicts locked themselves in a hotel room and began piecing together a second draft, and then another draft, until at last they completed the informational pamphlet entitled, *Sponsorship*. George H., Rosalie R., Charles K., Bob G., Beth N., Leah G., Dr. Tom, Doug W., Larry N., Louie C., Gina H., Gayle A., and Valen E. were just a few of those behind locked doors.

The group worked around the clock writing, editing, rewriting, and voting; they sought group conscience on each paragraph, each sentence, and at times each word that went into the pamphlets. Material would get handwritten, then discussed and voted on, and then sent down the hall to be typed and copied so it could be reviewed yet again. Lovell enlisted the help of a secretary who worked in his office in Orlando. There were long

distance calls and faxes going back and forth from the workshop writing room to Orlando.

Serenity In the Sun and the Florida Literature Conference took place the same weekend as the Mid-South Regional Service Committee. The Memphis event essentially was another meeting of the World Service Conference Literature Committee. The participants in West Palm Beach stayed in contact with Page C., the WLC chairperson, via telephone several times. Page was also in contact with other committees across the country, as they compiled final drafts of a dozen other proposed pamphlets. Jayson recalled, "The energy level and excitement ran high. In the end, everyone was physically and emotionally drained and elated at the same time."

The Florida Literature Conference completed their writing task. The proposed pamphlet was sent out to the fellowship for review and subsequently approved at the World Service Conference months later. It remains the same today as it was in November 1982. The original handwritten input for the *Sponsorship* pamphlet was discovered in the Florida Regional Service Office by the authors while researching material for this book.

FIRST (DADE COUNTY) H&I BANQUET

On December 4, 1982, the first Hospitals & Institutions banquet was held at Harvey Seeds American Legion Hall in Miami. Attendance at the inaugural event was over 400. Several professionals from local treatment programs, therapeutic communities and correctional institutes were among the attendees. Selected prisoners were even allowed to attend this event in their "whites."

In retrospect, this event was an astounding success. It allowed professionals to witness N.A. members from across South Florida in a social setting. It was an unexpected coup d'état as it played a role in legitimizing the N.A. program in the eyes of the professional community.

Bob B. from San Francisco was the featured speaker at this event. He was serving as the chairperson of the World Service Conference Hospitals & Institution subcommittee. He championed the use of the H&I can in open meetings in order to raise funds to purchase literature exclusively for institutional meetings. His enthusiasm for H&I service work was infectious and his commitment was unquestionable.

The inaugural event was also successful financially, as it rose over $1,500. In combination with funds raised from H&I cans, the committee's

bank account grew to previously unfathomable amounts. At a subsequent banquet, Louie C. announced that he was not going to pass the H&I cans. The crowd pondered what he was doing for a moment. He then picked up a large garbage can and challenged the attendees to fill it to the brim. Not so surprisingly, they did! "The committee was on a mission and the fellowship accepted the emotionally charged pleas for donations."

The focus on H&I development in Dade County in the '80s was so successful that their methods and policies were adopted as a model throughout the entire fellowship. The committee focused heavily on building relationships with any institution that would welcome them in order to gain access to as many addicts as possible. These facilities would become a huge feeder system for newcomers. It was the primary reason for the explosion of N.A. meetings throughout the county. By the end of the decade there were over 200 open meetings in Dade County, a success directly attributable to the impact of the H&I work performed during those years.

George H. once commented that, "Dade's H&I account had more money in it than the World Service Conference account." This was more bluster than fact. Through no fault of its own, the H&I can was reluctantly eliminated as a result of similar types of overzealous fundraising. On the other hand, the goal had been achieved: There did not seem to be a shortage of literature available to any institution within the confines of Dade County.

The community participants at the inaugural event included prisoners, patients (aka "clients") from several facilities. Several professionals from these facilities stood up and shared how the patients / prisoners were dramatically affected by the H&I panel meetings brought to their facilities. The audience responded in kind by cheering wildly. It was a pep rally of sorts for the growing H&I efforts.

John L. was the Dade H&I chairperson until December, 1982. He was elected as the Florida H&I chairperson a few weeks later and then in May 1983, at the World Service Conference, he was elected as the WSC H&I chair. He was the second member from Florida elected to a World-level position.

Hospital & Institutions service work was the keystone service in Florida. By 1986, more H&I meetings were taking place in the Florida Region than any other region in the world.

MELBOURNE – THE SPACE COAST

Brevard County is located east of Orlando beginning about thirty miles south of Daytona. It is one of Florida's oldest counties, originally established in 1854, and named after the state comptroller Theodore W. Brevard, who resided in that area. The county once extended both north and south of its current borders and included Indian River County to the south. Cape Kennedy is located in Brevard County as it has been since the space program's inception. NASA is the major employer in the area along with high-tech NASA sub-contractors.

The first meeting held in this area took place in late November or early December 1981 in Titusville. Shortly thereafter, other meetings originated in Melbourne and Cocoa Beach. Each of these three meetings existed in isolation for several months.

Danny C. recently moved to Orlando after completing treatment in Brevard County. He mentioned the existence of an N.A. meeting he attended while in treatment at the facility in Titusville while attending the Florida RSC meeting in February 1982. It was immediately decided that someone should make contact with this meeting in order to introduce the fledgling groups to the Florida fellowship; this became the first successful task of the newly formed Outreach committee.

Ed O. from Melbourne informally attended the May RSC meeting in Orlando. The Space Coast "area" later joined the Florida Region at the July meeting in Tallahassee after attending the first Florida Regional Convention. Thus, Space Coast became the sixth area in Florida. The term "area" was used loosely as many of the early areas consisted more of avid group members than a representative service committee.

The name of this new area resulted from an informal suggestion made at the July RSC meeting in Tallahassee by members who were not even from that area. A new trend had developed using the word "coast" as part of an area's name. This was started by the Gold Coast and then Palm Coast. The meetings' close proximity to Cape Kennedy was the deciding factor resulting in them deciding on the name, Space Coast Area.

The Space Coast Area has one of the oddest and quirkiest histories in relation to other areas in Florida. At first, the area encompassed any meeting south of Daytona Beach, extending all the way to St. Lucie County. The meetings in the Space Coast later merged with the Orlando Area when they fell on hard times. Then the groups broke away once they regained

their strength and grew. They formed a new area called the Indian River Area, which included parts of what are two areas today – Space Coast and Northern Treasure Coast. In the '90s, they again became the Space Coast Area covering the same area they originally did.

The first Hospital & Institution meeting in this area was held in a halfway house in 1982 during a time slot reserved for an A.A. institutional meeting. The Indian River A.A. Intergroup contacted the N.A. members calling it a "hostile takeover." Representatives of the two fellowships met and resolved the controversial issue by setting aside a new time slot reserved for an open N.A. meeting.

Shortly after the South Florida areas left to form the South Florida Region in 1991, the Space Coast Area had grown to become the single largest area in the Florida Region with 56 meetings. However, the area's instability seemed to parallel the difficulties in the local economy, which has always been tied directly to Cape Kennedy. As of the compilation of this book, the area had discontinued their participation in the Florida Region for nearly two years.

In December 1982, the Space Coast Area hosted the Florida Regional Service Committee Weekend. They held a Saturday evening dance and all the proceeds were given to the area to launch a hotline. Members came from across the state to support the fledgling area.

Annual elections were held with Lovell H. from Orlando becoming the new RSC chairperson; Biff K. was elected the vice-chair; John L. was elected the H&I chair; Valen E. was elected treasurer, and Billy M. was elected as the new Foreign Language and Special Services chair. Danny G., Denny M., Bob G., and Ted C. were re-elected as PI chair, Outreach chair, Policy, and Literature chairs, respectively. Big Robert was elected as the Convention chairperson for FRCNA-2.

THE FLORIDA REGION – ONE YEAR LATER

When interviewing those who participated in the Florida RSC during this period, some common issues prevailed: the need for new literature, conflicts between A.A. members who came to N.A., general lack of funds and the like. There were issues that became controversial in later years that were initially thought to be of no significance or importance during this time.

Almost everyone interviewed commented they felt as if they were all equals and united in one primary purpose, that no single area or group of

areas dominated the region. Biff K. from Orlando commented, "South Florida had several hundred, even thousands of members and Orlando had just a dozen members, yet each area had just one vote at the regional meetings." Danny G. from St. Petersburg said, "Everyone felt like they were equal. It created unity and kept us focused on our primary purpose."

Another issue was the distances members would travel to attend RSC meetings. In July 1982, the meeting was held in Tallahassee, and the following month it was held in Key West. The distance between these two cities is over 580 miles. In fact, the Key West meeting had 100 per cent attendance, including that of new representatives from faraway Gainesville and Jacksonville.

The members personally absorbed the cost of travel. It became a hardship for some participants, though this practice continued for years until area service committees and then regional service committees were financially stable enough to assist regional participants. The initial solution for lowering the cost of travel was to discontinue meeting every month and meet instead every other month, a practice that continues today.

At each RSC meeting from 1982 to 1983, the 11 area representatives would announce the number of meetings in their respective areas. The areas located in Southern Florida consisted of 3 areas: Dade, Gold Coast and Palm Coast. Approximately 100 meetings existed between the 3 areas. The 8 remaining areas statewide had between 10 and 35 meetings during that era. The Outreach committee had located 16 loner groups in various parts of the state. Pensacola with their handful of meetings was about to join the Alabama Region in early 1983. The Florida fellowship had grown in leaps and bounds from the inaugural 4 areas to 12 and the number of meetings had more than tripled in just one year.

THE FLORIDA REGIONAL SERVICE OFFICE

In July 1982, the newly formed Florida Regional Service Committee reached the conclusion that a need existed to establish a central office in order to create a reliable method for literature distribution throughout Florida.

A member in St. Petersburg volunteered a room in her apartment for the task; thus, the first office location was opened. It was located at 4545 10th St. The Florida fellowship had grown to over a hundred meetings. The "approval copy" of the *Basic Text* and the "stories booklet" had just been produced and circulated throughout the fellowship.

In December 1982, the Florida Regional Service Committee decided that the fellowship was in need of a more professional atmosphere. This necessitated that the next location would be accessible during normal business hours. Discussions began regarding establishing an office that would be open to any member of the fellowship. Charles K. began looking for potential locations in Fort Lauderdale. There were no funds available for such an endeavor, so the least expensive location was selected.

The office was actually a second-floor hallway that connected two buildings. The Royal Trust Bank sold the attached office building to a private commercial group and the walkway between the two buildings became part of the office complex. The RSO occupied a mere 64 square feet of space.

The office opened for business in March 1983 at the 2810 East Oakland Park Boulevard in Fort Lauderdale. It was decided that the office would store and distribute literature to the entire Florida fellowship, print a regional meeting list, newsletter and regional minutes, and store records and archives, including speaker tapes. The storage of regional minutes and archives was a valuable tool in compiling this book, as all of the original documents were found in the current office when the Florida History Project began.

The Florida RSC passed a motion in August 1983 stating, "...that Florida Regional Service Office pay for shipping charges on literature sales to any area in Florida." All the areas in Florida purchase their literature from the RSO and have done so since this motion passed. In hindsight, this motion ensured the future of the Florida Regional Service Office. The South Florida Region along with other neighboring regions continues to purchase their literature from the Florida RSO.

When representatives of the ad hoc committee searched through the old archives in 2002, they discovered the original reel-to-reel tapes from the 11th World Convention and the 6th World Literature Conference. These old tapes were transferred onto compact discs. Sally E. from California was the main speaker at WCNA-11 in 1981. At WCNA-30 in San Diego in 2003, Sally E. was on an old-timers panel. After the convention, Sally was given a CD of her speaking in Miami in 1981. A note was included: "Sally – We apologize for delivering your tape from WCNA-11 twenty-two years late."

In 1985, the office was relocated to larger quarters on NW 34th Court in the Oakland Park section of Fort Lauderdale, where it remained for

several years. The office was incorporated in 1986 and a board of directors was appointed to serve. Shortly afterward, a full-time employee was hired, and furnishings, data processing equipment, and storage racks were purchased. The focus during those early years was to amass a large stockpile of literature in order to keep pace with the explosive growth of the fellowship.

The office remained in Fort Lauderdale until the early '90s, after which it relocated several times to Orlando, Tampa, back again to South Florida to West Palm Beach in 1997 to West Palm Beach, and later to Lantana. In the summer of 2003, the office again moved, this time to its current location in Lakeland, Florida. The actual revenues in 1982 were under $3,000. Two decades later, the annual budget exceeded $600,000 and the original 64 square feet had grown to over 3,000. When literature orders from the WSO arrive at the RSO in 2003, they no longer come in small boxes, but are shipped on large pallets.

Today, the Florida Regional Service Office (RSO) serves as the distribution center of N.A. literature and other material as deemed appropriate by the Florida RSO Board of Directors. In addition to these services, in 2000 the RSO began providing services to conventions throughout the fellowship, including registration packages and merchandising purchases. It also compiles and distributes regional minutes for the Florida Region, leases space and provides services for the Florida Regional Convention and the South Florida Regional Convention boards. It stores archives from areas within the state as well as convention and regional archives. Its customer base extends well beyond the state of Florida and includes groups and areas in Georgia, Alabama, the Carolinas and some countries in the Caribbean, South and Central America.

Its mission is to provide literature and services to the fellowship at the lowest possible cost and to keep fellowship funds within the N.A. fellowship. It uses those funds to help carry the message to the still suffering addict.

The responsibilities of the Florida Regional Service Office, Inc. grew to also include publishing this book.

PENSACOLA JOINS ALABAMA

Bill B. from Alabama and Motorcycle Ed from Smyrna, Georgia, had been close friends, dating back to the '70s. Close relationships extended throughout the fellowship in Alabama and Georgia. The groups in Alabama

were widespread throughout the state. Near the beginning of 1983, the groups and areas in Alabama decided to form a regional service committee. Motorcycle Ed drove down to the formation meeting to support the neighboring Alabama groups.

The most cohesive fellowship in Florida at the time was located in Southern Florida, primarily in Dade and Broward counties. Pensacola is located nearly 700 miles away by car. Barry M. recalled the discussions that members from Pensacola had regarding joining the Florida Region. The distance was simply too much for them to overcome. Pensacola is located in the Central Time Zone, as is most of the Florida Panhandle; therefore, it was a practical solution to join the Alabama Region.

In April, the founding participants from Alabama were prepared to name the newly formed region and call it the Alabama Region. That changed when a carload of addicts from Pensacola walked through the doors. The Third Tradition Group had been in existence for several years. There was a small, but stable fellowship developing in and around Pensacola. Due to their relative isolation, at least on an N.A. map during that era, the fellowship remained united, building a strong foundation.

The Gulf Coast Area, as they were initially known, formed the nucleus of the Southern Alabama and Western Florida fellowship for the next several years. The groups from Western Florida later reformed an area known as the Greater Pensacola Area.

The Florida Region would have welcomed the Pensacola Area to the Florida Region, although it was easily understandable they became part of an adjoining region due to their proximity to other Florida fellowships during that era.

On another topic, during our research, we spent hundreds of man-hours researching information on the Internet. The history committee noted the Pensacola Area had developed one of the best websites in the fellowship.

RURAL RECOVERY – NORTH CENTRAL FLORIDA

Ray D. and Cathy D., his wife at the time, lived in Spring Hill, Florida. Both were relative "old-timers"; Ray got clean in 1972, Cathy a few years later. Ray transferred from Pennsylvania to Florida to become the marketing director at a treatment center under construction in Bushnell, a town in Sumter County northwest of Orlando.

Cathy D. started an N.A. meeting at the A Center, the local A.A. clubroom. Later the meeting moved to the Westside School Bus Depot on Applewhite Drive in Spring Hill, Florida, in March 1983. Rob S. attended the meeting from time to time, which he referred to as a "bikers' meeting."

Cathy D. heard about the upcoming RSC meeting in Orlando and decided to attend. The minutes from the April 1983, RSC meeting noted that the "Spring Hill Area" attended. Cathy gave a report on the one meeting in Spring Hill and few others they expected to start shortly, one at the center where her husband worked and another she was going to start the following month at Bayonne Point Hospital in Pasco County, just south of Spring Hill. Cathy and two others attended FRCNA-2 in July.

Narcotics Anonymous was now born in Hernando and Pasco County and shortly thereafter in Sumter County in 1983. The meetings struggled in these countryside communities for the remainder of the decade. In 1985, in an RSC Outreach committee memo, there were seven meetings listed as "loner groups" in north-central Florida.

Bruce G. and Biff K. both recalled taking carloads of members to Bushnell from Orlando to support several N.A. meetings held at the treatment center shortly after it opened. Several N.A. members began working at the center. White Deer Run – Florida was later bought out and renamed Koala Center in Bushnell, and they continued sending newcomers into the surrounding areas.

As patients were discharged from the Bushnell facility, they returned home to nearby towns and villages and started meetings. Other ex-patients of the Bushnell facility were part of the original cast in Polk, Citrus, Hernando, and Lake County.

THE RIVER COAST

Rodney M. was released from the White Deer facility in December 1983 and proceeded to start an N.A. meeting at the Homosassa Civic Center in Old Homosassa in Citrus County. The next meeting in Citrus County was the Easy Does It group, which originally met in an A.A. clubhouse in Inverness in late 1984, though it moved to several different locations until it settled into the Floral City Lion's Den in October of 1985.

The groups in Hernando and in Citrus County just to the north formed the River Coast Area Service Committee in August 1, 1989. In September, the River Coast Area held the annual River Coast Area Campout for the first time to celebrate the birth of the area.

In February 1990, the Homosassa Group asked the area for financial assistance with their Third Annual Fish Fry the following month, which had been a popular event even prior to the formation of the area. The area agreed to assist them, and the Annual Fish Fry became the oldest area activity, which continues to be held annually.

Raylene M. attended her first N.A. meeting in Charlotte, West Virginia, in 1983. Raylene and her husband John M. moved to Spring Hill, Florida, in early 1987. They began attending the few local meetings in Brooksville, Floral City, and Homosassa, Florida and were surprised at what they came across. "The meetings were not N.A.-structured meetings. The meetings in Homosassa and Floral City were using A.A. literature and another at Lykes Hospital in Brooksville was using A.A. literature and was being facilitated by a practicing mental health counselor. It was run like an outpatient group therapy session.

There was no clarity in the message of recovery. Those attending the meetings identified themselves as drug addicts and alcoholics in all of the meetings. "There wasn't even any N.A. literature in the meetings." John and Raylene recommended that members of these meetings needed to have a clear N.A. message. They told the groups that N.A. literature was available through the World Service Office in California and they shared about how N.A. meetings could be structured, leading to the message of hope that is found in Narcotics Anonymous.

They started the Spring Hill Basic Text group, which met for the first time in the summer of 1988. The meeting met at the Charter Counseling Center in the Oak Hills Medical Plaza next to Oak Hill Hospital in Spring Hill. Eventually, other meetings were formed in Hernando County at the Greenbrier Hospital where Sherri S. worked. She had recently settled there from the Bay Area. Sherri invited N.A. to start a meeting at the hospital. By then, even the local employee assistance office at Florida Power had asked for another meeting to be held there.

To the north in Citrus County, new meetings had begun at Seven Rivers Hospital in Crystal River, at Sun Coast Plaza in Crystal River, and another at the community room at First Florida Bank in Inverness. In Sumter County, just to the east of Pasco and Hernando counties, the meeting was still in existence at White Deer Treatment Center, though by this time, the facility had changed ownership and become the Koala Center.

Eventually, with the help of fellow addicts from the Bay and Tampa Fun Coast areas, as well as from other areas in the Florida

Region, the Hernando and Citrus groups formed the River Coast Area on August 1, 1989.

CROSS CITY

The Cross City Correctional Institute is in Cross City, about 40 miles directly west of Gainesville. The facility is located in northern Dixie County just off US Highway 19. The in-house meeting registered with the WSO in July 1984. They later registered with the Florida RSO, with the prison chaplain listed as the contact person.

The Thursday evening meeting met at 6:40 p.m., which may seem odd, but is not unusual in a prison environment. The meeting seems to have functioned independently of any service structure. From time to time, members from other rural counties were allowed to visit to speak with prisoners about addiction.

In 1986, the Florida Regional H&I committee assigned the meeting to the Uncoast Area in Gainesville, as it was reasonably nearby. This isolated meeting would come and go with the change of supporting staff. There are small rural counties around Gainesville that host many of the state's largest prisons, including death row with the infamous "Old Sparky."

THE RECOVERY COAST

Pasco County is positioned north of both Hillsborough and Pinellas counties and south of Hernando County. The Florida Legislature created Pasco County on May 12, 1887. Previously it had been the southern portion of Hernando County. The brand new county was named in honor of U.S. Senator Samuel Pasco.

The Pasco County area was inhabited from prehistoric times and contains a large number of archaeological sites showing human occupation as early as 9,000 B.C. In the era of the Second World War, the development of Pasco Packing Company (now known as Lykes) and later of Evens Packing Company in Dade City gave the county two of the largest citrus packing plants in the world. The procedure for making orange juice concentrate was, to a large degree, was developed at the Pasco Packing Fruit Company.

The coastal portion of the county was largely undeveloped until the second half of the twentieth century when it became favored as a retirement area. In recent years, huge residential developments have appeared around

U.S. Highway 19, causing the county's population center to shift to the west coast.

Initially there were meetings in New Port Richey, which is near the border with Pinellas County (the Bay Area). There were also meetings at Dade City Hospital and the original meeting in Pasco at Bayonet Point, as well as elsewhere in western Pasco County.

Initially, the few groups in Pasco were divided: Meetings on the west side of Pasco County were part of the Bay Area and meetings on the east side of the county belonged to the Fun Coast Area (Tampa). The Pasco groups eventually banded together as the distance from their locales to the meetings and activities in the Bay and Fun Coast became an issue. The groups from both sides of the county began to meet together in January in 1989. They discussed their similarities rather than differences. In May of that year, the fledgling groups in Pasco County formed the Recovery Coast Area Service Committee.

GOLDEN TRIANGLE TO CHAIN O' LAKES

In late 1983, Steve M. left White Deer Run and returned to his home to Leesburg where he started an N.A. meeting. Leesburg is located in rural Lake County, which is essentially a suburb of Orlando. In the ensuing few years, several other meetings started in towns nearby in Eustis and Tavares.

These three groups formed the Golden Triangle Area. The name was selected not because of any geographical boundary or local reference; it was referred to a member who wore a gold charm in the shape of the A.A. symbol. The area considered changing its name to the Golden Pyramid once the member purchased a charm with the N.A. symbol on it. The area existed for some time because of a few dedicated members, and once Jacque C. moved away from the area, it simply disappeared.

The remaining groups were part of the Heartland Area for some time, until Ken C. and his wife moved to Lake County from the Bay Area in the nineties. Again, a small area was organized amongst the local members and meetings grew in number and attendance. Along with meetings in Eustis, Tavares, and Leesburg, others began in other towns like Howey-In-The-Hills, Clermont, and Mount Dora.

Unfortunately, this area, too, would struggle once Ken C. moved back to the Bay Area. A young member, Angie M., was sent to an RSC Weekend held in the River Coast area to collect information. Angie was

asked if she would like a seat on the conference floor to represent her area and have minutes mailed to their area. Angie agreed, although she did not fully understand what she did. The "area" was geographic, not a service entity.

Angie asked several local members if they wanted to get involved in forming an area. Of course, many people were upset about her overlooking of the Second Tradition. They created a steering committee and met for several months. Eventually everyone agreed to form the Chain O' Lakes Area in January 1999.

Perhaps the future will see the growth in this area mirror that of other rural communities.

BASIC TEXT – THE FIRST EDITION

The *Basic Text* was approved at the 1982 World Service Conference. The World Service Office did not have the funds necessary to get the book published. Greg P. supposedly suggested a simple solution for the dilemma: They would pre-sell numbered limited-edition copies of the text for $25 in order to raise the funds needed. The money was to be kept in a separate account specifically set up for this purpose.

A friend of Jimmy's published a book entitled, *Thirst for Freedom*. It was agreed that the final version of the *Basic Text* would closely resemble that publication. Orders for the limited-edition book arrived at the WSO daily.

Several delays slowed the printing and distribution of the book. First, the WSO attorney made it clear that a signed release from the Literature Committee would be needed to ensure they or no individual or group could later claim ownership. The signed copy was received in mid-September.

A week later, the WSO Board of Directors decided on which printer to use. Of the three bids submitted, they chose to use a familiar vendor named Thought Process Printers. At the time, this press was producing the *Little White Book* and Informational Pamphlets for the WSO. The WSO (Jimmy) chose a loyal vendor rather than an established book publisher. Because this company was a small neighborhood printer, a large deposit was required. The deposit was equal to half of the projected cost for the 2,500 special limited version and 9,500 standard first-edition copies.

Jimmy, with the assistance of others, proofread the material before the final plates were made. He found what he believed were several

statements consisting of far more than typographical and grammatical errors. He described them as philosophical errors. One of the lines read, "The answer is that these things are not N.A." and "...all else is not N.A."

When Jimmy read that, he had a realization, a correction to a firm stance he's taken in the past. He had always maintained and stated that the World Service Office was not part of the fellowship. The errors he discovered agreed with that position. He then realized his own error. Those statements in essence disavowed the entire service structure as being part of the fellowship. Jimmy decided to take corrective action.

Jimmy notified Chuck S., the chair of the Board of Trustees, and Bob R., the chairperson of the World Service Conference, of the issues at hand. They, along with Phil P., Doug F., and Kevin F., met in mid-November to discuss the calamity. In the end, each party agreed that change was necessary and that waiting until the next conference would not be practical.

The WSO was getting calls daily from individual members and trusted servants across the fellowship clamoring for the book's release. Delays ensued during December and early January. Things got worse quickly. Phil P. discovered the delays were due to fiscal problems at Thought Process, and that the company's survival was in question. Phil dropped by the shop to check on things only to find that the printing equipment had been removed. Phil and others retrieved anything that belonged to them that same night.

There was distrust between those on the east coast and those on the west. This was exacerbated when news got out about the impending bankruptcy of the printer, the excessive delays, and the changes that were made in the text. The attitude on the east coast was, "Who do you think you are, changing *our* book?" In years to come, even those who opposed the changes most vehemently ended up agreeing the changes were correct.

The chapters in question were in second-draft condition at the Sixth World Literature Conference in Miami. According to the Warren and Miami conference minutes, the participants working on them were the same group of individuals: Chuck S., Sally E., Bob B. from LA, Bob B. from San Francisco, Charles K., Bob G., Doug W. from Fort Lauderdale, and George from Philadelphia.

Bob B. recalled that the quote, "all else is not N.A.," was intended to deal with affiliation issues, not the service structure. Meetings in clubhouses were the primary topic of discussion. Bob G. remembered that,

as a group, they went back and forth in regards to the questionable wording. All the pain and suffering could have been avoided, as there simply was not a clear majority one way or another.

By late February, the firestorm had grown throughout the fellowship. Members, regions, and areas began sending telegraphs and letters, which were presented to the WSO Board of Directors. In the book, *My Years in Narcotics Anonymous*, the author made note of a specific excerpt in Florida's response. The letter was written with the approval of the Florida RSC. In part it stated:

"Florida is demanding a halt to all WSO operations and the resignation of all WSO board members."

This was the first specific written request from the fellowship essentially asking for the resignation of Jimmy K., although, no one intended to remove Jimmy, only those around him. Through all the insanity, the book was printed using another publishing house. In late April, just a week before the World Service Conference, the WSO finally took possession of approximately 2,700 limited edition texts and 2,300 first editions. Printers generally have overruns; thus, a few hundred additional books were distributed.

ROSALIE & HER BAND OF MERRY MEN

Prior to the conference, anger over how the literature changes were made along with the delays and what was considered the flawed decision in choosing the printing company all converged to engender a hostile atmosphere. Individual members, groups, areas and regions sent rancorous letters to the WSO directors, WSC participants, and the Board of Trustees.

The Literature Committee mass-mailed an explosive letter to several hundred trusted servants in the fellowship. Dozens of these letters were sent to members in Florida; it was copied and distributed to hundreds of others. The letter detailed the perceived failures of the World Service Office. Blame for the errors as well as perceived stonewalling of the Literature Committee efforts in the past were bandied about. The letter placed all the responsibility on the shoulders of the WSO directors. In fact, it was a subliminal indictment of Jimmy K. His business skills were called into question; some even alluded to a suspicion that his health was a question mark.

In retrospect, many of those who leveled these accusations regretted their anger and the mistrust exhibited by their behavior. All of these communiqués were sent in the months immediately preceding the conference that only incited those who lacked faith in the World Service Office.

The World Service Conference convened on May 4th in Santa Monica, California. Bob R. had the unenviable task of chairing what was destined to become a conference of discontent. The first day was taken up by regional reports.

Rosalie reported, "...there were 140 meetings and 45 H&I meetings with about 1,300 members statewide. In less than two years, our fellowship [Florida] has grown six fold." She went on to present a philosophical overview of Florida's position with regard to the past year's events. "We pride ourselves in being apolitical," she said. "Florida would deal with the issues and not the personalities in keeping with our principles."

Rose detailed each subcommittee's accomplishments. She spoke about the work of the Foreign Language and Special Services committees. They were working on translating the literature into Haitian Creole, Cuban Spanish, and completing the *Little White Book* in Braille! It was translated with the aide of the Florida Center for the Blind and Deaf in Daytona Beach. Oddly, the World Service Office later chose not to accept the committee's gift. Also notable in her report were the activities of the Outreach committee: "One member went to the Middle East and started a meeting in Saudi Arabia." The announcement was unnoticed and went by without acclaim as the attendees were focused on the pending issues.

The fireworks began the next day in earnest with the WSO report that went largely ignored followed by an onslaught of motions and countermotions that lasted for hours. Bob R. attempted to move forward by having Sally E. present the Board of Trustees report.

A long list of pamphlets (IP's) were approved in succession, The *Am I An Addict?* pamphlet was adopted with the infamous question: "Did you use a matchbook to sharpen your needle?" The question was a source of both humor and special identification. Charles K. submitted it during the Warren Conference. However, the proposed revisions to the *Little White Book* were defeated along the lines of the Easterners versus the Californians.

The changes in the *Basic Text* were addressed, and finally the ongoing calamity was concluded, or so they thought. The fellowship succeeded in returning the text to its original language in the subsequent second edition. Ironically, once the emotion of the day had subsided, many believed that the changes were necessary and proper. This would be addressed in later editions.

Elections were held, and the impact of the Florida Region was in evidence as George H. was re-elected as the WSC vice-chairperson and Charles K. and John L. were elected to chair the Public Information and Hospitals & Institution sub-committees. Rosalie R. was elected as the Vice-chairperson of the Finance subcommittee.

Policy changes took up an inordinate amount of time. Nevertheless, changes in the service structure of the Board of Trustees expanded the membership of the board that allowed members to be elected by the conference.

The H&I handbook was quickly adopted along with a list called the *Do's & Don'ts for H&I,*" which was written with the assistance of the Dade County H&I committee.

Rosalie called together a caucus of the seven members in attendance from Florida. She wanted to propose an acceptable and bloodless solution to the ongoing logjam of motions and countermotions regarding the World Service Office. Her motion was read, "That the WSO hire a qualified business manager," and admitted as a "substitute motion," then later approved.

Though it was not the intent, nor was it Florida's desire, in effect, this motion led to the replacement of Jimmy K. as the office manager of the WSO. As her motion was being submitted for consideration she was asked, "Who do you think would be the right person for the job of WSO Office Manager?" Without hesitation, she pointed to Bob Stone, the conference parliamentarian.

It was a successful conference as far as the Florida Region was concerned. Four members from Florida were elected to WSC positions, H&I had a handbook, the limited edition *Basic Text* had finally been released, and the *Basic Text* had been returned to its original state. Both the trustees and directors of the WSO would now be elected by the fellowship, the WSO debacle in the end was resolved by Rosalie's motion, and a new stack of literature would be in meeting rooms soon.

AN ISLAND PARADISE – NASSAU, THE BAHAMAS

NASSAU, BAHAMAS - 1983

Christopher Columbus first set foot on the Island of San Salvador. It is one of the 700 islands that make up the archipelago known as the Commonwealth of the Bahamas. The Bahamas gained complete independence from Great Britain in 1973.

Nassau is the home of the Bahamian national capital. It's been the bustling hub of an island paradise since the shipwrecking days of the legendary pirate, Blackbeard. Prized for its sheltered harbor; the city made history and preserved it beautifully in Victorian mansions, cathedrals and 18th-century fortresses. An abundance of posh resort hotels, casinos, cabaret shows, and cruise ship docks make Nassau a vibrant tropical paradise.

Cecil M. found the N.A. informational pamphlet (IP) *Who Is An Addict?* and some other literature. The written word carried in the literature was the impetus necessary to bring together a group of addicts to start the first N.A. meeting in Nassau and the island nation.

He sought the assistance of Gary C. and Chris F. for this new endeavor. They met for the very first time on June 10, 1983. Initially, the inaugural meeting met in members' homes much like the "rabbit meetings" held in California during the 1950's.

After a few weeks, Richard M. was invited to join their fledgling group and now there were four. Richard volunteered his office as the next location for the meeting and everyone agreed. With the exception of Cecil, the other members wanted to keep it as a "private meeting." This too is eerily similar to HFD (Habit Forming Drug) meetings held privately in the '50s in Southern California prior to the birth of Narcotics Anonymous.

Cecil continued to insist that they go public and meet openly. Finally, the group conceded, so they located a more permanent meeting room at St. Benedict Hall on West Street. They formed the New Providence Group of Narcotics Anonymous, the oldest ongoing N.A. group in the northern Caribbean.

FORT MYERS – THE GULF COAST

The Calusa Indians are now not considered the first inhabitants of the Southwest Florida area. In 1886, Thomas A. Edison vacationed in Fort

Myers to improve his health. It was in Fort Myers that he built the first prefabricated home and the first modern swimming pool in the nation.

The first N.A. meeting in Fort Myers took place at Charter Colonial Hospital in 1983. Chick sponsored Dave. Chick was a counselor at the hospital and had attended N.A. meetings in California. He suggested Dave start an N.A. meeting there shortly after the hospital opened. Dave followed his direction, and the inaugural meeting took place.

Soon there was a second meeting held at Serenity Club in downtown Fort Myers. In fact, many of the meetings that followed were held at Charter Hospital or the Serenity Club. According to the 1984 World Directory, there were eight meetings registered with the WSO in Fort Myers.

Based upon interviews we conducted, it was understood that the first meeting in neighboring Charlotte County took place in 1985, at least it was the first meeting these members were aware of in Charlotte County. While reviewing Florida RSC records, it was discovered that the first meeting actually took place in either late 1983 or early 1984. In the RSC minutes was a notation that the "Port Charlotte Area" was in attendance. In 1985, another meeting began in the town of Punta Gorda, which later hosted a regional weekend.

PANAMA CITY

Panama City is a small municipality with a resident population around 5,000. The Panama City Beach area receives close to 5 million visitors each year. Tourism is the leading industry as evidenced by the many popular nightclubs, amusement attractions, recreational activities, restaurants and lodging establishments in the area.

It is home to the oldest annual N.A. convention east of the Rockies. The Fun in the Sun convention has been held each spring on Panama City Beach, commonly known as "The Golden Strip." The convention is actually not sponsored by the local fellowship but by the North Atlanta Area Service Committee, which has held this event in Panama City since 1977. It was not until 1983 that the first regularly scheduled meeting in Panama City took place. Barry recalled that a few members from Pensacola drove over to support their inaugural meeting. The Bridge to Freedom group was formed in June and still exists today. Initially, Rocky and his girlfriend, Andy and Sherry were early members. Sherry recalled that she knew all of them and two were still using. The group met

at a small church at 6059 US 98, just off Bay Boulevard and had one to two meetings per week for quite some time. In 1986, the group joined the Big Bend Area that mainly served Tallahassee, nearly an hour away.

The first activity in Panama City was a New Year's Eve party held in conjunction with the Big Bend Area. Recovery friends from Tallahassee came and supported the event. The group itself ultimately grew to five meetings a week. The Crossroads Treatment Program in Panama City acted as the primary source of new members until it closed around the end of the eighties or shortly thereafter. "We traveled a lot, we went to conventions – the entire area fit into a car." recalled Sherry. Later, the groups in Panama City tried to form their own area but later joined the Emerald Coast Area in Fort Walton Beach, an hour and a half away.

A VISION OF HOPE

The second Florida Regional Convention took place July 1-4, 1983, at the Galt Ocean Mile Hotel on Fort Lauderdale Beach. This once-grand hotel was in serious decline and lacked its previous grandeur, as it no longer served as a respite for the wealthy. The 975 registered attendees nearly doubled the previous year's attendance. Patti H., the registration chair, single-handedly comprised the entire registration committee as she checked in every attendee during the weekend.

FRCNA had a virtual monopoly during the early and mid-'80s as the only N.A. convention held over Independence Day weekend. This enabled it to draw attendees from across the country. A professional printer who was also a member of the local fellowship created the spectacular convention flyer. The colorful fireworks design was intended to lure participants with a false promise of a pyrotechnics display. By chance, the City of Fort Lauderdale's annual display took place offshore on a barge south of the hotel.

The convention occurred at a time when the local fellowship was bitterly separated. Clear divisions existed along philosophical and geographic lines. The "Eastside" members were staunch N.A. purists who advocated revising language found in the *Little White Book* to be more consistent with their viewpoint. The "Westside" attended both N.A. and A.A. meetings and opposed revising the literature. This division was a microcosm of events occurring across the county in the still-developing fellowship.

At one point, support for the convention was in danger as both parties threatened to boycott the event. The convention chairperson, Big Robert, admirably acted to unite the fellowship around the convention. Disagreements were put aside as everyone enjoyed the annual celebration of recovery.

In light of contemporary standards of political correctness, some of the planned revelry was a tad "off-color," though no one questioned the appropriateness at that time. Among the scheduled festivities were a teeny-weenie bikini contest, a "hot buns" contest, and a banana-eating contest. The hotel manager was thrown into the pool along with anyone else who ventured near the pool area. These actions left lingering questions about the spiritual maturity of the fellowship. Dr. Morgan, director of the Addiction Treatment Program at South Miami Hospital, threatened to ban her patients from N.A. after hearing of these activities. The events went on as scheduled, although, the point was clear, as it simply was not in keeping with the fellowship's spiritual principles.

Unscheduled events were the norm at that year's celebration. Spontaneous meetings were held on the beach and late night meetings were initiated in the Jacuzzi. An impromptu talent show was held. The hotel's bar was suddenly taken over by attendees for that event. An unofficial flea market of N.A. merchandise broke out as a few attendees began hawking their wares poolside.

The convention became a unifying force in Florida as attendees came from more towns, cities and areas, creating newfound relationships among N.A. groups and members. Cathy D. came from Spring Hill, a retirement community an hour north of Tampa, which hosted only a single meeting. Jack drove up from Key West. Larry attended from Jacksonville and, shortly afterwards, he along with others who attended the convention returned home and formed the First Coast Area Service Committee. The most heavily attended workshop was entitled "How to Start an N.A. Meeting," motivating those in attendance to start several dozen meetings over the ensuing months.

Steve B. from Santa Rosa, California, was the convention's featured speaker. He came to N.A. in the mid-'60s and began attending the original Moorpark group in Studio City. He was easy-going and congenial, traits that proved beneficial when he became the chairperson of the World Service Conference that year.

Another custom began at FRCNA-2 that continued for decades: The committee made available unlimited free coffee to all attendees during the weekend. Still, the convention exceeded the most optimistic financial expectations as it earned a profit in excess of $5,000.

THE LATIN CONNECTION GROUP & BEYOND

EL GRUPO CONECCION LATINA Y MAS

In the spring of 1980, several Cuban citizens requested asylum at the Peruvian embassy in Havana. Cuban President Fidel Castro utilized that incident as a pretext to unload thousands of Cuban refugees on the coasts of South Florida. The "Cuban Boatlift" brought thousands of hardened criminals to Miami, elevating the crime rate to new levels. At the same time, the proliferation of the cocaine trade in South Florida led to the drugs wars conducted by the "Cocaine Cowboys." The era was portrayed in dramatic fashion in the popular movie, *Scarface*.

It was inevitable by the summer of 1981 that Narcotics Anonymous would soon welcome an influx of Hispanics into its fold. This was especially true in predominately Hispanic Dade County. Several treatment programs opened specialized "tracks" for those whose primary language was Spanish. At first, the only Hispanics to get clean were bilingual. Another year went by until a Spanish speaking N.A. meeting began.

The Latin Connection Group began in 1983. It is the oldest ongoing Spanish speaking N.A. meeting in the United States, celebrating two decades of recovery in 2003. Miriam A., Jorge H., Frank D., Julio and others were some of the original members to attend this meeting.

The "helplines," or N.A. hotlines, kept names of bilingual members on their response list. Meetings generally stayed small and obscure for several years. The Florida Region recognized the need to address issues related to foreign languages and created the Foreign Language and Special Services subcommittee in early 1982. The *Little White Book* had only recently been translated into Spanish in 1981. Nevertheless, it remained the opinion of the Cuban Hispanics that the booklet was not readable in its current state due to the variety of Spanish dialects.

The subcommittee wanted the *Basic Text* that was likely to be approved at the upcoming WSC translated into Spanish. They sought out

and received quotes, which were forwarded to Bob Stone at the WSO in 1984. This started an odyssey that lasted for years. The full translation of N.A. literature into Spanish took nearly a decade after the *Basic Text* was approved. Members in South Florida were active in this process from the beginning, and the project was eventually turned over to a professional translation company by another former Floridian, George H., at the World Service Office in California.

Spanish speaking meetings began to grow in the '80s in Dade County. Their numbers have fluctuated over the years between eight and fifteen meetings a week. A noteworthy meeting occurred in the late '80s in rural Hardee County. This meeting was formed by a group of migrant workers in the orange groves of Central Florida. Fellowships in other cities began, including Tampa with the La Ultima Parada Grupo or the The Last Stop Group. On October 12, 1995, Paúl A., Chino, Tomás P., Jesús, Pedro A., Carlos, and Cesar formed Un Nuevo Amanecer or A New Dawn Group at the Center for Drug-Free Living on Columbia Street in Orlando. As the new millennium passed, additional meetings began in most metropolitan cities in Florida.

In addition, in the "Spanish" vein, the first South Dade Area Unity Convention was held at Eden Roc Hotel on Miami Beach. From the very start, it was a bilingual convention. There was a complete Spanish language track of workshops, and even the main speaker shared his message in Spanish. He was from the Colombia region. Jorge H. simultaneously translated his presentation into English. The theme for the event was "Love in any Language" or "Amor en Cualquier Lenguage."

FRCNA-9 featured a full set of Spanish language workshops. Joe M., who chaired the Hispanic activities, decided to hold the same workshops in Spanish as in English. FRCNA, SFRCNA and GCCNA continue to hold a track of Spanish language workshops and speaker meetings at major conventions in Florida.

"Hoy los miembros dicen que no tenemos ningunas barreras – tenemos lá unidad." When translated, this means "Today members say we do not have any barriers – we have unity!"

THE SOUTH BAY AREA

The first open N.A. meeting on the west coast of Florida was started in Bradenton in 1980 and, shortly thereafter, another meeting began

in Sarasota on South Pineapple Street. In early 1982, the Fresh Start Group and subsequently other nearby groups joined the Bay Area. The Bay Area Service Committee initially served groups in Pinellas, Hillsborough, Manatee, Sarasota, and Pasco counties.

Mark B. attended the August RSC meeting hosted by the Palm Coast Area at the Palm Beach Retreat, the same facility where the Florida Regional Service Committee was formed December 13, 1981. He announced the groups in Sarasota; Bradenton along with a new meeting in Punta Gorda had just formed their own Area Service Committee. They held the formation meeting on August 6, 1983 and have an established hotline that is doing well. "The South Bay Area has seven meetings and one H&I meeting," Mark B. reported. He explained that members chose to rename the area to the Sarasota ASC at the October RSC meeting in Naples.

The Sarasota Area hosted one of the wackiest Regional Service Committee meetings in February 1984. The weekend's festivities were held in a small country club where a local member lived. When the arrangements were made for the use of the facility, it was not clearly explained that the RSC meeting needed to end at a particular time. The meeting was excessively unruly; voices were heard throughout the facility. The elderly folks in the building were frightened. Within an hour, the manager notified them they would have to leave in short order. Shortly thereafter, the local police arrived to demand that that the boisterous bunch leave immediately.



Site of FRCNA-1 – Hyatt Regency Hotel in West Palm Beach – 1982



Site of FRCNA-2 – Galt Ocean Mile Hotel – Fort Lauderdale – 1983



Bowling Green Treatment Center – Bowling Green, Florida



Site of the Survival Group in early 1980s



Jimmy K. in New York City during the 13th World Convention – 1983



Lakeland Medical Center – Lakeland –
Early meeting place in the Heartland Area



Inaugural meeting place in Tampa – 1982

Chapter Seven

FROM INFANCY TO ADOLESCENCE

THE IMPOSSIBLE DREAM

Terry R. visited Fort Lauderdale just a year and a half prior to the 13th World Convention. Maureen F. asked him if he wanted to attend an N.A. meeting. The Clean & Serene Group met on Friday at 10:00 p.m. in Pompano Beach. Maureen "Mo" introduced him to Paul E., who was chairing the meeting that evening. Paul asked Terry to be that evening's speaker although Terry was at his very first N.A. meeting. This benign introduction led Terry to the N.A. fellowship.

Terry started the first meeting in New York City in April 1981. Terry initially printed copies of the N.A. literature supplied to him by Paul E. for the inaugural meeting. The inaugural group was the Awareness Group that met at Blessed Sacrament Church in Jackson Heights in Queens. Terry wrote to the World Service Office and received a starter kit with a few IP's and the *Little White Book*. He had tired of the delays with the literature orders, so he wrote a letter to the World Service Office. It passionately stated, "That it would be easier to get an ounce of pure heroin from my connection than it is to get literature from you f_____ people."

A few weeks later, Terry received a phone call in response from Jimmy K. Jimmy told Terry how delighted they were at the WSO to know that Narcotics Anonymous had finally reached New York City. He remarked they had just sent out $500 worth of literature, which the New Yorkers could pay back at anytime. Fawn F., a volunteer at the WSO, recalled how energized Jimmy became after reading Terry's letter. He'd gathered the volunteers and board members present that night and read the letter to the group. Tears of joy began to flow, as many of them were native New Yorkers. Finally, N.A. had made its way to the Big Apple via a benign introduction that occurred months earlier in Fort Lauderdale!

Fourteen months later, the New York fellowship grew to 10 meetings and 50 members. Six members drove to WCNA-13 in Milwaukee in September, 1982. The New Yorkers put together a bid package in an attempt to win over those in attendance. The vote to choose the WCNA-13 site was taken and the announcement was made – New York City!

"The Impossible Dream" was the theme for this convention. It was held in the Vista Hotel, part of the World Trade Center complex destroyed in the 2001 9-11 terrorist attack on America. Ironically, one of the hotel's largest stockholders was a trust owned by none other than former Governor

Rockefeller whose anti-drug laws prohibited addicts from gathering in public for years.

The opening meeting featured international speakers from England and Ireland. A meeting was held later that weekend with international members to discuss literature translations, which became a hot topic for decades to come.

In those days, independent vendors whose proprietors were generally themselves in recovery, were brought in to supply conventions with accoutrements such as jewelry and merchandise, and services such as recording the meetings and duplicating them onto cassette tapes. Bill H. from Gainesville who went by the moniker of Mr. Bill sold jewelry at many of these events. Bill discussed the odd arrangement with Bob Stone, the newly installed WSO manager. Bob was unaware at the time of the issues that would arise about the use of the N.A. symbol for personal profit. Bill offered to cease selling his wares if asked to do so. It was Bill who first suggested some type of licensing with the World Service Office.

The convention was held 1500 miles away from Florida, yet over 100 of the 1200 registered attendees made the trip from Florida. This trend continued as large contingencies of Floridians continued their travel to enjoy celebrations of recovery throughout Narcotics Anonymous.

The banquet was a memorable experience, which many recall fondly today. In the '80s, almost everyone attending conventions also attended the banquet regardless of the cost or the quality of the food. Each convention committee took special care to make it a special event. Those whose common attire was "colors & jeans" would for this one evening dress to the nines. This custom continued throughout the decade.

Over 900 of the 1200 people who attended the convention enjoyed the banquet as well. Members of the convention committee were adorned in white tuxedos and glamorous black dresses. One of the most shocking and memorable moments from this convention occurred shortly after the waiters began serving dessert, when an urgent important announcement issued from the podium: "Don't eat the cherries jubilee! *Please*, don't eat the cherries jubilee!!" The dessert had been copiously spiked with booze.

The main speaker at the convention was none other than Jimmy K., who had come back to New York for the first time since he'd arrived in the states as a Scottish immigrant with his parents. Jimmy's parents had made the trip from Paisley, Scotland to Ellis Island in the 1920's. Jimmy delivered a rousing and emotional speech, which detailed his life like no

other time he shared. This would turn out to be one of his last presentations before his death in 1985. Just prior to his death, Jimmy said, "The New York convention was one of the highlights of my life."

At everyone's place setting was a copy of the words to the song, *The Impossible Dream.* When the meeting ended, everyone stood and sang *"...To dream the impossible dream, to beat the un-beatable foe..."* According to Paul E., "It was an overwhelming experience."

The closing event was the spiritual breakfast. At the podium was none other than Father Dan Egan. He'd assisted the original group using the name Narcotics Anonymous in the 1950s and spent most his life helping addicts. He was known as "The Junkie Priest" which was the title of a book written about him in the '60s. The recovery speaker was Nona B., who also had spoken at the Sunday meeting at WCNA-11 in Miami. Once again, all stood and sang *Glory, Glory, Hallelujah.* Over two decades after WCNA-13, the memories Paul recalled "brought chills." It was an emotional experience for all those who attended.

During the convention, Jimmy stopped and talked to everyone. During an interview for this project, Paul E. proudly displayed one of his most treasured possessions – a limited edition text signed by Jimmy K. at WCNA-13. Danny G. of St. Petersburg also recalled that he sat and talked with Jimmy K. for some time, yet at the time, he did not realize who it was he was talking to. Jimmy was a humble man, he confirmed, "just another addict."

There are thousands of members in Florida who were native New Yorkers with strong ties to their former homeland; it is easy to see why this story was included. Many N.A. members attempted to find a geographical cure in South Florida after leaving their northern homes.

THE FLORIDA HEARTLAND

By 1983, most metropolitan areas and medium-sized cities in Florida had blossoming N.A. fellowships underway. The discovery of isolated N.A. meetings in a variety of rural settings began to take place in the early- and mid-'80s because of regional outreach efforts.

The formation of the Heartland Area provides an amazing story of fellowship development and growth in a rural setting. The area itself is comprised of Polk, Highlands, and Hardee Counties, and from time-to-time, parts of Hillsborough, Okeechobee, and Lake Counties, as meetings would crop up in small towns and villages. These counties are located

between Orlando and Tampa extending southward towards Lake Okeechobee. The area encompasses nearly 4,000 square miles; thus, it is the largest geographical area as it relates to the Florida fellowship. In comparison, the Beach & Bay Area (Miami Beach) consists of just 8.1 square miles.

One standard question asked of early and founding members whom the committee conducted interviews with was, "How did you first hear about Narcotics Anonymous?" The answers establish a genealogical network of growth of the N.A. fellowship. The Heartland network had multiple links consisting of alcoholism treatment centers, addicts in A.A., and N.A. members moving to the area. The area has multiple beginnings due to its vast geographic area.

Recollections of a particular incident or set of occurrences vary widely as memories fade over several decades. This definitely was the case in the Heartland saga as different accounts were given in regards to the inaugural meeting. There was enough documented evidence and reliable information to justify mentioning each of them.

Jake C. came to Florida from California. He brought with him a *Little White Book*. This resulted in an informal N.A. meeting held at the treatment center (Bowling Green Treatment Center) for their patients in early 1981.

Word spread to Winter Haven about the N.A. meeting at Bowling Green. It was reported that Mary S. and her husband Ray, "The Painter," along with Mary Ann, formed the nucleus of a fledgling meeting in mid-1981. The group supposedly met at the Health Center in Winter Haven for a short period of time (about a month) before moving to the Bartow Detox Center. If the meeting occurred as reported, it is unlikely it did not meet continuously, nor did it resemble the N.A. we know today.

In 1983, William B. went to treatment at the V.A. Hospital in Miami. He was told to go to N.A. meetings when he got home. He returned to Winter Haven and could not find one. When he went back to Miami for aftercare, it was strongly suggested that he start one on his own and so he did! Bill and another addict also named Bill started the first open N.A. meeting, as we know it today; they met in Polk County at the Tri-County Health Services in Winter Haven Bill named the group simply, after looking on the back of the chips, the Clean & Serene Group.

Don G. came to Polk County from Houston. He had been an active N.A. member back in Texas. Don was a consistent and outspoken member

of the fellowship, who carried the N.A. message with honor. Don died in the early 1990s with over 27 years clean, but left his mark upon the local fellowship.

In early 1983, another meeting began at Lakeland Regional Medical Center. Lynn Hankes, M.D., was the Medical Director at Lakeland Regional Hospital's Alcoholism Treatment Center, commonly known as "7 West." He had heard about N.A. at the recent Florida Alcohol & Drug Abuse Association Conference. He quietly began to support the fellowship while it was still in its infancy. Seven West brought their patients to outside N.A. meetings. During the next decade, the center sent hundreds of addicts into the local fellowship.

Through contact with the RSC Outreach Committee in July 1983, a prison meeting was started inside the Correctional Institute in Avon Park on Wednesday nights in October 1983.

Experience has taught us that early meetings existed in close proximity to each other without common knowledge. This occurred in metropolitan areas as well as rural communities. One may conclude this was the case in areas of rural central Florida including Polk, Highlands, and Hardee Counties. Some or all of the aforementioned meetings may have existed in isolation. The likely cause of this separation might have been the result of N.A. meetings being treatment-center-oriented or its membership being A.A.-oriented. Most likely, the root cause was that addicts meeting openly were still not an accepted practice, even in small recovery communities. The meetings that did exist likely did not resemble N.A. as we know it today.

In 1985, the Top of the Bottom Group met at 1104 Martin Luther King, at the Coleman-Busch building in Lakeland. Dick B. was helpful in starting this meeting. Almost simultaneously, another meeting was started on Thursday night – The Alive and Free Group at the First Presbyterian Church in Lake Alfred.

N.A. was listed in the phone book; although, it was located in Dick B.'s home in 1985. This was routine as many of the original N.A. hotlines were established in members' homes.

In the fall of 1985, David B. started the Surrender To Win Group in Lake Wales at the Good Shepherd Episcopal Church. Some of the other original members were Barbara M., Danny B., Margaret S., Chuck H., and Lou B.

A Tuesday-night meeting followed in Lakeland. That meeting was held at the treatment center at Palm View Psychiatric Hospital. The meeting later moved to Second and Virginia Streets in Lakeland. This completed an initial patchwork of meetings in the central Florida counties. They formed the foundation for an area and began to grow into a small fellowship.

Dick B. recalled that the Lake Alfred meeting held its first N.A. event in a nearby park. It was a memorable picnic with about 75 in attendance. "We had a powerful wind, rain and lighting storm. We were in an open pavilion and were sure the roof would blow away. But it didn't happen and a good time was had by all."

Richard G. checked into Koala Treatment Center in Bushnell, Florida, while he was there, he met Margaret. During her stay there, she met two staff members, Richard N. and Rob S., who were energetic N.A. members from Orlando. Finally, the locals gathered enough support to form the Heartland Area Service Committee in August, 1987. The four-county area became a cohesive N.A. community. They continue to celebrate their anniversary with a formal area gathering each August. The area initially received a lot of support from Biff K., Bruce G., Richard N. and other N.A. members from nearby Orlando.

The Florida Alcoholism Treatment Center (FATC) in Avon Park was the first and oldest twelve-step-oriented center in Florida; it was established in the 1950s. The center's management maintained an abiding commitment to A.A. and was extremely resistant to the N.A. fellowship at first. Eventually, even the staunchly A.A.-oriented treatment program asked Narcotics Anonymous to bring a meeting into their facility. One addict commented, "Today, a few steadfast A.A.-oriented facilities exist that reject the N.A. fellowship. Narcotics Anonymous in the Heartland continues to persevere and prosper." The vast majority of Hospitals & Institutions support the fellowship.

Marlene was a counselor who helped N.A. get into FATC, and she played a vital role pioneering N.A. in Highlands County (Avon Park & Sebring). She was an older woman who acted as a stabilizing force in an otherwise youthful fellowship.

The few existing meetings in south Lake County broke away from Heartland and joined other meetings in the northern portion of Lake County in Eustis, Wildwood, and Leesburg to form the Chain O' Lakes Area over a decade and a half later.

The total population of the Heartland Area is just over 550,000. With the exception of Lakeland, this is predominately a rural area, but they have grown to over fifty meetings with hundreds of members in the past two decades. The area has played host to several Florida Regional Conventions at Grenelefe Resort in Haines City as well as their own area convention. The Heartland Area has the distinction of being the current home of the Florida Regional Service Office location in Lakeland.

TREASURE COAST AREA

The birth of Narcotics Anonymous in Indian River County took place on July 29, 1982. A group of addicts met and held a business meeting and decided on the No Gimmicks Group as their name. They met each Thursday at 8:00 p.m. at the New Port Club at 845 7th Avenue in Vero Beach. It was the inaugural N.A. meeting in Indian River County. Keith, Gina W., George S., and Bob G. were the nucleus of the group. The No Gimmicks Group initially joined the original Space Coast Area that was based in Melbourne nearly 30 miles away. The active members from the south felt they could better serve the area.

On October 2, 1983, the active members of the two existing groups met at Fort Pierce Community College and formed their own area – the Treasure Coast Area. The other founding group hosted the initial meeting in Martin County. Mike J. and James were active members of the Turning Point Group. They met in Jensen Beach on Monday nights at 8:00 p.m. on Skyline Drive.

Word of the meeting soon spread throughout Martin County. Almost simultaneously, two more meeting were started. The third meeting was started on Saturday, December 10th at 8:00 p.m. in Stuart, and the fourth, a few weeks later, was held on a Wednesday night. The fourth meeting was in Indiantown, located west of I-95 and Lake Okeechobee, a rural area a few miles north of Palm Beach County.

ISLAND PARADISE – PART TWO

The fledgling Bahamian N.A. membership was able to make contact with the Florida Regional Service Office in early 1984 and spoke with Jeff P., the office manager. The RSO sent them literature and plenty of flyers about upcoming conventions and other events. The Bahamas group was now on the N.A. map. Back in the states, word of their existence spread

throughout the N.A. community. Members traveling to the Bahamas on business or pleasure were given the address of the New Providence Group. Once visitors began to appear, the group felt they had joined N.A. as a whole. Their interaction with visitors inspired them to travel stateside.

The New Providence Group grew to three meetings a week and then simply by word of mouth, two leading newspapers began printing meeting information. This led to the formation of another group – The Lunchtime Group. By October, 1985, the Bahamas hosted twelve meetings.

Cecil M., Mike T., Andrea C. and others decided to attend the 14th World Convention of N.A. in Chicago in 1984 over Labor Day Weekend. It was a bit-overwhelming coming from their isolated island paradise to a large American city. They met hundreds of addicts who gave them helpful information about recovery and service.

The following year several New Providence members traveled to Orlando to attend the fifth Florida Regional Convention. It was here that the members from Nassau met their compatriots from nearby Freeport, Bahamas.

During the roll call at the main meeting when the Bahamas was called, both the Nassau and Freeport members stood up. It was at this moment when they discovered their mutual involvement in the fellowship. The Freeport group was part of the Georgia Region.

The first group in Freeport was the Freeport Over-Comers Group. It started a few months after the New Providence Group. The founding members were Nancy C., who was a nurse from Georgia, and Linda and her husband Hilton. As far as anyone knows, the original meeting was held at Lucayan Medical Centre in Freeport.

After returning to their respective island paradises, the two groups decided to form an area service committee. The Bahamas Area returned to Florida a few months later and joined the Florida Region. The Florida Region then consisted of 15 areas in two countries!

The Bahamas ASC meetings were generally held in Nassau, but in early 1988, they held one in Freeport. After the area meeting in Freeport, another N.A. meeting was discovered on Grand Bahama Island; the name of the group was Recovery on the Rocks.

The first Bahamas Area Convention was held November 4-6, 1988, at the Whyndam Ambassador Hotel in Nassau. "Discover the Spiritual Connection" was the theme for the first event. Initially, the convention had plenty of support with over 550 in attendance and 350

attended the banquet. The initial support dropped off significantly over the years due to the proliferation of conventions in Florida and N.A. as a whole.

The Bahamas Area left the Florida Region and joined the newly formed South Florida Region in 1990. The South Florida Region was briefly named the South Florida – Bahamas Region. The Area Service Representative (ASR) [later known as a Regional Committee Member or RCM] made the decision after the ASR flew to Miami and then made the long drive to Tallahassee in December. The ASR made the decision without first consulting the area, though; the Bahamas Region decided to go along with the decision after all.

According to Eddie, "We did not get the same reception with South Florida as we did with the Florida Region, and at our January, 1990, area meeting in Nassau, an ad-hoc committee was formed to look into rejoining the Florida Region."

The Bahamas Area decided to end their relationship with the South Florida Region in 1991 when they formed their own region just prior to the World Service Conference where they were seated as a voting member. Eddie H. was the RSR and Perry P. the alternate RSR; the two men traveled to Van Nuys, CA. where the Bahamas was seated (accepted as a voting member of the World Service Conference) in a controversial decision. The whole process caused disharmony among members in the Bahamas.

By then there were 23 weekly meetings a week in the Bahamas. As quickly as they formed their own region, they decided it was more practical to function as an area. The Bahamas rejoined Florida at a regional weekend in Singer Island in April, 1992. The Bahamas remains a part of the Florida Region today.

The fellowship continues to struggle due to their geographic location, lack of funds, and cultural differences. In essence, these are similar issues shared by many rural N.A. communities in Florida.

I DON'T WANT A STINKING PINK CHIP!

In 1982, the WSO first began production of key tags (known also as key fobs) for clean-time recognition at N.A. meetings. Up to that point, members in Florida, among other places, had two choices for "doing the chips." Most used poker chips from the drug store. Using these during the meeting was often accompanied with a pitch: "We use poker chips to remind us that we are gambling with our lives." One dilemma with the poker chips was they came in the colors red, white and blue. In N.A. that

meant we still needed orange for 30 days, green for 60 days and yellow for nine months. The solution often reached was that addicts spray-painted the chips, thus creating the yellow and orange chips. Members who picked up those chips remember that it was not the best solution because carrying the chips in their pockets for any period resulted in the paint rubbing off on everything.

Some groups and areas found a vendor in Atlanta who was willing to produce all six colors on an oversized chip with the stylized N.A. emblazoned on one side. These products were adopted for a short time until the WSO began producing an affordable key tag with all the colors in a style that remains in circulation today. It was shortly after the key tags were added to the inventory that the WSO was requested by H&I to also produce chips, as many prisons did not allow the metal or the symbolism associated with the key tags inside prisons.

Early in the WSO's key-tag-production career, Bob Stone's non-addict status became widely know in N.A. by the general membership when he made the decision to replace the white key tag with one of hot pink. The vendor the WSO was using offered a significant price differential for the pink color. Stone did not realize the strong attachment to the white color (surrender, etc.) and many members had a strong reaction to pink. John C. cautiously admitted, "Yeah, my first key tag was PINK." Jack remembered that members of the Outlaws motorcycle gang who attended meetings then refused to pick up a pink tag: "NO F_____ WAY!"

Throughout this period, there were still no standardized medallions in N.A. In different places, different styles and different vendors were used. The most popular was a design owned by K.B. in Minnesota, a vendor who many N.A. communities used. She had been producing the medallions for several years. In 1985, available designs were included in the Conference Agenda Report; one of these was K.B.'s, which she agreed to release the rights to the design if chosen. It was and she did for a $1.00 fee.

A DECADE AFTER MAINLINE

The Mainline Group became the first ongoing Narcotics Anonymous group in Florida in October, 1974. The fellowship remained small and obscure until a handful of members from the five groups in South Florida formed an area committee in late 1979. A very small but active fellowship began to take shape. Nina P., Rosalie R., Robert M., and John A. went to the 10th World Convention in 1980 in Wichita, Kansas. While in at

the convention, they placed a bid to host the next convention in South Florida. The success of that bid was the turning point for the modest Florida fellowship. The 1981 event inspired members to renew their commitment to Narcotics Anonymous. A few months later, the Florida Regional Service Committee was formed with an urgent mission to reach out to any addict in recovery or seeking recovery in Florida.

The World Service Conference opened with 34 regional delegates in attendance. They welcomed Shane from Ireland. He was the first overseas representative at the conference. The regional reports were first on the agenda. Leah G. stood at the podium and reported that a decade after the Mainline Group was born, "…there are 230 meetings and 2000 recovering addicts in Florida. We have three new area service committees – Sarasota, Gainesville, and Treasure Coast." She was only recently elected as the Florida Regional Service Representative; her report detailed the actions of the seven RSC sub-committees.

Here is a summary of the highlights from her 1984 report: She announced the Literature Committee had completed work on a pamphlet entitled, *The Loner*." She spoke proudly about the Foreign Language and Special Services sub-committee, which was unique to Narcotics Anonymous. "They are in the process of translating literature into Cuban Spanish and have had all the informational pamphlets translated into Braille and sent to the World Service Office. They also have four Spanish-speaking radio spots on stations in Miami and Tampa…The Outreach Committee had formed two of the three new Area Service Committees, and the Regional Service Office had become a centralized communications center for the state of Florida.

Leah also reported on the success of FRCNA-2 and went on to announce the upcoming convention would be a five-day event in Tampa over the July 4th weekend. The committee already had their share of controversy, as one of the tentative workshops was titled "Sex & Serenity."

This conference made two decisions that changed the political landscape of World Services and, eventually, of the Florida fellowship. The World Service Office directors proposed they become responsible for *The N.A. Way* magazine and the Board of Trustees proposed an alternative method to the current literature approval process. The two-year-old magazine was originally set up as a sub-committee consisting primarily of members of the literature movement. The Literature Committee had been a major political force for the past several years; influencing issues that had

absolutely nothing to do with literature. A two-thirds majority approved the two proposals and Florida supported the prevailing side.

These two decisions by no means corrected errors made in the past. They did, however, go a long way to isolate the voices of many who had been the most active trusted servants in past years, especially those involved in the literature movement.

Florida was the only southern state to support these motions. This pattern continued for years as the Floridians generally supported the prevailing side on most important issues while their neighbors were in vocal opposition to the same issues.

George H. from South Miami was elected as the WSC chairperson as he had served as the vice-chairperson for the two preceding years. Leah G. from North Miami was elected as the incoming vice-chair. Bob R. sponsored George, and Leah was his close friend. She developed a close relationship with Sydney, Bob's wife. Whether or not such an assessment was accurate, the trio formed an alliance that strongly opposed the actions of those involved in the literature movement who had fallen out of favor. Even those in Florida who served diligently as part of the literature movement distanced themselves from them. The former literature committee members too, were united behind many of Florida's positions.

The Literature Committee current at that time presented a few relatively innocuous motions to remove *The Use of Medication in Recovery* as approved literature and approve revised guidelines in its place. Then more contentious issues arose from the floor. Chuck G. brought up the fourth- and ninth-tradition revisions again. After much debate, it was decided to adopt the fourth- and ninth-tradition language used in the first edition. The vocal minority vigorously opposed this as Bob Stone referred to them, in his book *My Years with Narcotics Anonymous*. After the vote, there were ongoing discussions in the hallways amongst the losing side, which began to talk about publishing their own version of the book. Chuck G. attempted to allay their concerns by agreeing to reconsider the motion and amending it to send the fourth- and ninth-tradition wording to the fellowship for their approval or disapproval.

Two new World Service Conference (WSC) sub-committees were approved. The Convention committee was an outgrowth of the previous year's ad hoc committee. The International committee was the other. The initial concept for the International committee had been discussed among members in Florida during the previous year because of the success of the

Outreach committee in Florida. The sub-committee reached out to members, groups, and areas in isolated or distant places within Florida, including loners living in rural and isolated areas. Essentially, the committee was to function along the same lines as Florida's committee, only on an international scale, by acting as a conduit between fledgling fellowships overseas and the Florida conference.

It was exactly one year since the *Basic Text* had been released and 40,000 books had been sold. Sixty days later, the changes were adopted by the fellowship by a vast majority; thus, a third edition was on the way.

BELIEVING IN MIRACLES

The Bay Area hosted FRCNA-3. At the time, the Area included all of Tampa and Pinellas County (Clearwater and St. Petersburg); Sarasota had separated and formed its own area less than two years earlier. This convention continued to serve as a unifying force throughout the state. The recent excitement about the explosion of the Area Service Committee formations made the event especially exciting as the fellowship came together at FRCNA-3. This raised the level of enthusiasm in the fellowship and several more area formed shortly after the event. From Jacksonville to Gainesville, and Sarasota to Ft. Myers and Naples, members from these fledgling fellowships began to interact in a casual convention atmosphere at the Tampa Hyatt Regency.

Attendance totaled 812 and the trend of out-of-state visitors making FRCNA their vacation destination. Many of the visitors would "come early and stay late," as the N.A. slogan goes. In addition, they vacationed and visited meetings in the region. This FRCNA was considered experimental since it was planned as a five-day event and it was the first major event held outside of South Florida.

This would be the last FRCNA that the pranks of throwing everyone in the pool and the napkin tossing at the banquets would be universally accepted behavior. Neither the Hyatt's General Manager, other guests at the hotel, or the convention's disc jockey appreciated the unexpected swim. At the banquet, the napkin-throwing got so bad that several attendees were slightly injured and other guests were scared. Biff K., the chairperson for the region, addressed the room and apologized for their behavior. Almost 20 years later, some members still joke: "Biff apologizes."

The program committee was mired in controversy when members from other Areas came to a convention committee meeting and insisted that the committee could not delay speaker selection and that a choice had to be made that day even though the prospective speakers' tapes had not been reviewed. Foregoing any review process – two speakers – one from Tennessee and one from Ohio – were presented, and the decision forced. By that evening, the process and choices had spread to every corner of Florida and the phone lines burned.

Seeing that a mistake had been made, the committee came to its next meeting and changed the main speaker lineup. This time, three first-time main speakers were selected: Tony D. from New York City, Randy J. from Baltimore, and Doreen P. from Washington, D.C. As of the time this text was drafted, all are still clean and all three participated as speakers at N.A.'s 50th Anniversary Convention.

MIRACLES HAPPEN

The World Convention came to the Windy City for the first time over Labor Day weekend, September 2-5, 1984. The fellowship was young but growing rapidly. The Continental Hotel was the site of the event; it was yet another hotel that had at one time played host to the affluent, but was currently in disrepair.

The world convention was an independent event, functioning autonomously from the service structure as it had been since its inception in 1971. The convention moved from city to city. The locals elected the committee and had the sole responsibility to make all the decisions regarding the event as well as deciding on their own policies and financial responsibility. The local committee, with the assistance of Bob Stone at the WSO, decided they should incorporate and seek tax-exempt status. The committee unwittingly had laid the groundwork for the formation of the World Convention Corporation, Inc.

Nearly 1,900 attended the convention, with long-time member Greg P. the featured speaker. At least a hundred members from Florida attended that year's celebration near downtown Chicago.

THE FUN COAST AREA

Tampa only had two N.A. meetings when the Bay Area was given the bid for the third regional convention. Discussions began at FRCNA-3,

held in downtown Tampa, about forming a new area. Tampa was the largest city in Florida without its own area committee.

On September 30, 1984, the groups from Tampa unanimously decided to form their own area. Bruce M. reported that in October 2003, the area hosts seven meetings a week and one H&I meeting. They had just created their first meeting list. The Fun Coast held their first fundraiser the 2nd of November 1984. It was a Halloween Dance and Softball Game in partnership with the Orlando fellowship.

The growth of the fellowship has been dramatic from 1984 to 2004. The have gone from a handful of meetings to nearly eighty. They hold an annual area convention and have thousands of members.

GREENER PASTURES – THE FOREST AREA

The Timucuan Indians were one of the earlier peoples to inhabit the area. The largest of their villages was called "Ocali"; however, its exact location in Marion County is unknown.

Marion County boasts over 1,000 farms and horse-training centers, over 450 of which are thoroughbred farms. In 1999, Ocala/Marion County was recognized by the U.S. Department of Agriculture census as the "Horse Capital of the World."

Rev. Robert Askren was a substance-abuse counselor in addition to being an Episcopal priest. He had heard about Narcotics Anonymous from Rev. Jim Jones, a fellow Episcopal priest working in the addiction field. He saw a need for a place for addicts to meet. He assisted in starting the first Narcotics Anonymous Group in Marion County, which met in the famous St. Patrick's Church parish hall in late 1984 in Ocala.

In 1986, Rose was the chairperson of the Uncoast Area in nearby Gainesville. Nick P., Jane P., and Don C. came to the meeting from nearby Ocala. Speaking on behalf of Ocala, they explained they wanted to join the area, and asked for their neighbors' support. Several months later, Rose wound up moving to Ocala.

At that time, there was just one meeting in Ocala – The First Ocala Group. This group had been in existence for some time. However, beyond the founding meeting, N.A. in Ocala had not been very active and was essentially isolated from the rest of the fellowship. When Nick P., Jane P., and Don C. first moved to Ocala from Jacksonville, they started a second meeting. It was held in Nick and Jane's apartment for almost six months.

One rumor has it that the second meeting was held in the Salvation Army, the result of a fairly substantial donation to the Salvation Army by one of the founding members of Ocala N.A. After all, people were leery of renting meeting space to Narcotics Anonymous!

The third meeting was held in the Marion Country Regional Hospital. It was memorable because it was almost impossible to find: members had to climb to the third floor, switch to another building, and then go up one more floor.

For a long time, growth was slow. Meetings usually consisted of the same four members with an occasional newcomer wandering in. Some stayed, and eventually the fellowship grew. There were meetings every night. The four stalwarts no longer held every service position, for which they were certainly relieved! Rose distinctly remembered holding seven positions at one time!

Eventually, Ocala decided to form its own area – The Forest Area, named after the Ocala State Forest, which occupied much of the surrounding area. Rose was the first area chairperson and Jane P. was the ASR. The Forest Area joined the Florida Region and became involved in the region, hosting the second annual Regional H&I Awareness Day.

The early area service committee meetings were often strange events. Attendees were all relative newcomers with very little service experience. Tempers often flared, resulting in hurt feelings among the area participants, and business took an extraordinary number of hours to accomplish. Nevertheless, the area continued to grow because all involved shared one common goal: a burning desire to see N.A. grow in the Forest Area.

Jane and Nick moved back to Jacksonville and Rose had the distinction of becoming the Regional Service Representative and then the first Regional Delegate when several of the service titles were changed. A decade later, Rose left Ocala.

Rose commented that when she meets people from the Forest Area today, they are unaware of what those early days were like. She remembers vividly sitting in those rooms, night after night, wondering if anyone was ever going to show up and they did. The early members displayed a passion and dedication for Narcotics Anonymous as this small rural fellowship struggled in relative isolation.

1985 WORLD DIRECTORY

In 1984, the most comprehensive meeting directory to date was released. The *Basic Text* and plenty of new information pamphlets were released less than a year prior. The WSO initially found that compiling the World Directory was a full-time project. The fellowship was growing too fast. A fourth of all the registered meetings no longer existed or had moved, and new group registrations were arriving daily.

The first attempt to revise the directory was aborted because of the overwhelming number of changes. When the directory was finally released, nearly 2,800 meetings and corrections were listed. The Florida section had 271 meetings listed in the 1984 edition. The fellowship in Florida was growing at a rapid pace that continued through the end of the decade. Two decades later, there were 261 regularly scheduled and H&I meetings in Broward County alone.

SYNCHRONICITY AREA

Palm Beach County is 40 miles in length. At one end is the county seat, West Palm Beach and at the other end is Boca Raton and Delray Beach. There was a natural geographical, political, and social separation between those two portions of the county.

The elder members generally led the Palm Coast Area in 1985 to the north. The first meeting in Florida began there and the area was initially formed from groups in and around West Palm Beach.

There were a few group members in the south end of the county who believed that the Palm Coast Area was geographically too large to serve their groups in Boca Raton and Delray Beach. "There was also a bit of a power struggle between members that were primarily N.A. members and those who were primarily A.A. members who attended one or two N.A. meetings.

At the Georgia Regional Convention held in February, 1985, ten members from Palm Beach County met in a hotel room to discuss their dilemma. Dawn R., Charlie M., Jeff P., Alan R., Lynn B., and Joe "the Plumber," along with several others, talked about breaking away from the Palm Coast Area and forming their own. Charlie M. and Alan R. were strongly opposed to this idea and the others were undecided.

They passed out flyers for an upcoming planning meeting that all group service representatives (GSR's) could attend. When the meeting

convened, they discussed whether to form their own area. Surprisingly, the response was overwhelming; in March, 1985, the groups in the south county voted unanimously in favor of the proposal. Alan R. changed his mind and was elected as the Area Service Representative and Jack C. was elected as the alternate representative.

They voted on a name and Synchronicity was the popular choice. The name came from the title of a hit song by the popular band The Police.

The new area was not without controversy. The We Do Recover group met at JFK Hospital on Thursday nights. The group was then a member of the Palm Coast Area. Half the membership consisted of members from Palm Coast and the remainder of the group hailed from the new area. There was a heated debate over where the group truly belonged. "Machine Gun" Mike even threatened Jeff P. with bodily harm over the controversy. Eventually the group decided to remain part of the Palm Coast Area.

Louie S. recalled members in the new area were attempting to recruit new groups to their area by persuading existing group from the nearby Gold Coast Area to join them. This trend was apparent, as groups in Deerfield Beach, Coral Springs, and northern Pompano in the northernmost part of Broward County soon joined the Mid-Coast area. The We Do Recover scenario was repeated in several of the northern Broward groups.

When they were introduced at their first regional meeting in August, one member broke out in song, mimicking the area's namesake theme. After much laughter and ridicule (as members would break out in song every time the named was called at Regional meetings), the group changed its name. A simple name was chosen, a comment on the group's location halfway between the Palm Coast Area to the north and the Gold Coast Area to the south: they began to call themselves The Mid-Coast Area.

WORLD SERVICE CONFERENCE – 1985

Florida enjoyed a year of progress as the N.A. message extended into more isolated and rural parts of the state. Miami's Jim G. along with Biff K. of Orlando represented Florida at the World Service Conference from April 29 through May 3, 1985. Jim did an outstanding effort preparing for the conference as he was elected just prior to the event after Lovell H., the previous RSR, resigned.

Jim's comments at the conference included the following:

- "We have approximately 350 meetings, 100 of which are H&I meetings."
- "The fellowship has between 3,000-3,500 members."
- "Increased financial support from area donations enabled us to increase the literature reserve by $2,000 and increase the RSC account by $500 per month. This helps us supply materials and services that are constant and steady. Florida contributed $4,000 to the WSO this year."

He went on to describe sub-committee activity statewide:

- "There are several areas that have extensive radio, television and newspaper coverage."
- "Most areas have hotline committees."
- "The Florida PI committee requests the This is N.A.? pamphlet becomes a priority."
- "The Literature Committee has completed work on The Loner and Unity pamphlets and continues work on Just for Today."

The RSC dissolved the renowned Outreach committee, as many thought there was no longer a need for the committee. As it was stated, "The Administrative Committee will take over their duties." Unfortunately, time would prove this decision faulty.

Jim announced that the RSO sub-committee was also dissolved. But, a corporation known as the Florida Regional Service Office Inc., an entity with a Board of Directors, replaced it. They had just elected four directors and another five would be elected at the next RSC meeting. The office had streamlined the literature ordering process, handling over $20,000 worth in the previous year.

Jim continued, exclaiming, "FRCNA-3 was a rousing success! It was held in Tampa. It was an example of a small area with a sincere need and willingness pulling off a BIG convention." He briefly mentioned that problems persist with speaker selection. "Direct amends were made by the Florida RSC due to the foul-up in this process." Jim concluded by giving a promotion-laden presentation of the upcoming convention. He said, "FRCNA-4 is going to be outrageous! There are over 300 pre-registered and the facilities are magnificent at the Hyatt Regency. BE THERE!"

A GIFT OF LIFE

Many members remarked they recalled several extraordinary occurrences that took place at the fourth Florida Regional Convention of Narcotics Anonymous. "A Gift of Life" was chosen as the theme for the

annual gathering held July 4-7, 1985, at the Hyatt Regency in downtown Miami, with 1200 registered attendees. Jay R. led a committee, which seemed more organized than had those in previous years.

Two major events were scheduled at the Hyatt during the same time span – FRCNA-4 and the Miss Universe Pageant. On several occasions, there were bizarre encounters between dozens of the most astonishingly attractive women as they were paraded past hundreds of gawking addicts. As is normal practice, attendees gathered in the public areas of the hotel only to witness these beauties being chaperoned by "Secret-Service-type" bodyguards through the stunned throngs.

Entire floors of the hotel were placed off-limits to everyone except pageant participants. A few N.A. members attempted to personally introduce themselves to these gorgeous women by visiting the restricted areas, thus, those in the dark suits promptly removed them from the premises. A woman attending the convention quickly developed a crush on Miss Venezuela. She attempted to visit the contestant in her hotel room at 4:00 a.m. and was promptly arrested. Friends bailed her out of jail the next morning.

The location of the Hyatt Regency lent itself to another striking memory of FRCNA-4. The hotel is positioned aside the Miami River. Hundreds of convention attendees gathered in the pool area and along the patio area that stretched the length of the hotel. Directly across the river from the hotel a naval cutter from the U.S. Drug Enforcement Agency docked and then began unloading their bounty of several hundred bales of marijuana and bundles of cocaine. Suddenly hundreds of people who'd remained inside the cool confines of the hotel began to exit onto the patio area to join the throng of onlookers; they were suddenly focused on the ironically stunning and peculiar event.

The era of Miami's cocaine cowboys exemplified in the movie *Scarface* came to an abrupt end in the mid-1980s. Cocaine was so plentiful in that era that it could be found almost anywhere. Shortly after checking into to his hotel room, Ken P. found a "baggie" containing his drug of choice under the bed while unpacking. He spent the next several hours in the marathon meeting sharing about his encounter with the "freaky hotel treat."

The banquet provided another memorable experience shared by several of those we interviewed. One notable memory of FRCNA-4 as well as other conventions of that era was that the "clean time countdown" began

at 20 years, in response to which, the room stood silent, unless an A.A. member attended. "Back then an old-timer had five years," Jay R. explained.

The #1 television show in those days was *Miami Vice*, which was filmed just a few blocks from the hotel. The TV show spawned a fashion trend that was vogue among those in attendance at the Saturday-evening banquet. It was "a sea of men in pastel jackets & pants, loafers without socks, and women wore every combination of flowered dress. It wasn't pretty!" as one member stated.

After the banquet speaker finished his 120-minute presentation, those remaining in the ballroom gathered in the standard closing circle. Susan C., a professional recording artist, sang the popular tune *We Are the World*. This moving song became a trendy prelude to the closing prayer at several N.A. conventions thereafter. The hotel waiters, servers and kitchen helpers even joined in the chorus!

The post-convention growth in Dade County was explosive. The primary vehicle fueling this expansion in both the southern and northern part of the county was the opening of two clubhouses. The Dade/Monroe County Area formed a single unit at this time, representing every meeting from the Dade/Broward county line to Key West. At the October RSC meeting, their area representative predicted it was only a matter of time before the area split into two or three entities.

THE PASSING OF AN ICON

In early June, 1985, Jimmy was admitted into the hospital for lung cancer and was later released back home. He was taken back to the hospital again in late July. Many of his friends were hopeful that his prognosis would improve, though Chuck G., among others, was concerned that Jimmy's end was near.

Chuck notified Bob Stone at the WSO of Jimmy's condition. He thought they should begin working on a draft of his obituary. Bob took on this responsibility. The World Service Office at the time did not possess many of the archives they do today, nor had any branch of service conducted any thorough research regarding the history of the fellowship. The final draft of the obituary contained a line stating that Jimmy was "one of the founders." Many wanted it to read "the founder"; unfortunately, there was no conclusive evidence of such a claim available at that time. After all, Jimmy himself had repeatedly stated, "We don't have any Bill W.'s in

Narcotics Anonymous." In word and in deed, Jimmy exemplified the meaning of humility. Jimmy was without question the backbone of Narcotics Anonymous for 35 years. He attended and participated at the preliminary planning meetings and the first recovery meeting in 1953. He was part of every significant "first" in the history of Narcotics Anonymous. He wrote the majority of the original literature, much of which is still in use today. He shared his keen insights about the program and recovery until the day he died.

Those close to him were emotionally devastated. A moving remembrance was held at an ashram in La Crescenta near Los Angeles on August 5th. His son led off the stirring ceremony; he spoke of his father with the love and devotion expected from a son. He then turned the ceremony over to anyone who wanted to share his or her experiences. One by one, many of those in attendance stood and spoke about the principles Jimmy had taught.

The Los Angeles Times published his obituary, which mentioned that Jimmy "lived in near poverty," as he had dedicated his life to the fellowship he loved so much. The World Service Office later took possession of many of the archives he possessed. This material was used to compile the conference-approved book entitled *Miracles Happen – the Birth of Narcotics Anonymous*.

In Memory of Jimmy K.

"Jimmy was a slight man, but he cast a large shadow. He will be a larger-than-life icon and hero to millions of recovering addicts in years to come."

Chuck S. – Whittier, California

"Jimmy's dream was to make N.A. available to any addict, everywhere!"

George H. – Los Angeles, California

"I sat and talked with this old guy for a while at the 13th World Convention in New York and didn't realize it was Jimmy K. until later. He was a humble man!"

Danny G. – St Petersburg, Florida

"He handed me our literature order – it was in a liquor box! Later I found out he rummaged around for boxes as they didn't have any money to purchase them."

Bob G. – Fort Lauderdale, Florida

"If it wasn't for Jimmy, I wouldn't be here today."

Bob B. – West Palm Beach

Although Jimmy never came to Florida, he maintained relationships with many via phone and letters over the years. He was the voice of N.A. to many of our founding members. His sacrifice and loving

service to the fellowship will never be forgotten "in the lives of many addicts."

D.C. UNITED

Larry J. from Jacksonville arrived and went to the front desk to register for his hotel room. As he stood in the check-in line, he overheard some people talking nearby about the great tapes they'd just purchased. Larry assumed they were with the N.A. convention. He began asking about the tapes and did not catch on at first; only later did he learn his new acquaintances were checking out, having attended the adult movie industry convention that had just ended. The tapes were not speaker tapes after all!

The theme that year was "United and Staying Alive in 1985" as the annual event got underway on August 29 at the Shoreham Hotel. Anywhere you went in the nation's capitol, addicts could be found touring the many exhibits and museums or sitting at local eateries. Twenty-three hundred addicts attended the event at the historic grand hotel.

The convention was well organized; the convention chairperson Anthony led them. He later went to work at the World Service Office, first organizing the World Convention and later as the executive director of N.A. World Services.

The Friday-night speaker meeting was a "coming out" party of sorts for Vito L. He had been clean for over two decades in A.A. He was a rarity in N.A. since the fellowship had only been in existence on the east coast since 1969. Vito talked about attending one of the few N.A. meetings in the world in California back in 1960, but for the most part, he spent the next quarter century in A.A. In later years, Vito met Billy A. from Allentown and a friendship ensued, resulting in Vito becoming an avid member of N.A.

Back then many of the addicts who found hope in A.A. were not supportive of the youthful N.A. fellowship. Many who participated in the early years returned to A.A. after N.A. began to grow. Many would say, "Drug addicts could get clean in N.A., but needed A.A. to recover." Vito took on an active role in N.A. proving such theories false on the east coast.

The D.C. convention was the last one held where actual attendees selected the next convention site. The convention corporation took over this responsibility the following year. Nevertheless, the D.C. crowd made a surprising choice – London, England! This established the World Convention as a truly worldwide event, the first that left the United States.

WE ARE OUR OWN FELLOWSHIP

In the very early 1980s, the Board of Trustees began publishing their letters to the fellowship. The Trustees' role of "Guardian of the Traditions" resulted in many letters being written to them asking for "interpretation of the Traditions" on specific matters. Many of the questions had similar themes or repeated questions the Trustees found themselves answering repeatedly. Sally E. and Sydney R. started compiling and distributing these responses, which helped many N.A. communities see thoughtful study of the Traditions as a way to resolve local issues in a principled way.

At the Trustees' December, 1983, meeting, it was decided that each Trustee would write an article that would be sent to Sally for potential publishing in the *Newsline*. These articles would later be called bulletins and the Trustees would review and consent to their publication.

John F., a Trustee from the Greater Philadelphia Region, in 1985, wrote Trustee Bulletin #13[1], entitled, *Some Thoughts Regarding Our Relationship to Alcoholics Anonymous*. This bulletin, which was widely reproduced and distributed, made a very articulate case for the importance of both using N.A. language and for not turning our backs or alienating members who had a stake in the A.A. fellowship.

It was noted that in the early days, A.A. faced a dilemma with addicts appearing at their doors. They struggled with the impact this might have on the identification of their fellowship. Their solution was to allow anyone to take and adapt their Steps as they saw fit. As N.A. communities developed their understanding of the unique message N.A. had to offer, it became clear that the A.A. and N.A. messages were different and that the alcohol-specific language did not fit well in N.A. This philosophical difference led to much confusion and controversy.

The article made an analogy with A.A.'s spiritual vs. religious argument when approving the steps with our dilemma of finding identification for all addicts regardless of drug. The importance of our identity was made in a way that it did not smack of "anti-AA propaganda." The analogy asked us to look at A.A.'s ten-strike of qualifying "god" with "...As we understood Him..." in the third and eleventh steps, turning what was the divisive issue of god into a cornerstone of A.A., alongside N.A.'s choice of using addiction as the common thread for all addicts, versus

[1]Bulletin #13 can be found and download at www.na.org

simply alcohol. By using addiction, N.A. had eliminated the need for members to focus on the drug of choice that brought them to N.A. and at the same time made the first step relevant for all members regardless of length of clean time.

This article also encouraged our members to avoid adopting an attitude of superiority or taking stands either for or against other fellowships, explaining that doing so would be a violation of the 10th Tradition, which prohibits involvement in outside issues.

It would be next to impossible to identify an N.A. community worldwide that was not affected by the proximity of a local A.A. fellowship. Many of the local N.A. fellowships have experienced great local controversy over the issue of members attending only N.A. and those frequenting meetings of multiple fellowships. Many of the Areas in Florida have experienced pitched battles over the use of language, outside literature and speakers. Some say, establishing its distinctive identity as a necessary growth stage for N.A, while others point to this as a sign of the need for more maturity on behalf of N.A. members.

A separate but similar aspect of the dynamics between A.A. and N.A. was the effect of A.A.'s evolution towards its policy on "Singleness of Purpose." In 1984, A.A. approved a pamphlet entitled, *The A.A. Member – Medications and Other Drugs*. (This replaced *The A.A. Member and Drug Abuse*.) Many local A.A. fellowships began incorporating aspects of this into their formats and group policies. Stuart S. said, "We would periodically get a rush of people at the meetings coming from A.A. who got shut down for talking about drugs or using N.A. language. I remember us purists would sit back and watch the 'anda's' (phrase used by some to describe those who identify themselves in N.A. meetings as "an addict AND A…" instead of simply an addict) try to dance around this one every time it came up as a topic. We would just share that addiction was the problem and N.A. was the solution. I watched this little melodrama play out numerous times in Florida, Virginia, and D.C."

IN JUNE 1945, BILL W. ANSWERED SEVERAL QUESTIONS FOLLOWING A PRESENTATION AT THE YALE SCHOOL OF ALCOHOL STUDIES:

> Bill explained, "…We are in exactly the same position with them [drug addicts] that the doctor and the clergyman have been in respect to the alcoholic. We just don't talk that fellow's language."

"We hope the bridge is going to be crossed. There may be a case here and there that has been helped. But in all, I suppose there may be about 50 cases of real morphine addiction in former alcoholics who have been helped by A.A. Of course, we have a great many barbital users, but we don't consider those people particularly difficult if they really want to do something about it, and particularly if it's associated with liquor. They seem to get out of it after awhile. But where you have morphine, or some of those other derivatives, then it gets very tough. Then you have to have a "dope" talk to a "dope," and I hope that we can some day find a bridge to the addict."

MARCH 1971 – BILL W. WROTE IN THE GRAPEVINE:

"You also have some people who are not alcoholics, but are addicts of other kinds. A great many A.A.s have taken pity on these people, and have actually tried to make them full-fledged A.A.s. Of course, their identification with alcoholics is no good at all, and the groups themselves easily stop this practice in the normal course of A.A. affairs.

"Thoughtful A.A.s, however, encourage these sponsors to bring addicts to open meetings, just as they would any other interested people. In the end, these addicts usually gravitate to other forms of therapy. They are not received on the platform in open meetings unless they have an alcohol problem, and closed meetings are, of course, denied them. We know that we cannot do everything for everybody with an addiction problem."

A.A.'S POLICY IS ARTICULATED AS FOLLOWS:

"Alcoholism and drug addiction are often referred to as 'substance abuse'" or' 'chemical dependency.' Alcoholics and non-alcoholics are, therefore, sometimes introduced to A.A. and encouraged to attend A.A. meetings. Anyone may attend open A.A. meetings. But only those with a drinking problem may attend closed meetings or become A.A. members."

George E. Vaillant, M.D., a non-alcoholic trustee of the A.A. General Service Board, made the following statement: "Unless alcoholism is kept relentlessly in the foreground, other issues will usurp everybody's attention." On balance, says George, "If everyone just keeps talking, keeps communicating, then I believe that those who would fare better in another program, such as N.A....will find an appropriate home."

In October 1985, many of the trustees noticed an article that Ron H. wrotefor the *Newsline*. The article articulated a position the Board of

Trustees wanted to convey in regards to the relationship between A.A. and N.A. Ron H. adapted his article, directing it instead at those in A.A. and sent it to the *A.A. Grapevine*. It was published in a 1986 edition of *The Grapevine*.

On many occasions, Jimmy K. repeatedly said, "We must stand on our own feet, separate and apart from any other program."

THE DADE AREA – NOW THERE ARE TWO!

Following FRCNA-4 and even beforehand, members in Dade County began discussing the possibility of splitting their area into two or three smaller areas. The Dade County Area in late 1985 was one of the single largest area service committees in the entire fellowship. An onslaught of private treatment facilities combined with the avid N.A. members who staffed them led to the explosive growth.

Chris C. reported at the October RSC meeting that he believed the South Dade and the Florida Keys groups would form their own area or possibly two areas shortly.

The groups in South Dade formed their own ASC that included the meetings in the Florida Keys as well as most meetings south of downtown Miami. "Area Service Committee meetings were so large that we weren't serving the groups as well," noted one member. Then there were two. The oddity was that Chris C. was the ASR for North Dade and Steve R. the ASR for South Dade, yet they were roommates in North Miami.

THE SEVEN SEAS MOTEL

For over two decades, members have attended Regional Service Committee Weekends throughout Florida. Two hundred and twenty regional weekends have been held in Florida during the past two decades among the Florida, South Florida, and the Northwest Florida-Alabama Regional Service Committees. During several interviews, individuals recalled fond, comical, and emotional memories from those weekends.

The Florida RSC was scheduled to take place in Miami in April 1983. At this time, the pre-conference event and RSC meeting were historically held in church halls or other community rooms. Harvey Seeds American Legion Hall was selected to host the dance and the RSC meeting that year. Those who attended from out of town typically stayed with other members or in an inexpensive motel nearby. It became apparent that no one spent much time locating suitable guest quarters for this weekend.

The Seven Seas Motel was located in a seedy section of Miami on Biscayne Boulevard not far from the American Legion. One addict said, "It is the worst facility ever used by N.A. in our history – maybe anywhere on the planet!"

In those days, trusted servants were willing to settle for less to be of service. A common phrase at meetings was "going to any length to stay clean." The Seven Seas gave new meaning to "any length."

Irving G. recalled his registration experience. As he slipped the $19 fee under the bulletproof glass, he noticed the clerk was wearing a side arm. The clerk then slid a set of sheets through the window. Larry J. remembered stepping over a fellow junkie on the way to his room – though this junkie was not clean; he had a syringe hanging from his arm.

Frank M. checked into the "orgy" room as the desk clerk referred to it. It had four double beds, faded red paint peeling off the ceiling and walls. There were fresh bloodstains on one of the flimsy blankets. The clerk mentioned that the room was used years earlier for several scenes during the filming of *Deep Throat*, an infamous porn film. Prostitutes used the several rooms at the downtrodden motel for rendezvous. After George walked past a room that had police tape draped across the doorway, he remembered thinking, "I shot dope in better places."

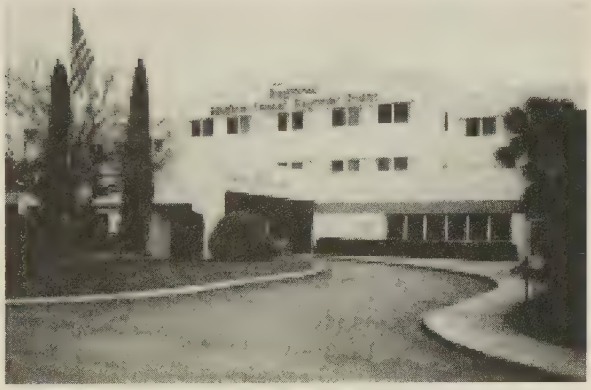
Others remembered the ever-popular Skyway Inn in St. Petersburg where the hotel room doors did not close and the showers were cold. You could always count on empty beer cans and liquor bottles littering the breezeways, and women of the evening "entertaining" their clientele in adjacent rooms. In the RSC minutes, a motion was found "that Narcotics Anonymous as a whole never EVER use the Skyway Inn again." The motion passed unanimously.

The Ormond Beach Hotel was another ill-famed RSC site. The same motion passed for this hotel. It was a quaint old hotel, especially memorable for those who had the misfortune to lean on the decorative railing surrounding the porches. Biff K. said, "The railings needless to say were decorative and no longer functional as a few us found out on their way to the ground, when the railings gave way." Flickering lights were commonplace, as was a less-than-safe feeling about the electrical wiring in the place. Patti H. could not get the hotel room door to close, so she went to the front desk and was given another room; the same problem existed with many of the rooms. The hotel was actually condemned by the local board of health a few weeks after the RSC weekend.

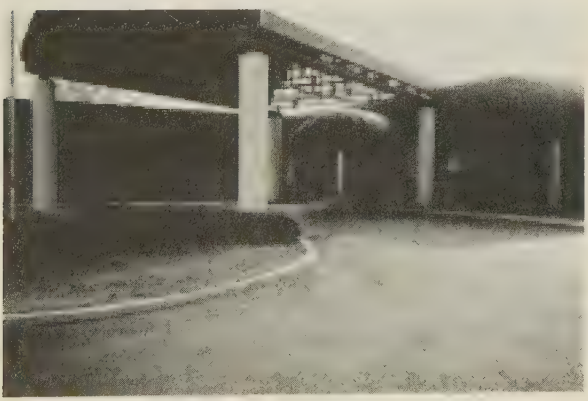
Key West is the only city among these infamous sites that was noted twice. Many attendees were taken aback after they checked into the Atlantic Shores Motel in Key West. Someone forgot to notify them that the hotel catered mainly to openly gay clientele – very open! The other option that same weekend was the El Rancho Motel, which speaks for itself. Bruce G. simply walked around town until he found something more suitable at the Southernmost Motel. These facilities are long gone or have had drastic renovations and facelifts. The only exception is the Seven Seas Motel, which, in 2004, is still in operation.



A Club – Spring Hill – inaugural site of first meeting
in Herando County – 1983



Inaugural site of first meeting in Pasco County – 1983



Early meeting place in Eastern Pasco County



Site of FRCNA-5 – Orlando



Site of meeting at Jacksonville Naval Air Station – Building 590



Citrus-Marion Mental Health Center – site of meeting in Ocala

Chapter Eight

THE JOURNEY CONTINUES

ANOTHER DISEASE COMES CALLING

Gina H. was involved in the literature movement from the beginning, traveling across the country from event to event between 1979 and 1982. Her story remains in the *Basic Text* under the title "No Excuse for Loneliness." Gina was an eccentric, artsy type from Tennessee who came to Florida to further her education. She was a slight woman who supported herself by drawing portraits of tourists and locals along "The Strip" on Ft. Lauderdale beach between 1982 and 1984.

It was during this period that she contracted AIDS, a disease that few people had knowledge of at the time and far fewer understood. Nevertheless, by the end of 1984, the number of AIDS cases in the U.S. had risen to 3,064. Gina was the first member in Florida to have obvious symptoms of the disease. It was thought to be a "gay men's disease" at the time. All that was known was there was no known cure. Fellow members were confused, as the media had over-dramatized how the disease could be transmitted.

Some months later, Louie C. was standing in the back of a meeting room at the coffee table and in walked Lloyd. He was well-liked by many. Furthermore, he had started his own business. Lloyd liked to jog and did so every day. Louie looked at him and asked if he was depressed. Lloyd said he was jogging and got so winded; he then said the eight words Louie would never forget. "I don't know – I just don't feel right." The next day Lloyd went to the doctor and shortly afterwards found out he had AIDS.

There was a panic in meetings. Louie C. said "We were afraid to touch each other, and God forbid anyone sneezed." The coffee bar at "The Warehouse," a local clubhouse used solely for N.A. meetings, began providing plastic stirring spoons with each cup of coffee. People were afraid to drink anything anybody else touched; everyone started to reflect back to whom they had slept with and then back to whom that person slept with, and so on. There was an "epidemic of fear and prejudice." This went on for some time.

Initially, Gina was ostracized. People in the fellowship would not hug her, or, in some situations, even touch her hand during the closing prayer. Irving and Gina became very close and he became her friend and advocate. She finally moved home to Tennessee where she passed away in 1987. Her parents sent her ashes back to Florida and requested her friends in N.A. release them where she spent most of her time. An entourage

attended the impromptu sunset service. One addict remembered that a whole flock of birds hovered over her ashes as they floated off into Biscayne Bay. The birds took off just as the sun finally set.

In the United States, the Surgeon General's Report on AIDS was published at the end of 1986. The report was the government's first major statement on what the nation should do to prevent the spread of AIDS. The unusually explicit report urged parents and schools to initiate "frank, open discussions" about AIDS.

Therefore, Lloyd decided to do something to try to set everyone's mind at ease to whatever extent possible. He invited health care professionals, including doctors, nurses and others who now specialized in treating AIDS patients, to visit The Warehouse and speak at a fellowship seminar. Everyone was invited to attend. Lloyd's contacts in the medical field presented educational information about the disease and explained the steps everyone needed to take to prevent contracting and transmitting the disease. The bad news members received that day was that intravenous drug users were highly susceptible. Thousands of N.A. members arranged to be tested once the early version of the test became available. For each member who tested positive, hundreds of others rushed to be tested. Sexual interaction among members practically ceased. In every city in Florida, this scene was repeated in the fellowship. A predominant number of members with the disease were in South Florida, which had ranked the third highest in terms of the rate of infection in the country, just behind New York and San Francisco.

Suddenly it was local public knowledge that Ricky, Julio, Frank, Doreen, Laura, Al, Katy, Bruce, Louie S. and dozens of others had tested positive. Many of them were very active trusted servants. By then, Gina and Lloyd had passed away, victims of the epidemic.

Ricky R. was the first Hispanic in Broward to stay clean. He did service work in order to reach other Hispanics, for which he is owed a debt of gratitude. He was well-spoken and attended many meetings, so by the time he got sick, the local N.A. community had learned more about AIDS. Rick helped unseat the unfounded fear of hugging members with HIV.

Kristi F. noted, "It was a controversial issue in the Sun Coast Area," and throughout Florida. Members would share about being HIV positive, only for others to admonish them that such a topic comprised an "outside issue," a violation of an N.A. tradition. Those living with HIV did

not feel welcomed in some meetings and were intimidated against sharing openly in them. Kristi noted, "It was a scary and sad time."

Frank was the Regional Service Committee Public Information Chairperson; he was vigilant in service work and was well-loved by members across Florida. "He was involved in service right up to the end," Biff recalled. When Frank passed away, the church was filled with hundreds of members.

Dr. Tom was very involved with the 11th World Convention and Hospital & Institutions work. He chaired the Florida RSC H&I subcommittee. He helped compile the pamphlet *The Use of Medication in Recovery* and participated in many other service committees throughout his recovery. Bob G. commented that Tom was a "father, brother, uncle and best friend to everyone he met." Once he became ill, he passed within a few months.

Alvin P. from Tampa was a very active and influential member of the Tampa Fun Coast Area. Chuck H. remembered, "He helped a lot of new members of our fellowship who went through treatment at Charter Hospital in Tampa." Although sick, Alvin continued to be of service. He spoke at the Heartland Clean Time Celebration in 1994. He was a Florida regional speaker at FRCNA-14 in Orlando in 1995. He passed away shortly afterwards. Alvin touched the lives of many members in the Central Florida corridor.

Some members nevertheless beat the odds, surviving until manageable medications were available in the later 1990s. Bruce G. "opened up" while chairing an "Illness in Recovery" workshop at FRCNA. It was probably the first time the Region started to address the topic. Some did not open up until their symptoms made their suffering apparent, which only created further suspicions. Others, finally, denied their plight to the end Louie S. spoke extensively about the miracle of surviving through the illness until he found the right medications. He never stopped reaching out to help other addicts who suffer from the illness.

Louie R. shared that he had the virus at a Tuesday meeting in Naples. He had been in the hospital with pneumonia and was then diagnosed. Louie and his wife, Stephanie, were dedicated members of the fellowship. Bob K, a newcomer, told Louie after the meeting "If I found out I had AIDS, I would be out the door to stay high until I died." Louie replied simply: "The object of recovery is to die clean, no matter when it is…" His grace left an impression upon all those he met.

N.A. members even served on various boards and committees in the community to assist addicts with the disease. Maud B. eventually became a board member, and the last year she worked there served as the Chairperson of the Board and the CEO for AIDS Center One. Maud remembered that one of the lines that kept her going at the center was a quote from the literature that stated, "...just that much faster do we become acceptable, responsible, and productive members of that society," a reference to not only the N.A. community, but to society itself.

As time went on, many passed away, but the Florida fellowship recovered from the loss of hundreds of members. "We grieved together as a fellowship." said Louie C. God bless those whose lives were lost; they are all deeply missed.

CARRYING THE MESSAGE BEYOND FLORIDA

Narcotics Anonymous meetings have existed outside of the United States as far back as the late 1960s and early '70s. One notable story shared with us by Betty K. involved what was possibly the first attempt to carry the message overseas. Jimmy K. sent the *Little White Book* in packages he shipped to his son who was stationed in Vietnam. Jimmy told him to pass them on to those who may need it. We have no evidence that a meeting ever occurred, but the possibility that one did no doubt exists, considering how many meetings began because of one booklet getting into the right hands.

During the '70s and early '80s, evidence of overseas meetings was limited to rumor. Documented confirmation of meetings that began in faraway places was scant. In August 1971, Sylvia M., who was then living in Northern California, received a letter from an Al-Anon member in San Paulo, Brazil. The Al-Anon member mentioned assisting in starting a meeting for addicts in March, just a few months prior. The group was called Toxicomanos Anonimous. Sylvia M. sent a return letter and included some N.A. literature.

In the 1976 World Directory, there were meetings listed in Australia, Germany, and Canada. In 1996, the Australian fellowship published a small booklet entitled *Recovery Down Under*, which detailed the history of their fellowship. The first piece of N.A. literature was translated into German in 1978. A Spanish version was available shortly thereafter.

Communication with overseas groups was generally limited to letters sent by Jimmy K. and others he enlisted to respond to the growing

number of international inquiries in the 1970s. He solicited others to tape meetings and, on other occasions, members simply sat around his living room recording their conversations. Jimmy sent the reel-to-reel tapes to foreigners from time to time. He sent them to a prison in Canada and to fledgling meetings in Australia, among other places, as the need arose and was communicated to him.

The first attempted N.A. meeting in Florida occurred when Ross M. moved to Key West in 1969 to care for his elderly parents. His was the first case of an N.A. member traveling to Florida and starting a meeting there. Previous chapters of this book documented instances when N.A. members traveled outside Florida and carried the N.A. message of recovery. In some cases, addicts who found hope in A.A came to Florida and were introduced to Narcotics Anonymous.

In 1979, Bob M. left a treatment center in West Palm Beach and started a meeting in Joplin, Missouri. Steve went to Nashville in early 1980 and met Gina H. in an A.A. meeting. She spotted the *Little White Book* he carried in his back pocket, which resulted in their first meeting being formed shortly thereafter.

In 1980, Paul E. began traveling back and forth to New York City to visit his father. While there, he handed out N.A. literature to addicts he found at A.A. meetings. Rick E. was sent to South Africa from Fort Lauderdale as part of a Young People's A.A. exchange program, where he passed out N.A. literature, leading to South Africa's first N.A. meeting toward the end of 1980.

Dudley S. attended his first N.A. meeting at the Back Room Club while visiting Miami in 1979. He was an addict who had found hope years before in A.A. Upon his return to London, England, he began recruiting other addicts. An A.A. member who'd obtained some N.A. literature from a member in Germany turned it over to Dudley. Together they started the first N.A. meeting in the United Kingdom on the fifth of August 1980.

Terry R. visited Fort Lauderdale in early 1981. He attended several meetings during his stay. A few months later in April, he started the first N.A. meeting in New York City.

In 1981, there were two foreigners in attendance at the WCNA-11 event in Miami. Olivia had moved to New York from Ireland and confirmed the existence of N.A. meetings in Dublin. Ireland became the first overseas country to attend the World Service Conference.

This initial introduction initiated a dedicated effort to reach out and carry the N.A. message to members across the globe. George H. later said that it was Jimmy's vision, "that every addict anywhere would find recovery in Narcotics Anonymous." George himself worked at the WSO; he acted as an emissary when he visited faraway lands. He was instrumental in helping several international fellowships develop.

Howie loaded his car for a trip to Miami from Massachusetts. He brought along a car full of members he sponsored. While in South Florida, they attended several N.A. meetings in Miami and Fort Lauderdale. Howie started the first N.A. meeting in Boston when they returned to New England. The inaugural meeting was held on Saturday nights at Waltham Hospital.

A patient at South Miami Hospital's addiction treatment program had come to the states from St. Thomas in the Virgin Islands. The newly formed Florida Region gave him a handful of literature, and a meeting was started in St. Thomas in 1982. George H. reported the meeting in his RSR report at the 1982 World Service Conference.

Rosalie R., in her RSR report at the 1983 World Service Conference, noted "A member from Florida traveled to Saudi Arabia (in 1982) and started an N.A. meeting while there." This was the inaugural meeting in the Middle East.

Miami is commonly referred to as "The Gateway to South America and the Caribbean." A pattern of carrying the N.A. message beyond Florida continued throughout the '80s and early '90s, resulting in an expansion of the fellowship across the globe.

Rim B. from Daytona traveled and moved throughout the states often during the '80s. In 1993, he returned to his native homeland in Kiev, Russia. He started the first meetings there and stayed in communication with the WSO. Rim, in his own words, was "a wandering soul." He reached out to addicts in "some of the strangest places," from the inner-city neighborhoods in Miami, to Utah, then New England and, finally, Russia.

These types of efforts occurred whenever members traveled. Sometimes these were spontaneous occurrences; at other times, they were planned and orchestrated.

Bill H. from Gainesville traveled to Mexico on vacation. He went to a small A.A. clubroom and found several addicts among those attending meetings. Bill passed along some N.A. literature to his newfound friends. He returned a year later on a subsequent trip. This time Bill found several

N.A. meetings that had sprung up as a direct result of his "carrying the N.A. message" the year before.

The Florida Region sent Ron M., Sandy, and C.J. to the Bahamas as part of an outreach effort in New Providence Island, more commonly known as Nassau. While visiting the island, they met Don P., who was the area chairperson at the time. Don disclosed that he and other N.A. members regularly took his yacht on treks through the Florida Straits south to the island nation of Cuba. Initially, these trips focused on attaining fine cigars. Later they assisted a few addicts with their desire for recovery. They supported several small N.A. meetings that had cropped up on the communist island. Another breakthrough – recovery is alive in Cuba.

The fellowship in South Florida had a strong Hispanic connection. Many came to the states from Cuba, Brazil, Columbia, and Puerto Rico, as well as dozens of other Central and South American countries. Louie S. recalled, "I know the New York fellowship claimed they started the first meeting in San Juan, but it was actually the Gold Coast Area that donated literature to the first N.A. meeting in Puerto Rico.

Jorge H. accompanied several workers from the World Service Office on trips to South America to support the struggling fellowship in early 1990. The Floridians acted as tour guides and translators. One such trip brought together Toxicos Anonymous, the fledgling fellowship that had developed in a few South American countries, and the existing N.A. fellowship. This trip resulted in one united fellowship known as Narcoticos Anonymous.

Members of the Narcotics Anonymous fellowship continue to carry the message of recovery by assisting faraway members in their efforts to live "Just for Today."

OUR WORDS HAVE MEANING

As part of the initiative to stress the importance of a clear N.A. message, the World Service Conference asked the Trustees to present recommended changes to the *Little White Book*. The line, "One is too many, and a thousand is never enough," was to be removed. The New Attitudes group from the Bay Area noticed that that line was to be removed and came to the Bay Area ASC and made the motion that the line should not be removed. That motion was passed and at the April RSC meeting held in the Dade Area, the motion passed at the RSC. Florida's RSR took this to the World Service Conference and the line was added back in. Thanks to the

New Attitudes Group, one is still too many and a thousand is still not enough.

A host of changes were made that replaced language that was drug-specific or otherwise inconsistent with N.A.'s intended message. Some were subtle, like "...first fix, pill or drink." On the other hand, changing the word, "recovered," in "we are recovered addicts who meet regularly..." to the word, "recovering," significantly changed the way we described ourselves in our literature.

One dilemma faced within the scope of this project was the stories included in the *Little White Book*. Should they be edited as well to be consistent with the N.A. message or left in their formats? Should they have been replaced with new stories? Every option contained its own inherent controversy, but the solution selected at the conference was to replace the original stories with new ones. This caused an uproar that lasted for years, and many founding members fought hard to have the *Little White Book* changed back to its original form. In the end, the fellowship was moving forward with the changes, and while a motion to reconsider the change was debated and ultimately defeated, the fellowship as a whole would not look back. A number of N.A.'s earliest members are still upset with the outcome of this decision.

N.A.'s literature has always been a highly emotional topic. The arguments that transpired over the language on the Fourth and Ninth Traditions in the *Basic Text* highlights the emotional response N.A. members have for their literature.

FRIENDS OF THE FELLOWSHIP

Throughout its history, N.A. has benefited from the physical, emotional, and spiritual support offered by "friends of the fellowship." These individuals were non-addicts, mostly well-meaning individuals who performed tasks or services on behalf of our fellowship without any desire or expectation of personal enhancement.

Some were health care professionals who fostered support for a fledgling fellowship before it was vogue to do so. The love and support of Nar-Anon has always played a significant role in the lives of many addicts. There were A.A. members who believed that addicts needed a place of their own; they identified with the suffering addict and opened their hearts, speaking on behalf of our fellowship before we took our place as a full-fledged entity. N.A. members often remain unaware of these contributions,

as these loving individuals assisted in virtual anonymity. In some cases, the individuals themselves were unaware of how much their efforts affected the lives of recovering addicts. It wasn't until the late '90s that N.A. began to acknowledge the significance of such contributions.

Phyllis S. grew tired of her husband's antics as his addiction progressed despite repeated attempts to recover. Eventually, she sought help for herself. With the aid of a few others, Phyllis started a Nar-Anon meeting in early 1980. As word got out about the group, it grew rapidly. Parents and spouses found hope separately and apart from their struggling loved ones. Over the years, Nar-Anon members provided encouragement for their loved ones as well as for other members of N.A. Their contributions were significant to the growth of Narcotics Anonymous in Florida.

Many early recovery-movement pioneers were mentioned earlier in this book. Two such individuals were Dr. Victor Vogel and Houston S., whose idea that the Twelve Steps could work for addicts as they had for those with an alcohol affliction, eventually resulted in the birth of the fellowship known as Narcotics Anonymous. Father Dan Egan worked with the predecessor version of Narcotics Anonymous in the late 1940s in New York. In the 1980s, he connected with the fellowship. Even Mother Teresa, herself a "miracle worker," would eventually tap Father Dan to open a house for addicts in Calcutta. The house in Calcutta would host the first N.A. meeting in that city. Father Dan held spiritual retreats for N.A. members and continued his practice of working with addicts until his passing in 2000.

Some friends of the fellowship took on higher profile roles with N.A. A few dozen participated as non-addict members of the Board of Trustees. They came from various backgrounds as judges, probation officers, clergy, and treatment professionals. Dr. Michael Bohan from Virginia was instrumental in assisting N.A. to access the U.S. Military and remembered as well for his many contributions to public information efforts.

Bob Stone became the parliamentarian for the World Service Conference in the late 1970s. Rosalie pointed out that Bob might be a suitable office manager in 1982. He went on to serve in that position for most of the '80s, overseeing much of the initial growth as well as the many controversies within the fellowship. As a non-addict, he adopted those around him as subordinate mentors and friends.

Irwin, an attorney from Miami, went by the moniker "Stretch." Though a non-addict, he was elected to the WSC Board of Trustees. His wife was a member of the fellowship and Irwin had attended Nar-Anon meetings. He holds the distinction of being the only person elected to the Board of Trustees from Florida.

As far as Florida history is concerned, the first name to rush to the forefront of many was Peter A. of West Palm Beach. Peter was an avid A.A. member who knew about the existence of Narcotics Anonymous. Peter spoke with his good friend Bob B. about doing something for addicts. Peter told him about the fledgling California based fellowship. Because of this prompting from his friend, Bob helped found the Mainline Group in West Palm Beach and, in turn, Narcotics Anonymous was born in Florida. Peter supported the fledgling group even after he was asked not to attend because he was not an N.A. member.

Pastor Connie Sjostrum was the sheriff's office chaplain. He provided space for the first meeting in Broward County at his storefront office in downtown Fort Lauderdale. The pastor ran a small recovery house where many original N.A. members stayed. He charged very little for their lodging and forgave many of their debts. He was a speaker at the 11th World Convention of Narcotics Anonymous in 1981.

Wesley P. likely was the only one of A.A.'s earliest members who read the *Little White Book* cover to cover. In late 1979, he was told that an "N.A. Big Book" was being written in Georgia. Wesley immediately insisted that such a book "must be written by and for addicts." In his role as a beloved A.A. member, he quietly influenced the elders and other A.A. members to support the fledgling N.A. fellowship. This support opened doors to many churches and facilities that were staunchly A.A. oriented. Wesley made it clear that the Traditions had to be respected; he insisted that those attending A.A. meeting should introduce themselves as an alcoholic only. He further stated that addicts should do the same in N.A. (introduce themselves as an "addict only") meetings to respect the Traditions. This occurred in late 1979 when only a handful of N.A. meetings existed. He was a friend to N.A. in a true spirit of humility, though he never attended a single N.A. meeting.

Mel was the beloved caretaker at First Congregational Church in Fort Lauderdale. Reverend William Ring was the man who first allowed N.A. to meet at the facility. He remained a friend of the fellowship. Many times over the years, Reverend Ring enlisted the assistance of Paul E. to

perform twelve-step work with some of the members of his parish. The church was the site of many early N.A. and Nar-Anon meetings and many fundraising events. N.A. members simply called the facility "Mel's Church." He would open and close the doors for every meeting, spending hours of his own time listening to addicts share about their struggles. He protected N.A.'s reputation with the church despite the occasional unruly incident. When he passed away, more than half of those in attendance at his funeral were members of N.A. and Nar-Anon.

Reverend Jim Jones was the Director of Concept House in Miami, a therapeutic-community-style treatment facility for addicts. In 1981, it was his decision to eliminate "drinking privileges" for staff and patients at the facility. He hired members of N.A. to work with patients and used the N.A. program as the basis for his program. Open N.A. meetings were allowed to meet there and patients were taken out to N.A. meetings. All of these were revolutionary actions in the "TC community." Hundreds of N.A. members clean today found recovery at Concept House. Reverend Jones was instrumental in opening the doors of Episcopal churches across the state for N.A. meetings as well as for providing the space for the sixth World Literature Conference in Miami. He was a true friend to Narcotics Anonymous.

Rev. Robert Askren was a substance abuse counselor in addition to being an Episcopal priest. He had heard about Narcotics Anonymous from Reverend Jim Jones, a peer, as he too was an Episcopal priest working in the addiction field. Reverend Askren recognized the need for a place for addicts to meet. He assisted in starting the first Narcotics Anonymous group in Marion County, which met in the famous St. Patrick's Church parish hall in late 1984. He then made sure the treatment facility sent addicts to the meeting.

In 1983, the Florida Center for the Deaf and Blind agreed to translate N.A. literature into Braille. This was no small task. The center provided the entire translation free of charge. To assure that it was correct, the school trained an N.A. member (free of charge) to understand this universal language. When the translation was complete, the school provided a master copy to the Florida Regional Service Office. The stories were even included in the *Little White Book* translation.

HOSPITALS & INSTITUTION COMMITTEES

As N.A. grew, so did the number of H&I meetings the fellowship sponsored. In February of 1987, there were 139 registered H&I meetings in the region. This was a 54 percent increase from the recorded 85 meetings in 1985.

Communication throughout the region was at a high due in part to the *H&I Handbook*. This new handbook helped H&I service workers better understand their roles as it included much clearer, more concise directions than the prior handbook.

Most of the areas were regularly attending the regional subcommittee meetings. Initially, there was a form developed that listed treatment facilities and information about them. This information was then forwarded to the individual areas that could service them. Later, the Florida Drug and Alcohol Association Directory was obtained for the same purpose. On file were "Sunshine" or "Goodwill" letters from facilities requesting meetings for their locales.

A few areas conducted H&I-oriented activities. Dade's Fourth Annual H&I Fundraiser incorporated an H&I Awareness Day workshop into their usual banquet and speaker format. Gulf Coast had both Thanksgiving and Christmas dinners at the Copeland Road Prison. Gold Coast held a fundraiser that was well supported by their area. The Regional H&I Committee began strategizing a semi-annual H&I Awareness Day hoping to strengthen and promote unity within the region.

The H&I cans were phased out due to the consensus within the region that separate fund flow structure involved with funding H&I efforts through exclusive H&I revenues was in line with the unity of the fellowship. The area and the regional H&I committees began relying on the budgets presented to and approved by the service body they were accountable to for funding, including literature. The RSO was packaging literature in "H&I Packages" which made it simpler for institutions to order the appropriate literature for their clients.

Great strides were made in the outreach efforts. The Pen Pals Project was started. This project was basically a structured correspondence network where RSC H&I matched members of the fellowship with addicts in institutions who had limited access, if any at all, to Narcotics Anonymous.

In a 1986 report in the WSO *Newsline*, the numbers of H&I meetings were listed by state. The numbers of meetings in Florida were

proportionately higher than in any other state, and the sheer number of meetings exceeded even those held in California. Larry J., the Regional H&I chair, gave his annual report at the 1988 April RSC. He reported a total of 196 institutional meetings. That astonishing statistic reflected the existence of more H&I meetings than regularly scheduled N.A. meetings in half the existing regions.

A decision by the Florida Department of Health & Rehabilitative Services mandated a requirement to hold N.A. meetings in the facilities they funded in order for these facilities to maintain their continued funding levels. This led to an immediate growth spurt in Hospital & Institution meetings statewide. In 1985, Jay R., the Florida H&I chairperson, met with the Director of the Florida Bureau of Prisons. He recognized that the vast majority of prisoners were there on drug-related charges. This meeting literally opened the doors of prisons, county jails and road camps throughout the state.

In 1988, the number of H&I meetings in Dade County alone exceeded the number of regular meetings in every existing area in Florida. The loss of the H&I cans required areas to fund these services in a different way. Some held annual large events to raise funds; others held smaller monthly or bi-monthly fundraisers for their area. All or a portion of the funds were contributed to their H&I committees.

In the late 1980s, the Florida RSO sent a letter and literature order form to hundreds of for-profit, private treatment facilities statewide. The intent was to shift the expense related to literature purchases. Even with fundraising activities, the funding from H&I cans severely affected available funds for literature. Many of the for-profit facilities began purchasing literature directly. Even some government-funded facilities were given small budgets to purchase N.A. literature. This allowed funds to be given to facilities without available funds for their inmates or clients.

Louie C. once asked members in a large meeting, "How many of you found N.A. through an institution?" The vast majority of hands were raised. This is a clear signal regarding the importance of H&I service work. Jimmy K. once said, "The newcomer is the lifeblood of this program."

WORLD SERVICE CONFERENCE – 1986

Jay R. of Miami and Biff K. of Orlando represented Florida at the 1986 World Service Conference. The following is a synopsis of their report:

"We have between 350-400 meetings plus another 115 H&I meetings, or about 465-515. The fellowship has now has between 4,500-5,000 members."

By then, there were 15 areas in Florida as several had split during the previous year. Some of these separations were handled with the love and support of the fellowship, while others were laced with animosity. Even though principles were not always initially placed before personalities, traditions were eventually respected once again and all ended well.

The RSC divided the region into three zones: Northern, Central, and Southern Florida. This enabled bi-monthly weekends to be rotated equally throughout the state. The implementation of this plan seemed like a practical solution to rotating the weekends.

Biff spoke about several issues the areas had in common. The most common involved clubhouses that had more than one twelve-step fellowship meeting in their facility. In such instances, the resulting appearance is that N.A. is affiliated or is endorsing the other fellowships and, in turn, the facility itself. This problem continued to occur in several areas throughout Florida early in the new millennium.

Biff continued his report, which focused on the on-going subcommittee work going on in Florida. Policy committees were functional in most areas. PI committees were holding learning days in various areas across the state and the region had a contingency fund to assist developing areas with PI work. The Literature committee finished their work on revising the pamphlet, *The Group*, and passed it on to the WLC.

Then Biff gave a lengthy report on H&I activities, focusing on how areas financed their work. Biff reported that the monies from the H&I cans along with area fundraisers went a long way to fully fund the needs of such functions. Regardless of the amount of money collected, it never seemed to be enough, as institutions soaked up literature the moment it was made available.

His report on the upcoming convention mentioned that they were going to implement a standing convention committee for the next event, as inexperienced members in each host area simply could not manage the practices in the past. A prudent reserve of $4,000 was recommended in order to avoid causing financial stress and to reduce the dependence on fundraisers that divert funds away from necessary local services.

He concluded with a brief report of the Regional Service Office activities. They had purchased over $100,000 worth of literature in the past year, although some areas chose to order literature directly from the WSO as the RSO had a few obstacles.

Dan S., the representative from Germany, gave his report in broken English. He stated that the WSO and the U.S. fellowship were working too slowly at translating the literature into other languages. He thought that Americans spent too much time and energy fighting with each other and left addicts in other countries to die in the streets. His point was clear and helped to focus the participants on their primary purpose.

Bob Stone reported the WSO received over 2,000 new group registrations in the previous year, bringing the total to over 6,000. The first World Directory was printed a decade earlier listing only 200 meetings.

Much discussion was held about the unwieldy system used to collect funds for Hospitals & Institutions work. When the H&I can is passed in meetings, it diverts funds away from other services.

MIRACLES CLUB – A TALE OF COOPERATION

Clubrooms have paved the way for Narcotics Anonymous to hold any number of meetings at its own discretion. Having a local facility of its own dedicated to providing space for N.A. only is in line with Jimmy's proclamation that "we must stand separate and apart from any other Twelve Step fellowship."

The Back Room Club began in 1977 in Miami. It was a first in Florida and one of the only places an addict could openly find help without government intrusion. The House of the Rising Sun Clubhouse in Marietta, Georgia, served as the virtual capital of Narcotics Anonymous in the southeastern U.S. during the late 1970s and early '80s.

The 4141 Club was not actually a clubroom. It was a room rented to an N.A. group. Broward Community College (BCC) held the lease on the room; however, BCC only used it three days per week for a three-hour class. With a key to the room in hand, meetings were eventually scheduled every night of the week and during the day on weekends. This went on for approximately a year. During this period, the Gold Coast Area (ASC) was formed in this room and the sixth World Literature Conference spent their last two days here completing the last chapter in the *Basic Text*.

Over the years, many recalled the names of clubrooms across the state, beginning at the Old Anchor's Aweigh Club in Key West. The most

prominent names that came to mind included: The Cornerstone Club, South End Club, The Warehouse, Honey's Place, Serenity Place, Times Square Club, Our Place, and others too numerous to mention.

In order to capture the meaning of a clubroom or clubhouse to the Florida fellowship, one clubroom was chosen and the early facility pioneers would tell their own stories filled with miracles. So appropriately, we chose the Miracles Club of West Palm Beach, circa 1985. Here is their story:

The thought of opening a clubhouse for addicts in the West Palm Beach Area came about because of a dream in one addict's mind – Denny M. There were already four clubhouses in the West Palm Beach area, but they catered to A.A. members. They were not too open about the addicts that would show up and talk about their addiction. Many of the A.A. members that were members of these clubhouses did not understand addicts. They would not allow any N.A. meetings in their clubhouses.

One of the early discussions about an N.A. clubhouse, as it was referred to, was at the "Serenity by the Sea Convention," in November 1984. Denny brought up the idea of looking into opening a clubhouse in West Palm Beach for addicts. One of the first things done was to put together a board of directors. "We felt in order to be successful we would need the backing and support of the local commissioners and business community." The following people became the first board of directors and corporate officers for the yet unnamed clubhouse: Denny M., Erik P., Gary T., and Burt S., Bob. B., Mike L., and Judge Rodgers.

Upon the election of the board, it was decided that there was a need to raise funds to get a building. The vast knowledge and experience of the board members made it possible to secure some non-profit grant monies. The club received some large donations from anonymous Palm Beach donors, and others. Additional fundraisers were held to continue raising the monies needed to find a building, rent it, and open up.

The board and others who were "friends of the board" worked hard on developing the articles of incorporation and bylaws, so we could file with the state as a non-profit organization. These also allowed donations to be used as a tax deduction.

The first fundraiser prior to having a building was held at the Saint Francis of Assisi Church in Rivera Beach. There was a potluck dinner, a dance and a speaker meeting, a great turnout and a great time had by all. Four thousand dollars was raised from this event. One of the big money-making events was paying to put pies in people's faces. Denny M. and Gary T. both took pies in the face that night.

Denny, an addict named Bob F., Chris C., and Jayson T. all searched for months for an available place that would meet their needs and their pocketbook. They looked up and down Dixie Highway in West Palm Beach. They wanted to be accessible to "the addict who still suffers." They knew a lot of street addicts were hanging out on Dixie Highway. They looked at an old Winn Dixie Grocery, an empty furniture store, and other empty buildings from 50th Street, south on Broadway, and then down Dixie Highway to Southern Boulevard. They had the support of a couple of board members from the local A.A. club; they would be grateful to see the addicts find their own place, and not come around the local A.A. clubhouse.

The Miracles Club was an empty, dilapidated building, formerly the Plasma Corporation of Palm Beach. The building was full of old custom-made eight-foot tables that had been used as blood drawing stations for the many alcoholics and addicts that would come in and donate plasma to get enough money for a bottle or a fix. A local A.A. real estate developer, Harry H., was active at the A.A. clubhouse and was close to Bob B., a director on the board. Harry helped the addicts of N.A. to acquire this location.

The building had a lot of potential, with both a large downstairs area, room for a coffee shop, and a large upstairs. One look at the insides and "we knew that it would need a lot of work," said Jayson T. The building had rats, mice, roaches, and leftover needles and blood drawing equipment all over the place from its previous tenant.

It was this very history that got the club its name. Denny M. used to be one of those addicts who would go to this building to sell his blood for a fix or a bottle. He had been desperate, with no hope. Then in December 1985, he was signing a lease for a building to help others who were as hopeless and desperate as he had been.

The environment was dirty and uncomfortable. It needed a lot of work and cleaning up. Bob B., who was executive director of a local addiction treatment program, brought clients from the program to help with the cleanup. They watched out for each other, talked recovery, and had meetings during the day and on weekends as they worked on the renovations. They donated their own time and money to fix up this place and call it their own haven of recovery. Addicts learned to work together toward a common goal. It was amazing what was going on in there. The club got a whole lot of support from expert carpenters, painters, tile setters, plumbers, and electricians who were members of the fellowship. They worked with the same zeal as members who had worked on literature or on conventions.

The Miracles Club was incorporated on December 4, 1985; its doors opened shortly thereafter. As a result of the availability of a space like

the Miracles Club, N.A. in the Palm Coast Area just exploded. The social gatherings and the fellowship were enjoyed and appreciated by all involved, and the fellowship continued to grow and grow. For the first time, a noon meeting was held seven days a week, along with numerous other new meetings. A few of the other established N.A. groups like Mainline moved into the clubhouse. The dances and functions on Friday and Saturday nights were well attended and a boon to the local fellowship.

The club thrived for several years and became the hub for local addicts. Gary L. became the club manager and ran the coffee shop. If you were new and coming into N.A. in Palm Beach County, you found the Miracles Club. N.A. members would donate to keep the club open. The club would have fundraisers to support it, most often dances with DJs or the occasional live band. The Palm Coast Area Service Activities committee would rent the space for area functions. It was not long before addicts came from all over the state to attend activities at the Miracles Club. As the N.A. fellowship grew, so did the activities that would attract recovering addicts. There were sock hops, costume parties, period theme parties, Halloween parties, Christmas marathon meetings and dinners, and New Year's Eve parties.

Over time, the club endured many setbacks as well. Addicts would break in and steal whatever they could find – food, candy, cookies, cigarettes, money. Then came the big expenses. One day the air-conditioning compressor and copper tubing from outside the building was stolen. It cost about $1,000 to replace the unit and place a locked steel cage around the unit. Within six months, the new replacement unit was stolen. The building had been up for sale and was sold. This marked the end of an era, and the beginning of looking for a new location. The Miracles Club was reborn several times.

WHO WANTS OUR LITERATURE?

In the mid-1980s, there was a lot of enthusiasm and energy devoted to "mainstreaming" N.A. Many felt that N.A.'s focus on addiction and recovery would springboard the fellowship to a preeminent place in the public eye that so far no one had shared with Alcoholics Anonymous. H&I and Public Information (P.I.) outlets, once reluctant to work with the fellowship, were starting to accept N.A. as a viable resource. The fellowship was starting to be sought out by the professionals who had shunned N.A. in the recent past. The World P.I. Committee had produced professional TV spots that many believed were going to lead to an avalanche of newcomers

to the fellowship. It was requested that the WSO pursue conventional book distribution for the *Basic Text* to make it available at bookstores nationwide.

It was in the context of these times that Bob Stone reported to the 1986 Conference that the Hazelden Foundation wanted to carry Narcotics Anonymous literature. There was a qualification to their offer, however, Hazelden wanted the book at a cost that would significantly undercut any other retailer's prices. On closer inspection of the fine print, Hazelden's offer contained a thinly veiled threat: The company was prepared to produce their own book about N.A., and the writer they'd previously employed to write *What is N.A.?* was available to produce this new book as well.

Hazelden had the year before produced a pamphlet called *What is N.A.?* which many members found to be an undesirable introduction or interpretation of N.A. One primary objective was the listing of A.A.'s Steps followed by a disclaimer that N.A. has the same steps but changes "alcohol" to "drugs" in Step One. The philosophical shift from the substance alcohol to the root of the disease, addiction, was a key element in N.A.'s identity being discussed and shared about throughout the fellowship. The identity of this fledgling fellowship was very much a part of this seemingly trivial semantic differentiation. Many viewed this Hazelden product as a divisive publication meant to trivialize Narcotics Anonymous at a time when N.A. was at last beginning to establish its independent identity.

At that conference, no one was particularly happy with the resolution, but the understanding was Hazelden would get their discount but they were not allowed to undercut the WSO sales price. The *Basic Text* was to include an index of other items and information on how to order literature directly from N.A. It was not the best deal in town, but N.A. would now be a featured item in the largest recovery and treatment catalog in the world (reported at the time to be a distribution of 1 million per printing). The hope was the exposure would help N.A. in its relationships with the recovery industry.

THE LIE IS DEAD – WE DO RECOVER

The state convention was held July 3-6, 1986, in Orlando for the first time. The committee suffered through a calamity of errors. The "fun" began as soon as the host committee decided upon a host hotel in early November 1985. When the administrative committee, headed by RSC chairperson Charles K., refused to allow the FRCNA-5 host committee to

distribute the flyers they had already produced, the entire convention committee except the vice-chairperson, Richard N., resigned at the Serenity in the Sun Convention held in November, 1985.

In those days, the FRCNA flyers were officially released and circulation began at Serenity in the Sun. The reason the administrative committee refused to allow the flyers to be released was that they were in fact an explicit endorsement of the Crowne Plaza Hotel. There was a full-page advertisement for the hotel including artist renderings used as the centerpiece for the flyer. Another major concern was construction was running behind schedule and might not be completed in time for the event.

FRCNA was to become the very first major event held at this hotel. Construction workers and hotel staff were in the process of completing the final touches to the facility as attendees arrived. The staff were new and they were unaware of the ways of the N.A. fellowship. "They didn't know what to make of the whole thing: the hugging, people draped over lobby furnishings and an array of Harley Davidsons parked at the front door." said Matt V.

The hotel was connected to the Florida Mall. The mall had just held their grand opening prior to the event and was flooded with N.A. conventioneers. The line at a gourmet coffee shop was long and continuous. The manager told a committee member that he made his first eight months' expenses from that single weekend: "He was a happy camper – ecstatic." By the end of the weekend, the storefront windows throughout the mall had signs in their windows proclaiming: "Thank You N.A. Please hurry back!" Most of the merchants had no idea what the letters N.A. meant. They simply noticed on everyone's t-shirts and name badges.

Dutch H. from New Jersey was the main speaker as 650 of the 1,180 registered for the convention were seated for the banquet. The convention quickly outgrew the hotel, and it became clear that management of the event was outgrowing local committees.

Many in the crowd listened to a preliminary version of the "Clarity Statement" as it was read for the first time in Florida. The statement was essentially a draft version of the final product commonly read at conventions. It became a source of controversy at meetings and conventions for years to come.

The convention again served to unite a rapidly growing Florida fellowship and participation from outside Florida continued to increase.

LIVE FROM LONDON

From 1971 to 1977, the first seven world conventions were held in California. There was plenty of concern about the convention leaving California and going east of the Rockies to Houston, Texas. At the 15th WCNA in Washington, D.C., the London fellowship was awarded the bid for the next convention and similar concerns immediately arose. It was the first time the event left the states.

Suzie G. from North Miami became a casualty of London's contrary traffic patterns. Americans drive on the right, Europeans on the left! She looked the wrong way when crossing the street, walked into traffic, and was struck; she suffered a broken hip and a concussion as a result. Suzie was hospitalized for a long while. She is still clean, but no longer attends conventions.

The 16th WCNA took place August 28-September 1, 1986, and was held at the Wembley Conference Centre adjacent to famed Wembley Stadium. The majority of attendees came from the states and greater London. The convention was rumored to have as many as 1,500 attendees, though about 1,000 was a more accurate count. Scheduled not long after the U.S. Air Force used French airspace to bomb Libya, there were some security concerns regarding Americans, which held down attendance. Princess Diana quietly viewed the meeting from the Royal Skybox in the auditorium.

"Everyone from Europe was into learning as much as they could from the Yanks, and were extremely outgoing and available and hospitable to us all." Another one of Biff's memories was that many of the Americans attended local meetings that featured "tea breaks." Both the London and British fellowship's growth exploded after the convention, as the fellowship also began to flourish across Europe.

Obviously, this event hosted members from more countries than ever before. Members arrived from across Great Britain, Ireland, France, Germany, Italy and other free European countries. A few came from the Middle East including Israel. The Aussies were present along with others from Japan and India, as well as a handful of people from South America. It was estimated that nearly 500 people traveled from the states. Naturally, Florida was well represented with several dozen in attendance.

At an "International Meeting" held on the first day, the two speakers bridged a gap that religious leaders, diplomats, politicians and

others had heretofore been unable to accomplish. Attendees watched in awe as a member from Bahrain, a small island country in the Persian Gulf, and a member from Israel hugged each other. Ahmed spoke of how God worked in his life, as he was able to avoid the devastating legal penalties handed out for drug use where he lived in the Middle East. Many of his friends had been sentenced to having their hands cut off as punishment for this crime. The woman from Israel told of holding N.A. meetings in bomb shelters; on one occasion, air raid sirens blared as the meeting continued unfazed.

Some of the Americans stayed on and traveled to meetings throughout Europe. Sadly, a few relapsed on excursions to Amsterdam. Patti H. from Fort Lauderdale attended a meeting in Dublin while visiting family in Ireland. It was eye-opening to see 40 addicts in a noon meeting so far away from home. Others remembered "terrorizing" Paris before and after the convention. "Everywhere we went, you would see addicts from the states," commented Biff K.

The 8th WCNA broke new barriers when it was held outside California. The 16th WCNA became Europe's Houston event, breaking new geographical barriers and spawning a whole new era of growth. N.A. was truly becoming a worldwide fellowship.

THE LONDON ALTERNATIVE

Typically in the early '80s, area or regional conventions were not scheduled before or immediately after the World Convention on its customary Labor Day weekend. The size and scope of the event would surely be affected by the distance between Florida and London.

Meanwhile, back in Naples, the local fellowship decided to take advantage of an opportunity by holding an alternative convention. They targeted the hundreds that normally attended the World Convention who could not attend the faraway celebration.

They held a convention called The London Alternative. It was held September 19-21, 1986, a few short weeks after the event in England. The opening meeting was a beach ball meeting, which involved throwing a beach ball into the audience; whoever caught the ball would come to the podium to share.

Ed W. recalled the inadvertent speaker selection worked out anyway. Several members of the planning committee heard a tape of a New Yorker named Frank, and Ed had met him once previously, but they had no way of contacting him. One evening, Ed ran into a friend who knew Frank

and provided his phone number. When they called to ask if Frank would speak, he mentioned his girlfriend, Fran, was a good speaker as well. As a result, Fran was also invited to speak. Ed decided to pick them up at the airport since he had met the tall, imposing man before. Ed was shocked when "this short, stocky guy walked up and introduced himself as Frank." Oops! They had inadvertently asked the wrong Frank, though it turned out fine. In fact, several years later, Fran was chosen as the main speaker for the 19th World Convention in Orlando.

Saturday featured Frank and Fran from New York, with Mr. Bill from Gainesville slotted for Sunday morning. The weather for the weekend was fabulous, and while there was pretty good attendance for the main meetings, most of the workshops were practically empty. Stuart S. remembered, "If you were looking for a recovering addict that weekend, the best place to start was the beach or the pool."

The Gulf Coast fellowship made a small profit that was immediately spent on establishing helplines for the Naples and Fort Myers fellowships.

THE FLORIDA PANHANDLE

In 1987, the Greater Gulf Coast Area consisted of groups from the Florida Panhandle and the southern tip of Alabama, from the Alabama-Mississippi border on the west to the Central/Eastern Time Zone in the east, and extending from the shores of the Gulf of Mexico to the Alabama border. The area encompassed a total land mass of over 10,000 square miles. At one point, the Big Bend Area left the Florida Region for the Northwest Florida/Alabama Region, further expanding this area by a few thousand more square miles. This occurred in late 1985, though they returned to the Florida Region by 1987.

In early 1988, Richard N. chaired an ad hoc committee to decide if this vast area would be better served by dividing into several small area committees. A few months later, the groups decided to form four areas out of the Greater Gulf Coast. Pensacola had the strongest fellowship and thus kept the name the Greater Gulf Coast Area. Groups in and around Mobile, Alabama, formed their own area. Fort Walton Beach, a small beachside city just east of Pensacola, formed the Emerald Coast Area, and the Panama City fellowship formed the fourth area. The groups in eastern Alabama and

Fort Walton Beach struggled and later folded their area committees, rejoining the newly renamed Greater Pensacola Area.

WORLD SERVICE CONFERENCE – 1987

Biff K. reported the existence of 16 area service committees in Florida. The Region is divided into four geographical zones to better facilitate rotation of the RSC weekend. Nonetheless, there is increased feeling that perhaps the Region is too spread out geographically. It is anticipated that at some time in the future, it may become necessary to divide the region to better serve the areas. In 1987, Florida hosted 480 regularly scheduled meetings and carried 151 H&I meetings, yielding a total of 631 meetings overall. The Florida Region celebrates unity through their convention. The Florida RSO purchased $120,000 worth of literature with another $40,000 order on its way. The Florida RSC donated nearly $10,000 to the World Service Conference this past year.

The active sub-committees included Policy, H&I, Public Information, Literature and a new committee, Helpline.

By the end of 1986, the H&I cans have been completely removed from use in the Florida Region. Each area decided individually, and collectively as a Region, that the separate fund flow structure involved with funding H&I efforts through exclusive H&I revenues was not responsible or in line with the unity of the fellowship.

The Area and Regional H&I committees now rely on budgets presented to and approved by the service committee it is accountable to fund all aspects of H&I work, including the task of providing literature. Before the removal of the cans, the Regional H&I committee subsidized the area literature needs at an average of $300 bimonthly since the cans were not effective in those areas. "Since we have begun to work with budgets, the Regional H&I literature assistance has been reduced to $70 bimonthly." The funds once placed in the cans for H&I find their way into the baskets to benefit all of our fellowship's service efforts.

After all the problems encountered with previous conventions, new guidelines were adopted for the Florida Convention in the hope of alleviating some of the difficulties and bring more consistency to the committee. These guidelines were adopted from a region that is one-third the geographical size of Florida. One problem became evident, the result of which a decision was made to revise the guidelines to better suit the Florida landscape.

THE JOURNEY BEGINS

The Diplomat Hotel on Hollywood Beach was selected as the site for FRCNA-6 initially. The hotel and adjoining country club was a one-time luxury resort hosting the likes of Frank Sinatra, Sammy Davis Jr. and other celebrities who used it as their South Florida getaway retreat. By 1987, the hotel had begun to show signs of severe deterioration, but management there offered guaranteed seaside hotel rooms at a fair rate along with substantial meeting space that would suit the convention's needs.

The conventions usually came off without a major hitch, but this was not the case with FRCNA-6. Three months prior to the convention, the planning committee hit a bump in the road. A few key committee members were given a tour of the hotel rooms and meeting space the manager had arranged for the convention. They gasped as most of the hotel and meeting rooms were moved across the street, unbeknownst to the committee. They went from the more luxurious main hotel to a large rundown motel owned by the Diplomat. The motel portion had been closed for several months due to health and safety code violations. The manager had landed another more lucrative convention for the same weekend. Consequently, he shifted the planned event across the street since the convention rates were substantially lower. The manager referred the committee to the fine print on the original contract.

The person who signed the original contract turned it over to others on the committee. To their astonishment, they discovered that the hotel had every right to make these changes. The committee members were therefore responsible for the debacle. Emergency meetings were held and the solution was clear – find another location quickly.

Two brand-new hotels had opened nearby. The Hilton was built at the end of Fort Lauderdale's south runway without permission from the FAA. They were in litigation with the county, which was considering having it torn down. As a result, the brand new hotel had very little business.

Representatives met with the Airport Hilton and Sheraton Hotels, which were located across Griffin Road from each other. They proposed moving the convention to those sites along with the 600-plus room nights already reserved if management was willing to meet their demands. The hotels would match the rate offered by the Diplomat and provide total run of the facilities, free meeting space, unlimited parking, and transportation

between the hotels, beaches and airports, as well as 1,000 gallons of free coffee. They must have been starving for the business as they accepted the offer. The room block exceeded their capacity, thus two additional hotels provided overflow rooms at rates lower than the convention rate. It was the first true multi-site convention and was the first one to offer transportation between the sites.

Scott R. was the arts and graphics chairperson for the convention. He was a professional graphic artist, and the quality of the work attracted many to the convention. The flyer, program, and merchandise became collectors' items that are still sought after today. Scott became the resident graphic designer for the next FRCNA and WCNA-19.

There were 2,702 registered attendees; 1,823 of those paid the registration fee and another $1,000 was collected in donations for newcomers. This windfall allowed over 900 newcomers and patients from institutions to attend free of charge. The hotel notified the committee that all those attending the convention would have to wear badges in order to meet their liability insurance requirements. After the convention was concluded, the committee discovered they made a $40,000 profit, which they turned over to the region. The region in turn donated $28,000 to the World Service Conference. It was the single largest regional donation made prior to 1988, according to WSC records.

Most of those who wrote down their memories about FRCNA-6 noted several inconsequential events, such as how hard it was to find parking, the cloud of smoke in a lobby designed for far fewer people, the late nights in the jacuzzi, and meeting rooms that were designed for 50 people filled with over a hundred. In the end, the hotel appreciated the business, as they contacted old committee members for years to come about returning.

The calamity that caused the frantic move of FRCNA-6 just 90 days prior to the convention had repercussions. The region created an ad hoc committee whose purpose was to form a corporation in order to protect the convention and individuals on the committee as well as the integrity of the convention itself.

PRAYERS IN N.A. MEETINGS

Many members had become increasingly uncomfortable with the use of the Lord's Prayer as the standard closing prayer in Narcotics Anonymous. It was the early- to mid-'80s when this issue came to a head in

Florida with passionate arguments on both sides of the issue. In Fort Lauderdale, sometime near the end of 1980, the California Group became the first N.A. group in Florida to cease using the Lord's Prayer in their meeting format. They substituted the Serenity Prayer in its place.

Discussions have been held within the fellowship regarding gender specificity, the use of the words "God" vs. "Higher Power," and the universality of the "N.A. Language." The fellowship took up and considered these issues over several conference years.

The first time the issue of gender specificity was discussed was at the World Service Conference (WSC) in 1987. In 1984, a member from Miami wrote a letter to the Board of Trustees (BOT) describing his objection to the use of the "Lord's Prayer" in N.A. meetings due to their Jewish heritage. The BOT response was that "Each group is autonomous."

Beginning in 1989, the WSC Literature Committee adopted a posture of eliminating gender-specific language and attending to and balancing the use of "God" and "Higher Power" in new literature development as well as in revisions to conference-approved literature.

One set of *"Baby Blues"* was even produced that changed the gender references for God from "He" to "She," which generated some controversial responses. At the 1991 WSC, the Upper Midwest Region made the following motion: "All subsequent literature that is to be revised and produced [is] to have non-gender-specific language and that all references to God are changed to 'Higher Power' or 'Power greater than ourselves.'" The World Service Board took no further action as it would have radically altered the classic Steps and Traditions. There was a "cry for sanity" in Florida. One addict recalled, "Several old-timers, especially those still involved in A.A., maintained that N.A. is taking God out of the program."

In 1992, the World Service Board issued Bulletin No. 19 in response to this motion. A motion committed by the WSC regarding replacing the word "God" with "Higher Power" or "Power greater than ourselves," it stated in part: "These substitutions would not resolve our dilemma since they still would not meet the needs of many members, particularly those who believe that the 'Power greater than ourselves' in the Second Step is not equivalent to the God as we understood Him in the Third Step."

At the 1993 WSC, a working group was assigned to consider a motion brought by the Australia Region. The working group's

recommendation was for the Fellowship to consider the following: Does the language of the Steps and Traditions truly reflect the principles of the program and, if not, what language does the fellowship feel would better reflect those principles?

The Oxford Group was a Christian-based program and predecessor to Alcoholics Anonymous. Both Bill W. and Dr. Bob were both influenced by their teachings. When the Twelve Steps were initially written, they did not contain the words "Higher Power" or "God as we understand him." Dr. Bob believed that the use of "God" alone should be toned down in order that "We separate ourselves from the Oxfords and keep the doors open to alcoholics from various religious backgrounds and even the atheists and agnostics." It was Bob, along with several others, who urged that those all-inclusive words be added to the final version of the A.A. steps.

The Serenity Prayer authorship is less clear. What is undisputed is the claim of authorship by the theologian Dr. Rheingold Niebuhr, who recounted to interviewers on several occasions that he had written the prayer as a "tag line" to a sermon. Dr. Niebuhr was quite accurate in suggesting that the prayer may have been "spooking around" for centuries. "No one can tell for sure who first wrote the Serenity Prayer," writes Bill in *A.A. Comes of Age*. "Some say it came from the early Greeks; others think it was from the pen of an anonymous English poet; still others claim it was written by an American Naval officer." Other attributions have gone as far afield as ancient Sanskrit texts, Aristotle, St. Augustine, St. Thomas Aquinas, and Spinoza.

For over half a century, the Serenity Prayer gained popularity in N.A., while A.A. and other Twelve Step fellowships have adopted it for use in their meetings and as part of individual programs.

The origin of the N.A. Third Step Prayer is far more concise. It came together as a result of the Literature Committee movement that compiled the *Basic Text*. The best way to label authorship of this prayer is that it was written "by addicts, for addicts." Thus, it is rooted in the spiritual principal of anonymity. It is widely accepted that Jimmy K. was the author of the Gratitude Prayer, which he wrote in the 1970's.

Gratitude Prayer

My Gratitude speaks...when I care and when I share with others The N.A. Way.

Excerpt from Little White Book – 1976 Edition

In 1994, the working group developed an issue statement, which read in part: "Recovery… is a spiritual process. Our program encourages us to explore and develop our own individual paths. The issue has been raised by some members that the use of wording such as "Him" and/or "God" may present a barrier to members or the still-suffering addict from experiencing this process."

Following all these discussions, groups across Florida began adopting variations of the Serenity Prayer and the Third Step Prayer in place of the Lord's Prayer. Bill commented, "As the N.A. fellowship matured spiritually, we recognize that change sometimes means not changing anything at all."

Third Step Prayer

Many of us have said,
"Take my will and my life.
Guide me in my recovery.
Show me how to live."

Excerpt from the Basic Text – 5th Edition (p. 25)

LIVE YOUR DREAMS

The 17th World Convention took place September 3-6, 1987, in New Orleans, Louisiana. The French Quarter was an attractive place for attendees to "hang out." Several bars in the Quarter began posting signs promoting virgin drinks once they learned recovering addicts did not drink. This was the first convention run solely under the corporate umbrella of World Convention Corporation and not by a local committee.

The host facility was the Sheraton Hotel on Canal Street. Other events were held just across the street at the Marriott Hotel, and the upscale Meridian served as an overflow hotel, though many opted to stay there instead of at the main facilities. The large events were held at the "old-style" convention center; the Rivergate was used for the main meetings and the banquet.

FRCNA-6 had 2,702 attendees, which was the largest convention until WCNA-17. There were 3,820 registered attendees and several hundred more unregistered attendees. The count at the main meeting was just over 4,000 in the stark main room.

Four of the featured speakers, Leah A., "Brother Rick" G., Dutch H., and Sydney R. had spoken at FRCNA previously. The Florida event in the early years sought out speakers who were not on the "circuit."

Instead, it was their goal to find exciting speakers who might later become circuit speakers.

New Orleans nightlife encourages "wild and spontaneous behavior." A group of Floridians witnessed an unnamed trustee in a local strip joint tossing dollar bills at one performer's feet. He soon found out the voluptuous babe was not a woman, but a male cross-dresser.

The convention made over $40,000, which was needed to pay off some of the debts incurred from the previous year's event in London. The fellowship was growing dramatically as more than 2,000 new meetings registered with the WSO during the previous year. This was never more evident than at WCNA-17, as it was the first convention with attendees from all 50 states and nearly two dozen countries.

WORLD SERVICE CONFERENCE – 1988

Jay V. from St. Petersburg was the representative from Florida. He gave the following report: "We now have 18 area service committees in Florida. We held our first regional service conference outside the continental United States in June which was hosted by the Bahamas Area in Nassau."

The region had 565 regularly scheduled meetings and 196 H&I meetings. This represented the single largest period of growth in the Florida fellowship. The focus of service was on reaching the addict through Public Information efforts. Radio talk shows, billboards, bus benches, as well as area learning days and community awareness days, were used to reach out to the community. It was mentioned that hospitals and institutions were starting to buy literature from our office, thus alleviating the area committees of supplying it.

The region created a convention board after FRCNA-6 in 1987, whose functions included site selection. It was decided the convention would be rotated from zone to zone each year. The board decided to incorporate in 1988 to deal with all the major convention issues.

The FRSO purchased roughly $160,000 worth of literature and the RSC donated $24,155.98 to the WSC, more than any other region.

The FRSO is the distribution point for literature. There is now a full-time paid employee in the office. The problems with literature being delivered in a timely fashion were alleviated. They distribute literature throughout Florida, Puerto Rico and a number of islands in the Caribbean.

HOW TO GET SIX EDITIONS IN SIX YEARS

The first edition of the *Basic Text* finally reached the fellowship in 1983. By 1989, the fifth edition was being distributed. This section consists of a simplified overview of how six editions occurred in six years.

After two years and a hundred thousand person-hours, the text portion of the *Basic Text* was completed at the sixth World Literature Conference in Miami and Fort Lauderdale in September, 1981. It was proofread and printed in an approval form, which was sent out to the fellowship for review in November of 1981. A seventh conference was held to compile the stories portion of the book. This material was then proofread and printed in an approval form, which was also sent to the fellowship in February, 1982. Therefore, the fellowship was given between three months and six months to review the two booklets group by group and decide to approve them or not as the first edition of *Basic Text*.

The *Basic Text* was approved at the 1982 World Service Conference. A suggestion was made to sell a "special edition" copy for $25 in order the raise the funds needed to print the book. The WSO simply did not have the resources then to print the book without a new source of funding.

The manuscript was then turned over to the World Service Office to produce. Jimmy K. and others began to proofread the material before the printer made the final plates. During this process, Jimmy noticed there were some "errors" that conflicted with our traditions and were essentially unsound. A few trustees, office board members and conference participants got together and made the agreed-upon changes.

The WSO directors chose to use a local printer that eventually filed for bankruptcy after collecting $10,000 in deposits. After several months, the WSO was able to get the Limited Edition and First Edition approved in smaller quantities than originally planned.

The fellowship felt that no matter how valid the changes were, the problem was that they were made without the input of the fellowship as a whole. Jimmy K., Chuck S., Bob R., and Chuck G., along with the WSO directors acted in good faith, though the fellowship believed they erred by making the changes without their approval. At the 1983 World Service Conference, the fellowship voted to print a second edition. They simply restored the text to its original form as approved the previous year. Once the second edition was printed and distributed, it quickly became clear that the

fellowship agreed with the changes that were made earlier without their approval. In 1984 after some minor editing, the third edition was published.

The fellowship finally decided that the *Little White Book* needed to be revised to reflect language that was more acceptable to the fellowship. When the *Basic Text* was constructed, each section of the existing booklet was used as an introduction to the corresponding chapter, only adding to the confusion.

George H. and Leah G. from Miami, along with others, headed a movement to revise the *Little White Book*. Florida had submitted motions to edit specific parts of the booklet as far back as 1982. The booklet stated, "We are deeply grateful to the A.A. fellowship for pointing the way for us to a new way of life." Though this was unquestionable, reading it in meetings right before the reading the Traditions, which clearly stated, "An N.A. group ought never endorse, finance, or lend the N.A. name to any related facility or outside enterprise, lest problems of money, property, or prestige divert us from our primary purpose," created a conflict in spiritual principles. Once the *Little White Book* was edited, the Basic Text was updated with those changes, creating the third edition revised in 1986.

Then the fellowship decided that the *Basic Text* could be improved with some light editing in grammar and punctuation. The World Service Office was given the task of completing this project. The WSO did not have the text in their computer, so it was left to individuals to type it in text format. Nevertheless, no one had reviewed the work of the typists who entered the material onto the computer. In the interim, the WSO hired a professional editor to review the text and make the minor changes. Unbeknownst to the editor, he was working on the flawed manuscript: whole paragraphs had been left out! Once the editor's work was completed, it was published as the fourth edition in 1987. Once it was distributed, there was an uproar in the fellowship. Wholesale changes had been made to the book and the blame was placed squarely on Bob Stone's shoulders.

.After this discovery, the WSO thoroughly reviewed the calamity of errors and made the corrective measures necessary to publish a restored and corrected book. This would become the current fifth edition of the *Basic Text*, published in 1988. In retrospect, each edition was caused by human error and not any intentional malfeasance melodramatically reported in other historical accounts.

ONCE A DREAM, NOW A REALITY

The World Convention finally returned to California after an 11-year absence. Anaheim in Orange County hosted the celebration September 1-4, 1988, near Disneyland. Nearly 9,000 registered for the event and another thousand or so attended without registering. The main event represented both the largest banquet with nearly 4,500 seated for this portion and nearly 10,000 in the audience for the largest meeting ever assembled in one room at that time.

BLOWN AWAY IN THE PANHANDLE

An article in the NA Way magazine featured one of the oddest occurrences in N.A. history. The Alabama/Northwest Florida Region held their first convention in Gulf Shores at an oceanfront hotel. They chose "Footsteps to Freedom" as the theme for this inaugural event. It was scheduled to take place on the second weekend of September 1988. Depending upon one's viewpoint, this event was either a case of poor timing or an expression of unity in the Alabama and the Florida Panhandle.

The announcement was made early Friday morning: "EVACUATE THE HOTEL IMMEDIATELY!" Convention planners were both shocked and dismayed as their plans were immediately altered by a fast approaching Hurricane Florence, which was headed towards the convention site. The hotel manager quickly arranged for an alternative site for "Footsteps to Freedom" two hours inland. It is most apparent that "Footsteps" might be the only convention ever abruptly moved due to an act of God.

A few of those attending the event began preparations for the "eye of the hurricane." They were emergency service workers who were required to stay behind and protect the citizenry, and they were the only ones registered for the event who did not take the two-hour trek to Montgomery, Alabama. Several hundred addicts formed an endless caravan away from the impending storm. The convention continued hours later at the Sheraton Hotel, just across the street from the historic Union Train Station. Some of the best meetings were held in the cars headed north. Inconvenience was accepted as God's will. It was unity in action!

SPECIAL INTEREST or COMMON NEEDS?

The argument has always been made that to place a requirement or criteria other than addiction on the format, description, or name of a group

is inconsistent with the Third Tradition. Those seeing a valid role for these types of meetings use the term "Common Needs," and those opposed to them use the title "Special Interest."

Included in Bulletin No. 18, issued by the BOT, was a report on the topic from the "WSC Ad Hoc Committee on Special Interest Meetings." The committee, formed by a motion at the 1988 WSC, clearly indicated this report was "offered for informational purposes only and does not necessarily reflect the position of the WSB itself." Formed "for the purpose of investigating the issue of special interest meetings in N.A.," the intent of the motion was to help the fellowship come to grips with and perhaps come to a solution to the issue and provide some forum for the input of ideas from the fellowship.

Composed of fourteen members including Jay V., the RSR from Florida, the committee spent most of its initial meeting discussing what the conference wanted them to accomplish. They set the following goal: Provide a definition of "special interest meetings." They decided to investigate precisely what role special interest meetings played in the N.A. fellowship and provide a forum for the fellowship to participate and comment on this issue.

The committee wrote to each RSC chairperson and RSR requesting information concerning special interest meetings in their regions; 24 regions, including Florida, out of 58 responded to this request. There were special interest meetings held in 20 regions. The Florida Region, due its sheer size and diversity, was included on the ad hoc committee. These 20 regions reported they had 184 special interest meetings in total; over 30 of these were located in Florida.

One old-timer noted, "Narcotics Anonymous meetings themselves in the '70s were considered 'special interest meetings' in Florida." There existed only handfuls of addicts in various locales throughout the state who had found hope in A.A. Addicts who found some hope in A.A. and wanted a place to talk about drugs started several "first" meetings in towns and cities across Florida.

The earliest known special purpose meetings existed in Fort Lauderdale in 1980. Printed in the *South Florida Meeting Directory*, two special interest groups were listed: a "young people's" group was listed as being held on Sundays and a women's meeting was held in a member's home.

The World Board of Trustees specifically addressed the topic of special interest groups during their annual meeting on Thursday, May 6, 1982. As a result of a letter the Trustees received regarding a women's meeting, the following discussion took place. These are the excerpts from the minutes of that meeting:

Chuck S. – Stated that he did not see any Tradition violations in a women's meeting as a special purpose meeting.

David C. – Quoted the Third Tradition, stating that "the only requirement for membership is the desire to stop using," and does not see a special purpose meeting in violation of this Tradition.

Sally E. – Stated that a group's primary purpose is "to carry the message to the addict who still suffers." Said that if a meeting bars an addict newcomer from that meeting and tells him, "No, you can't come in. Get out," then it is a break and she has not seen a meeting that has barred a suffering addict yet.

Chuck S. – Called for a decision from the Board on whether or not a special purpose meeting is a break in any of the Traditions, and that the chair would entertain a motion.

James D. – Stated that it was difficult to vote on something verbally given. Stated that he had an obligation and a responsibility as a Trustee to have the information in front of him before he makes a decision.

Chuck S. – Then asked the Board to make a decision on whether or not it was a violation of Traditions to have special purpose/interest meetings, i.e. men's, women's, gay's, etc.

Chuck S. – Stated that people have special needs and special interest groups serve these needs. If an addict shows up at a special interest meeting, they should be directed to an open meeting, not told to "get lost..." If there are no other meetings they should carry, the message to that addict.

Jack B. – Asked what Tradition was suppose to be violated?

David C. – Stated the Third Tradition applied to 'membership' not to 'admission to a meeting'.

Sally E. – Said that it would be a break of the Fifth Tradition if the suffering addicts who shows up at such a meeting and is not a) helped or b) directed to an open meeting.

A motion was made by Mike B. "that it was proper to have special interest groups as long as they don't exclude an addict seeking recovery." Sally E. seconded. After continued discussion, the motion passed.

The first time anyone in Florida began addressing special interest groups was just prior to the 1982 World Service Conference. The Florida Region submitted several motions to the conference regarding changes they

wanted to the *Little White Book*. George H. took the motions to the World Service Conference. One motion that stands out which passed unanimously in Florida was inserting "sex or sexual preference" into the phrase "race, color, creed."

As the fellowship grew, the membership itself became somewhat diversified. N.A. was still relatively small, so when a meeting was set up that seemed in any way exclusive, some automatically considered it exclusive, rather than inclusive. These groups struggled for support.

The New Path Group was founded in April 1984. It was the first N.A. group specifically geared toward gay, lesbian and bisexual members in Florida. It was held at the Lambda South Club off Las Olas Boulevard in Fort Lauderdale. Ironically, all the original group members were straight; John C. commented that "none of us were gay or lesbian!" In 2004, the New Path Group continued to meet five nights a week and had recently celebrated their 20th anniversary. In the late '90s, the New Path Group, Rainbow Group and other groups started a convention called "Rainbow Weekend." The annual convention is supported by the local fellowship. Betty K., Jimmy's widow, was the main speaker at one recent Rainbow Weekend.

During the next several years, these types of groups began as areas diversified or grew in size. Other types of meetings occurred: men's, women's, gay and lesbian, young people, a "couples in recovery" group, and the infamous Pills Group. A few areas even had a policy of excluding special interest meetings from their meeting schedules.

The Pills Group is one of the oldest groups in the North Dade Area. This long-standing meeting began and remained located in Miami Beach. The name of the group speaks to their special interest. The group began at the behest of a treatment provider: Mt. Sinai Hospital is located in Miami Beach and hosts the Pills Group in one of their auditoriums. The original intent addressed the needs of members whose specific choices of drug were pills rather than street drugs.

There were a few short-lived groups for members suffering from AIDS in Miami, Fort Lauderdale, and a few other cities. Initially, uninformed members shunned those suffering from that disease. Together, they formed a few groups.

The WSC Ad hoc Committee concluded that the Twelve Traditions do not prohibit groups from holding special interest meetings, provided the group has no requirement for membership other than the

desire to stop using. Groups exercising their autonomy are best suited to decide whether there is any necessity to have special interest meetings. The only authority present in the group is a loving God expressed in a group's conscience.



Salvation Army – Early meeting place in Ocala, Florida



St. Patrick's Church – Inaugural meeting place in Ocala, Florida



Early Orlando meeting place



Florida School for the Deaf



Early meeting place in Indian River Area



Early meeting place in the Treasure Coast Area



Space Coast Meeting Place on 1330 South Fiske Street-Early '80s

Chapter Nine

A FELLOWSHIP IN CRISIS

BEHIND THE SCENES

When it came to the topic of the "split" of the Florida Region and the formation of the South Florida Region, the Florida RSC minutes revealed that; surprisingly, the Florida RSC minutes made no mention of what was occurring behind the scenes.

"Believe it or not, that was the way it went," according to Lynn B. "There was a lot of talk and rumors about what was going on, but not much hit the floor of the RSC. Most of what went on was behind the scenes."

Actually, there was only one mention in the minutes, a motion that was adopted that established an ad hoc committee that looked into "alternatives."

WORLD SERVICE CONFERENCE – 1989

In April 1989, Alan R. from Delray Beach (Mid Coast Area) reported, "The Florida Region now consists of 20 area service committees serving 774 regularly scheduled meetings. In addition, our H&I committees are carrying 232 meetings into Florida's institutions.

"The Public Information committee has participated in two major events, the Annual Conference of the NAADAC and FADAA. Both of these organizations are comprised of professionals in the substance abuse fields. We purchased a display booth in order to conduct the events in a professional manner. Twenty months ago, we established a Helpline committee, which has allowed for more participation from the areas. The Literature committee continues to hold workshops around the region to review and write recovery material.

"We incorporated our convention and established a board of directors. This is the first year we function as a convention managed by a full board of directors. It is also the first time the convention has been held in North Florida at the Jacksonville Convention Center. We mark another first, as the convention itself will be taping the event instead of going to an outside vendor.

Our regional service office is still going strong with purchases this year that will reach over $160,000 of literature from WSO. Our special worker has been successful in getting the orders out in a timely fashion. The Florida RSC has donated over $16,000 to the World Service Conference."

NEW AREAS EXPLODE

Between 1981 and 1985, eighteen areas came into existence. Between 1988 and 1989, eight new areas joined the Florida Region. When a new area service committee formed, it was typically the result of several groups coming together in a specific geographic area or an existing area dividing into two due to sizeable growth. Each ASC in Florida generally covered a specific geographic area. Prior to 1986, all were centered on a substantial metropolitan area.

The Heartland Area joined the Florida Region shortly after FRCNA-5 in August 1986. Nearly two years went by before another area was formed. The Big Bend Area returned to the Florida Region. They left briefly to join with the Greater Pensacola Area as part of the Alabama/Northwest Florida Region. This time a group from Panama City became part of the Big Bend Area.

The Golden Triangle Area consisted of a handful of meetings in Lake County, named after a charm on one member's neck; when she purchased another charm with the N.A. pyramid on it, they changed their name to the Golden Pyramid Area.

This began the deluge of area formations. The Orchid Island, Recovery Coast, South Broward, River Coast, Conch Republic, and Central Dade Areas joined the Florida Region in succession.

Two new types of areas came into existence. The first was considered proof of the fellowship's growth. It was comprised of groups mostly located in rural or isolated parts of Florida. Between 1988 and the end of 1989, there was a succession of seven new areas across the state.

A handful of groups from Vero Beach in Indian River County decided to form their own area in February. They became the Orchid Island Area in 1988. The existing area was named the Indian River Area, which caused them to change their name back to the Treasure Coast. They supported groups in St. Lucie and Martin counties.

The groups in the northernmost part of Broward County had become part of the Mid Coast Area in 1985. The Gold Coast consisted of over 70 groups holding over 100 meetings a week. The south end of the county decided to form a new area to support the 20 meetings that existed there. The South Broward Area was formed in April 1989.

The Florida Keys consists essentially of a string of islands isolated from the mainland though connected via dozens of bridges. The Keys groups were part

of the South Dade Area and for obvious reasons; they had grown enough to sustain their own area. The Conch Republic ASC was formed in April 1989. They even held an annual convention-like event at that time.

The groups in rural Pasco County did not feel comfortable being part of the Bay and Tampa areas. In early April 1989, the groups in both the east and west sides of the county came together to form a new area they called the Recovery Coast.

Shortly after FRCNA-8 in early August, 1989, the groups in Hernando, Citrus, and Sumter counties, which are rural counties in north central Florida, also decided to form their own ASC (River Coast ASC)... Several large private addiction treatment facilities existed by now in these counties, which were supportive of N.A. The consistent influx of new blood from these facilities into meetings helped to stabilize the existing groups.

Dade County had two areas: South Dade and North Dade. There were 180 meetings between them. The Warehouse, a large clubroom, held 50 meetings at the time. Groups in the central part of the county felt isolated from the predominately affluent and Hispanic groups in the southern part of the county and were dismayed by the concentration of meetings at the North Dade clubroom. Even prejudice was brought up as a justification for the formation of the Central Dade Area in December 1989. Geographically, these groups were located in predominately African-American and Afro-Caribbean neighborhoods.

By the end of 1989, addicts could easily find an N.A. meeting in every large and medium-sized city in Florida. All the areas that existed early in the new millennium were formed by the end of 1989. Any subsequent areas were a result of an existing area dividing into two or three areas due to natural growth inherent as more addicts stayed clean in N.A. For example, the Gulf Coast Area served groups in both Fort Myers and Naples. The Sunset Area was formed shortly after the South Florida Region was formed because of N.A. growing in Naples; thus, it was a natural geographic separation.

GIFTS OF GRATITUDE

FRCNA-8 was the first convention fully administered by the FRC, Inc., Board of Directors. The Board's Site Selection committee negotiated a contract with the Jacksonville Convention & Visitors Bureau that included use of the Prime F. Osborn III Convention Center. When it was built in

1919, Jacksonville Terminal was the railroad gateway to Florida. It was the first time the regional convention was held in a convention center.

The convention center was accessible via a skyway monorail system connecting the Omni and Hilton Hotels. The Jacksonville Landing, a shopping and entertainment complex was located nearby along the river.

There was some apprehension initially among the host committee members about interacting with the convention board. In the end, the event went smoothly. The board had previously purchased a radio communication system for the committee and added more units to accommodate the multi-site coverage. They also purchased taping equipment in order to eliminate the use of outside vendors to keep the profits within the fellowship. The board later formed FRC Sound, an in-house convention taping company to accomplish this aim.

The event took place July 6-9, 1989. Larry J. was the chairperson of the host committee. He performed his task admirably with a host committee consisting of relative newcomers. FRCNA-8 was considered a success since it was the first foray into North Florida by this event. The event was scheduled in relatively close proximity date wise to the WCNA-19 event in Orlando, so even the decreased attendance didn't diminish the success of the event. Even the boat cruise on the St. John's River was sold out. All those in attendance enjoyed the event as it acted as a Florida pep rally for the 19th World Convention.

RURAL NORTH FLORIDA

Very little is known about the original N.A. meeting in Lake City. The Regional Outreach committee located an existing meeting in Lake City that registered with the World Service Office in May of 1983. They met on Tuesday nights at 8:30 p.m. at 707 North Market Street in Lake City.

In August, 1990, the Living Clean group formed at 163 Montrose Street in Lake City located near the crossroads of I-75 and I-10 in northern Florida. Wes and Ann started the group with some other members. The meeting met on Wednesday and Friday nights at 8:00.

The following month, the Just for Today group formed at the Lake City V.A. Medical Center at 7:30 p.m. They registered with the World Service in 1992. Greg M., Wes, and Ann were the founding members of the group.

Meetings have come and gone for over a decade in rural Northern Florida. Most of these meetings survived for short a time, while a few went on for years. During the '90s, N.A. meetings existed in Keystone Heights, Mayo, Jasper, Trenton, Melrose, Williston, and Archer.

BREAKAWAY AREAS

A new phenomenon started in 1988 – breakaway areas. Generally, they were not based on typical geographic boundaries. These areas had liberal or no specific territory. Each claimed it existed to further "a set of principles," though the issues varied from area to area.

The Orchid Island area covered basically Vero Beach north to the Brevard – Indian River County line. It consisted of a handful of groups led by strong personalities. Once those personalities moved away or ceased participating, the areas came to an end a few years afterwards. Those groups either faded away or joined the nearby Treasure Coast Area.

In the mid-'90s, the Tampa Freedom Coast initially consisted of just four groups from the Tampa Funcoast Area. They, too, remained small and folded in less than a year.

In May 1999, the Serenity Coast Area was established in Northern Palm Beach and Southern Martin counties. It consisted of three groups initially, peaking at five. One of the groups was the oldest in Florida: the Mainline Group. The Serenity Coast ceased after just a year.

The only "breakaway area" still existing in the new millennium was formed in October 2000. The No Boundaries Area was later renamed the South Atlantic Area. It consisted of a set of 20 groups in North Dade, Central and South Broward counties. They have no contiguous geographic boundaries.

THE MAGIC IS REAL

FRCNA-7 was held in Orlando in 1987, and was essentially a warm-up or practice run for the 19th World Convention. The WCNA-19 host committee was unique as most of the officers and subcommittee chairpersons were not from Orlando. By convention time, the host committee ranks swelled to hundreds of volunteers from across the state.

WCNA-19 – Host Committee

Chairperson – Jay R. – South Miami
Vice-Chairperson – Charlie M. – West Palm Beach
Secretary – Dianne G. – South Miami

Treasurer – Phil C. – North Miami
Entertainment – Karen S. – Orlando
Program – Patty Mc. – South Miami
Marathon – Miriam A. – North Miami
Convention Information – Patti G. – Fort Lauderdale
Arts & Graphics – Scott R. – Fort Lauderdale
Merchandise – Jorge H. – South Miami
Facility Operations – Lovell H. – Orlando
Decorations & Banquet – Beth G. – Fort Lauderdale
Registration – Barry R. – South Miami

The graphic artwork used for this event was considered extraordinary. The '80s era Florida conventions used vibrant flyers with extravagant artwork and matching merchandise to give their events a competitive edge over other regional and area conventions. The over-the-top graphics were intended to catch the attention of members and hopefully attract attendees as more and more N.A. conventions came into existence. WCNA-19 items are some of the most desired by N.A. memorabilia collectors. Comedy shows, a multitude of dances, luncheons, Sunday brunch and an international coffee shop were some of the events at WCNA-19.

The 1989 event was held over Labor Day weekend as was customary. The headquarters hotel was the Stouffer Sea World Resort, an elegant locale in comparison to past host hotels. It was located just across the parking lot from the aquatic park. Attendance at this event was overwhelming but manageable in Orlando, a city that thrives on large conventions and tourists. There were 7,244 paid registrants with well over 9,000 people in attendance, making it the largest N.A. convention outside of California to date.

Floridians represented over half of those in attendance. The sheer volume of recovering addicts overwhelmed many. Previously, the largest event in Florida was FRCNA-6 in 1987 with just over 2,500 attendees. Jayson T. declared, "No matter where you went, whichever restaurant you ate in, you were sure to see someone with an N.A. t-shirt or a badge from the convention."

The majority of the meetings and events took place at the Orange County Convention Center located a mile away from the Stouffer, Marriott, Hilton and other hotels hosting the participants. This required special accommodations – a mass transit system. Chartered buses ran continuously throughout the weekend. The experiment was not only a first, it was an unequivocal success. The accomplishment enabled WCNA planners to

consider additional cities for future events whose event centers and hotels were scattered over a large area.

The Friday night speaker was Bob R. from Missouri. He attended his first N.A. meeting at the Mainline Group while in treatment in West Palm Beach in 1980. He spoke of his love for wife. She had prompted him to seek help and had supported him in his recovery. He went to the convention only at her insistence though she was gravely ill. While on the stage sharing, Bob's wife passed away. Once he finished, his friends took him aside to inform him of the untimely tragedy.

So many people went across the parking lot to Sea World that the fellowship had taken over the theme park. At one of the dolphin shows, the trainer came out and introduced herself, she said, "Hi everyone! My name is Nancy and I'm the dolphin trainer." The entire audience in unison yelled back, "HI NANCY!" Laughter broke out as a stunned Nancy pondered how 3,000 people were put up to this.

Father Dan Egan attended this event. He had provided assistance and advocated for homeless and downtrodden women in New York in the '50s and '60s. A 1964 book entitled *The Junkie Priest* was essentially a journal of his experiences. One of the women who Father Dan had helped was Fran O., the Friday-night speaker. She attended a few meetings of a New York version of N.A. in the '50s before finding recovery years later in the Narcotics Anonymous we know today.

The host committee was very organized, as they had previous experience working on preceding FRCNA host committees. Bob Stone noted in his book, "The Florida fellowship deserved high marks for putting on a great event."

Unfortunately, this event was the last held in a unified Florida fellowship, as much of South Florida would soon secede from the Florida Region to form another region. The next section describes the most painful era in Florida's history.

WINDS OF CHANGE ARE UPON US

The roots of the division of the Florida Region had been building for some time. Many members recall a variety of motives, reasons, and indicators that would lead to the division. In the end, there were a number of factors and variables that led to the birth of the South Florida/Bahamas Region.

In the mid-'80s, the Dade County ASC proposed the idea of proportional voting at the Florida Region (larger areas having a larger share of the total vote count) a motion which, to their dismay, received little support. Soon afterward, the Dade area split into two separate areas: North Dade and South Dade and the Florida Keys. The growth in the early- and mid-'80s led many to think that multiple regions were the way to serve the Florida fellowship.

In 1986, the Florida RSC Administrative Committee proposed a method of rotation for the Florida RSC weekends. The state had been broken into four geographic zones and the Florida RSC weekend would rotate among them. Unintentionally, the new rotation program precluded South Florida from holding as many RSC weekends as they had been accustomed to hosting over the previous past five years.

Open conflict over WSO and WSC management and service trends were breaking out fellowship-wide. All the elements of this melee were in play in Florida. This philosophical chasm was present at the Florida RSC and especially in South Florida. Members who had felt disengaged were actively involved but found their unpopular viewpoints were not embraced in the Florida Region. The "Us versus Them" mindset was alive and well on all sides of the philosophical divide and many members remember feeling disenfranchised from the Florida Region.

By May 1989, Chris C. from Miami, the chairperson of the Florida Region, wrote a letter that was aptly entitled "Winds of Change." In part, he said "The discussion about 'when to divide' the region has long since replaced the 'if we divide.'" The RSC did set up an ad hoc committee, which came to several possible conclusions including the recommendations to either divide into three or two regions or revise the existing region.

The South Dade ASC sent a questionnaire to RSC's fellowship-wide from their "Ad hoc Subcommittee to Gather Information and Opinion as to the Formation of a New Region." Many felt the enclosed questions pretty much drove the ultimate outcome of splitting the Region, but most of the questions related to distance, rotation of RSC meetings, and travel expenses.

The Tri-County Public Information Task Force was the setting that fostered much of the discussions to start the new Region. Dave T. remembers, "As time went on, more and more people began showing up for these meetings, especially when they found out that they were catered with jumbo shrimp, stone crabs, Hawaiian coffee, and Key lime pie. As more

people showed up, the planning meetings for Florida Spring Service Break (FSSBNA) began including more and more discussions concerning the beginning of the South Florida Region. Eventually, the work of the task force and the planning for FSSBNA became intertwined with the *Baby Blues* movement to create the South Florida Region."

One of the main reasons the Areas in South Florida gave for wanting their own region was the cost and distance of travel to regional meetings every two months. They said they could hold the RSC weekends in one day (typically they were held over a weekend period) and avoid the cost of overnight stays in hotels. (When the South Florida Region was formed, they held a one-day meeting for six months, before returning to the weekend protocol.)

Tom M., the Gold Coast ASR, recalls, "My view and understanding was we would form a new region (not as a split) to bring unity and better serve the South Florida areas. In addition, we were spending so much money on travel... By starting a new region, we would make positions available to more people. I seconded the motion..." In retrospect, many believed those who were influential in the formation of the South Florida RSC were motivated by a desire to simply have their own vote at the World Service Conference. Thus, they would be free to pursue an agenda critical of the management of World Services.

Elections took place in the fall of 1989; Jeff P. was the new chairperson at the time of the split. Most of the discussion of the split including the bickering, accusations, and disagreements occurred off the floor of the region. This was a battle held in the hallways and hotel rooms.

When the new region came to fruition, it came with a whisper rather than a bang. Nothing dramatic was done on the floor of the Florida Region. Several areas announced they were leaving in December, 1989, and the areas that left did so at the February RSC meeting in Tampa.

"There was a tremendous amount of tension in RSC meetings during the last two meetings where the south areas attended," Lynn B. recalled. "I don't think some of the members from the north really believed that the south areas would go out on their own, and others wanted them to go as soon as possible. I remember it was a sad day."

The Gulf Coast report was typical of the tone and message on that last day. It read, "Due to the South Florida and Bahamas Region forming, we have decided it is our best interest to join this new region. This is for financial and geographic purposes and especially for unity in the fellowship.

Therefore, this is an official resignation from the Florida Region! See y'all at functions and conventions. Freda C." Of course, Gulf Coast did not make a completely clean getaway, as they decided to leave a $100 donation to the Florida Region that day.

After the split, the Florida RSC moved their scheduled meetings to the months opposite the South Florida/Bahamas RSC meeting. This way trusted servants could attend the other RSC's meeting, thus keeping the door open for communication. To facilitate communication between the two RSC's, liaisons were appointed to attend the other's RSC meeting. South Florida sent Lou P. as its liaison and Florida sent Andy S. Both positions were eliminated in a matter of months. On the surface it appeared the split would be amicable. In fact, the Florida RSC would introduce the new region at the WSC and make the motion to seat South Florida/Bahamas Region at the April Conference.

The unity and friendliness would be short-lived. The real fireworks began shortly after the split. Much of the rhetoric, accusations and recriminations started flying in the following months and very much represented a piece of the battle over the *Baby Blues* tearing up the entire fellowship.

The terms "Dark Side" and "vocal minority" became synonymous with the rebellious proponents who were against the direction of World Services, supporting the *Baby Blues* and pushing for an alternative service structure like an East Coast service conference." Stuart S. said, "I remember speculating on the value of these members' programs that seemed not to accept the conscience of the fellowship as a whole. We called them 'Dark Siders,' a term (Dark Side of the Force) used in the movie *Star Wars*. It seemed that every stride we made in N.A. they would criticize and pick at it. We did not have the Twelve Concepts that, in part, cautions us now 'to carefully consider all viewpoints in our decisions.' Nevertheless, we had been fighting a philosophical war so hard it would not have mattered. It felt like the fellowship was in two camps and we just quit listening to each other."

Steve R., from Florida was the World Public Information Chairperson at the time. He used the term "Dark Side" in the Public Information report for the November 1990 Fellowship Report. "In reference to observers coming to meetings that do not convey a positive image of N.A....where some members of the Dark Side are pushing 'the illegal text' ('or the only truly real text, depending on your politics!')." This was the

first time this derogatory term showed up in an official fellowship publication.

Members from South Florida, whether they were active with the new RSC or not, felt a great deal of the animosity. Ned B. recalls the period from the perspective of a relative newcomer, "The only thing I remember of the split is we in South Florida felt like lepers, like we didn't belong, and for me it was a sickening feeling."

The South Florida/Bahamas RSC became very closely associated with the illicit *Basic Text* known as the *Baby Blues*. As discussed previously, those involved with the initial printing report the first copies originated in South Florida, and a number of trusted servants in South Florida were involved with them. Dave T. remembers, "Lou's house became the unofficial setting for many South Florida RSC and North Dade ASC committee meetings, including ad hoc meetings on RSC Policy and the Florida Spring Service Break planning committee."

Lou became more and more involved with the Baby Blues movement, (Dave M., Billy A. and several other out-of-state visitors were frequent guests at Lou's) and a few committees continued to meet there. Many people locally and across Florida and the fellowship as a whole began to believe that the South Florida Region/Bahamas was behind the book. This fact was noted in a World Service Conference report, clearly stating, "Several areas were distributing the booklet – North Dade… was at the heart of the debacle." The South Florida/Bahamas Region in order to distance itself from the negative publicity put an abrupt stop to meetings at Lou's.

In any case, members involved with the Florida Region had the perception that the new RSC was closely tied to this volatile issue. The newly elected Florida Chairperson, John H., sent a letter to South Florida/Bahamas RSC stating the Florida RSC's new policy: "…that no one who was involved with the distribution of the *Baby Blues* can serve the Florida RSC." This would apply "to liaisons to the Florida RSC or anyone South Florida/Bahamas appointed to the Florida RSO or Convention Boards." As a point of reference, Lou P. served as South Florida/Bahamas RSC Liaison to the Florida RSC and he served on the Florida Regional Convention Board of Directors.

At the 1990 World Service Conference, which took place a few months after the inception of the South Florida/Bahamas Region, it was clear to the most naive participants that the Florida fellowship was obviously divided. The Florida RSC agreed that their regional service

representative (RSR) would introduce the newly formed South Florida Region and make the motion to seat them as part of the conference. Mutual cooperation at the conference ended at this point. The 1990 WSC minutes noted both Forrest and Jeff, representatives of the South Florida/Bahamas Region, were quite vocal throughout the conference. Motions that required individual tallies further pointed to the divide between the two Florida regions. On more than 30 occasions that roll call votes were taken, the two regions voted opposite of each other. This pattern continued for years to come. Ironically, some intimated that the formation of the South Florida region was motivated in order to grant the area its own vote at the World Service Conference.

In June of 1990, tensions and accusations had risen between Florida and South Florida. The Florida RSC passed a series of motions related to the financial split that, as money in Narcotics Anonymous often does, created disunity and controversy. Florida decided that any financial disbursements to South Florida/Bahamas RSC must be considered item by item and require a two-thirds majority vote to pass. Florida also decided that no funds would be given to South Florida/Bahamas until it was absolutely clear that such money would not be used to print the "bogus texts." Florida then passed a motion to resume fund flow and passed $6,723.36 to WSC. The above was on top of withholding the split in the proceeds for FSSBNA, a total of approximately $1,500. Additionally, it was agreed that the convention pay back the $10,000 to Florida only and that it go straight to WSC as a donation. The $10,000 was loaned to the convention and part of the agreed financial split was for $5,000 to be paid back to each region.

Glen T. remembered that the Florida Region withheld funds from FRCNA from South Florida in retaliation – at least South Florida thought they did – or a desire to not help fund, Florida Region thought, the *Baby Blues*. Holding the funds increased the tension already present between the regions. When this news hit South Florida, the reaction was strong. "I remember it being announced at The Warehouse without explanation – 'Florida is not sending the money!' The whole room went wild!"

Board members active with the Florida RSO believed that attempts were made by the Florida Region to act fairly and consider the South Florida/Bahamas RSC in regards to decisions that pertained to the office; the rift was too big between the regions. It was reported that the efforts seemed condescending, at best, to the South Florida/Bahamas RSC. In November, when the RSO distributed $3,000 to the Florida RSC, some

South Florida members believed that Florida was depleting assets of the Florida RSO and that this represented bad faith in the split of assets. South Florida felt they had no control over the office at all and eventually discontinued appointing directors.

To add insult to injury, a new skirmish erupted in the Florida Region over the site selection process for upcoming FRCNA's. A few board members accepted complimentary rooms and golf at a potential convention site. This became known as "Innis-Gate" (for Innisbrook Golf Resort). This behavior, along with the resulting fallout from the event, led some in South Florida to point at the Florida Region as consumed with "money, property and prestige."

Many others thought the reason for the split was to attain a vote (voting privledges) on the floor of the WSC. The main issue that divided the Florida membership were differences of opinion concerning the WSC & WSO, "which had nothing to do with Florida or the newcomer." Tom M., the Gold Coast ASR, said, "Later on, I found out I had been dope-fiended (lied to) on the real reason we split. The formation of the new region was to have voting power at World Service Conference (WSC). I did not realize the same people pushing for the split were also in the underground of printing the *Baby Blue* or what I call the Bastard Blue (for illegitimate). That information was kept quiet until after the split and it was all about going against Bob Stone and George Hollihan and the WSO. This was all unknown to me until later. I felt used and betrayed."

Jeff G. remembers moving back to Florida during this period. "South Florida was a mess, and very few of the old-timers were willing to help. They were angry about this whole thing. When I approached them, I felt like I had done something wrong by getting involved; I was honestly trying to help. Those Dark Siders hated me once they realized I was from California, my sponsor was a Trustee, and George H. was a friend. They thought I was just another problem."

This was a very difficult time for Florida, but again it must be put in the context that N.A. as a whole was deeply divided, and the prospect of N.A. being split apart was very real. Though the fellowship was able to come back from the brink there were many in N.A. who thought a new Twelve Step fellowship was a possible outcome.

THE BLUES – FLORIDA STYLE

Vigilance is one important key to recovery. If simple tasks are overlooked, the results could become catastrophic. The fourth edition of the *Basic Text* was one such blunder. The fellowship was growing at a rapid pace. The World Service Office staff was consumed with a multitude of other projects.

The fellowship decided in 1987 that the *Basic Text – Third Edition Revised* would be improved with some light editing in grammar and punctuation. The World Service Office was given the task of coordinating this project with a professional editor. They did not have the *Basic Text* saved on their computer – scanners were not available then – so it was left to a few individuals to type it in a text format in order to provide the editor with a proper manuscript.

The calamitous error occurred when no one reviewed the work of the typist who entered the material onto the computer. Entire paragraphs mistakenly were left out of the manuscript; the order of words in sentences were reversed, and words that were acceptable to spell check software ('80s version spell check software was inept by today's standards) were actually typos. The defective material was given to the editor; thus, the final product was doomed to failure. A second error occurred when the resultant material went to the printers without a detailed review or comparison.

Near the beginning of 1988, when the fourth edition was released, the entire fellowship went crazy. Readers of the *Basic Text* were astonished and dismayed by the drastic changes and omissions. When WSO Executive Director, Bob Stone, finally compared the two versions, he stated, "I'm horrified that it occurred on my watch." The fellowship demanded immediate action.

At the 1988 World Service Conference, Bob Stone convincingly stated that a return to the third edition revised was not possible as several contracts had been signed with outside entities and deposits were in hand. He strongly suggested, "We fix the book by inserting the missing lines." A "vocal minority," as Bob referred to them in his book, felt the resulting fifth edition was accepted as a compromise. They believed it "missed the mark." In retrospect, the fifth edition has proven itself the most valued written tool in the recovery of 750,000 members worldwide over a decade later.

Frustration began to build among some, especially concerning the perceived interference in the literature development process by the WSO. The fourth edition debacle became a focal point for those readily dismissed

as troublemakers. The cost of the literature itself was questioned. There was an allegation that the World Service Office was making far too much money from the sales of literature. Another issue was made of the failed attempt to use "professional writers." As it turned out, this claim was accurate, as over $100,000 in fellowship funds was spent on two problematic projects. The first was the fourth edition of the *Basic Text* and the other was the ongoing *It Works: How & Why book.*

In response, a few individual members began to talk about the printing of a bootleg version of the *Basic Text* commonly referred to as the *Baby Blues*. The paperback consisted primarily of the third edition revised without the stories section, although in some cases, further editing occurred. In some versions, chapter six "was altered to reflect the writings in the original approval version of the text." Yet another version produced in California replaced the word "He" with "She" when referencing God.

One may ask, "What does this all have to do with Florida?" One member shared this simple answer: "The fallout from the lack of vigilance started a succession of events that altered the Florida fellowship."

A group of members in South Miami began talking about the bootleg text idea, which was bandied about between many who felt disenfranchised. One of the members was a relative newcomer who worked at a print shop at the time. He was enlisted for the endeavor. "They tore off the back page of the basic text and the stories were then removed too. It was pasted up and used as master copy. This way it could be printed as inexpensively as possible. The third edition revised was used for the master copy because that was the last edition that had actually been circulated throughout the whole fellowship for approval. "The first *Baby Blues* that ever saw the light of day was printed and distributed in Miami, Florida."

The group started printing as many bootleg booklets as they could afford. A few members made donations and others provided additional resources, although participants claimed the funds were limited. Research ultimately revealed conclusive evidence that outside funds were accepted for the printing of the booklets. Some members began giving them away to anyone who wanted one.

The vocal minority were also adamant that monies from literature sales and activities that functioned as fundraisers were undermining donations from the fellowship. This proclamation created a grassroots effort to end a practice that would influence the funds available for service work locally.

Most N.A. members had become accustomed to and accepted the fact that they were supporting fellowship services by paying an entry fee at each of these events; the customary fee was nominal. This was simply accepted as a normal practice since the very first area activity in late 1979 and continued in every subsequent fundraising event and convention over the years.

Unprecedented growth during 1987 enabled each fundraiser held by the Gold Coast Area to consistently raise excess funds for service work. For nearly six months, the area donated at least $1,000 to the Hospital & Institution sub-committee to distribute N.A. literature free of charge to those in government-run facilities. There was a groundswell of opposition to mandated entry fees and, in response, the popular term "suggested donation" was inserted at the very beginning of 1988. For-profit facilities that were accustomed to paying entry fees on behalf of their patients and purchasing their own literature began to cease this practice due to the newly adopted philosophical change. Members locally began dodging the "suggested donation." Many misinterpreted the philosophical change to mean they could attend any event at no charge or by simply "tossing a dollar or two in the basket." As a result, the profits from the events dropped off significantly and so, in turn, did the excess funds. The lack of literature funding in H&I work led to an atmosphere which justified the open distribution of the *Baby Blues*.

One interesting story involves the distribution of the bootlegged booklets within the prison system. Maud B. was working at the Broward County Jail in Fort Lauderdale. At the time, the sheriff's department under Sheriff Nick Navarro in 1988 made a change in the enforcement philosophy. They began arresting everyone, those with a "habit" along with the dealers. During this time, many addicts hit their bottoms. They could no longer say that their using had not cost them anything. Addicts were arrested for simple possession in his reverse sting operations. Some of our members today will tell you that the first words that they heard in recovery were, "You have the right to remain silent."

Sheriff Navarro ordered that the jail administration set up a minimum-security section especially for these non-violent criminals. One of the blocks had 4 large cells that housed 54 men in each cell. The block was turned into "program cells" for addicts. H&I meetings were scheduled every night. Hospital & Institutions growth was in its heyday. They had far more requests for meetings than they could handle. Many of those involved in

H&I work were coming into the jail, and they saw firsthand that there were few *Basic Texts* for the inmates to read.

Glen T. gave Maud B. two cases of the *Baby Blues* to distribute in the cellblock. "There were 280 men in jail cells looking for recovery," said Maud. Each pod was designed for 54 men, though many voluntarily slept on the floors in order to be around recovery.

Maud was in a quandary; she worked at the jail and was the area secretary at the time. The Gold Coast Area decided, "If any one of their officers were handing out the illegal text, they were now required to give up their service position." Maud had to make a decision. She asked herself: "Do I allow the men seeking recovery to have the bootleg booklet or do I keep the booklet out of the cells and go by the area's decision? She thought, "The written word was carrying the message of recovery," and the inmates did not need to know the origin of the paperback booklet. "Any N.A. literature, even though it was from another edition, is better then no literature at all." In the end, she concluded it was her job to assist the inmates and having the booklets might be beneficial. The *Baby Blues* found their way to hundreds of addicts in the Broward County Jail. "I left my service position, and seeing that I had already given out all the *Baby Blues* books, I did not have any more to give out in the jail system."

During interviews for this publication, almost to a person, each interviewee recalled the "averted distribution of the *Baby Blues* at FRCNA-9 in Miami." Lou P. or "Big Lou" was a strong proponent of the recent dissolution of the Florida Region, the controversial Florida Spring Service Break and the *Baby Blues*. He never withheld his disdain for World Services and any individual, area or region that supported their stance. Many believed Lou provided the financial backing for the publication. The facts bear out that he did contribute substantial funds, though he was not the sole benefactor.

Glen T. talked about how naive he was when he first became involved in the *Baby Blues* movement. Soon afterwards, he figured out "what it was really about!" Glen had a choice to either become uninvolved or continue as a participant with the *Baby Blues* gang. He considered how "he was treated with much disdain by those who opposed the *Blues*." He chose to stay involved. Glen announced "my father (a non-member and non-addict)…was a major financial contributor to the movement." He donated nearly $10,000 to fund the mass printing of the bootleg booklets in Florida.

One irony of the movement was that many of their participants' complaints espoused adherence to the Traditions. Here the *Blues* movement accepted money from a non-addict, non-member, and a clear violation of the Seventh Tradition. Another motivator for the movement was the fact that the WSO had accepted monies in advance of the publication from "outside" vendors, primarily Hazelden. In light of the aforementioned admission, the movement was unwittingly living in its own "glass house," another irony.

Lou was a board member on the Florida Regional Convention Board of Directors for FRCNA-9. The board president asked that he "not bring the *Baby Blues* into the convention," and that he serve as "the chair of a special BOD task force to ensure that the Florida Regional Policy prohibiting Baby Blues at their events be enforced." Lou agreed to keep the others at bay, and he kept the commitment. His car was loaded with boxes of the bootleg booklets. The BMW was stolen right out of a restaurant parking lot during the event. The irony was Lou had valet-parked the car. The BMW turned up later; apparently, it was taken for a joyride and then driven into a canal. The bootleg booklets were ruined. Some who opposed Lou's stance thought it was ironic, and yet others believed it was fate or karma, God intervening on behalf of the fellowship. Those who supported Lou made claims that his enemies stole the car and disposed of it in a watery grave. Most were unaware that Dave M. had another vanload of the booklets in the parking lot. Lou's sunken car only added to the furor.

Several of those in attendance at the 20th World Convention in Portland, Oregon, in 1990 recalled, "Bob B. from San Francisco came to the podium and began to scold Lou P. as one of the leaders of the illicit text gang." An elder had unfairly berated Lou. The outburst was truly inappropriate, as Bob would later admit. Lou was not the leader; he was not innocent, nor was he a victim. Those involved with the movement received letters from the WSO and their attorneys forewarning them to cease and desist or they would all face litigation.

According to Joe M., the ODOP Group held a *Basic Text* study group in southwestern Broward County. The meeting format centered on reading the *Basic Text*. "We wanted to make a *Basic Text* available to everyone who attended our meeting, so everyone could read along during the meeting. We decided to print our own fifth edition. We couldn't afford to purchase that many texts." Joe and Sandi S., who was the RSR for South Florida Region, then studied the Fellowship Intellectual Property Trust

document. Together they interpreted the document "as giving any N.A. group the authority to print literature, as long as they didn't alter it or sell it." They also printed, "A full complement of the IP's for barely any cost at all."

For the most part, the bootleg copies were given away in state- and county-run treatment centers, detoxification centers and the like. A few area service committees in South Florida gave them to groups for a short period. A few ardent *Baby Blues* proponents began giving them away individually to "newcomers or to anyone who wanted and needed one." For the most part, the Baby Blues only reached a very small portion of the Florida fellowship. The movement was limited to a few locations throughout the country. In Florida, it was primarily in Southern Florida, although small pockets of members supported the grassroots effort statewide. Several elder members in Daytona comprised the only vocal group in the Florida Region.

The *Baby Blues* was produced in different locales throughout the fellowship. Members in Colorado, California, and England produced a *Resentment Red* version; several versions were produced by a few members in England, including the *London Lime Baby Green*. Over a dozen versions were printed in the states, including the *Georgia Baby Peach, Ohio Purple Edition, Texas Yellow Rose, California Gold*, and others. Some of the more bizarre versions of the bootlegged books included an American Indian version produced for a Native American treatment program, and the *Pink Booklet*, which even changed words that referred to God from "Him" to "Her."

The versions seen most often in Florida had blue, green and off-white covers. The booklets were even distributed at a few North Dade Area Service Committee meetings.

Dave M. was suffering from AIDS at the time and felt he had little to lose by taking his claims of malfeasance fellowship-wide. He was one of the vocal minority who began printing the *Baby Blues*. He never denied this fact, as he would defend his position to anyone who was willing to listen. "Dave was nothing more than a front man for the movement." Individual members, a few areas, and even a few regions bought the books and supported the movement. He was, if nothing else, the self-appointed leader of the movement.

The movement participants were convinced that the proceeds from the sales of the *Basic Text* were being diverted to build a bureaucracy at the WSO. The group perpetuated what later turned out to be inaccurate claims

about the WSO, creating a false impression of an Evil-Empire-like administration at the WSO. On the contrary, Steve R., who spent extensive time around Bob Stone, never once heard him say, Those members are a..... and should be run off. Most often, Bob would sit, eyes cast down and shoulders slightly slumped, head in hand. "What can we do to satisfy these folks? No matter what we say, it seems not to be enough." Nevertheless, Dave was convinced that key members who had compiled the original *Basic Text* and other literature (IP's) were now being consistently pushed aside and were no longer welcomed in the literature process. It was true that much of the early literature workforce (1979-1983) no longer participated in the process; however, the vast majority had focused their energy elsewhere for some time. They did so by choice.

The WSO attorney sent a "cease and desist letter" to those suspected of printing and distributing the illegal publication. The legal representatives were simply attempting to get Dave and the rest of the movement to cease printing and distribution of the booklets. Those advocating on Dave's and the others' behalf were feisty. Instead of simply ceasing at this point, they made the decision to make their point crystal clear by "going all the way." The WSO directors decided they had no alternative but to file a suit against Dave, the self-appointed and designated leader of the movement, in order to bring to an end the ongoing debacle. Dave admitted in a 1990 transcribed meeting that it was his intention from the beginning "to make a federal case out of it." He was intent on arguing his point in a federal court in Philadelphia.

Some have said, "How preposterous it was that the WSO would sue one of its members." During our research, we found that this type of occurrence, unsavory as it is, was commonplace in A.A. history. The elder fellowship's GSO was forced to take similar actions from time to time. A few cases sounded eerily similar to "*The Blues*."

The federal judge was wise. He recognized the impact his decision would have upon the fellowship. Neither party seemed to budge, so he nudged them both. He told the WSO he was ready to find against them unless the two parties could get together and resolve the dispute amicably; therefore, they did. They agreed to hold "a fellowship-wide referendum on the *Basic Text*," where both sides were duty-bound to cease all finger-pointing and name-calling." wrote David H. in a story he posted on the internet. The judge was satisfied; he essentially had scolded both parties,

telling them to refocus their efforts and get back to their primary purpose. This effectively ended the story on January 4, 1991.

Essentially, Dave M. found a loophole in N.A.'s literature copyright. The outcome of the *Baby Blues* movement and the federal court case could have resulted in individuals actually owning the rights to N.A. literature. Fortunately, this did not occur. One significant by-product of the *Blues* fiasco was the creation of the Fellowship Intellectual Property Trust document. The adoption of the document ensured that the literature would not be "held hostage" by individuals or groups of individuals, nor would World Services be legally defenseless. The loopholes were now closed.

Some housekeeping measures needed to be completed. Three motions were to be put before the conference (1991 WSC held in Dallas that year), as agreed upon in the settlement. During the normal course of business, the 1991 WSC participants technically defeated this portion of the agreement. The agreed-upon referendum was essentially killed, though the general spirit of the judge's recommendation had been met. Dave grew much sicker and died. One additional attempt was made by his colleagues to resurrect the case on April 22, 1992. Wisely, the judge failed to act. Therefore, the 1992 attempted resurrection was unsuccessful, bringing to an end of the *Baby Blues* debacle.

The fellowship in Florida was impacted more than any other locale in the fellowship because of the struggle. The same core group who supported the division of the Florida Region and the Florida Spring Service Break event also supported the *Baby Blues* efforts as well as many of the controversial issues during this era (1988-1993); chiefly these individuals lived in North and South Dade, along with those in South Broward County. Many of the old-timers and those involved in service during the '80s simply tired of the unruly behavior that consumed the fellowship near the end of the '80s and early '90s, and they dropped out of service, leaving South Florida fertile ground for continued rebellion.

FLORIDA SPRING SERVICE BREAK

In 1987, a group of members from South Florida attended the Mid-Atlantic Regional Learning Conference (MARLCNA) held in Lancaster, Pennsylvania. Lou P. returned to Florida with an idea in mind to hold a similar event. The get-together was quietly promoted as "MARLCNA South" up and down the East Coast, though in Florida it was announced as a Regional event.

It was originally a project of the Tri-County Public Information Task Force, an ad hoc committee of the Regional Public Information subcommittee. This meant it was originally a Florida RSC-sponsored event. The RSC trusted servants had little or no oversight about this happening.

The first affair took place at the Holiday Inn at the corner of A1A and Sunrise Boulevard on Fort Lauderdale Beach, renowned since the '50s as a prime destination for college students during spring break. Hence, the event was named the "Florida Spring Service Break" or FSSBNA (fizz – ba – nah) for short.

The main function of the weekend was to address the proposals and topics in the 1989 Conference Agenda Report (CAR) for the upcoming World Service Conference. The event occurred shortly after the release of the much-maligned fourth edition of the *Basic Text*. It attracted many of those who Bob Stone referred to as the "vocal minority," members who were angry and bitter about the omissions in the fourth edition. Service stalwarts considered FSSBNA nothing more than an event designed to perpetrate the Us versus Them mentality prevalent during that era.

Barbara J. from San Diego chaired the main workshop on the CAR Report. Bob R. from Los Angeles was a former trustee; he was selected as the Saturday-night main speaker. Bob thought this was an official "Regional" event. His wife, Sydney R., a former trustee herself, was invited to participate as the Sunday-morning speaker. Both had been critical of recent literature development methods; in particular, the use of professional editor in what became *It Works, How and Why*. They were invited with the hope that they would support an "anti-World Service message." To the disappointment of the event proponents, this did not happen.

A few "off the wall" workshops were on the program. An outrageous workshop on the "The Group" featured the "N.A. Meeting from Hell," a spoof of addicts acting out their worst behavior including examples of traditions violations. One of the more infamous pieces items of N.A. paraphernalia, the "syringe pen," was given out with each registration. Regional trusted servants were incensed and embarrassed by the item.

During interviews for this publication, many pointed to this event as providing the impetus for the divisiveness within the Florida fellowship. Joe M. said, "It created added momentum; however, the wheels were churning before this event." Several others were not as restrained. They pointed to the out-of-state members of the vocal minority for influencing those they sponsored and others in Florida who were relative newcomers.

There was some validity to this statement. Many of the same individuals were involved with FSSBNA, the formation of the South Florida/Bahamas Region, the *Baby Blues* and the related federal court case that followed. On the other hand, several trusted servants in the Florida Region retaliated in an equally inappropriate manner by constantly berating anyone who supported or were involved in any of these activities. "It was a get-together for all the troublemakers in N.A." said one addict. One example of the rift was obvious in the Florida and South Florida RSC minutes. When a motion was brought up to pass along South Florida's share of FSSBNA profits, the Florida Region kept tabling the motion to the policy committee. In turn, these sorts of admonishments only served to unite the group and added to the rift. Those who were on opposing sides back then later agreed, "We wouldn't call the early FSSBNA's a spiritual event."

WORLD SERVICE CONFERENCE – 1990

Andy S. from the Bay Area was the Florida Representative in 1990. He opened his report with the obvious statement that, "This year has been quite a year for our region. The big topic for us has been, 'Should we form a second regional service committee?' We formed an ad hoc committee to look at alternatives. We talked in the halls. We fought and bickered. Then we gave birth to the South Florida/Bahamas Region. The Florida Region will be asking that this new region be seated at this World Service Conference.

"We have not completed the details of dividing our assets. The RSO employs one full-time worker and one part-time worker. The office has a solid inventory of literature and supplies. Negotiations are still underway to determine if the office will be shared or moved into the boundaries of the Florida Region.

"The Convention Board has submitted a proposal for the two regions to hold the convention mutually for the next two years and then the Florida Region would solely manage FRCNA.

"The H&I committee has established a Pen Pal program between members and inmates in prisons. The Third H&I Learning Weekend will be held in Clearwater Beach. Our PI committee has begun showing PSA's on slides that are used in movie theatres, TV advertisements and we are holding sessions for members to be trained on public speaking.

"The Literature committee has begun putting out a regional newsletter. Six editions have been produced during the past year.

"The Convention Board has signed contracts for the next two conventions and should have the third year completed shortly. This year's event will be held in the South Florida Region at the Deauville Resort on Miami Beach. The region supports the WSO efforts to translate the *Basic Text* into Spanish, as our region has worked on and supported the translation since our inception in 1981."

A NEW WAY TO LIVE

FRCNA-9 was held on its customary Independence Day Weekend in 1990. It occurred during tumultuous times as it followed the inaugural Florida Spring Service Break event, initial distribution of the *Baby Blues*, and the recent formation of the South Florida/Bahamas Region.

The annual celebration took place July 5-8, 1990. The FRCNA BOD had chosen the Deauville Resort Hotel on Miami Beach almost two years prior to the event. The hotel had a vast lobby area, which seemed perfect for an N.A. convention. Nevertheless, the tension among attendees was evident, as the typical volume of people intermingling morphed into clusters of members separated by the unusual mass of space in the lobby.

Those who shared their memories noted they had never experienced a swimming pool quite like the one at the Deauville – a salt-water pool. Others recalled the elevator operator who was drunk or heavily medicated: He seemed to stop the elevator at will; the doors sometimes opened in between floors or not at all.

There were 988 paid registrations; however, the main ballroom was filled to its capacity of 2,000 when Barbara J. from San Diego, the main speaker, went to the podium. True to the spirit of the program, the gathering moved many of those who were unconcerned or unaware of the recent debates. Ned, who was then a newcomer, recalled that his first convention was a spiritual experience. He recalled that during the main event when key tags were being given out, he noticed that one finicky banquet waiter was paying special attention to the ceremonial rite. Then the waiter stepped up on stage and accepted his own white key tag. The next year at FRCNA-10, the waiter picked up his one-year medallion.

One point of significant historical note was that a full set of Spanish speaking workshops were placed on the program. This practice continued over the years at FRCNA or SFRCNA for each subsequent Regional convention.

"A New Way to Live" was the last FRCNA held in the newly formed South Florida Region. The next two years' sites had already been contracted to take place at Saddlebrook Golf & Tennis Resort outside of Tampa and at the PGA Golf Resort in Palm Beach Gardens, respectively.

RECOVERY: THE JOURNEY CONTINUES – WCNA 20

Again, this event was held on its assigned Labor Day Weekend. This was the first major event held in the Pacific Northwest. Portland was not a first tier city from a tourist standpoint, which affected the attraction of the event. Attendance fell far short of projections, which altered convention planning for the next several years. Registration for the event was off, as only 3,337 paid to attend. Conservative estimates placed actual total attendance at 4,500. This marked the first time attendance dropped off from one year to the next.

Nevertheless, Portland was known as the "City of Roses." The physical beauty of the city and the surrounding areas was awe-inspiring. Part of the event was to be held at the home of the NBA's Portland Trailblazers.

Those in attendance at the 20th World Convention in Portland, Oregon remember that Bob B. from San Francisco came to the podium and began to scold Lou P. as one of the leaders of the "illicit text gang." It was truly inappropriate, as Bob would later admit, though Lou was not the leader, he was not a victim either. The controversy surrounding the fellowship may have detracted a few to skip this year's event.

FLORIDA SPRING SERVICE BREAK – 1991

The second FSSBNA opened with personality clashes almost immediately. According to one addict, "It was one of the low points" between two opposing factions: Members of the Florida Region and those who were involved with the new South Florida/Bahamas Region and the *Baby Blues* representing those who supported the regional split and the *Blues* fiasco and those who opposed them. There were loud and acrimonious confrontations and nearly a few fistfights that weekend. Irreverent merchandise was sold at this event, further contributing to the controversy surrounding this event. There was an unsavory feeling of disunity. The seminar was organized entirely without Regional funding or supervision. Leftover merchandise from the previous year's event was withheld from the Florida RSC, so it was used for this year's startup capital.

Big Lou provided his own frequent flyer miles for the speaker's transportation.

Another controversial workshop on the agenda was a pep rally for the possible formation of an "East Coast Conference." Billy A. from Allentown, Pennsylvania, was one of the architects of the proposal; the committee selected him as the Sunday-morning spiritual speaker. He angered several attendees by violently swinging his wooden staff at a few of his opponents. David T. summed it up when he said, "The committee managed to alienate almost everybody."

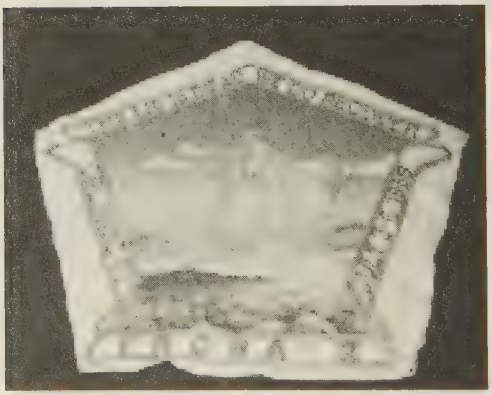
An unexpectedly large turnout on Saturday night bailed the committee out of an enormous financial deficit. Big Lou frantically traveled the country after FSSBNA-2 in an effort to sell off the remaining merchandise before the next RSC meeting so they could appear to look "profitable" for fear of the Region canceling the event.

Afterwards, the Public Information subcommittee realized the spiritual downside of continuing to sponsor the Florida Spring Service Break. They made a motion to discontinue their involvement. The planning committee did, however, introduce the concept of Seventh Tradition donations to support events in South Florida. They succeeded in generating just enough revenue without having a set registration fee.

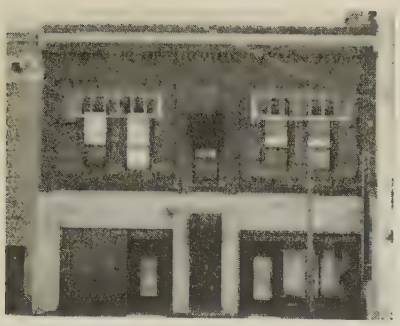
The event continued for several more years. During the FSSBNA-8 event, those who were adversaries in the past worked together harmoniously on the same planning committee. The juvenile activities of the past ultimately subsided. As the years went by, the fellowship as a whole matured spiritually. The Florida Spring Service Break stopped functioning as a movement and the event itself simply ceased.



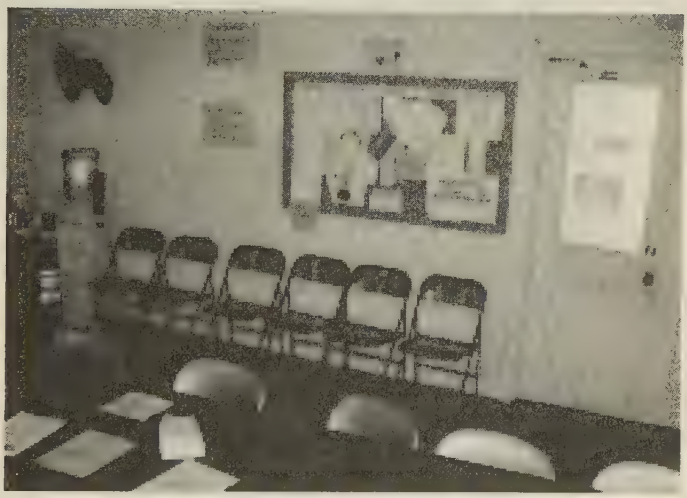
St. Simon's Church – Fort Walton Beach



FRCNA-5 Banner – Orlando



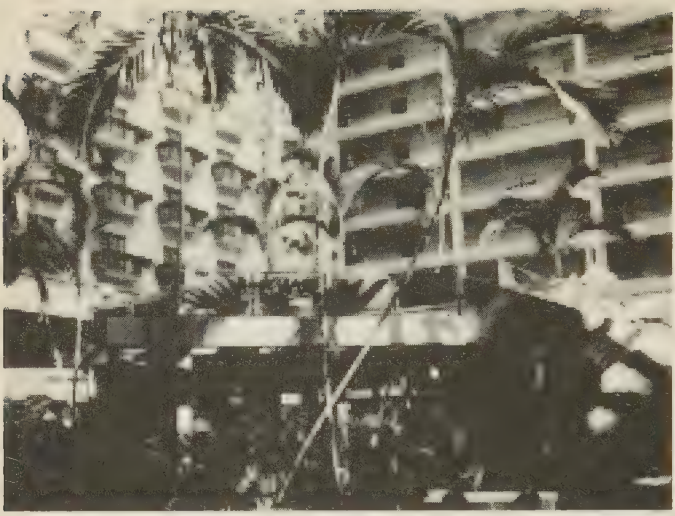
Early meeting place in Palatka



Meeting Place in Pensacola



FRCNA-7 Banner – Orlando



Outside View of Sea World Resort Hotel – site of 19th World Convention – 1989



Deauville site of FRCNA-9 and SFRCNA-1

Chapter Ten

IT'S JUST THE BEGINNING

THE COUNTRY CLUB ERA

Attendance at the inaugural Florida Regional Convention numbered a mere 500. From the time the fifth convention was held, however, attendance swelled to thousands. This growth spurt created obstacles in event management. Multi-hotel sites were used for FRCNA 6, 8 and 9. Orlando and Miami were the only cities with large enough hotels to host the entire event in one facility; therefore, mega-resort country club facilities were tapped to host the next several events.

FRCNA-10 took place July 5-7, 1991, at Saddlebrook Golf & Tennis Resort, located 30 miles north of Tampa. Saddlebrook was home to two Arnold Palmer signature golf courses and the home of teenage tennis prodigy Jennifer Capriati. Prior to the event, some unsubstantiated rumors that the facility had exclusionary rules and regulations preventing minority membership nearly led the board to cancel or move the entire convention. This proved unnecessary as the rumors were confirmed to be unfounded.

"The First Ten Years" was the theme for this year's event. Another memorable logo was chosen for the event: It consisted of a brick wall with each of the previous convention themes written in graffiti like lettering, with a green lizard resting atop the wall. The 2,419 registered attendees seemed to enjoy the wide-open atmosphere at the facility, and the convention board consisted of members who happened to enjoy golf, so the idea went over well. "FRCNA Jack," (Jack G.), the board treasurer, spent most of the weekend counting cash. Jeff S. said, "Jack was carrying over $45,000 in cash to the vault."

Again, the convention made a healthy profit. The South Florida Region received a $21,438 check for their portion of the profits for the two conventions done in partnership with the Florida Region.

The next year's event took place July 2-5, 1992, at the PGA National Resort & Spa just outside of West Palm Beach. It was home of the headquarters of the Professional Golfers' Association of America. Although located in Northern Palm Beach County, which was part of the Florida Region, it was geographically located in Southern Florida and thereby attracted members from the large fellowships in Miami and Fort Lauderdale.

The convention theme for FRCNA-11 was "Winds of Change." This was appropriate, as it was the first year the convention was held without the support of the South Florida RSC. Attendance was at an all-time

high; there were just over 2,500 paid registrants, although various estimates and rumors had it that there were well over 3,000 people in attendance for the Saturday-evening speaker meeting. One member fervently claimed, "4,000 junkies were in the house."

The throngs of addicts – especially the long line of motorcycles – overwhelmed the normally high-class clientele and pretentious staff at the resort. The Fourth of July fell on a Saturday in 1992. This led to several impromptu fireworks displays. Unfortunately, a few errant flying missiles landed on the roof of the building, setting off a small fire. The combination of the fire and the crushing crowds were too much for the facility to handle. This was the only facility that has not invited FRCNA to return.

In 1993, the annual event was held in rural Florida for the first time. The twelfth convention was held at Grenlefe Resort in Haines City. The host area was the Heartland Area, a small fellowship developed there during the previous decade. The staff at the facility seemed to welcome the fellowship; in turn, the convention board favored further use of this facility in subsequent site selection.

"A Spiritual Awakening" was selected as the '93 theme for the July 1-4 annual celebration. Although attendance dropped off as the regional partnership ended, it did not effect participation from the metropolitan areas three hours south of Haines City. Hundreds of members from South Florida continued to support the convention en masse.

FLORIDA CONVENTIONS

Three annual conventions were in place in Florida by the end of 1982. In 1988, the second regional convention, the Alabama/Northwest Florida Region held their inaugural event just outside Pensacola. A few months later, the first Bahamas Area Convention was held November 4-6 at the Ambassador Hotel in Nassau. The convention had over 550 in attendance. Support dropped off over the years due to the proliferation of conventions in Florida and N.A. as a whole.

In the '90s, as areas statewide continued to grow, so did the local celebrations, beginning with a handful of relatively small annual events to dozens. One after another, areas started holding their own local gatherings. Several annual events grew into multi-day get-togethers. Some have continued annually, others ended after a few years. In the mid- to late-'80s, the Florida Region's H&I subcommittee held its annual Awareness Day. In the ensuing years, other subcommittees decided to get involved in

the event. The event was eventually known as the Florida Regional Awareness weekend. The weekend was a time for service workers and people interested in getting involved in service to come together, learn what specific subcommittees were about, and share about the benefits of service involvement. It continued for many years and was dissolved in 2001 when attendance and interest waned.

Small campouts became large campouts; then they became area "conventions" of sorts. The Swamp Recovery Campout began as a few addicts out in the woods. It developed into several hundred. The River Coast Annual Campout beginning in 1989 the same year their area was formed.

The Dade Unity Convention ceased meeting, although it began in the early '90s at the height of Dade's growth spurt. The Gold Coast Area Convention began in 1991 and became one of the single largest area conventions in Florida. Another type of event that became popular was the "spiritual retreat" which, in effect, is a convention with an emphasis on the spiritual principles. Several of these took place in the early '90s in the Conch Republic, Palm Coast, and Gold Coast.

During the mid- and late-'90s, the First Coast, Daytona, Orlando, Fun Coast, Mid-Coast, Un Coast, Conch Republic, and Big Bend areas began holding their own conventions. Treasure Coast and the Heartland Area also started their own area conventions. Another convention that originated in the late '90s, Raïnbow Weekend is an annual convention for gay, lesbian and bisexual members, although the event has never been restricted and is open to any N.A. member, as noted on their flyers. It is the only convention sponsored by a set of groups. The local Florida fellowships became more diversified and grew spiritually; this type of event has been welcomed by the fellowship as a whole.

A total of 25 regional, area and group conventions and spiritual retreats were held annually as of 2004. Total registrations for all these events exceed 18,000 annually.

IT WORKS: HOW & WHY

A DECADE OF TRIAL & ERROR

Opinions vary widely as to what occurred with this piece of literature. At the 1982 World Service Conference, several participants in the Literature committee meeting suggested they begin writing a "Twelve & Twelve book" tailored to Narcotics Anonymous. The committee chose

instead to focus their efforts on pumping out a massive amount of IP's during the next year.

Ginni S. was the newly elected chairperson at the 1983 conference. It marked a change in leadership for the committee. The committee met and decided on a lengthy list of projects, which may have been a little overzealous. Three books were chosen: the *Twelve & Twelve* (referring to the Alcoholics Anonymous book, *Twelve Steps and Traditions*), an N.A. history book, and *Just for Today*, a book of daily meditations. Each of these three projects took a decade or longer to reach publication.

The N.A. history book was initially not a priority. It took 15 years to reach publication stage. The first edition of *Miracles Happen* was published in 1998. It tells the story of Narcotics Anonymous from its inception through the end of the 1970s. The *Just for Today* book was completed in 1991 and published the following year.

The *Twelve & Twelve* was renamed to reflect the era when there was a fellowship-wide emphasis away from the use of A.A. colloquialisms. Surprisingly, one of Bo's ex-wives suggested the name of the book. When she spoke with Ginni, she said the book should reflect, "How the Steps work and why the Traditions provide the stable framework within which our program exists." Shortly thereafter, the committee agreed on the new title, *It Works: How & Why.*

Rather than describe a lengthy convoluted story, this piece was a brief overview of *It Works: How & Why*. After all, few of those interviewed for this book concurred on the timetable and reasons for the various delays. Bo S. wrote in an e-mail: "Initially, many felt that if the *Basic Text* was going to come from the fellowship at large, particularly the East Coast, then California should have the honor of doing the Steps/Traditions book." Later that year, Ginni scheduled a World Literature Committee meeting on the East Coast in Jameson, Pennsylvania. In December 1984, several trustees were assigned to work with the committee on the Traditions.

The following year another conference was scheduled in San Diego to work on the Twelve Steps section of the book. Mostly raw material from this conference was compiled, printed, and distributed in 1985 and nicknamed the San Diego Draft. The cut-and-paste method used by the previous literature movement was unwieldy. Most of the initial input was a rehash of leftover material used during the *Basic Text* compilation. These factors initiated a discussion on the subject of considering alternative methods to complete their task.

Bob Stone suggested hiring outside professionals to expedite the writing process. Bob recruited Ginni, who he hired at the WSO as the literature coordinator, a position designed to assist conference committees and the office to come together to better accomplish their goals. She remained on as the Literature chairperson. After further consultation with conference participants and the board of directors, they hired a writer. This decision backfired as quickly as it started in 1985. A separate review committee was set up to deal with this portion of the book. They continued their work on the steps.

A series of events occurred in 1986. The Trustees formed an ad hoc committee to work on the Traditions. Another professional editor was selected to compile material on the Traditions in August.

In September, the Literature Review committee edited the work from the previous writer. The material they produced was printed in a small white booklet as an approval version of the Steps and distributed to the fellowship.

The booklet contained phrases common to A.A., as the original professional writer was a member of that fellowship. Although the committee edited it, the material still seemed unworthy of approval. At the next conference in Charlotte, North Carolina, in October, the vocal minority was strident, pointing out the deficiencies in the booklet to all the participants.

At the 1987 WSC, the approval booklet was put to a vote and defeated. Back to the drawing board; far more work lay ahead. The package was returned to the fellowship for input. Ten literature conferences were initially scheduled from 1987-1988 including one in Miami.

Meanwhile, the professional editor had plenty of questions for the Trustees in regards to the Tradition material. They bantered back and forth until they too had a booklet. The Traditions were compiled, printed, and distributed in late 1988 to the fellowship. Although other issues in the fellowship repeatedly sidetracked the Trustees, they decided to take over the work of the Traditions in 1988.

The saga continued until 1993 when the fellowship reached a consensus. *It Works: How & Why* was finished. It was approved by the World Service Conference and published shortly thereafter. The process of literature development was continually reviewed by subsequent conferences. This story points out just some of the difficulties the fellowship has had to overcome to reach a consensus opinion in regards

to literature approval. It is truly a labor of love by those who participate in the process.

SOUTH PACIFIC SERENITY

WCNA-21 – SYDNEY, AUSTRALIA – 1991

The first international N.A. meetings on record occurred in Australia in the 1970s. Jimmy K. recorded reel-to-reel tapes and sent them "Down Under." By 1976, there were over a dozen meetings in existence in that country; though the land mass there is similar in overall size to the entire U.S.A. WCNA-21 was the first time a major N.A. event was held in the Asia-Pacific Rim. The trek from Florida involved a total of 24 hours of flight. Despite the distance, several dozen Floridians attended.

The theme for the convention was "The Gift." The Australian fellowship planned the convention with an "Aussie" flavor. Jeff S. told us "about 2,000 addicts attended this event. Friday night they held a 'Broadway' play with an addiction-related flavor. The show was named *Oz*, an obvious takeoff on the *Wizard of Oz*. On Saturday evening, instead of a single speaker, they selected to have a panel of speakers from across the world."

Most took advantage of their time in the "Land Down Under"; many spent several weeks touring the vast country. Some rented motor homes and spent the next six weeks as tourists, stopping in cities and small towns along the way to attend meetings and giving the locals an emotional boost. Others took trips to the Australian Outback. Upon their return to Florida, a common phase heard around meetings was "g'day mate."

1992 SOUTH FLORIDA MEETING DIRECTORY

In December 1991, the South Florida Service Committees decided to produce a new regional meeting directory for release and distribution prior to the third Florida Spring Service Break. The February 1992 directory, which came in booklet form, was a virtual testimonial to the growth of N.A. in South Florida. There were about 40 errors and duplicates listed in the 1992 directory. After deducting the errors, the list included nearly 450 existing meetings in a booklet shaped like the *Little White Book*.

The booklet was a good indicator of the fellowship's growth since the formation of the South Florida/Bahamas Region just two years prior.

The Dade County fellowships had more than 200 meetings per week and Broward hosted over a hundred.

The Bahamas formed their own "region" in 1990, although this act was quickly rescinded by their membership after the 1991 World Service Conference. They eventually rejoined the Florida Region as the Bahamas Area.

A compilation of area meeting schedules and Florida RSC minutes from February and March of 1992 revealed the Florida Region had 375 meetings, a 20 percent increase since the South Florida Region had been formed just two years prior.

Our research supplied some surprising facts, the comparisons pointed out some unexpected revelations. In December 1989, just prior to the formation of the South Florida Region, there were 785 regularly scheduled meetings in Florida, not including those in the Panhandle. As of January 2004, there were over 650 meetings in the Florida Region. When compared to the 375 in 1992, the statistics revealed a continued pattern of significant growth in that region.

Conversely, only a small increase in total meetings had been recorded in the South Florida Region since the 1992 meeting directory was published. Fewer than 500 meetings existed in 2004. Causes for the lack of significant growth vary. Primarily, there was a dramatic decrease in Dade County, caused mainly by the eventual closing of a dozen for-profit treatment facilities in Dade. Additionally, the Bahamas Area would soon rejoin the Florida RSC shortly after their region in 1992. The relatively new South Atlantic Area is a non-geographically aligned breakaway area located in South Florida, although they chose to join the Florida Region. Therefore, there has been a 10% increase in the number of meetings since the inception of the South Florida/Bahamas RSC. Although many areas have grown dramatically, the overall growth of the region has been stymied.

The increase in terms of additional meetings between 1992 and 2004 revealed a limited overall growth of a few dozen meetings. The limited growth was surprising as many simply assumed that the South Florida fellowship grew leaps and bounds since the inception of the new region. On the other hand, it is clear that the average attendance at meetings in Dade County as well as the rest of South Florida have increased exponentially. Therefore, any comparison in terms of the number of meetings alone was not a fair determination of their growth.

Another factor considered was the levels of literature sales to each region. The Florida RSO purchased the equivalent of $250,000 worth of literature from the WSO in 1990. A comparison of 1991 and 2003 Florida RSO financial records show that the South Florida Region purchased 30% more literature, although some of this increase may be attributed to the release of additional literature a few years later. By 2003, annual WSO literature purchases exceeded $450,000.

Regardless of area or regional growth, the overall growth in terms of the number of meetings as well as membership has been momentous throughout Florida.

NUMBER OF MEETINGS	1980	1992	2004
St Petersburg /Clearwater	0	49	89
Greater Tallahassee	0	19	16
Greater Daytona	1	26	38
Greater Jacksonville	1	40	65
Greater Ocala	0	14	18
Greater Tampa	0	28	72
Lakeland / Polk	0	17	50
Greater Orlando	1	34	62
Indian River County	0	5	0
N. Palm Beach County	3	36	68
Pasco County	0	9	13
Hernando / Citrus County	0	11	16
Brevard County	0	30	24
Sarasota/Bradenton	2	21	38
Martin/Indian River/St. Lucie	0	17	28
Greater Gainesville	0	19	32
South Florida	0	0	18
Bahamas	0	0	22
Lake County	0	5	14
	8	**380**	**683**

NUMBER OF MEETINGS	1980	1992	2004
SOUTH FLORIDA REGION			
South Palm Beach County	1	24	64
North Broward County	9	82	100
South Broward County	0	28	52
North DadeCounty	4	133	79
Central Dade	0	24	14
South Dade County	0	82	76
Florida Keys	0	48	51
Naples / Collier County	1	9	17
Fort Myers / Port Charlotte	0	17	25
South Sarasota County	0	0	12
Bahamas	0	28	0
	15	**475**	**490**
NW FLORIDA/ALABAMA REGION			
Pensacola / Ft. Walton Beach	2	28	53
Part of Lower Alabama Area	0	3	12
	2	**31**	**65**
	25	**886**	**1238**

JUST FOR TODAY BOOK

THE PURPLE BOOK

The daily meditation book *Just for Today* was another literature project that took a decade to complete. *It Works: How & Why* was the literature priority in 1983, the same year the daily meditation book was first proposed as a project.

The compilation of the daily meditation book was a low-key affair; it was finally approved and produced in 1992. A gift edition was also printed and released in 1993.

Just for Today was initially distributed with the purple cover, and then a graphic design took its place. It was later discovered that the "Sunset" cover too closely resembled a cover of a Hazelden book. This cover was changed to a more generic cover.

DISCOVERY IN RECOVERY

SFRCNA-1 – MIAMI BEACH – 1993

The Florida Regional Convention (FRC, Inc.) was incorporated in 1988. The South Florida RSC officially formed in February 1990. The new region agreed to continue supporting the annual Florida Regional Convention for two more years. The committee members for those two conventions came from areas in the geographic boundaries of the Florida RSC. These committee members familiarized themselves with the liaison relationship; the South Florida committee members had not.

The South Florida Regional Convention had a rocky start. The South Florida RSC passed a motion to make the area service representatives (ASR) the acting Board of Directors. Apparently, the implementation of a board system troubled a few committee members. They were unaccustomed to the new structure. Personality clashes ensued. Within a few months, the convention chairperson was removed. Then the board president resigned "to clear the slate."

"Discovery in Recovery" was chosen as the theme for the inaugural event. The initial hullabaloo passed quickly; the committee moved ahead with their plans and a formal board was established soon thereafter. After some debate and missteps, the Deauville Resort Hotel was chosen as the site for SFRCNA-1. The Deauville was used four years earlier for FRCNA-9 and was a familiar site for the fellowship.

Frank, Sammy, Dino, and Joey were just a few of the elite who called the Deauville Resort home when visiting illustrious Miami Beach. In 1964, the Beatles played their second-ever show in the United States right there in the Napoleon Ballroom.

The affair was held October 7-10, 1993, with only 602 paid registrants. Total attendance was much higher as the available seats were nearly filled. Another consequence of the animosity between the two regions was the absence of members attending from areas in the Florida Region.

After the inaugural event, the Board of Directors established a formal corporation to manage the event. The board simply duplicated the policies and procedures used by FRC, Inc. The board was revamped with an entourage of new members. They quickly moved ahead on plans for the next several years.

Fort Myers was selected to host the second annual convention. "The Ties That Bind Us Together" was the theme for the October 6-9, 1994,

event. Fort Myers had a small convention center that suited the event well. The Harborside Convention Center was located along the river near downtown Fort Myers.

In an attempt to facilitate and promote unity in the South Florida fellowship and in keeping with the convention theme, the Board of Directors selected George H. to speak during the weekend. George got clean in South Miami, became involved in World Services, later joining the staff at the World Service Office. He was involved in resolving many controversial issues over the years. It was hoped that his presence would attract many of those who avoided anything to do with the South Florida Region during these acrimonious years.

Just fewer than 1,000 people attended, which was considered successful because only 200 had pre-registered a month before the celebration. The banquet was surprisingly sold out at the last minute.

The Fort Lauderdale Airport Hilton was the site for SFRCNA-3. Again, this hotel previously hosted a large N.A. event, FRCNA-6. John C. chaired the convention that took place October 5-8, 1995. The local fellowship attended en masse; there was no way to reliably count the attendees as most simply failed to register. It was estimated that nearly 1,800 attended over the course of the weekend.

The convention continues, the South Florida fellowship began to grow spiritually, leaving the mistakes of the past behind: More will be revealed.

MAINLINE – THIRTY YEARS OF HOPE

OCTOBER 23, 1974 – OCTOBER 23, 2004

The social psyche of the '70s changed over the years. The passionately conservative population in the Palm Beach County of the '70s dramatically changed to a keenly liberal constituency. Addicts, especially those in recovery, are no longer looked down upon as the "dregs of society."

Bob B. listened to his newfound friend Pete F. and called Jimmy K. in faraway California. Their dream of freedom from active addiction for any addict would soon become reality. The handful of addicts who met informally at a coffee shop during the summer of 1974 could never have imagined that their small gathering would lead to the birth of a fellowship of tens of thousands of recovering addicts throughout Florida.

On October 23, 1974, the coffee shop gang met at 421 Iris Street in West Palm Beach. The Mainline Group became the first Narcotics Anonymous group in Florida. With their newfound hope, faith and determination, they survived and flourished together through years of isolation.

Finally, other addicts who found hope through Narcotics Anonymous in Miami and Fort Lauderdale found the Mainline Group. They were never alone again. The Mainline Group survived and prospered as the N.A. message that "no addict need die seeking recovery," spread across the state.

We thank the God of our understanding for inspiring the coffee shop gang.

MORE WILL INEVITABLY BE REVEALED

Chapter One recognized that drugs and thus addiction existed far back in human history. It is clear that attempts were made to free people from the bondage of addiction prior to the founding of this nation. Primitive methods of abstinence programs surely occurred even prior to the founding of this nation.

The Washingtonians were the first self-help organization; they began in the mid-1800s. The Christian-based Oxford Groups taught two men a set of principles they used once they finally met to develop a program for themselves and others who suffered from alcoholism. Bill W. and Dr. Bob founded the first Twelve-Step program in June, 1935; the new program went nameless until they published their own book entitled *Alcoholics Anonymous*. From the name of their book came the name of their fellowship.

The U.S. Public Health Service established two hospitals. One was in Lexington, Kentucky, which opened in 1935, and the other was established three years later in Fort Worth, Texas. They were essentially prisons for addicts. A court order was usually required for admission. Addicts struggled and died with little to no hope for sustained recovery from active addiction.

Houston S. and Victor Vogel, M.D. met; Houston proposed that a group using the principles found in the A.A. program, but adapted for addicts, might have the same triumph that A.A. had been reporting at the time. They held an in-house meeting known as the NARCO Group at Lexington that lasted until the facility closed in 1963.

Danny C. attended the NARCO meeting and found hope there. Upon his release from Lexington, Danny returned to New York City. With the help of several public officials, he started a small group he called Narcotics Anonymous. Regrettably, the group relied upon outside organizations for support. Danny stayed clean until his death a few years later. Danny's protégée, Rae L., kept the organization alive into the early '60s.

One addict found hope in A.A. in North Hollywood, California. Jimmy K. found recovery in 1950. During the next several years, he learned as much as he could about recovery. Jimmy heard of the fledgling effort led by Danny C. in New York. Consequently, Jimmy contacted Danny. Jimmy thought they missed their mark; he said, "They were more of social service organization." However, he liked the name Narcotics Anonymous.

In Chapter Two, we presented a brief history of the birth of the Narcotics Anonymous program as we know it today. Beginning in July, 1953, seven planning meetings were held to create a program for addicts. The founding participants finally decided on Narcotics Anonymous as their name, adapting the Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions as well as altering the meaning of the First Step from one of substance to one of assumed disease. They further added the word "We" before each step in order to emphasize they needed each other more than ever.

Finally, on October 5, 1953, the first meeting of Narcotics Anonymous took place at a small church in Sun Valley, a village in the San Fernando Valley just outside Los Angeles, California. Jimmy K. was there in the beginning, and then when N.A. nearly died in the fall of 1959, it was Jimmy and his friends Sylvia and Penny who resurrected the lone meeting that November. Commencing then, Jimmy was at the forefront of almost every activity in N.A. He played an integral role in almost every "first" in N.A. history.

Members in the '60s began to build a foundation for their fledgling program as it grew outward to other locations in California and then across the country. The focus of the third chapter was on the birth and growth of the fellowship outside of California, mostly east of the Rockies and beyond. Early movements began in Philadelphia and Central Pennsylvania and nearby southern New Jersey because of one *Little White Book* reaching the right person. Other meetings and subsequent developing fellowships sprung up in the first half of the '70s in Georgia, Kansas, Nebraska, Iowa,

Wisconsin and Texas. The message had reached Canada and faraway Australia.

A short-lived meeting in Key West became the first N.A. meeting held in Florida, although it was a false start of sorts. In 1974, Bob B. made contact with Jimmy K. in California. Shortly thereafter, a small group of addicts who met at a coffee shop formed the inaugural N.A. group in Florida. A fellowship grew and flourished. Other groups started up in Miami, Fort Lauderdale, Pensacola, and Orlando. The first Hospitals & Institutions meeting began in 1976 at a remote Florida Road Prison close to the Everglades.

The '70s ended with a firestorm of activity. N.A. members from elsewhere moved to Florida, and 12 members from South Florida attended the 9th World Convention in Atlanta, resulting in a newfound commitment for the N.A. program. Their enthusiasm was apparent a few weeks later when the first service committee was formed, the South Florida Area Service Committee. Contacts followed with members from other fledgling N.A. fellowships around the country.

During 1980, the Miami and Fort Lauderdale fellowships developed quickly. Addicts could now attend an N.A. meeting every day of the week. An ad hoc committee was established to attempt an unlikely bid for WCNA-11. Nina, Rosalie, John, and Big Robert came home from WCNA-10 in Wichita, Kansas. Surprisingly, they brought home the winning bid for the next convention!

The literature movement was on the move as a handful of members from Florida joined the endeavor to write the "N.A. Big Book." Hospitals & Institutions efforts were underway, as large institutions like South Miami Hospital, Concept House and Coral Ridge Hospital opened their doors to the N.A. message.

The 11th World Convention was a complete success, inspiring those in attendance, as well as those who participated in the 6th World Literature Conference immediately following the convention. The conference yielded the first ten chapters of the *Basic Text*.

Those who experienced these major events were energized again. The trusted servants formed the Florida Regional Service Committee three months after the World Convention. Their stated purpose was to draw together addicts from across Florida to create one united region. Members from across the state would no longer exist in isolation. Meetings were located in Daytona, Orlando, St. Petersburg, Tallahassee, and Naples.

Others followed in Melbourne, Jacksonville, Titusville, Gainesville, Tampa, Key West, and Sarasota as well as Vero Beach and Port St. Lucie.

In July of 1982, the first Florida Regional Convention was held in West Palm Beach. It functioned as the single point of unity statewide, bringing together a diverse fellowship. The Florida Region decided to open an informal "central office" located in a member's home in St. Petersburg. The fellowship continued to grow quickly, so a more suitable location was needed; a formal office opened in Fort Lauderdale in early 1983.

In April, representatives from the Pensacola fellowship walked into the formation meeting of the Alabama Region. Their visit altered the region's title to the Northwest Florida/Alabama Region. Later in the month, the *Basic Text* was released and an array of new pamphlets followed a few months thereafter. The new literature provided a stream of funds that enabled the World Service Office and the World Service Conference to conduct the business of Narcotics Anonymous. The new literature also gave the fellowship a modicum of credibility.

By 1984, there were 250 meetings statewide. The N.A. message had spread to most rural areas such as Spring Hill, Avon Park, Lakeland, Lake Wales, Bartow, Lake City, Panama City, Ocala, Fort Myers, Palatka, Deland, Leesburg, Marathon, Key Largo and Bayonet Point, Port Charlotte, Fort Walton Beach and dozens of other small cities and towns.

Based upon reports given at the World Service Conference, the quantity of Hospital & Institution meetings in Florida outnumbered that of any other region or state in the fellowship. The director of the Florida Bureau of Prisons sent a dispatch to each prison stating that Narcotics Anonymous should be welcomed. The impact of Public Information efforts was almost immediate: Participation at the annual Florida Alcohol & Drug Abuse Association Conference netted a virtual triumph for the Public Information committee. Suddenly all publicly funded treatment programs were required to welcome Narcotics Anonymous or risk losing funding for their facilities. We were gaining a degree of respect from "that society" at large. A few medical schools required that their students attend open N.A. meetings.

As the '80s ended, the amount of meetings swelled to over 800 and the annual convention had outgrown the vast majority of hotel convention centers in most metropolitan areas. Issues that occurred in the greater fellowship began to have an effect on the Florida fellowship. From 1989 to 1991, several hostile controversies became routine, even though members

not living in Florida perpetuated them. The initial results were unfortunate, although in spite of the controversies, addicts continued to recover, demonstrating that the spiritual nature of the program could overcome any controversy.

By the mid '90s, the fellowships began to mature; frequently a dozen or members clean over a decade were seen in hundreds of meetings. By then, there were in excess of a thousand meetings statewide. The diversity of the fellowship changed opening the doors of N.A. "to anyone regardless of..."

The theme of the 7th World Convention was "Now We Are Thousands." It was held in 1977, although their claim was more of dream than reality. There were just over 200 verifiable meetings worldwide.

Three decades after a handful of addicts gathered around a table in a coffee shop in West Palm Beach, the Florida fellowship alone claimed the San Francisco theme as its own – "Now We Are Tens of Thousands." Certainly, the fellowship will continue to grow...more will inevitably be revealed!

IT'S JUST THE BEGINNING...

Narcotics Anonymous as we know it today began in 1953, first emerging in Sun Valley, a suburb of Los Angeles, California. There were other noteworthy attempts to form groups by the same name, although each eventually faltered. Narcotics Anonymous has grown into one of the world's oldest and largest organizations of its type.

For many years, N.A. grew very slowly, spreading from Los Angeles to other major North American cities and Australia in the early 1970s. In 1983, Narcotics Anonymous published its self-titled book commonly known as the *Basic Text*, which contributed to tremendous growth. Within a few years, groups had formed in Brazil, Colombia, Germany, India, Ireland, Japan, New Zealand, and the United Kingdom.

By the time the new millennium arrived, Narcotics Anonymous had become well established throughout much of the Americas, Western Europe, Australia, and New Zealand. Newly formed groups and N.A. communities are now scattered throughout the Indian subcontinent, Africa, East Asia, the Middle East, and Eastern Europe.

The growth of the Florida fellowship was notable. By the time the first edition of this book was published, there were over 1,250 regularly scheduled meetings each week. Another 800 panel presentations or Hospitals & Institutions meetings took place weekly throughout Florida. Thirty area service committees exist covering every metropolitan area and several dozen smaller cities and towns. Two dozen conventions and major events are held annually to celebrate the miracle of recovery. More than 40,000 addicts attend N.A. meetings each week in Florida. No addict need ever be alone again.

For nearly 30 years, a few addicts sitting in a coffee shop in West Palm Beach became inspired; they found hope for their dream…"to find the freedom from active addiction." This reality has been proven again and again in the lives of many addicts in Florida and beyond.

"A simple way has been proving itself…

32,000 meetings open to any addict and 8,500 H&I meetings
750,000 members worldwide in 110 countries on 6 continents
5 books & 38 pamphlets/booklets in 46 languages

… in the lives of many addicts"

WHAT WAS THAT ADDICT'S NAME?

We are told from the day we walk into our first meeting that "the newcomer" is the most important person in any meeting. This statement does not remove our personal responsibility to reach out to those who may still suffer or struggle after finding recovery. Many of our friends have struggled, yet they stayed clean through adversity. Let us not forget those who came before us…

What was that addict's name? Remember that one addict who used to come to meetings awhile back? The one you remember who used to share so honestly with a lot of passion. The one who used to talk about their love for Narcotics Anonymous and recovery and the fellowship.

You know the addict that was at the meetings who seemed to have a grasp of the Twelve Steps, who seemed to welcome newcomers, offered their phone number to them. Don't you remember their name? They used attend many meetings regularly, was once a trusted servant for their home group? They opened that one meeting for a long time. Many good things started to happen in their lives: school, religion, new relationship, and new promotion at work.

They slowly over time have drifted away from N.A. meetings and service to others, the one thing they used to talk about in meetings that meant so much to them.

I heard from someone, was it that article in the paper, or was it the obituary section? I caught a fleeting glimpse of their name, dead from the horrors of addiction; left a family of loved ones. I forget where I read that, just as I have forgot their name until I read about it. Died, listed as a transient, cremated and the ashes sent to the family.

Now I remember whom that addict was. I also remember why I remember them. It was how the disease of addiction took over their life clean. As the question in the Basic Text says "Do we know that our addiction changed us into someone we didn't want to be: dishonest, deceitful, self-willed people at odds with ourselves and our fellow man?"

I remember now what happened. They shared in a meeting how they were at odds with fellow N.A. members that all these newcomers were not sharing what they needed to hear, were acting out on sick behavior that at one time they had done themselves.

I remember addicts sharing with them, I remember sharing myself, too; however, the disease of addiction was too powerful. Addict ego was too powerful and words fell to the wayside. I remember now they said, "Oh, I already know that." "I know where the meetings are. When it gets bad, I come back."

Author Unknown

Sad Memories

- *" Going to a meeting one night and hearing that this kid I had sponsored for a short-time had died of an overdose."*
- *"Hearing that George H. had suffered a stroke, nearly died and would probably be paralyzed for the rest of his life."*
- *"The production of the Baby Blues and other negative acts towards our fellowship as a whole."*
- *"So many of my friends in the fellowship dying from AIDS."*
- *"At the midnight meeting....when Mark P. shared he'd learned that afternoon he had 'the Virus' Almost everyone in the circle cried as Mark choked back his sobs."*
- *"Here we were a bunch of social misfits, a class of people that no one wanted to be with and when one of our members told us she had AIDS many of us not only refused to hug her but some of us even refused to touch her during the closing of meetings."*

Humorous Experiences

- *"There are so many. Good belly laughs have been a-dime-a-dozen at times. Sitting around in convention hotel lobbies laughing hysterically at 2:00AM at such nonsense."*
- *"In the summer of 1979, playing stick ball outside of St. Francis Mission, on 6th Street, before the New Freedom group meeting. The women were beating the men and Mark F. said he was going to "take his bat and ball and go home."*
- *"A group of us witnessed an unnamed trustee in a local strip joint tossing dollars bills at one performer's feet. He soon found out the voluptuous babe was not a woman, but a male cross-dresser."*

Most Memorable Experience

- *"My most memorable experience in recovery is my relationship. God brought me my wife, through the doors of N.A. We hugged and the rest is history."*

- *"Meeting Jimmy Kinnon in New York in 1983 at the World Convention. He talked to me like I was his best friend, although we just met."*

- *"I have watched us grow up from being mostly hard-core junkies, saying "Work the steps or die M...F..." To a fellowship that includes people from all walks of life with all levels of bottoms."*

- *"Because of my age, I would have to say that the most memorable experience in my recovery was the 25-year reunion of my old home group. To see all those people still clean with over 20 years. That was not only memorable but also a miracle!"*

- *"Watching my son pick up his one year medallion"*

- *"Having some hope for the first time in my life that things could be different.*

Oldest Ongoing Meetings

West Palm Beach – Mainline Group – October 1974

North Miami — Bridge Group – June 1975

South Miami – New Connections Group – August 1977

Pensacola – Third Tradition Group – October 1979

S. Miami – Survival Group & Bradenton – Fresh Start Group – April 1980

Oldest Events

Fun In The Sun Weekend – Panama City, Florida — May 1977

Florida Regional Convention – West Palm Beach – July 1982

Serenity In The Sun Convention – West Palm Beach – November 1982

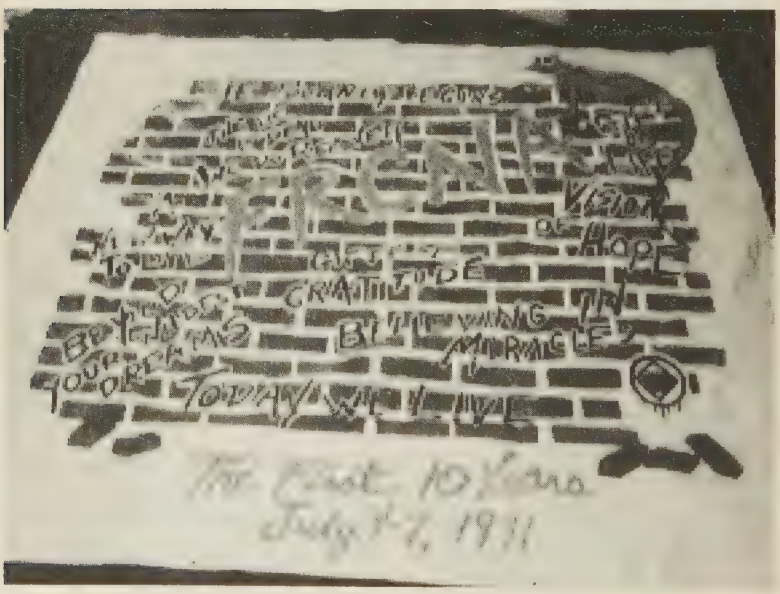
Dade County H&I Banquet – Miami – December 1982

Gold Coast* Anniversary Dinner – July 1983

**The Gold Coast Area celebrates the first meeting in Broward County each year. The area itself was formed in 1981.*



Just For Today – 1st Edition (Purple Cover)



FRCNA-10 Banner



Florida Reginal Service Office – Lakeland – 2004



FRCNA-11 Banner

REFERENCES AND SOURCES OF INFORMATION

The information in this publication is a compilation of available fellowship archives and memorabilia as well as group, area and regional records. Books, magazines, newspapers and internet sites were also used to ascertain and corroborate data, as were interviews conducted with members of Narcotics Anonymous. We noted the aforementioned compilation materials below in order to give proper attribution to these sources of information.

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Tampa Tribune (news articles matching "Narcotics Anonymous") – www.tampatribune.com
Orlando Sentinel – (news articles matching "Narcotics Anonymous") – www.sentinel.com

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FLORIDA REGIONAL SERVICE CONFERENCE MINUTES

December 1981
January, February, March, April, May, June, July, August, October, December 1982
February, April, June, August, October, December 1983
February, April, June, August, October, December 1984
February, April, June, August, October, December 1985
February, April, June, August, October, December 1986
February, April, June, August, October, December 1987
February, April, June, August, October, December 1988
February, April, June, August, October, December 1989
February, April, June, August, September, November 1990
January, March, May 1991

SOUTH FLORIDA REGIONAL SERVICE CONFERENCE MINUTES

February, April, June, August, December 1990

February, April, June, December 1991

February, June, August 1992

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Home Videotape of Jimmy K. – (video that consisted of a brief history of N.A. by Jimmy) (1984-1985) Sun Valley, California

Audio-recorded interviews by Jack W., Florida (1997-2001).
[Robert McG., Biff K., Danny C., Steve D.]

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[Bob B., Bob G., John L., Leah A., Valen E., Jayson T., Biff K.]

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(Bob J. – CA, Fawn F. – MD, Terry R. – UT, Mel H. – CA, Chuck G. – CA, Sally E., – CA)

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Florida Regional Service Office / Various Area Service Committees / Individual collections

Various Regional, Area, Group Minutes and Correspondence (1983-2003)
Florida Regional Service Office / Various Area Service Committees / Individual collections

Various Regional and Area Newsletters (1983-2003)
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Original documents used to develop I.P. – Sponsorship (1982), Use of Medication in Recovery (1982), The Loner (1984-87) – Stored at Florida Regional Service Office

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Florida Regional Service Office (RSO) – floridarso.org

Florida Regional Service Committee (RSC) – www.naflorida.org

South Florida Regional Service Committee – www.soflarscna.org

Northwest Florida / Alabama Regional Service Committee – www.alnwflrscna.org

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30th World Convention of Narcotics Anonymous – commemorative CD-ROM

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Photo of Marco Polo – WCNA-11 – Miami – Courtesy of Florida Regional Service Office

Photo of Holy Cross Church – WLC-6 – Miami – Courtesy of Florida Regional Service Office

Photo of FRCNA-1 Flyer – Courtesy of Florida Regional Service Office

Photo of Holiday Inn – Datura Street – WPB, FL – Courtesy of Florida Regional Service Office

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Photo of former Wyndham Sea World Resort Hotel – host hotel for WCNA-19, Orlando Courtesy of Florida Regional Service Office

Photo of original Miracles Club (Circa 1986) – Courtesy of Florida Regional Service Office
Photo of Father Dan Egan – Courtesy of Florida Regional Service Office

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